A Commander Without an Army

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Am I going to regret this, I'm going to regret this, I'm making no promises that this gets finished, But it might be a fun ride until I crash and burn, canon lesbian couple ha ha ha WOOO

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by A_Big_Old_Skeleton

Summary

Grievously wounded, Catra is left to figure out what the hell happened, where she's going to go next, and who, if anyone, she's going to fight for now.

Notes

Oh lord what have I done now

See the end of the work for more notes

Waking Up

Catra's consciousness came in flashes, disorienting in their irregularity. The sounds of battle, and a glimpse of burning wreckage… a Horde tank, maybe? A faint screaming in a voice that seemed familiar, but she couldn't place it. Darkness. Being scooped up by chitinous arms (Scorpia, her mind sluggishly reminded her). A crisp sky, next to a black cloud on her left that she couldn't see through. Her arm felt like it was on fire, and her face… something was in her face. Darkness, again. She couldn't see anything. Someone was pinning her down, while someone else did something to her arm. She screamed, a ragged, broken cry. There was a sharp pain in her neck, then blessed unconsciousness. A broken roof. Someone paced back and forth just out of sight, arguing with someone else, but her brain couldn't seem to understand the words. Her vision seemed wrong, but she couldn't figure out why. She tried to move, but her limbs wouldn't respond. The arguing stopped, and a rapid set of steps approached her bed. A welding mask with red eyes peered down at her, looked to the side, and gave what she assumed was instructions. A rush of warmth flooded her system, and she fell into unconsciousness once more.

She woke up with a burning thirst and a fever that seemed to threaten to burn herself alive. There was the faint whirr of machinery nearby, and the sound of rain outside. Her voice was rough with disuse, but she managed to croak out a faint, "water." Then, because nobody seemed to respond, she attempted to raise her voice a little and repeat herself.

"Subject appears to be awake," came a familiar voice from somewhere out of sight, "and thirsty. Intravenous fluid supply is clearly not a substitute for drinking water. Possibly psychosomatic element to the act of drinking? Further investigation required."

"Entrapta?"

“Subject recognizes me! Cognitive functions may have escaped major damage!”

There was the sound of a door slamming open, and the unmistakable voice of Scorpia. “Commander! You’re awake!”

“And thirsty!” Entrapta added.

“And thirsty!” Scorpia agreed, and then hastily added, “I’ll get you water right away, commander!”

A few minutes later and Scorpia loomed over her, with a water bottle held gently in her claw. Catra tried to sit up, but found that she couldn’t. Scorpia’s other claw gently helped Catra into a sitting position, and she drank greedily.

“Small sips, Commander. You’ve been out of it for a while now.”

“Four weeks!” Chirped Entrapta cheerily. “We were arguing about whether or not to move you before you regained consciousness a few days ago.”

Catra looked over to her left, but something was still blocking her vision. “What… happened?”

“Do you not remember?” Entrapta asked. When Catra shook her head, Entrapta spoke into her recorder again. “Update: subject may have suffered some loss of memory due to overwhelming trauma.”

Scorpia looked distinctly uncomfortable. “Er, well… there was an… accident.”

“Accident?” Catra echoed. Confused.

“Well,” Entrapta cut in, “Friendly fire scenarios are usually accidental, but my theory-”

“No need to go into that now,” Scorpia interrupted hastily, “A shot hit your tank and the whole thing went up. You’re lucky to be

alive.”

Catra took a moment to process this. “How bad was it?”

Scorpia looked uncomfortable again, and looked over to, Catra assumed, Entrapta with a pleading look. Entrapta popped into view with her hands behind her back, looking, Catra thought, like she was making a special effort to appear clinical.

“The brunt of the blast hit your left side - that’s the direction the shot came from, I assume. I was able to dig most of the shrapnel out of you without much trouble, but there’s a few shards that were too close to vital organs to safely remove without better facilities which, for obvious reasons, we don’t have right now.” Here she gestured around the room, and Catra noticed the whirr of machinery she’d heard had been a few scavenged monitors which had wires leading to her chest and head - presumably tracking her vitals. Something else nagged at her, then, but she couldn’t quite place it.

“You also took some significant damage to your skull,” Entrapta continued, looking apologetic. “I tried to save the eye, but…”

Catra felt her stomach churn unpleasantly. “The eye?”

“I’m afraid you’ve lost it.” Entrapta said, and seemed unsure how to continue for a moment. “Apart from some additional trauma caused by the explosion - the short-term memory loss, some cuts, and so on - your head was well protected. That’s because you had the presence of mind to throw your hand up and shield yourself. But… you might want to look down, now.”

Catra looked down to where her right hand rested on the sheet. A needle stuck out of her hand, running to, she assumed, the aforementioned intravenous fluids. She looked left, where she could feel her left hand, but what she saw was her arm, terminating a few inches above the wrist.

Entrapta’s voice grew fainter. “Your arm and hand took the brunt of the explosion. I saved as much as I could, and I’ve been

designing a replacement, but it'll take some time."

Catra, not for the last time, leaned over the side of her bed and vomited.

"Ohh, yeah," Scorpia said to no-one in particular, "That's all water."

If Entrapta had a response, Catra didn't hear it. Darkness swept over her again, and she fell back into unconsciousness. Her last thought, as her thoughts fled, was whether or not Adora knew what had happened.

What's Left Behind

Chapter Summary

> Adora searches for some kind of answer on the battlefield. She's not happy with what she finds.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Where's Catra?" She-Ra shouted, amidst the tumult of battle. There was a dull thwump as a Horde-launched shell detonated in front of her, and she raised the shield to deflect the force of the blast, protecting herself and Glimmer.

"Maybe she's sitting this one out?" Glimmer shouted back, conjuring a few sparkling bombs and flinging them into the sides of yet another Horde tank, which sparked, was quickly abandoned by its crew, and exploded spectacularly.

She-Ra shook her head, frowning. "It's not like her to sit one out. She's got to be planning something."

The Horde army had rolled one of its larger mechanized divisions directly into a small village just beyond the borders of the Fright Zone. It was transparently a feint to draw the Rebellion out, but Adora wouldn't hear of leaving the villagers to their fate. Queen Angella had been firm that the resources of the Rebellion were stretched far too thin as it was to be falling into traps, but Glimmer had fired back that only the Horde would leave civilians to die in order to gain a tactical advantage. In the end, Angella acquiesced to sending a small detachment made of volunteers to provide enough time for the village to evacuate - but, she stressed, their orders were to *delay,* not to save the village.

"Adora! Bigger tank!" Bow shouted, pointing off in the distance. Another thumping explosion rocked the ground, and Adora heard the cries of the wounded.

She looked over to Glimmer with a look of determination. “That’s got to be her. Go make sure the evacuation is proceeding as planned - teleport the wounded out of here, if you can. If I can take that tank out, Catra will sound a retreat.”

“How do you know?” Bow broke in, loosing an arrow into a Horde drone.

“Because if this is a feint, there’s no sense in spending more resources than is necessary. Losing a command tank is too big of a loss for an operation of this size, and Catra will have to pull out in the hopes that it’ll save enough to offset the loss. Otherwise she risks Hordak’s wrath, and… you don’t want that.” She-Ra shuddered involuntarily. “Now get moving! Take out as many drones as you can, and I’ll handle the-”

She never got the chance to finish her sentence, as a shot slammed into the side of the command tank with such force that it spun around, a gaping hole in its side. She-Ra barely had time to register a glimpse of someone scrambling out of the wreckage before the entire thing exploded, sending out a shockwave that nearly knocked her flat. Bringing a hand up to shield her eyes, she began moving toward the wreckage almost without thinking anything beyond *Catra’s in there* , but then a shout from Bow warned her of another group of Horde soldiers who’d broken through the Rebellion’s defensive line, and she was off to fight them. Then, finally, whoever was leading the Horde attack in lieu of Catra seemed to decide they’d had enough, and sounded the retreat.

The surviving soldiers cheered, and She-Ra found herself surrounded, being clapped on the back and thanked. She demurred, and accepted the praise heaped upon her somewhat reluctantly, and could not stop herself from constantly looking over at the wreckage of Catra’s tank, which was still smouldering.

“Ha! Give ground my ass!” Glimmer cheered. “My mom’s gonna *flip* when she - Adora?”

Adora, having dropped her She-Ra form, was now walking with an air of purpose through the wreckage of the battlefield. "We should look for survivors," she called back over her shoulder. "There… there might be survivors."

Glimmer looked like she was about to argue, but Bow put a hand on her shoulder and squeezed gently. "Adora's right," he said, and then raising his voice, added, "If you find any wounded Horde soldiers, call for a medic. We don't leave anyone behind, got it?"

The celebrating soldiers looked more than a little nonplussed, but a few seemed to think it was a worthwhile cause and began the hunt. Adora had only one destination in mind, but she kept pausing as she spotted another Horde soldier she'd seen in passing, or exchanged a few words with at one time or another. When she spotted one soldier breathing shallowly, she sprinted over as quickly as she could.

"Hey, hang in there, okay? We're going to help you."

The soldier was not someone Adora recognized. His face was drawn tight with pain, and his hands both clutched feebly at a gruesome wound in his stomach. He seemed to be having trouble focusing, but he managed to cough out a plaintive "help me."

Adora dropped to her knees and immediately began applying pressure to the wound, the first aid training she'd had drilled into her as a Horde cadet coming back quickly. She looked back over her shoulder and shouted "Medic! I've found someone!" before turning back to the soldier and putting on a more gentle expression. "I need you to stay awake for me, okay? What's your name?"

"F-Finch. Private Finch, 3rd mechanized division." The soldier's eyes flitted up to Adora's face and there was a flash of recognition. "You're *her* . You're… you're the Great Betrayer."

Adora was taken aback, but quickly recovered. "Nevermind who I am. Tell me about yourself, Finch."

Finch did not seem interested in talking about himself. “They said you were merciless. T-that you killed thousands of Horde soldiers.” He took another painful breath. “S-said you’re a monster.”

“Well I don’t know a monster would be trying to save your life right now,” Adora said, a little more acidly than she perhaps meant to, “and at any rate, it doesn’t matter anymore. What matters is you staying alive, okay? You can tell me what else they say about me, if that helps.”

“Why? W-why did they leave me here?” Finch’s voice carried a note of panic.

“I’m sure…” Adora said, trailing off because she knew exactly why and didn’t want to say, “the retreat wasn’t well organized. Your commander’s tank got destroyed early on, remember?”

This seemed like the wrong thing to say, as Finch only grew more agitated. “C-commander Catra’s dead?”

Adora hurried to reassure him, to try to calm him down. “I don't know. I haven't seen her body, so there's a chance she's still out there.” With an almost wistful grin, she added, “She's probably too stubborn to die.”

Finch reached up and grabbed at Adora's shirt, trying to pull himself up. “She’s got to still be alive. Sh-she takes care of the soldiers. Keeps us… keeps us from getting sent on suicide missions like Shadow Weaver used to plan. P-please, you have to find her!” So great was his agitation that Adora had to hold him down to keep him from making his wound worse.

“If she’s alive, Private, I promise I’ll find her.” Adora said, “Right now, though, we’ve got to keep *you* alive, okay?”

“Sh-she was going to save us,” Finch muttered, half to himself, “that’s what they said. Stop the war and forge a truce with the Rebellion. Break the cycle…” His breathing slowed, then stopped.

“Hey! Private! Private, I need you to breathe, okay? I need you to -” Adora fumbled, seeking a pulse, then looked into his eyes, which were already empty. She pounded his chest a little, trying to get his heart to start again, but it stubbornly refused to do so. “No no no, I can fix this, I can save you, just… I didn’t want this, I have to… the medics will be here and you’ll be fine, you’ll see, hey, you’ll…” her voice trailed off into a shuddering sob, which she quickly swallowed as the sound of an approaching medic grew louder. Taking a deep breath, she stood and wiped her bloody hands uselessly on her trousers.

“Princess! Where’s the-”

“He uh, he didn’t make it.” Adora said, mastering herself. “I’m going to keep looking for survivors. Follow me.”

The two medics fell into step behind Adora as she continued her grim search. As Adora drew closer to the wreck of the command tank, she felt her pace slowing, as if she thought not seeing Catra’s body would somehow mean she was still alive. She didn’t want to know if Catra was dead. Not really. The two medics slowed pace with her, assuming that she was merely being thorough in her search. There were no other signs of life, just bodies - some blackened and twisted. Adora fought a raging tide of nausea to look closer for something that could have been Catra’s - the helm she always wore, for a start - but didn’t see anything. The wreckage of the tank was impressive to behold.

The force of the explosion had blasted the side of the tank outwards, and the corpses of the tank crew were slumped in place. Adora peered curiously at the controls, which were completely unfamiliar. With a start, she realized they resembled First Ones technology, which should have been impossible. The Horde had been trying for centuries to integrate First Ones technology into their weapons, and this? This was genuinely troubling. For a moment, Adora almost forgot her grim errand, but a muttered swear from one of the medics brought her back to reality.

She approached the bodies of the crew, and breathed a sigh of relief. Catra wasn't here. Which meant, maybe, that Catra had survived, somehow. She tried not to think about why she was so relieved to discover that her nemesis was still alive, but then again Adora was at least honest with herself when it came to Catra. There was a flash as Glimmer appeared next to the tank, looked inside, and blanched.

" *Goddess* , this is awful. I've never…" there was a pause where the princess retched noisily outside. Adora finished her investigation of the tank's interior and stepped back outside. Glimmer looked at her with an expression of shock and disgust. "I've never seen the aftermath of a battle like this before. Princesses are meant to… you know, command. We don't stick around once the battle's over."

Adora gave Glimmer a look with an unidentifiable emotion churning behind her eyes. "Maybe they should."

Chapter End Notes

> Hey look, there's another chapter, just like I promised. Unfortunately for y'all, it was a flash back! But it's an important one that I wanted to do now rather than later. We'll get back to Catra (and the present) next chapter.
>
> Also now it should be clear this is a multi-part deal, since I fucked up the initial posting of this and forgot to mark it as such from the get-go.

An Escape, and a Plan

Chapter Summary

> Catra tries to find out what's going on, but is interrupted by people trying to kill her.
>
> Rude.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

When Catra woke up again, it took a moment for the reality of her situation to set back in again. This time, she was ready for the shock when she looked down at her arm. Her right hand cautiously approached it, and she couldn't help but flinch as she touched the spot where her hand had been. Scorpia appeared, having been sleeping somewhere nearby, Catra guessed, with another glass of water and an apologetic look on her face.

"Here you go, Commander. Sip it slow, now. You don't want a repeat of last time." There was a gentleness to Scorpia's voice which almost, but not quite, managed to cover the fact her voice was shaking.

Catra sipped slowly, trying not to think too hard about the fact that she could still feel her left hand. Scorpia watched her carefully, ready to step in and help if needed. Eventually, Catra placed the glass to the side and gave Scorpia a reassuring squeeze with her good hand. "It'll be okay, Scorpia. We'll get back to the Fright Zone." Even as she said it, Catra wasn't sure she meant it.

Judging by Scorpia's expression, it hadn't been what she wanted to hear anyway. She stood up quickly, saying something about needing to check the perimeter. Catra huffed in frustration and ran her hand over her face, feeling the bandages that covered her ruined eye and what felt like stitches criss-crossing her left side.

She'd been lucky, Catra thought. If she'd been a second slower, or Scorpia hadn't been nearby, there was no way she would have survived. If Entrapta… she frowned. What had Entrapta been doing near the battlefield? The Horde barely tolerated Catra's refusal to lock Entrapta up, but Hordak had been very clear on one thing: Entrapta was not to leave her workshop. Ever.

As if summoned by Catra's train of thought, Entrapta wandered into the room, and indicated the door behind her with a curious expression. "What'd you say to Scorpia? She seemed distressed when I passed her."

"Entrapta, what are you doing here?" Catra asked, ignoring the question.

"What? I'm here to evaluate your wounds." Entrapta seemed confused, and after checking a few of the monitors, turned back to Catra with a satisfied expression. "Okay, let's have a look under those bandages."

She raised a pair of scissors, but Catra's good hand shot out and grabbed her wrist. "No Entrapta, I mean what are you doing outside of the Fright Zone? For that matter, why haven't we gotten into touch with central command?" An idea of the reason was forming in her mind, and she didn't like it.

This question seemed to strike Entrapta as faintly ridiculous, or at the very least unnecessary. "What do you mean? I had to flee as soon as I heard you were being removed."

The uncomfortable feeling in Catra's gut blossomed into something far more unpleasant, and she felt her heartbeat slow as she processed the news. "Removed, huh? So Scorpia's 'friendly fire' comment…"

"She didn't want to give you any kind of a big shock just after you woke up," Entrapta said, shrugging with her hair, "which was probably the right idea." There was a flicker of something like

embarrassment on Entrapta's face. " I'm not always great at judging that sort of thing. She's been helping me with that."

Catra felt anger begin to blossom in her chest. "So you chose to lie to me." Her hand formed a fist.

Entrapta didn't seem particularly flustered by Catra's reaction. "Yes, we did. You nearly *died* , Commander. I won't apologize for caution in a delicate situation."

Catra opened her mouth to say something suitably cutting in response, but was interrupted by Scorpia dashing into the room. "They've found us! We've got to move."

Entrapta swore in a very un-Entrapta-like fashion and produced a syringe. With a movement that was so fast it caught Catra completely off-guard, she jabbed it into her neck. "Sorry Commander, but we need you on your feet for this."

There was a spreading warmth in Catra's veins, and she felt her limbs flex in response. "The hell did you just inject me with?"

"Experimental cocktail of… look, it's probably fine. I think. It'll make it easier for you to keep up." Entrapta waved a hand dismissively, then seemed to reconsider after a stern look from Scorpia. "Er, that is, I can tell you about it later, when we're not about to die?" She looked over to Scorpia and received an approving nod in response.

Catra levered herself out of bed and reached to pull the IV out of her hand until she remembered she didn't have a hand anymore. She yanked it out with her teeth instead. For a few seconds, she stood, trying to decide if she was going to vomit or not. The nausea passed, and she nodded to Scorpia and Entrapta, who were watching her closely.

"Where to?"

Scorpia jerked her head the the direction she'd come from. "We've got a skiff out back. If you make it there, the navigation has our

fallback location programmed in. Entrapta's set everything up."

Something about the way Scorpia spoke rang an alarm bell in Catra's mind. "What do you mean 'If I make it there?' What about you?"

Scorpia shook her head. "You're the primary objective, Commander. You're too important."

"Important for what?" Catra said, frustrated, "I don't understand!"

Scorpia looked genuinely confused. "Do you really not know?" She shook her head in disbelief. "You're…" A cracking sound echoed through the room and Scorpia grimaced. "No time. Entrapta, get her out of here! I'll catch up!"

Entrapta hesitated, then stepped in close and brought Scorpia's head down to her height, briefly resting her forehead against hers. Scorpia whispered something that Catra couldn't quite catch and then, in a louder voice, repeated herself. "Go! I'm right behind you."

Entrapta hoisted herself up on her hair and held a hand out for Catra. "This way, Commander."

Catra nodded, having decided for the moment that keeping herself alive took priority over figuring out what the hell was going on. The two darted out the door, leaving Scorpia behind.

"Here," Entrapta said, dropping Catra's hand in order to unclip something from her belt, "You'll probably want this. You know, in case they… In case you need it."

Catra took the shock stick in her hand. It felt strange wielding it in one hand, but with whatever Entrapta had injected her with running through her veins, she felt like it would probably not be a problem. Entrapta led her around the perimeter of the building, and Catra finally had a look at where she'd been laying unconscious for the last four weeks. It was the ruins of some village or another - Catra had never seen it before, but from the

amount of foliage growing in the ruins she assumed it must have been sacked in a battle years ago. That meant they were fairly deep in Horde territory, but not in the Fright Zone. Apart from the building they'd been staying in, everything else was barely standing. It had been, she realized, an excellent place to hide if you were trying to hide from the Horde.

There was a shout and the sound of multiple energy discharges behind them. Entrapta very pointedly did not look back, though Catra did. There were no signs of any soldiers in pursuit, which meant that Scorpia was probably still alive, for now. Catra gripped the shock staff harder and concentrated on following Entrapta while keeping a wary ear out for the sound of anyone in pursuit. They stayed low, making their way to the edge of the settlement ruins. Entrapta paused and fiddled with some other device on her belt, and there was a shimmer in front of them, which revealed a Horde skiff waiting for them.

"Never seen a Horde skiff do that." Catra commented.

"I may have made some slight modifications to this one." Entrapta admitted, not without a hint of pride in her voice, "I'll get her warmed up. Get yourself strapped in. There's a pulse rifle over there - you'll probably need it."

"You think Scorpia won't be able to hold them off?"

There was a very un-Entrapta-like snort of annoyance. "Of course she'll hold them off. But she'll hold them off by being taken captive, because that was the plan we agreed on, and I've decided the plan was poorly thought out."

"So instead we're going to get her." Catra surmised, grabbing the rifle and quickly giving it a once-over. "Sounds good to me. Heroic sacrifices never quite sat right with me."

"I know," Entrapta said, as the engines roared to life, "It's part of your appeal."

Whatever response Catra had was forgotten as she felt her stomach plummet into her shoes as the skiff launched itself into the sky, behaving in a very un-skiff-like manner. Entrapta aimed directly for the building they'd been staying in, which Catra could now see was surrounded by a group of Horde shock troops: Hordak's elite soldiers, including those who served as his honor guard whenever he deigned to travel. Entrapta flipped a few switches and the skiff rolled to its side, causing Catra to yowl in a fairly undignified manner before she realized this gave her an excellent shot at all the soldiers and the yowl became a battlecry that became a whoop of exhilaration. The rifle bucked, and she cursed at her inability to hold it steady without a left hand, but then she used the recoil to walk her line of fire across the group and felt like she'd done okay.

The soldiers scattered, and Entrapta righted the skiff and brought it swooping in low in front of the building, leaving Catra a clear view of the approach to the entrance. There was a thud behind her and she swore she felt the skiff sink a little, followed by a shouted "Go!" from Scorpia. The skiff leaped into the air like it had been kicked and flung itself across the sky. For a while, Catra sat panting in her seat, feeling the adrenaline slowly exit her system. The only sound, beyond the sound of the skiff's engines, was the sound of both her and Scorpia breathing heavily and the occasional sound of Entrapta toggling some switch or another.

Eventually, Entrapta unstrapped from the pilot's chair and walked back. With a methodical care, she began to check Scorpia for injuries, making small noises of disapproval every time she found another cut or crack in the carapace of Scorpia's claws. Scorpia remained quiet through this, seemingly too tired to form a response. Eventually, Entrapta rested her forehead against Scorpia's again and smiled.

"You were supposed to leave me behind." Scorpia said, a hint of accusation in her voice. "It was the right plan."

"It was a stupid plan." Entrapta said, "and this accomplished the same result without your being seriously injured. You may not

have noticed, but I am not fond of patching you up."

"Thank you." Scorpia said.

"If you're finished with… whatever it is you're doing," Catra said, feeling slightly annoyed and jealous for reasons she didn't want to think about, "Perhaps you could explain what you meant by my being 'so important' you were going to get yourself captured or killed over."

There was a faint dusting of red on Scorpia's cheeks, but she recovered quickly. "You're the Commander, commander. That's why."

"If what Entrapta told me before the attack was right, I don't think I'm the commander of anything anymore." Catra replied.

"That's not what I meant," Scorpia said, frowning a little. "You're… Look, how long have you been Hordak's second in command?"

Catra took a moment to think back. "Three years, I think? It was just after the assault on Brightmoon."

"Right," Scorpia said, nodding. "And in those three years, how many casualties have we had?"

Catra grimaced. "3,589 dead, 38,093 wounded. Most of the wounded returned to active service within six weeks."

"Shadow Weaver could never answer that question," Scorpia said, simply, "and I guarantee the numbers were a lot higher. Next question: how many of the battles fought by the Horde since you became commander have you not been present for?"

"I don't know, ten? Twenty, maybe? I've been injured from time to time."

"Exactly. You're out there fighting with the soldiers - and not just leading from behind either. You're a demon on the battlefield, to hear the rank and file tell it."

"You mean to hear *you* tell it." Entrapta cut in, causing an embarrassed look to cross Scorpia's face.

"I mean, you're pretty good at fighting, Commander. The fact that you've gone toe to toe with She-Ra so many times and survived alone is worth commenting on."

Catra snorted. "Adora always pulls her punches with me. She holds on to… what we used to be."

"It's made you a legend of the battlefield," Scorpia said, shrugging, "and it's made a lot of the rank and file more loyal to you than they are to Hordak."

"So Hordak decided to get rid of me before I became a problem." Catra leaned back and looked up into the sky with a sigh.

"Not just that," Entrapta said, cutting in, "he figured having you as a martyr would make it even easier to control the troops - killed in service to Hordak, to whom you were always unfailingly loyal."

"But that all falls apart if I don't die like I'm supposed to, so now there's elite Horde soldiers hunting me. Great." Catra ran her hand over her still-healing face and tried not to scream with frustration. "So what do we do now?"

"What happens next? Well, that's up to you." Scorpia said, nodding in Catra's direction.

"Scorpia and I started establishing a base of operations on an island off the coast of Scorpion Hill as soon as we had you stabilized." Entrapta broke in again, rolling her eyes at Scorpia's dramatic statement. "It's defensible, it's hidden, and we've already got a skeleton crew of volunteers working to fortify the place."

"Skeleton crew? You mean you're not the only ones who know I'm still alive?"

"Not quite." Scorpia looked embarrassed again before continuing. "Hordak's plan didn't go quite as he planned, and in the aftermath

a lot of soldiers who were at the battle and saw your tank go up started thinking you'd been set up. I helped them desert with the promise that we'd get revenge on Hordak for betraying you."

"Why not join the Rebellion, then?" Catra asked, curious.

"Somehow," Entrapta said, with a smirk that might have been sarcastic, "the soldiers seem to think the Rebellion might not be eager to take on a bunch of Horde operatives with no magic swords or kingdoms."

"So instead they're what, building a leaderless army with no kingdom to fight for?"

"Leaderless?" Scorpia shook her head. "No, not leaderless. You, Commander, would lead. That's their hope. That's all they want. Just to serve under you, and take vengeance on those who wronged us."

"Vengeance, huh?" Catra looked at the stump terminating her left arm through her one remaining eye, thought back to the screams and fire erupting in the cabin of the command tank, and the feeling of the explosion throwing her across the battlefield, leaving her a broken thing. She thought of fighting loyally for the Horde, taking missions and never questioning what they were doing or why. She thought of burned out, ruined villages which had served no tactical purpose but had been destroyed all the same. She thought about Adora, and what sort of welcome awaited her if she tried to join the Rebellion. Finally, she spoke. "I can work with vengeance."

Chapter End Notes

> Scorpia, as it turns out, is difficult for me to write in a situation where her normal goofball tendencies would be way too tonally jarring. I apologize, she's a little out of character here, but let's call it the stress of her situation and Entrapta's influence and leave it at that.

Anyway, this chapter got real long on me, but it covers a lot of ground and is hopefully worth the trouble. I need to figure out if I want to check back in with Adora and crew next, or keep the view on Catra for a while, so until I decide on that it'll be a bit before the next chapter is even started, much less finished and posted. Watch this space, I guess?

Oh, and thanks for reading/giving kudos/commenting! If you haven't already realized that I am a chatty ol' bastard in the comment section, well, now you know.

EDIT: Yikes, some of these lines *clunked*, huh? I've cleaned some of that up (the other clunky lines I just haven't noticed yet).

A Planned Investigation

Chapter Summary

> Adora gets permission to conduct reconnaissance. With a few caveats.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora stood in front of Queen Angella, back ramrod straight as had been drilled into her as a Horde cadet. While Adora tended to wear her heart on her sleeve since joining the Rebellion, she could fall back into the old ways when she needed to, and this was one of those times.

"The Rebellion *needs* She-Ra, Adora. The Horde has been more aggressive in the last weeks, and we cannot have you running around on some… personal vendetta."

Several response rushed through Adora's head, and she bit them all back in favor of the one she knew would be most effective. "Our forces have been more than up to the task. It doesn't help that these are barely incursions - not one of these attacks have had a force large enough to accomplish anything of note."

"Was it not *you* and my daughter," Angella said, putting the emphasis on where she clearly thought the majority of responsibility lay, "who convinced me that only the Horde would ever sacrifice civilians to gain a tactical advantage?"

"I'm not advocating leaving the Horde to run rampant, your Majesty," Adora said, refusing to let herself lose her temper, "As I said, our forces are more than up to the task. They are far better trained than they were three - even four years ago."

"And so is She-Ra, or am I mistaken? She-Ra's place is on the front lines. You give the people hope, and you keep the Horde in

check by your presence alone."

Adora shook her head firmly. "I don't think we're keeping the Horde in check! These recent attacks are a delaying action, to buy time for some plot we don't know yet. Catra-"

"Has not been seen by you or any of our contacts in over a month," Angella said, sighing heavily. "Adora, you have to face facts. I know she was your friend once, but she's gone and you need to-"

"She's not *gone!* " Adora couldn't hold back her outburst. She flushed heavily and bowed her head. "I am sorry, your Majesty. I do not… I do not intend to search for Catra." When Angella raised an eyebrow, Adora continued. "The technology in her tank was First Ones technology, and I believe that if we do not uncover when and how it was integrated with Horde equipment, we will find ourselves at a severe disadvantage."

Angella steepled her fingers. "You're talking about the wreckage we recovered? Our scientists have been studying it, but they seem to believe it was a prototype."

Adora shook her head emphatically. "That doesn't make sense. The Horde doesn't *do* that. Certainly not with a one-off prototype."

"Friendly fire happens, Adora. Even with a well-oiled military machine like the Horde."

"No I mean, they don't send a prototype out into the field unless they're already manufacturing them."

"Unless they're desperate." Angella noted. "The Rebellion's done more than force a stalemate these last three years - we've made actual territorial gains. The political situation for the Horde could be unstable enough to force their hand."

"It's not worth the risk of there being some worse threat out there! We can't afford uncertainty." Adora replied, pressing her

luck, “At the very least we should increase our intelligence gathering efforts. I know Fright Zone’s territory better than anyone else here, I can be in and out without anyone noticing. I just need a chance to see what they’re up to.”

Angella sighed, “And if I don’t say yes, you’ll just run off and do it anyway, I’m sure. Very well, Adora, you can have your mission. On two conditions.”

“Which are?”

“One, you go alone. I won’t risk any troops or personnel - and certainly not my daughter - on what is likely to be a wild goose chase.”

Adora nodded. “I assumed it would be a one-man mission to begin with. Done. What’s the other condition?”

“The sword stays here. If you’re captured or killed, there can be another She-Ra. The Sword of Protection is wholly unique.”

Somehow, Adora managed to hide her surprise. She hadn’t planned on using her She-Ra form anyway, but to hear Angella so pointedly lay out her expendability was… less pleasant than she’d been prepared for. Still, it only took her a few seconds to nod her assent. “Of course.”

“Very well. Find evidence of this new threat, Adora, and you will have done the Rebellion a great service once again. Fail to find any evidence, and at least we’ll know for sure.” Angella waved her hand in dismissal. Adora turned on her heel and began heading out of the throne room, only for Angella to call out behind her. “One more thing, Adora: Come back in one piece. I don’t want to have to tell my daughter her friend is dead.”

“Of course, your Majesty.” Adora called back over her shoulder. *I’d hate to* inconvenience *you* , she didn’t add.

Glimmer was, as expected, furious with her mother. “What do you *mean* a solo mission? And without the sword? Is she *insane* ?”

Adora sighed deeply. “No, she’s just being the queen. It’s the right decision, considering everything. She’s convinced I’m just trying to find out what’s happened to Catra.”

Glimmer spluttered, beside herself with anger. “But you aren’t! The whole… you said yourself they wouldn’t put something that valuable at risk unless they had something better!” There was a pause, then, “You *aren’t* just trying to find out what happened to Catra, are you?”

“I wish I was,” Adora admitted, an undercurrent of anguish in her voice, “she *can’t* be dead. I *know* she’s not dead.”

“Adora…” Glimmer’s hand rested on her friend’s shoulder and gave a gentle squeeze. “We didn’t find a body, but… That tank *exploded* . Even if she got out, the injuries she would’ve suffered…”

“The Horde’s medical teams are second to none. They could have saved her.”

“The Horde is the reason the tank exploded. You said it yourself, friendly fire is highly unlikely in the Horde. Maybe… maybe she fell out of favor.”

This was something Adora had considered herself, though she’d not spoken the suspicion aloud. It had not escaped her notice that the Horde had been far more careful with its troops since Catra’s ascension to second in command. Some small part of her hoped Catra was also trying to give the Rebellion an advantage, that some part of her *wanted* the Horde destroyed for what it had done to her and Adora. Deep down, Adora believed, Catra was a good person. Under Hordak, though… that would have been a dangerous game to play, and if Catra had been playing it, killing her in a staged friendly fire accident would have been a mercy.

“I… suppose that’s possible,” Adora finally said, “but she’s still alive. I know it. I just have to *find* her.”

“Well,” Glimmer said, deciding to pick her battles, “first you have to find out what the Horde’s planning. Come on, I’m sure I’ve got some equipment that’ll come in handy.”

The two walked to Glimmer’s (formerly) secret armory, where she busied herself grabbing a few weapon options and a small communicator device (a souvenir from Entrapta, back when she’d been on their side). She laid the items out on a table in front of Adora, who raised an eyebrow and gave a wry grin.

“You know, this is a stealth mission. Not an assault.”

“Shut up,” Glimmer said, hugging Adora tightly, “I don’t want to lose you. You check in with Bow and I with the communicator, and the second that something goes wrong we’ll come in guns blazing.”

“You don’t use guns.” Adora teased, unable to help herself. “You’ll come in with glitter bombs and whatever arrow Bow’s come up with last.”

“You know what I mean.” Gimmer said, sniffing back a few tears. “Swift Wind will get you in and out, right?”

“Yeah, I spoke with him earlier. He’s pretty sure I’m right, but I think he’s just saying that because he likes me.”

“Well he would. You’re very likeable.”

“Hopefully any Horde soldiers I run into will think the same thing and let me go.” Adora joked, a little darkly.

There was a ruckus outside the armory door which, as it turned out, were caused by the appearance of a flying horse in a palace hallway. Swift Wind stuck his head in the doorway. “Hey! Adora! We getting out of here or not? I think they’re mad about my hooves on the tiles.”

Moments later they were standing out next to the palace runestone. Adora wore a small pack of mostly food and water,

along with the communicator and, because Glimmer insisted, a pair of daggers shoved in her belt. Sitting astride Swift Wind, she looked down at Glimmer (and Bow, who'd followed Swift Wind), and smiled reassuringly.

"I'll be back before the week's out. Promise."

"You better be!" Bow said, looking cheery as always. "Otherwise I'll have to put up with Glimmer fretting."

Adora laughed at Glimmer's offended expression. "Ready, Swift Wind?"

"Hey, I've been ready to go all day." Swift Wind sounded a little annoyed, which was more or less par for the course when it came to Swift Wind in any kind of city. "Hold on tight now, you can't turn into a giant magical lady if you fall off anymore."

With a beat of his wings, he shot into the sky, and was quickly lost to sight. Adora was on her way to the Fright Zone.

Chapter End Notes

Adora, this is a sneaking mission. Try not to get caught.

A Business Partnership

Chapter Summary

> Entrapta lends a hand. Scorpia has a proposal. Catra has... insomnia.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra shot up in her bed, covered in sweat and biting back a scream. Her missing hand felt like it was on fire, and her eye throbbed mercilessly. She gulped in air and drew her legs up to her chest, willing her heartbeat to slow back down. It had been another nightmare about the tank. The screams of her crew echoed in her memory, and the mad dash she'd made, scrambling out the hole torn in the hull only to be blasted into the air when the tank detonated. Having calmed down somewhat, she hopped out of her bed and walked across the room to where a small sink jutted out of the wall. She filled a glass with water, went to turn the tap off with her missing hand, and felt like screaming. She did *not* feel like having to talk to Scorpia about why she'd screamed though, and so she kept quiet. The water was surprisingly good, lacking the oily taste she'd been accustomed to in the Fright Zone - Entrapta's doing, Scorpia had informed her.

Sleep eluded her for the rest of the night, leaving her staring with one good eye up at the ceiling. The other eye, her ruined eye, was covered by an eyepatch which she couldn't bring herself to take off, even asleep. It itched when she didn't keep it covered, she'd learned. The night crawled on interminably, and Catra's thoughts were dragged where they always went in the late watches of the night, when she was too exhausted and too vulnerable to care about her pride: Adora. Still, four years on, the wound that never quite healed, not even when Catra was riding high as Hordak's second in command, quietly making sure the soldiers - *her* soldiers - were better taken care of, establishing

squads that played to their strengths rather than sending them off to die unsupported and underequipped. Even as she felt a fierce pride every time an operation concluded with no casualties, even when she won shocking victories that kept the Horde from collapsing and earned Lord Hordak's praise, she found herself wishing she had Adora with her to see it.

Catra had thrown herself into building the Horde, and it had kept her from dwelling on it too much, but it was never enough. She still missed Adora. Now, she supposed, they were on the same side, sort of. Except, of course, Catra had rolled through villages left undefended, and seen civilians living in squalor. She'd even been thanked a few times, for running off some local governor or other who'd turned out to be an asshole. That the Horde was welcomed *anywhere* was a sign of how weak the Alliance's grip on their own holdings were - or a sign that the leadership was so concerned with the Horde they'd let anyone willing to pledge allegiance do whatever they pleased. Add to that the long history of Catra handing Alliance forces their own ass, and, well, it was doubtful she'd be welcomed with open arms anyway.

"An army without a kingdom, huh?" Catra muttered to herself. What was she supposed to do with that? She'd been greeted by a group of soldiers when they'd landed the night before, all of whom seemed to be of the opinion that Catra would have already had some kind of a plan. It had been Scorpia, of all people, who'd given orders to the soldiers regarding some operational plan and helped Entrapta hustle a still weakened Catra to the infirmary. Today, apparently, Entrapta would have some kind of a replacement for Catra's missing hand, or so she'd claimed. Something to look forward to, Catra supposed, although it wasn't helping her sleep at the moment. At least trying to come up with some kind of a plan distracted her from her usual late-night reminder of the fact that somehow, she still missed Adora's warmth. Except now she was thinking about that, and it just made her more frustrated, and if she could just… *sleep* instead of sitting here stewing in her regrets and trauma and guilt it would be nice. She focused on her breathing, and after what felt like far too long she must have fallen back to sleep for at least a little

while, because a polite knocking on her door brought her, bleary-eyed, into consciousness.

"Commander? I've got your hand ready!" Entrapta's voice chirped from the other side. "If you want, I can show you how it works so you can start getting used to it immediately."

Catra fumbled around for some clothing, mumbling a few swears as she did so. Once she had herself looking reasonably presentable, or at least presentable enough for Entrapta, she opened the door. Entrapta bustled in, cradling a mechanical hand in her arms. Catra folded her arms and eyed it dubiously. Inventions from Entrapta tended to fall into two categories: incredibly useful, or explosive. Very rarely, it was a combination of the two.

If Entrapta noticed Catra's apprehension, she gave no sign of it. "Without any real access to my old workshop, I haven't been able to pull anything more complex together, but those would've required implants anyway, and I assumed you might be a little hesitant to have implants after spending so much time under the knife lately, so…"

"Entrapta," Catra said, cutting her off, "Just show me how it works."

"Right, of course!" Entrapta lay the hand down on a desk standing in the corner of the room. "You stick your arm in this end," she started, grinning at the annoyed look Catra gave her. "There's a suite of sensors inside that will read your arm's muscle movements and translate them into, well, what they would be with a… normal hand. Er, sorry."

"As long as it works, I think you're forgiven." Catra said, reaching out to grab the hand. "I take it these straps are meant to go around my shoulder? Give it support?"

"Yeah, it's like a harness of sorts. And you'll want to put something over your arm to keep it from chafing. Keep the uh,

the… well, keep it comfortable. You know. I've got one right uh, here."

Catra reached out with her good hand and gave Entrapta's shoulder a comforting squeeze. "Hey, uh… I appreciate this. It's not… I'm sure it wasn't easy. You know, developing something like this."

"Oh it was easy enough," Entrapta said, seemingly torn between a desire to stay and see if the hand worked and the desire to get the hell out of what was obviously an awkward situation for her, "Try it on, I can make any necessary adjustments as you get used to it."

Rolling the provided… well, Catra supposed it was basically a sock, over her arm, she picked up the hand and slid her arm into the socket. It was a little snug, though she supposed it had to be. Entrapta showed where to fasten the straps, and Catra was relieved to see that it could be done one-handed. The idea of having to ask for help every time she put the hand on was… distressing.

"The power switch is here," Entrapta indicated, "and you don't have to worry about a power source. It's a kinetically charged battery - as long as you're moving around it'll naturally charge itself."

The hand was a red color, and the wrist of it was a ball joint that looked strange to Catra's eye. "I don't… how do I move?"

"Just…look at the hand and think about moving your fingers." Entrapta said.

The fingers wiggled a little. Catra balled it into a fist, then flexed the hand experimentally. "There's no sensory feedback?"

"No, that would require you to have a direct neural link with the hand," Entrapta said, conversationally, "I mean, we could try something like that further down the line, but we just don't have the resources for something like that right now."

“I see.” Catra said. “What’s it made of?”

“It’s a similar alloy to what we use in most of our melee weapons,” Entrapta said, “but I refined it down to something a little lighter. Should be able to stand up to any debris or uh, conventional projectile weapons. Put enough force behind it and you’ll cause some serious damage too - but you’ll also risk warping the joints and then the whole thing will need to be fixed, so don’t go trying to punch through walls or anything.”

Catra looked at the water glass she’d used the previous night and reached out to pick it up. The glass stayed firm under her touch, although she couldn’t feel it. She willed herself to squeeze harder, and it shattered, eliciting a squeak from Entrapta.

“Oh! Well, be careful about that too. Unless you meant to do that. But I can maybe wire in some kind of basic feedback - a rumble or something that lets you know if you’re really squeezing hard… oh, or maybe something like a little… hmm…” She whipped out a notebook and started scribbling in it. “I’ll see about making a few new prototypes.”

Catra stared at the hand again, the fingers twitching with subtle movements as she adjusted to the idea. “Don’t make it a priority,” she said, “I’m sure we’ve got other issues that are a little more pressing.”

“Whatever you say, Commander.” Entrapta said, cheerily ignoring the command and continuing to scribble down notes. “That reminds me! Scorpia wanted to see you once you were up and about. There’s a proposal she wants your input on.”

Catra nodded, as if that made perfect sense, then shook her head. “Wait, what proposal? The hell is she up to?”

Entrapta shrugged. “We’re all here for the same thing, Commander. Scorpia’s been putting a lot of thought into how to take the fight back to Hordak without our getting, you know, crushed.”

“Never figured Scorpia for much of a thinker, honestly.” Catra muttered.

This earned her a snort from Entrapta. “She pays a lot more attention than you give her credit for, Commander. You know she was one of Hordak’s favored Captains too, before all this happened.” There was a defensiveness to Entrapta’s tone that made Catra think she might want to drop the subject altogether. Or maybe apologize.

“Very well,” Catra said, stretching and looking for a jacket to throw on to hide the straps holding her hand to the rest of her, “Let’s go see what she has to say.”

Scorpia was sat at a desk that was slightly too small for her, looking over a stack of papers and frowning as Catra entered. Her eyes lit up as Catra entered, waving with her new hand. “Hey Scorpia,” she said, casual as anything, “Entrapta says you’ve got some kind of proposal.”

“Commander!” Scorpia bounded across the desk and wrapped Catra up in a bone-crushing hug that, for once, Catra endured. “It does my heart good to see you up and about, you really have no idea. I’m sure it gives the men hope too.”

Catra had noticed, as she’d made her way across the facility, that various Horde soldiers seemed to pause as she walked by and salute her. It was, she assumed, an old habit from the Fright Zone - you saluted the Commander as she walked by, and the gods help you if you didn’t. Catra had nodded at each soldier whenever it happened, and it was only now that any of it seemed strange to her. “Yes, I uh, I’m sure it did. Hell if I know why.”

“I told you the other day,” Scorpia said, in a patient tone, “you’re a hero to them. They thought - we all did, for a while - that we’d lost you. Yet here you are, walking and talking just like… well, not just like it never happened, obviously, but you know what I mean. Right?”

Catra, in what was becoming a regular occurrence, decided it was best to just nod. “Sure. Now what’s this proposal of yours?”

Scorpia nodded, and her manner shifted to something a bit more serious. “Well, as I told you, we’re out here on our own, and while we’ve got some resources coming in from teams out scavenging whatever they can find, we need more of… well, everything, really.”

“Food, water, shelter, that sort of thing?” Catra ticked each off on her new hand, and was briefly frustrated to discover that the thumb seemed a little harder to control than the rest.

“Well, yeah, plus more weaponry and manpower. We’re a group of about sixty, and that’s hardly going to put up a fight against Hordak’s forces. Or the Alliance forces, should they discover our location and decide to come calling.”

Catra frowned. “So what can we do? Scavenge harder? Ask for charity?”

Scorpia shook her head. “No, we trade for it.”

“We don’t really have anything to trade, do we?”

“Of course we do!” Scorpia said, seemingly surprised that Catra hadn’t figured it out yet, “We’ve got soldiers. Not many to start with, but more than enough to hire ourselves out as security, maybe pull some smaller-scale sabotage and espionage, heck, even assassinations if the job makes sense. We’ve got military expertise, and we can use that in trade for food, equipment, whatever else we need.”

“You’re talking about becoming mercenaries.” Catra stated flatly. “Sell our skills to whoever pays the most?”

“If that’s what you want to do. Or we take the jobs that *do* something. We’ve got men from the old intelligence unit who can get us work that’ll weaken Hordak’s organization, or even give the smaller players on the Rebellion side a little aid that can help keep

Brightmoon off our backs." Scorpia seemed incredibly pleased with herself. "Trust me, the Princess Alliance is no stranger to hiring people to do their dirty work - and if they're hiring us to do it, it means they don't see us as a threat. It might even give us some leverage in negotiations when we take down Hordak."

"Provided they never realize we'll probably also be killing their people when we need to, I assume?"

"Exactly. I'll admit Commander, I was never much for politicking, but you don't grow up a Princess and not learn how to play the game. Trust me," she said with a confidence that Catra had never seen before, "This will work. The more jobs we do, the more people will hear about our organization, and we can pull recruits right out of the ranks of the Horde and Rebellion armies. As long as we treat our men better than anyone else, and promise the chance to fight alongside the Commander."

"The Commander?"

"You. You're the Commander. I said you'd become something of a legend, remember? Even now, there's soldiers on both sides of the fight stuck with terrible leaders who don't know the value of a soldier's life - or maybe they just don't care. You *cared* , Commander. You cared, and you've gone toe to toe with some of the fiercest enemies the world's ever seen and come out on top. Hell, Hordak himself hasn't been able to kill you. That's a legend, Commander. That's you." With that, Scorpia fell silent, having seemingly delivered her pitch.

An army without a kingdom, Catra had said to herself earlier that morning. Stuck in the middle of a fight that she wasn't sure she believed in. All she knew how to do was fight, so why not fight on her own terms for once? It seemed like a pretty good idea, and hell, hadn't she already committed to vengeance on Hordak? Maybe there was even some kind of redemption to be found out there - a way to make up for the attacks on defenseless villages she'd led. Catra took a deep breath, and for the second time since

waking up, decided to go for it. “Okay Scorpia. What’s our first job?”

Chapter End Notes

It's coming along, I suppose. I started reading *Against the Day* again, to see if some of the tone of that rubs off on this - and to remind myself what good writing looks like. A bit of the ol' self-depreciation there.

Thanks to everyone who's left kudos and comments and stuff! They're all very good, and I'm thoroughly enjoying them. Do feel free to let me know how you think I'm doing! Next chapter will be up whenever it's done. We'll check in on what Adora's infiltration is up to. I don't know if we'll keep ping-ponging between viewpoints as the story progresses, but at least for now that seems to be the pattern.

Infiltration

Chapter Summary

> Adora has some suspicions confirmed, and hears some news that doesn't sit well with her at all.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Two hours in the Fright Zone was enough for Adora to begin thinking that maybe it had not been her best idea to come in alone without the Sword of Protection. Clearly a lot had changed in the three years since Brightmoon - one of those things happened to be, apparently, far more regular patrols of the border. Swift Wind had been forced to abort their initial approach, which left Adora to make the approach on foot. It had taken her nearly two hours of careful observation to find a gap in patrols long enough to make her move. Getting out would be be a problem, she thought, but if she was a little noisier during her exit it probably would not be much of an issue. Swift Wind would be able to get in and pull her out.

“Hey! Adora! Does this thing work? Do you have any idea how hard it was to make this work with hooves?”

Speak of the devil , Adora thought, and keyed her own transmitter twice to signal Swift Wind that she could hear him, but also couldn’t talk.

“Were you saying something? I couldn’t hear you!”

Adora keyed her transmitter twice again, rolling her eyes a little.

“I didn’t get that, you have to hold the button down to- oh wait we talked about this didn’t we? Okay well in that case, I’ll let everyone know you made it in. Did you make it in?”
Adora signalled an affirmative while suppressing a laugh.

Ridiculous horse. He was a nice distraction from the fact that anyone who got enough of a look at her to realize who she was would try to kill or capture her. It wasn't the most pleasant of thoughts, but the outskirts of the Fright Zone had plenty of places to hide. Catra had frequently found new places to hide every time they'd been ushered out of the main base on training missions, and the basic espionage training they'd received had given Adora enough experience to pick her way across what was a mostly ruined landscape.

It was difficult for her, now, to consider how she ever could have thought the Fright Zone anything even closely resembling a home. There was barely any vegetation in the harsh no-man's land that separated the edge of the Horde's territory and the Alliance, replaced instead by blasted craters and wire, interrupted by the occasional wreckage of vehicles or, sometimes, an old town. There were also, obviously, Horde outposts scattered across the landscape, from which regular patrols headed into the remote areas where, as it happened, Adora was trying to hide.

From where she'd arrived, Adora expected it to take at least two days to make it to the actual R&D complex on foot. That was assuming everything went according to plan, and the Horde hadn't relocated its labs in the last four years. Adora readjusted the straps on her pack and trudged forward. She'd changed into her old Horde uniform, in the hopes that it would at least allow her to blend in a little, but the pack on her back was not exactly standard issue. She'd need to stash it somewhere when she made it closer to the main facility.

The first day was, fortunately enough, uneventful. Adora made camp in a ruined building in a settlement near a copse of trees which seemed to offer more shelter than most. It was an area deep enough in Horde territory that it hadn't seen battle in a long time, allowing nature to recover and reclaim some of the buildings there. Adora carefully checked for signs of recent activity, and was briefly surprised to see signs of relatively recent occupation: a small bed, some discarded ration tins, and (most disturbingly) a pile of bloody bandages.

Are there people living off the Horde's radar in the Fright Zone? Adora thought to herself. There had been deserters of the Horde, of course, but the only reason Adora had ever heard of them was because they were inevitably dragged back in chains and publicly executed. It was part of recruit training, sometimes, to aid in the execution - something Adora had never had to do herself, thankfully. It had always been her assumption that if you got out of the Horde, you got all the way out - which is to say, you left the Fright Zone and hid somewhere else. Which, if you believed the Horde, meant you were dead within a few days as a roving Princess would murder you as soon as look at you.

It was, she assumed, possible that Horde deserters who believed the propaganda would necessarily stay within the Fright Zone's borders. Of course, judging by the state of the area, whomever had been hiding here had been captured or killed - there were clear signs of battle, and the area outside was scorched by plasma fire. Adora estimated it had probably happened close to a week ago, which meant, she hoped, there would be no Horde hunters swinging by any time soon. Cautious nevertheless, she spent some time setting up noisemakers at points of entry before she bedded down for the night.

Sleep was, as it turned out, a little more elusive than she hoped. Something about being back in the Fright Zone, she supposed, brought her thoughts increasingly back to Catra's fate. Was she alive? Had it actually been an accident, and she was recovering in the Horde's infirmary? Or had she crawled off somewhere and died, alone and wounded? If she had survived, but hadn't gone back to the Fright Zone for some reason, where was she, and why hadn't she tried to find Adora? She had to know that Adora would help, regardless of everything. Hell, Catra had exploited Adora's unwillingness to abandon her on a number of occasions, always to Adora's dismay. Which meant, as far as Adora could figure, that it was most likely Catra was dead or still with the Horde in some form or another. Either way, Adora thought, she would have an opportunity to find out one way or the other. Maybe she'd even have a chance to save her, make up for having failed to bring Catra along in the first place, something that Catra had certainly

never forgiven Adora for, and Adora, increasingly as the years went by, was unable to forgive herself for as well. Eventually, these thoughts finished running themselves around Adora's brain, and she fell asleep.

She was up with the sun, and after taking some time to get herself awake and fed, she shouldered her pack and set out again. Later that afternoon, she reached the edge of the massive junkyard that surrounded the Horde's primary headquarters, and heaved a sigh of relief. This was territory she was more familiar with. Mountains of junked equipment, training bots that had been too broken to bother repairing, and the occasional heavily decomposed corpse of some unfortunate cadet or guard who'd been caught in a landslide of shifting refuse. The Horde did not have a policy of giving funerals to those weak enough to perish in accidents, preferring instead their bodies would serve as a reminder of the importance of caution to others.

Adora was surprised to see signage warning about particularly dangerous areas posted throughout the yard as she moved through it. Judging by the illustration of a frowning Catra, Adora supposed it must have been her idea. The sound of bootsteps brought her to alert again, and she cast about, looking for a suitable hiding place. Unfortunately for her, she was more or less out in the open - the only cover available was a shallow ditch that, if she was lucky, would at least give her a chance. She scrambled into it, pulling her backpack over her in the hopes that it would pass for random debris and give her a slightly better chance. She drew the knives Glimmer had given her and desperately hoped she would not have to use them. It soon became clear there were two sets of boots - a basic security patrol, Adora thought. If it came to it, she could kill them both. The two guards, as they grew closer, were not paying much attention, if their conversation was anything to go by.

"You hear about that squad that deserted? I heard they've mobilized some of our best trackers to go after them."

"That's not much of a surprise. I heard they were some of the Commander's old honor guard."

"Disloyal dogs. They're sullying her memory by abandoning the Horde."

"Did you catch the execution of the tank squad that fired on her? Hordak pulled the lever himself."

"Of course he did! You saw how furious he was about what happened. The Commander's death was a shock to everyone, him most of all."

Adora had to bite back a cry. So, Catra was dead, then. Or at least, the part of her that refused to give up hastened to add, the Horde considered her dead. The news weighed her down, settled deep in her chest and stayed there. The conversation continued without her paying attention, and by the time her attention returned she wasn't sure what they were talking about.

"-that last engagement was a disaster, no two ways about it. Makes me glad I drew guard duty, you know what I'm saying?"

"Hush! You want someone to overhear that kind of talk? They'll have you brought up on charges of treason."

"Oh please, everyone knows the Commander's replacement isn't up to the job. The top brass is putting all their hopes on that fancy new weapon of theirs. Whatever the hell *that* is."

Adora's heart beat faster. So there *was* a new weapon after all - and it wasn't finished yet. That was something, at least.

"Wasn't that one of the Commander's projects? Who's running it now?"

"Hordak himself, if you believe the rumors. He's the only one with enough experience with First Ones technology."

“Surprised to hear it - he’s already taken over the Commander’s duties rather than replace her. Wonder where he finds the time.”

“Well, he said it himself. There’s no replacing Commander Catra. We’ve all got to try to live up to her…”

The voices faded into the distance, and Adora waited for another few minutes before emerging from the ditch. Immediately, she sholdered her pack and continued her journey. A few hours later, she caught sight of the massive edifice of the Horde’s main complex, and began heading in the direction of the R&D building. There was, she knew, an access hatch which led to the building ventilation and electrical conduits, some of which, she knew, were large enough for her to use. There was also a small storage shed which, at least four years ago, had been a good place to steal away with Catra in between training sessions. A secret place, just for them. The sun was setting, and Adora was tempted to keep going, but she knew she would need to rest if she wanted to be on her toes during what was, after all, the most dangerous part of the whole endeavor.

It was, perhaps, the universe taking pity on her, but the storage shed remained as disused and abandoned as ever. She took a moment to secure the area, then set up a small camp of sorts - really just a bedroll hidden behind some shelving. Then, it was just a matter of eating a small meal and resting until it got much later. As she slumped down on her bedroll and shut her eyes, the thought of Catra being dead seemed to jump out at her like some dreadful specter, and so caught her off guard that she started crying; a soft, stifled mourning of everything that had gone wrong between them, and everything that could have been if she’d just been smart enough to take Catra with her in the *first* place. It wasn’t right that Catra should have died on the opposite side of the battlefield, without Adora there to help her, to have at least had the *chance* to save her (or at least, a darker part of her thought, to die with her). Her grief exhausted her, and Adora fell asleep, to be wakened later by the soft chime of her alarm deep in the night, to begin her search.

She left her pack in the shed - it would only get in the way now - and slipped out into the darkness. A few spotlights made routine sweeps of the grounds, but their patterns were predictable and Adora slipped through easily enough. The access hatch was right where she remembered it, and it only took her a few moments to undo the (very basic, she thought) lock and slip into the ventilation tunnels. She had a mental map of the complex in her head, but after a short while moving with agonizing slowness through vents, it became clear they were not laid out in the same way as the hallways, and followed their own paths through the complex. Eventually, Adora resigned herself to dropping out of the vents and making her way through the hallways - which, of course, would only increase her odds of getting caught, but she couldn't afford to waste time.

Dropping into the hallway as silent as a cat, Adora quickly got her bearings. The main weapons development labs were on the floor above her, accessible via a lift or a stairwell - Adora took the stairs. She eased her way out into the hallway, dreading the sound of a patrol. So far, however, she'd been lucky.

Her luck ran out as she rounded the corner leading to the lab's main entryway. A lone Horde guard stood just in front of where she needed to be, casting his gaze down the hallway. Adora managed to duck back before he saw her too clearly, but there was the sound of a weapon being drawn and footsteps nonetheless.

"Who's there?" The voice had a commanding tone. "This area is off limits to everyone but Lord Hordak and his aides. Identify yourself immediately."

Adora's heart sank, and she drew her dagger. As the guard rounded the corner, Adora ducked low and got in under his defenses quickly. One hand covered his mouth, while the other pressed the edge of the blade against his throat. He had the good sense to go still and drop his weapon, then. Adora dragged him into the stairwell, where she suddenly let the knife go and, while he was distracted, choked him into unconsciousness.

You should have just killed him , a feline voice in her head said. *He'll wake up and they'll know someone was here. But you always were a softie, huh Adora?* Adora picked her dagger up off the floor, gripping the hilt so tight that her knuckles went white, and took a deep breath before heading back in the direction of the laboratory.

The laboratory was really more of a workshop - tables littered with guns and other weaponry in various states of assembly (or disassembly). Adora frowned - a lot of the components on the tables looked like First Ones technology, which was not good. The prize, as it turned out, was a massive cannon suspended from the ceiling. It was an energy cannon, that much was immediately clear - but it seemed far more complex than any Adora had ever seen. A set of schematics left carelessly strewn on a nearby chair provided the answer as to why. Someone had figured out how to produce an energy that would cancel out the energy produced by Etheria's runestones. Another note on the schematics caught Adora's eye:

Combining the cannon with the bipedal platform proposed by E. will provide the maneuverability/survivability necessary to get within range regardless of terrain (ref. report 1048: Whispering Woods Terrain Challenges for further discussion)

"Bipedal platform, huh?" Adora muttered to herself. "Don't like the sound of that."

She rolled the schematics up and thrust them through her belt. There was proof enough of her suspicions - and it included something to have the Rebellion's spies listen out for to boot. Adora glanced out the window and was dismayed to see the sky already beginning to take on the grey light of dawn. She'd have to hurry to get back out into the junkyard before sunrise where she'd have an easier chance of finding a safe spot to hide. Doubtless once the guard was discovered the whole facility would be on alert, making her exit even more difficult. Best to get beyond the walls, at the very least.

It was a lot easier when you had the keys to a skiff, huh? Catra's voice echoed in Adora's head. *Of course, you were never up for taking a joyride. Well, except once* . Adora shook her head again. She'd pushed herself too far, eager to get in and out, and it was coming back to haunt her.

It didn't take her too long to get out of the R&D building and back to the storage shed. She transferred the schematics into her pack and headed out, moving as quickly as she dared. The sun was just beginning to peek over the horizon when she dropped on the other side of the wall, back in the familiar wasteland of the junkyard. Luck was with her once more, as she was able to find yet another one of her and Catra's old hiding spots and, from the looks of it, nobody else seemed to have made the discovery. Adora curled into a ball and was asleep within seconds.

Chapter End Notes

I actually wound up cutting this chapter a little short. We'll deal with Adora's exfiltration in the next chapter.

There was a draft of this where the words Metal Gear were uttered in an incredulous voice, but I just... I don't know, it would bother me to make the connection that explicit. While I am just having a grand old time essentially doing a crossover fic, part of me wants to keep the serial numbers filed off, because it would just... sound wrong. Does that make sense?

There was also a draft of this where Adora straight-up *murdered* that guard, but again, it felt too out of character for her. I mean, she's killed people - in this very fic, no less - but that was on the battlefield, not sneaking up on a dude and knifing him in the brain, you know? I'm discovering that I have drawn all sorts of arbitrary lines in the sand with this. This is because I am a ridiculous person.

Thanks for reading! And commenting! And leaving kudos! I enjoy your comments as much, if not more, as you enjoy this nonsense I'm writing!

Flight

Chapter Summary

> Adora needs very badly to get out of the Fright Zone. Catra helps, sort of.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The sound of heavy footfalls roused Adora from sleep to a full, adrenaline-filled alertness within thirty seconds. She rolled over into a crouch, grabbed the two daggers, and listened with baited breath. Shouted commands echoed through the air urging a thorough search of the grounds, and Adora found herself cautiously creeping up to the entrance to her hiding spot to take a look around. The immediate area looked clear, but from the sound of things a search team was coming dangerously close to her location. She had a choice to make: either she stayed, and hoped that nobody found her, or she set out moving as fast as she could and hoped to outrun pursuit.

If you stay, she thought, *you might as well slit your own throat and save them the trouble. Horde trackers aren't known to be bad at their jobs* .

There wasn't really much time to decide, so Adora went with her gut, grabbed her pack, and took off. She moved just short of a sprint, knowing that breaking into a run would only give the trackers a more obvious path to follow. As it was, she had to balance moving swiftly with being careful not to leave traces of her presence - difficult to do when the ground was mostly dirt. At least it hadn't rained recently - it would make things slightly easier - but she'd still need to do something to put them off her trail sooner rather than later.

It was probably inevitable that she'd be spotted at some point, at which point it would no longer matter how fast she went. The

trick would be making sure that when that happened, it was on her own terms. As Adora moved through the junkyard, she kept an eye out for a good spot to set up an ambush.The junkyard had plenty of spots for an ambush, but it was also too close to the main headquarters for comfort. She'd need to stay ahead of them until she got further away - if, of course, she could maintain her current pace.

How long can you run, Adora? Catra's voice echoing in her head again, *And at what point will you not have enough energy to fight?*

Adora hated to admit it, but the voice had a point. She cleared the perimeter of the junkyard and took off at a proper run now, not bothering to worry about leaving a trail to follow. If anything, she *wanted* a trail, wanted to be able to lead the Horde trackers right where she wanted them. Trouble was, she didn't quite know where she wanted them, yet. The land outside the junkyard was mostly open plains and the odd patch of brambles, along with a few small streams, none of which were particularly good places for an ambush.

Beggars can't be choosers, Adora.

She made for a small copse of trees. It would be far too obvious, she knew, but the trackers would have to enter it or risk losing her trail. They would be expecting an ambush from above, and the longer she didn't attack, the more anxious they'd become. If the trail led them out untouched, they would likely drop their guard a little, assuming she was too busy fleeing to worry about ambushes. Which was precisely why Adora waited for the group to pass completely through to the other side before she rose up from the small ditch she'd dug for cover like some kind of creature from hell and went to work.

It was a team of four - two in front and two behind - armed with projectile weapons and stun batons. The trick was going to be avoiding the stun batons, which would fry her without She-Ra's resistance to help cushion the blow. Fortunately, nobody had their

batons out, figuring, most likely, that they would start fighting at range (or more accurately, that they would be able to shoot her down without having to fight at all). It ended up being a costly mistake. By the time they realized what was happening, Adora had already sunk her dagger deep into the back of one soldier's neck, dropping him with a wet, choking sound. Before they realized they were under attack by an assailant that was already in melee range, Adora had redirected the shot from one into another, and the squad of four was now a squad of two, one of whom had finally managed to pull their stun baton, the other who was furiously trying to backpedal to draw a bead on her.

The baton-wielder swung out, a panicked blow that still managed to graze the side of Adora's head, and the shock staggered her for a moment. She allowed her momentum to carry her to the ground just as she felt a bullet whizz overhead. A surge of anger went through her, then, at these soldiers trying to kill her, at the organization they represented that had taken so much away from her. Her daggers found the stun-baton soldier's legs, then, as he screamed and bent over, found his throat. The soldier with the gun took a few steps back at that, and Adora took advantage of his fear to charge forward with a guttural yell. Panicked, the soldier squeezed off a few shots, but before he could effectively cause any real damage, Adora was driving her daggers into his chest, following his body to the ground. She rolled forward and sprang back to her feet, then pivoted to face the woods and stood there, panting as the combat high began to bleed out of her system.

A burning pain in her side let her know that at least one shot had found its mark, and the blood on her hand when she pressed it to her side confirmed it. She'd been reckless, charging like that. There wasn't enough time to see to the wound properly - it was a sure thing the Horde would eventually notice a team of their trackers had failed to report back in, and she needed to be far away by then. She wiped her daggers off, then bent down and cut a strip of cloth off one of the fallen trackers' uniforms to make a crude bandage which she wrapped tightly around her waist. While she was at it, she took one of the projectile throwers as well.

They seemed a bit crude for the Horde, Adora thought, but it made sense if you wanted to send troops out on long engagements in foreign territory. One of Catra's ideas, Adora assumed - one of the things that had surprised Adora in the years spent fighting her friend was the surprising pragmatism she displayed in the equipping of her troops.

Thinking about Catra just made Adora's chest ache in a way that had nothing to do with the wound to her side, and she shifted her focus to getting as far away as possible before exhaustion (and her wound) caught up with her. She set off at a fast pace, trying her best to ignore the way her side felt like it was on fire. Still, she managed a good pace for the greater part of the afternoon before a wave of dizziness washed over her. The makeshift bandage was soaked through, and she was sweating profusely. There was another copse of trees, and she made her way there on increasingly unsteady feet. Her foot snagged on a root and she went crashing suddenly to the ground, where she lay there, feeling her senses slowly dim as unconsciousness took her.

Her eyes snapped open at the sound of a familiar tread on the ground. A set of feet sticking out of what might have at one point been called stockings, if stockings had enormous holes ripped in them by claws, came into view and stopped.

"Hey, Adora. Looks like you're in a bit of a spot, huh?" Catra loomed over Adora's prone form, an eyebrow raised and an amused expression on her face.

"Great," Adora muttered, "Of all the people to show up, it was always going to be you, wasn't it?"

Catra crouched down and looked over Adora with a critical eye. "You know, you pushed yourself way too hard back there. Not that it wasn't an impressive fight, but… you probably could have gotten away with hiding, you know?"

Adora levered herself up on her side to better face Catra, and stared into her mismatched eyes. "This isn't real," she said quietly,

“I’m delirious, or dreaming.”

“You always were quick on the uptake,” Catra said dryly. “I’m dead, remember? And you… well, you’re not dead yet, but if you don’t pull yourself together and wash that wound, the resulting infection will sure as hell kill you.”

Adora winced again as she levered herself up into a sitting position, removed her pack, and slumped against the same tree whose roots has been responsible for her tripping. She began to peel the makeshift bandage off, hissing as the crusted blood pulled away from her skin. Catra winced in sympathy.

“I'm pretty sure it's not as bad as it looks, but all the same… That looks pretty bad.”

Adora huffed slightly. “Thank you for pointing it out. I wouldn't have noticed otherwise.”

“Hey, I'm your hallucination, Adora. You obviously noticed it.”

“Thank you for reminding me that I’m hallucinating,” Adora sniped back, “it’s really helping.” Before Catra could respond, Adora cut her off. “And yes, I know that it’s me reminding myself I’m hallucinating. Let me have this.”

Catra shrugged. “It’s your hallucination. Have at it.”

Adora poured water over the wound, gritting her teeth as she did so. The water ran red, and then ran red, and for the sake of variety, faded to clear as she cleaned the wound. It looked ugly - a neat hole that ran right through her abdomen. Catra looked in and whistled low.

“I take it back, it *is* as bad as it looks.”

“If you’re not going to help,” Adora said testily, forgetting for the moment she was talking to herself, “then at least keep the commentary to a minimum.”

Catra shrugged again, and remained silent while Adora dug some gauze out of her pack, along with a small metal rod containing a switch. She flipped it and, after a few minutes, the tip began to glow red. Adora took a deep breath, gritted her teeth, and jammed the glowing tip into the wound. Her flesh smoked, and she bit back a scream unsuccessfully.

She must have passed out for a moment, because suddenly Catra was slapping her face. "Hey! Wake up! You aren't allowed to die here, Adora!"

Adora focused in on Catra's face. "Crap. It's gotten worse, hasn't it?"

"You think?" Catra crossed her arms and stood up, looking around worriedly. "Get a fresh bandage on and get up, I'm sure someone heard you screaming earlier."

Adora quickly packed the wound with gauze, then wrapped a fresh bandage around her waist. Using the tree as support, she levered herself into a standing position, swaying slightly. Catra nodded in approval and helped Adora get the pack on. Her hand lingered on Adora's shoulder, and Adora closed her eyes for a moment, savoring the touch.

"I miss you, you know? Even after everything we've done to each other."

"Yeah," Catra said, quietly, "I know. Get moving, will you? I don't want you to die in the fucking Fright Zone."

Adora nodded, drank the remainder of her water, and started moving. There was, she knew, a river within a few miles where she could replenish her supply. Her fever did not seem to have gone down, but the wound in her side wasn't bothering her too much, and some reserve of strength seemed to be driving her onwards for the moment. Catra kept pace beside her, but said very little, apart from the occasional word of encouragement.

When Adora saw the glint of sunlight off the water, she quickened her pace.

"Good! You can refill your water and maybe cool that fever of yours a little." Catra grinned. "Plus, there's an old settlement nearby. You can get some proper rest and get the hell out of here by tomorrow."

Adora knelt on the riverbank, refilled her canteens, and dunked her head in the water. She was disappointed, upon resurfacing, to find that Catra had disappeared. Alone, and feeling foolish for feeling like what had been an hallucination was anything but that, she continued to the settlement Catra (*no, you remembered it yourself*, Adora thought angrily) had remembered being in the area. Another four years of disuse hadn't made it any more livable, but it did provide Adora with some shelter. She went to contact Swift Wind, to let him know that he could pick her up tomorrow, but only then did she notice it had been shorted out by the stun baton strike.

"Guess it's all on foot until I can reach a Rebellion settlement." Adora muttered to herself.

"Looks like it," Catra said, appearing suddenly.

"Great," Adora said, "I guess my fever's spiked again."

"Yes, but look on the bright side," Catra said, "You can sleep it off now."

"Or I'll end up dying."

"Honestly? I don't think you're gonna die here, Adora. Your wound is cleaned, and with a little rest, you'll be… well, not *great* , but rest is what you need. I mean," gesturing at herself, "If I'm here, you know there's a problem, right?"

"I wish you were here," Adora said, feeling her eyes start to burn, "If you were here, I'd just… go. Take you with me. You and me

could just… we could just go somewhere else, away from everything, and figure our shit out.”

“It’s a nice dream,” Catra said, wistfully. “But it’ll have to happen in another life.”

“I’m sorry,” Adora said, drowsily, “I’m so sorry. I never should’ve...”

She fell asleep, with tears still running down her face.

Chapter End Notes

> The specter of continuity basically demanded that I continue directly from where the last chapter left off. We'll check in with Catra (the real one, not the hallucination) next chapter, I think.
>
> I promise I will stop making Adora miserable eventually.
>
> As always, thanks for all the kudos and comments and such! I am delighted to #engage with you. Please #enjoy my #content.
>
> EDIT: Tightened up some bits here and there, because I am procrastinating.

On the Job Training

Chapter Summary

> Catra does some light recruiting near the border between the Horde and the Alliance.
>
> Also some assassination.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Alright Commander, the drop's coming up, so let me go through this with you one more time," Scorpia's voice crackled in Catra's ear as the skiff shot through the air, "Your target is a small-time administrator named Thaddeus Kerroweigh. He runs a small outpost that ostensibly serves the Princess Alliance, but the plain fact of the matter is that he'd fit in better with the Horde."

"A would-be emperor, huh?" Catra snorted derisively. "Why doesn't the Alliance put someone else in charge?"

"The Alliance is just happy that he claims to hate the Horde."

Catra's hand balled into a fist reflexively. "Ah, of course. As long as he's not on the Horde's side, he's free to do whatever he likes."

"Pretty much. Our client - or should I say *clients* - are a group of residents that have had enough. In return for taking care of their problem, they've agreed to provide us with shelter and supplies. Sort of a forward operating base for sending operatives into the Fright Zone. Plus-"

"It lets other settlements in similar situations know there's a solution to their problem." Catra finished, cutting Scorpia off. "I get it."

"Exactly!" Scorpia sounded immensely pleased with herself.

“Does our boy have a retinue I need to worry about?”

“His loyalty to the goals of the Princess Alliance,” Scorpia said, somehow managing to not sound like she was being sarcastic, “has earned him a squad of soldiers - no idea where their loyalties lie beyond the Alliance, but it might be worth trying to avoid an engagement with them if possible.”

“What, you think we can convince them to join up?”

“Or at least look the other way when our people pass through.”

Catra shrugged, then remembered Scorpia was sitting in an office on base and not in the skiff and couldn’t see her. “Worth a shot, I suppose.”

The pilot’s voice broke in. “This is as far as we go, Commander. We’ll keep circling until you call for exfil!”

Catra nodded, took one last look over her equipment, then hopped over the side of the skiff. She landed in a low crouch, grinning. Her rehabilitation had gone well so far - her legs, at least, did not seem to have lost much of their old strength. The arm - she was still having trouble thinking of it as *her* arm - had required a few adjustments from Entrapta, but it more or less functioned well enough for Catra’s purposes. She’d brought a stun baton, knife, and, though she hoped it wouldn’t come to it, a rifle slung over her back. Catra had never been one for ranged weaponry - and she hadn’t quite gotten used to aiming with only one eye yet - but she appreciated its uses.

The skiff drop point was about half a mile from the town itself, so Catra set off in a loping run for the outskirts. It felt good to run again, to remind herself that she was still capable of something. That was, she suspected, part of why Scorpia had insisted on Catra doing this mission. It wasn’t just a way of announcing their new organization’s existence, it was a way of getting Catra back on her feet. Catra was, at least, self-aware enough to realize that she needed it. Really, they all needed some kind of proof Scorpia’s

idea would work. Certainly seemed like a sound theory, based on what Catra had seen herself.

The settlement was, Catra noted, poorly-defended to begin with. Apart from a basic stockade to keep any wild animals out, it lacked even rudimentary guard posts, and the squad of soldiers appeared to be keeping to a compound in the center of the settlement. It took Catra less than an hour to determine that Thaddeus had two bodyguards, neither of whom seemed to be particularly observant. Or, at least, it seemed like little enough happened in the settlement that they didn't seem to be on edge. As for Karroweigh, Catra disliked him almost as soon as she saw him. He strutted about with the self-assurance of the untouchable, dressed in clothing that was much nicer compared to the other residents, and looked, as it happened, far better-fed to boot. It was completely unsurprising. He too did not appear to be particularly paranoid, which suited Catra's purposes just fine. She found a nice rooftop to sit on, and waited for the majority of the town to go to bed.

Once most of the lights had gone out, Catra made her move. She dropped to the street level and began making her way to the administrator's house. There was a pair of guards standing at the main entrance, looking bored and half-awake. Catra could have killed them easily, without too much fuss, but Scorpia's suggestion that the soldiers might be as grateful for the removal as their clients would be echoed in her mind. Sighing, Catra readied her stun baton. She flicked it on and then threw it as hard as she could. It connected squarely with one guard's temple, sending him to the ground. The other guard took a moment to realize what was happening, which was all the time Catra needed. She charged in, and in a few seconds had her hand across his mouth, and her knife to his throat.

"I'm going to take my hand off your mouth in a second, and you're going to tell me if there's anyone else inside apart from your boss. If you call for help or try to raise any kind of alarm, I'll end you. Nod if you understand."

The guard nodded.

“Good.” Catra said, and removed her hand. “Now talk.”

“There’s kitchen and serving staff on the lower level. His bedroom’s on the second floor, end of the hallway. One guard, no other way in or out of the room, unless you fancy climbing through the window.”

“I *do* fancy, as a matter of fact.” Catra purred. “No other guards around the perimeter?”

“Two more at the back entrance on the south side, but his room’s on the east side.”

“This was very helpful,” Catra said, tightening her grip, “But I’m going to have to put you to sleep now. Remember, I could have killed you.”

The soldier went limp, and Catra dragged the unconscious duo around the side of the building where they were a little less obvious. Then, she sized up the wall. It was, to her delight, very climbable. Or at least, it would have been very climbable if she’d had both her hands and wasn’t forced to use the prosthetic with its fatter fingertips and vexing lack of claws. As it was, the climb was far more of a struggle than it should have been. Catra perched on the sill and eased the (unlocked, of course) window open.

Karroweigh was snoring, sprawled across the bed. Catra watched him for a few moments, thinking. She’d never assassinated anyone before, though she’d obviously ordered an assassination or two in her time as Hordak’s second in command. Actually doing the deed herself seemed to carry a greater weight. She should, Catra thought, have performed an assassination before ever ordering one. It only seemed appropriate.

Catra advanced slowly and quietly, drawing her knife. Time slowed down the closer she got to the corpse-to-be. She stilled her thoughts, stilled her heart, slipped into the same space she’d go

to in a battle where there was only her and her foe, and one had to die. The blade glinted in the moonlight. Catra drew the blade swiftly across Kerroweigh's throat, and used a pillow to muffle the gurgling sound he made. After a few seconds he stopped thrashing. Catra stared at the door to the bedroom, waiting to see if the bodyguard had noticed the noise. Nothing. She waited a few minutes more, just to be sure. She could feel the blood on her knife hand starting to grow tacky, and mechanically wiped her blade on the bedsheets to clean it.

Exfiltration was a simple matter of climbing back down - which, if Catra was being honest, she could have done by just jumping out the window if she'd really needed to. Climbing was quieter, and carried less risk, and (more importantly) she needed the practice. By the time she reached the ground, her arms were on fire, the straps from her prosthetic were digging into her skin, and she'd had to rely far more on her right hand than she'd done in the past. The two guards from the main entrance were still unconscious, right where she'd left them. Catra resisted the urge to give them an affectionate pat as she walked by.

Rounding the corner, Catra came quite suddenly face to face with a lone soldier. It was a young, tired-looking woman, wearing a uniform that was falling into disrepair. A short ponytail stuck out in a too-familiar manner, reminding her of Adora. Maybe that was why Catra hesitated to drop into a fighting stance immediately. The soldier, to her credit, did not hesitate. Immediately, she had her rifle up and aimed directly at Catra's head.

"Who are you? What are you doing here out after curfew?"

Catra quickly considered her options, and then shrugged and raised her hands to show she meant no harm. "Didn't know there was a curfew, to be honest. Just passing through."

"Nobody out here's just passing through." The soldier took a few steps forward, squinting to see Catra's form in the dark.

“Can’t see to well in the dark, can you kid?” Catra said, conversationally. “Might make it difficult to hit me if I decide to fight after all.”

In response, the soldier took a few more steps forward, which was precisely what Catra had been hoping for. With a few deft movements, she stepped forward, grabbed the rifle by its barrel, and delivered a blow to the soldier’s chest that caused her to stagger back, losing her grip. The soldier came in with a low sweep that Catra hopped over, but the soldier allowed the momentum from the sweep to carry her body around and up into a spinning backfist that Catra only barely got her arm up to block in time. There was a metallic clang and the soldier cried out in pain and alarm, giving Catra time to spin the rifle around and point it at the soldier. The two stared at each other, breathing hard.

“Not bad, kid.” Catra said, after a moment. “You came in too hard, though - didn’t see what you were hitting. How’s your hand?”

The soldier, who had until this moment been cradling her hand, dropped it and stood up straighter, staring defiantly back at her. “If you’re going to kill me, get it over with.”

Catra raised an eyebrow, then grinned. “I’m not going to kill you, kid.” To demonstrate her sincerity, she flipped the rifle around and offered it back to her. “There’s no reason for you and I to fight. I’ve already done what I came her to do, and you don’t have a boss to protect anymore.”

There was a moment of confusion on the soldier’s face, and she took a step back as realization hit. “You’re… you’re *her* .”

Catra’s arm was starting to get tired from holding the rifle out, and it seemed like the soldier wasn’t going to take it, so she let it drop. “Who am I?”

The girl spoke in a small voice. “The Commander of the Horde. Hordak’s Right Hand. You’re supposed to be dead. That’s what

they said."

"Well," Catra said, gesturing at her eye and arm, "they were partially right. But it's just Commander now. I don't work for the Horde."

Confusion again. "Then why…?"

"Did I kill the administrator here? I was paid to. Plus, I don't think anyone will miss him that much." Catra leaned in, maybe a little too close, almost daring the soldier to hit her. "I mean come on, was this what you signed up for? Guarding some asshole in a border town, watching him abuse his power, all because someone above you decided that as long as he claimed to be against the Horde it was okay?"

The soldier stiffened. "Those were my orders."

"And you've carried them out. But eventually," Catra said, quieter now, "eventually, those orders are going to ask you to do something abominable, and they won't say why. And if you fail, they'll leave you. And if you succeed, they'll bury you so nobody will know they told you to do it. Because they're supposedly the *good* guys, remember? When that happens, you'll have to decide where your loyalties lie - either with your comrades, or with the mission, or maybe to an ideal."

"Why are you telling me this?"

Catra thought about this for a while. Eventually, she said, "Because not knowing almost killed me, and you're a good soldier. You've got potential - and I need soldiers like you."

The soldier's eyes narrowed. "If you think I'm going to join the Horde…"

"The Horde tried to kill me." Catra said, rolling her eye in exasperation. "I'm building something different. If you're interested, find me. Ask around, find out who hired me, and get in touch. But for now…" Catra tossed the rifle back to the soldier,

“you’ve got a choice to make. Go check on your comrades, or shoot me.”

Then, in what she was sure was the dumbest thing she’d ever done, Catra turned her back on the soldier and took off down the road, heading for the settlement wall. Fortunately for her, the soldier hesitated just long enough for Catra to disappear back into the darkness. Within a few minutes, Catra was outside the walls and on her way to the exfiltration point. A quick call summoned the skiff, and Catra climbed aboard.

The pilot looked back as she strapped into a seat. “Commander! How’d it go?”

“Success. Have our representative make contact with the clients and make sure they hold up their end of the deal.” She keyed the radio, calling Scorpia. “Scorpia, we might have someone asking around about the company soon. I assume you’ve got a way for them to be vetted before we go bringing them out to the facility?”

“Come on, Commander, I know you trust me more than *that* .” Scorpia replied. “We’ve got a few false fronts set up that they’ll come in through. After we’re sure they’re not a threat, we bring them out.”

“I knew I could count on you, Scorpia,” Catra said, grinning to herself, “We’re on our way back. See you in a few.” Clicking the radio off, Catra looked back in the direction of the settlement. “Good luck kid,” she muttered, “You’re gonna need it.”

Chapter End Notes

> This is the part where I admit that coming up with a way for Catra to recruit people that didn't involve like, strapping fultons to them and then essentially interrogating/brainwashing them into service or whatever the precise mechanics in MGSV (and Peace Walker) are took a shocking amount of thought. In the end, I figured her charisma would do the work. It gave me a chance to have

Catra feel sad about Adora for a bit too, so you *know* I had to take that opportunity.

Anyway, this is also the part where I say "oh shit I have to finish some stuff on the not-fanfic thing I do if I'm going to stick to my schedule for that, so this is probably gonna go dark for a month or so."

As always, your comments and kudos and just, you know, silent watching without commenting or kudosing are tremendously appreciated.

Old Friends

Chapter Summary

Adora runs into some old friends.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

When Adora woke, she wasn't sure to be disappointed or not that Catra was gone. She was also dreadfully thirsty, and her side felt awful. There were also, damnably, the sound of footsteps approaching, which meant she needed to be up and back on the run quickly. She downed some water and started moving, wincing at the way her bandages shifted and tugged at the wound. They'd loosened while she slept, apparently, but there was no time to fix it.

In fact, there was no time to leave either, as she discovered. When she exited the building in which she'd taken shelter, she ran almost headfirst into a group of three Horde soldiers. Instantly, she dropped into a fighting stance and, with a confidence she did not feel, shouted, "I've already killed four of you. I don't want to kill more."

The shortest of the Horde soldiers cocked its head to one side, then reached up to remove its helmet, revealing the familiar face of Lonnie.

"Adora?"

Adora stepped back in surprise. "Lonnie? You're a tracker?" Then she shook her head and was back to her threatening posture. "I'll still kill you if I have to. Don't make me."

Lonnie, in response, raised her hand and the two other soldiers removed their helmets as well, revealing the faces of Kyle and

Rogelio. “Of course we’d run into you,” Lonnie said, sighing, “It’s been that kind of day.”

“Hi Adora!” Kyle said, waving. “We’re deserting!”

A light clicked on in Adora’s brain. “You’re who they were talking about. Catra’s old honor guard.”

Lonnie rolled her eyes. “Honor guard? They’ve been gone for weeks. We’re just grunts, same as always. You really think they’d make Kyle an honor *anything?* ”

This earned a displeased noise from Rogelio and, in spite of herself, a chuckle from Adora. Then, because she had to ask, because if she didn’t ask she’d never forgive herself, she asked the question she didn’t want to ask. “Is it true? About Catra, I mean.”

A look passed between the three deserters, and Lonnie’s expression became decidedly uncomfortable. “I… uh, yeah. I mean, yes. She’s uh. She’s gone.” Then, upon seeing the way Adora’s expression crumpled, she hastily added, “Sorry.”

Somehow, Adora managed to control the shake in her voice. “Thanks. I heard some soldiers earlier and… I had to be sure.” Then, perhaps luckily, a twinge in her side caused her to wince and briefly distracted her. Lonnie peered closer.

“You’re hurt.”

“I told you,” Adora said, gritting her teeth, “I killed four trackers yesterday. Wasn’t a perfect performance, though.”

Lonnie gestured to Rogelio, who unslung his pack and pulled out some bandages. “We’ll patch you up. We’ve got better odds of getting out of here if we stick together.”

Adora waved him off. “I’ve got my own supplies. I’ll take care of it.”

Lonnie rolled her eyes. “Four years and still gotta prove you can do it all by yourself, huh?”

“I just… you don’t need to worry about me.” Adora said, defensively. “I’m fine.”

“No she isn’t!” Catra said, appearing perched on Rogelio’s shoulder. “Oh wait, they can’t hear me. Accept the help, Adora. I thought you were past this.”

Adora closed her eyes and took a deep breath. Exhaling slowly, she nodded to Rogelio. “Sorry. Thank you for the help.”

Lonnie looked at Adora with a piercing gaze, as if she’d heard Catra’s voice. “Glad you’re seeing reason.” she said, finally.

Rogelio quickly had the old bandage off. When he saw the cauterized wound, he clucked disapprovingly, and began to properly clean the wound. Adora bit back a hiss of pain and, to distract herself, asked Lonnie another question. “Do you know where you’re going? I can get you to a Rebellion settlement, they’ll put you up as long as you’re cooperative.”

“We’re not going to the Rebellion.” Lonnie said, a little curtly. “No offense, but… I don’t think some grunts are going to be get any kind of a warm welcome over there.”

“Then where are you going?” Adora asked, confused.

“Somewhere else.” Lonnie said, a little too cryptically for comfort.

“Somewhere else?”

“Somewhere else. There’s... “ Lonnie paused, as if debating how much to say. “We aren’t the only ones leaving the Horde. There have been quite a few since Catra died.” Adora winced, either from hearing the words or from Rogelio’s ministrations, as Lonnie continued. “There’s a place for us, or so the rumors say. Away from this war. Away from fighting battles we don’t want to fight. Where we can choose to be soldiers. Supposedly.”

"So you're chasing a rumor?"

Lonnie shrugged. "It's only a rumor if it turns out not to be true. But last week I ran into a fellow I'd not seen since Catra died while out on patrol. He'd been there, and was back here recruiting."

"Recruiting?"

"Well, more like he'd heard people were defecting and wanted to offer assistance. Same thing if you ask me."

"So where are you heading, then?"

Lonnie gave an almost apologetic look. "I can't tell you." At Adora's quizzical look, she clarified. "That's part of the deal. You're uh, not exactly unaffiliated. The price of entry, so to speak? It's leaving your old loyalties behind."

"You think I'm a threat?" Adora said, curiously. "Why would I be a threat?"

Lonnie shrugged. "You aren't really a threat, but… you telling the Alliance there's a group of ex-Horde soldiers running around with no affiliation and hey, here's their location is a threat."

"The Alliance wouldn't -"

Lonnie cut her off. "They would, Adora. Whatever you're about to say they wouldn't, I can *assure* you they would. We wouldn't be left alone, and that's why I can't tell you. But until we part ways, it'll be nice to have you along." Rogelio finished his work and stepped back. Lonnie nodded approvingly, then looked back at Adora. "So, you coming, or what?"

Adora nodded, and grabbed her own pack. Rogelio had indeed done an excellent job of dressing the wound, and the pain had actually lessened somewhat. "Just like old times, huh?"

Lonnie snorted. “Yeah, except I don’t have to listen to you and Catra flirt with each other.”

“I never *flirted* with Catra!” Adora said hotly.

“Yes you did.” Lonnie said.

“Yes you did.” Catra added.

Adora crossed her arms and tried not to blush too much. “Whatever,” she said, a little flippantly, “It’s not like it matters now, huh?” As soon as she said it, she felt the loss anew, and her expression soured somewhat.

Lonnie gave Adora another long look. “Yeah, I guess it doesn’t.” She turned her attention to the others. “Kyle! Stop daydreaming and get that patrol schedule out. We need to know how much time we’ve got to get across the border.”

Kyle saluted and quickly produced the schedule in question. “According to this,” he said, “we’ve got about an hour before the next patrol’s scheduled to come through here. If we hurry, we’ll stay ahead of them all the way to the border.”

Lonnie tossed Adora the helmet she’d been wearing. “I’m pretty sure word of my defection hasn’t gotten out yet, but your face is a little too well-known. If we run into any other soldiers, let me try talking to them before you go all Little Miss Stabbypants on them, okay?”

Adora nodded and slipped on the helmet, and the group moved out at a rapid pace. They walked in silence, mostly, pausing now and again to double-check their bearings. It really did feel like one of their old training missions, except for the obvious absence of their fifth member. Which was, Adora thought wryly, sort of even more accurate, as Catra had a habit of disappearing during their training expeditions to find a spot to nap or some other place to explore.

Lonnie was apparently having similar thoughts, because she spoke up again. "You remember that huge storm we got caught in during training? Out on the open plains with all that lightning around us and Catra just kept cursing at you for refusing to turn back?"

"We were closer to our destination! It didn't make sense to turn back. She just didn't want to have to make camp while it was raining." Adora said, smiling a little at the memory. "I thought she might never talk to me again after that. As it was, I think that's the angriest I'd ever seen her. Well, until… you know."

"Yeah." Lonnie said, quietly. "You know we all hated you for leaving, right? And not just because I had to take orders from *Catra* , of all people. You left us behind with Shadow Weaver. Wasn't until Catra took her down that things started improving."

"I know," Adora said, resisting the urge to shout about how the Horde was evil. "I think that's what Catra never forgave me for. But I couldn't go back. Not after I saw what the Horde really was. Not even for her."

"Hey, you're talking to someone defecting from the Horde. You don't need to tell me what the Horde really is." Lonnie said, holding her hands up. "Hell, Catra knew too. The only difference is that you left, and she ended up trying to make the best of it. You could have done the same, you know. I think that's what she wanted, even if she never said so."

Adora sighed. "No, she did say so. Multiple times. And I said so too, but… then I didn't." Her shoulders slumped. "Can we please talk about anything else?"

"What," Catra said, *sotto voce* , "you don't want to just really open those old wounds again?"

Adora almost forgot Catra wasn't real for a second, and was glad she was wearing a mask so Lonnie couldn't see her face. Lonnie, for her part, shrugged and began filling Adora in on the political

situation in the Horde instead. “Honestly, I don’t know how they come back from losing Catra. She was probably the best thing to happen to the Horde in ages. Certainly gave Shadow Weaver a run for her money, I’ll tell you that much for free.”

Adora felt curiosity take over, and asked, in spite of herself, “What exactly did she do that made her so… respected?”

This got a laugh out of Lonnie. “I know, ‘respected’ and ‘Catra’ weren’t two phrases I thought would ever go together, but… she implemented better training programs. Ended all the harsh punishments Shadow Weaver was so fond of doling out. It wasn’t just that stuff either; even our food got better with her in charge. She prioritized keeping the grunts,” here Lonnie gestured to herself, Kyle, and Rogelio, “in good health and didn’t send us out underequipped. These rifles we’ve got were developed by one of her crew - they’re easy to keep in working order and you can even modify them with a bunch of crap depending on what kind of mission you’re being sent on. The uh, results are the same as the old weapons too, except without the risk of it overheating and blowing up in your hands. We had actual strategies in combat, and maybe most importantly, she knew when to sound a retreat. Shadow Weaver would just feed us into the meat grinder until she ran out of soldiers.”

“I heard from a soldier that she was trying to end the war.” Kyle piped up. “Like, they said she was gonna convince Lord Hordak to make peace.”

Rogelio made a snorting sound conveying what he thought about the odds of *that* particular rumor being true were.

“Yeah, I don’t know about that one,” Lonnie agreed, “I mean, Catra is… well, *was* , I guess, a great soldier and commander. I don’t know how good of a diplomat she was. At any rate, Hordak’s not ever going to stop until he’s got the whole planet under his boot.”

“So why not fight against him? Why not join the Rebellion?”

Lonnie rolled her eyes. “Gods, did you try giving this speech to Catra every time you fought? No wonder she was always trying to kill you. Look, let me explain this one more time, so maybe you’ll get it: even *if* the Rebellion was somehow interested in doing anything with a couple no-name Horde grunts beyond throwing us in prison for war crimes, we’d just be tools for another cause, and then what? I have to kill a bunch of my old comrades? I end up getting killed by some Rebellion soldier with a score to settle? I’m *done fighting on other people’s terms*, Adora. We all are. I want to live somewhere apart from this war, and if I pick up a weapon again it’s because I’ve got something I believe in enough to fight for it.”

Adora frowned, but some part of her knew Lonnie had a point. If not for the fact that the Sword of Protection had chosen *her* , would the Rebellion really have taken her in? Would she have the sort of position she had now - and even with that position, she still found herself getting trotted out at diplomatic events while other soldiers took the risks She-Ra should have been taking.

That seemed to end the conversation, and they trudged on in silence, broken only by the occasional instruction from Kyle. Eventually, they caught sight of one of the border outposts, and Lonnie called a halt.

“You’re *absolutely certain* you’ve got the patrol schedule right Kyle?”

“Yes ma’am! If we cut across here,” Kyle indicated a spot on the map a few kilometers away, “the patrol from this outpost will miss us entirely. We’d better hurry though - we’ve got a pretty narrow window.”

Lonnie nodded. “Good. If you’re wrong, I’m letting them shoot you.” She looked over at Adora. “Think you can manage a run with that side of yours?”

“Do I have a choice?”

Lonnie chuckled grimly. “Not really.”

Adora nodded. “Then I can manage it.”

It was, Adora thought later, one of the hardest things she’d ever done. They ran for barely thirty minutes, but somewhere in the run her wound re-opened, and she felt her strength sapping from her rapidly. Stubbornly, she kept running, not caring that she was leaving a bloody trail for anyone who cared to follow. They crossed the border without incident, and just to be safe, kept moving until they were well away. Eventually, Lonnie called for another halt and turned to Adora.

“There’s a Rebellion settlement about ten klicks that way,” she said, pointing to the northwest. “I assume you can get in touch with your friends or whatever there. This is where we part ways. If we see you again, well, hopefully we’re not on opposite ends of a battlefield this time, eh?”

Adora nodded, swaying slightly. “Thanks. I uh, I don’t know if I would’ve made it out without you.”

Rogelio hissed and pointed to Adora’s shirt, which was stained a deep red. Lonnie’s eyes widened. “Rogelio, go ahead and patch up the Princess one more time, huh? A final favor. In return, we’d appreciate it if you don’t try to follow us.”

“Don’t worry, your secret’s safe with...” Adora said, and then paused, shaking her head. She saw Catra rushing in to catch her. The world tilted sideways and she hit the ground with an audible thud.

The next day, Adora woke up in a Rebellion settlement’s hospital. She was surprised, when she asked how she’d gotten there, that nobody seemed to remember who’d brought her in.

Chapter End Notes

It's Lonnie, everyone! Also those other guys.

I don't know why I like the idea of Rogelio as a medic, but I do.

On a whim, I went through the first mission of MGSV again recently (I got a new video card and wanted to see the pretty pretty lighting effects). I've also been playing some MGS4, which gave me some more thoughts about some other things to add here and there. We'll see how it goes. I still don't have a lot of this stuff worked out, beyond "how do Catra and Adora meet again" and "do they fuck."

I guess there's some stuff about sticking a Metal Gear in there too. I mean, Adora's got those plans. Probably should've asked Lonnie about them, huh? Guess you were too busy reminiscing and bleeding everywhere. Tsk tsk.

As always I live solely off your comments and kudos. If you wanna talk about how great Liquid Ocelot making gun noises at the end of Act III is, we can do that too (it's REAL GOOD).

Diplomatic Toolkit

Chapter Summary

> Adora returns to Brightmoon with everything she brought out of the Fright Zone.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The first thing that happened when Adora landed in Bright Moon was that she was nearly tackled by a teleporting Glimmer. “I’m so glad you’re okay!”

Adora hugged back, wincing at the pain in her side. “Sorry to cause so much worry. My communicator was broken, so I couldn’t even check in.”

Bow joined in the hug, rushing in with an overly dramatic sob. “We were all so worried!”

Adora savored the feeling of being back with her friends for a moment, before she remembered that she was, in fact, back from a mission. “I need to speak with your mom, Glimmer. With everyone, really. I was right. The Horde’s developing a new weapon.”

Glimmer’s expression turned grim. “She’s waiting for you. Let’s go.”

Queen Angella did not quite manage to hide the relief in her eyes when she saw that Adora was in fact alive and well, or at least well enough to stand on her own two feet. “Adora. Report.”

Adora stood ramrod straight and began speaking, holding her arms behind her back. “Infiltration was successful, and confirmed my suspicions. There is a large effort underway in the Horde to complete the construction of a new type of weapon, being headed

up by Lord Hordak personally. The plans," here Adora dug into her pack and removed the prints she'd taken, "show a mastery over First Ones technology I've not seen before. There's also a reference to a new platform for the weapon - a bipedal system for movement, but I wasn't able to find any further information on that."

Angella frowned deeply. "This is troubling news. It seems the Rebellion is once again in your debt, Adora. I'll have our researches start looking over these plans immediately."

"Our intel teams should probably see what else they can dig up, now that we know what to look for." Adora added.

"Of course." Angella nodded, and then dropped some of the formality in her voice to ask, "How are you holding up? I heard you were wounded."

Adora mustered a reassuring grin. "I've had worse. A little time with the Sword of Protection and I'll be fully recovered."

An unreadable expression flickered across Angella's face, then was replaced with a gentle smile. "I'm glad to hear it. I daresay the Rebellion would find itself in dire straits without you."

"Just doing my part, your majesty." Adora bowed low. "If there's nothing else, I think I'll get some rest. It's been a long few days."

"Of course, dear. I hope you'll join us later for dinner?"

"You know me, your majesty. I'm not one to miss a meal."

Angella laughed. "How could I forget? Dismissed, Adora."

Glimmer and Bow flanked Adora as she walked out of the throne room. As soon as she was back in the palace hallway, she slumped against a wall and exhaled deeply, hand drifting to her still-wounded side. Immediately, Glimmer was there, face full of concern.

“Are you okay?”

“I’m fine,” Adora reassured her. “Just… tired.” *and grieving, and wounded* , she didn’t add. “Not being able to become She-Ra was… difficult.”

“Back to a mere mortal, huh?” Bow asked, jokingly. “I can give you tips. The secret is, have a lot of cool arrows.”

“I'm not that good of a shot, really.” Adora replied, and glanced over at Glimmer. “Those daggers you gave me turned out to be useful, though.”

“I should've made you wear more armor.” Glimmer said, frowning, “It would've kept you from getting hurt.”

“Or the extra weight would've made me too slow and noisy, and I would've been in even worse trouble.” Adora said, placing a reassuring hand on her friend's shoulder. “It doesn't matter. I'm back safe and more or less sound, and we got important information about what the Horde is up to. I'm comfortable calling this a win.”

Glimmer didn't look particularly reassured, but nodded anyway. “Well come on, we'll help you back to your room. You can tell us how the whole trip went, if you want.”

The urge to avoid the topic of the mission entirely had been growing steadily in Adora's gut since she landed. Something about the way Glimmer had reacted to seeing the dead on the battlefield where Catra had died made Adora want to shelter her from it. Like talking about gutting four Horde soldiers might make Glimmer think less of her, or cause her to be frightened of her. Glimmer was, after all, not well-acquainted with fighting up close. Her powers were better suited to ranged combat, where she didn't have to get blood all over her. Adora envied that, sometimes. *But that's how you were trained, Adora. Hand to hand is the basis of all combat, remember? Only a fool trusts their life to a weapon.* Glimmer wouldn't understand.

Come on, Adora. You're going to drive yourself crazy if you don't talk about this to someone. Hallucinations of your dead friend don't count.

"I… I think that might be good." Adora said, finally. "At least it will keep me from sleeping through dinner, right?"

The trio headed for Adora's room, where Adora quickly shucked her pack and flopped down on her bed with an audible sigh. Her eyes fluttered closed for a moment, and she let out a breath it felt like she'd been holding for the better part of a week.

"So," Glimmer said, "tell us everything."

Adora did not tell them everything. She did detail the approach, and the whole infiltration, but she left out the part about the soldiers discussing Catra's death. When she described her flight from the junkyard, Bow whistled low.

"How many tracker groups do you think they sent after you?"

"Enough to make hiding impossible," Adora said, "but I guess I'm not sure. I only really encountered one group. That's how I ended up hurt."

"How big was the group?" Bow asked, ever-curious.

"Just four. Horde trackers travel in groups of four - two in the front, two in the back. I was lucky I managed to get the drop on them." Adora hesitated, and then went into a recounting of the fight, trying not to notice Glimmer's look of shock. "The last guy managed to get a couple shots off before I got to him. I'm lucky he panicked, or he might have actually done some real damage."

There was an extended silence after she finished. Eventually, Glimmer spoke up. "Adora, I'm so sorry. That… that can't have been easy."

Adora felt a flash of annoyance. "It's no different than what I do every time I'm out there as She-Ra. Close combat is just a reality

of war."

"That doesn't make it easier! It's...brutal!"

"If you were going to be horrified by me stabbing people, you should've started four years ago!" Adora snapped. "This is how I was trained, Glimmer! It's what the Horde made me! I'm a weapon! They've taken *everything else* from me!" There were tears in her eyes now, but she barely noticed them.

Glimmer and Bow both looked back at her, deep concern etched on their features. It was Bow who spoke up first. "Adora, what *happened* out there?" Hesitantly, he put a hand on her shoulder. "You can tell us."

Adora, already exhausted, angry, and a million other emotions she couldn't name, slumped forward, burying her face in her hands. "She's *dead* ." she finally managed to choke out. "She's dead, and it's because of this fucking war, and the fucking Horde, and I couldn't save her, because she was on the wrong side."

Understanding dawned on her friends' faces. "Oh, Adora," breathed Glimmer quietly, "I'm so sorry. I never… I know she was important to you."

"Yeah," Adora said, feeling a deep exhaustion, "she was."

"We're going to beat them." Glimmer said, quietly. "It won't bring her back, but… we'll get revenge, at least."

"Weren't we going to do that anyway?" Bow whispered, a little too loudly.

Adora let out a huff of laughter. "You're bad at this." It felt good to make any kind of joke at all, even if some part of her felt guilty. Hadn't she just been crying? Adora felt like she might fly apart at the seams, and took a second to try to pull herself back together.

"Hey, Adora." Bow said, after a moment. "You're going to be okay. You know that, right? You're strong, and Glimmer and I are here

for you. We'll make it through this together, okay?"

Adora desperately wanted to believe him, but something deep within her wouldn't let her. Still, she appreciated the gesture, and gave a shaky smile. "Yeah. We'll be okay." She stood up suddenly. "I should get cleaned up before dinner, huh?"

Glimmer gave her a concerned look. "Are you sure?"

"Yeah, I'm only just now realizing how gross all this travel has gotten me." Adora said, making a face. "I haven't really had a chance to freshen up since… when I left. The medical center wasn't particularly concerned with cleaning anything that wasn't," she gestured to her side, "this."

Still clearly not quite buying it, Glimmer nevertheless nodded and stood to leave. "Alright. If you need anything, let me know, okay?"

Adora gave a reassuring smile. "Of course, Glimmer."

Bow waved and with a cheery "bye, Adora!" headed out. Glimmer gave Adora a hug and headed for the door too. She hesitated at the doorway, and looked back over her shoulder at Adora.

"The Horde hasn't taken everything from you, Adora. You still have me and Bow. Don't… don't forget that, alright?" There was a fragility to her voice that broke Adora's heart.

"I won't." Adora said, her own voice a little shaky. "I promise."

Adora stripped down and padded into the washroom, where she hopped into the shower and almost immediately felt her muscles relax. For a while she simply stood, watching the water running down the drain move from a reddish brown muck to clear. She focused on the sound of running water, letting the noise blot out thought and feeling, letting her exist in an isolated moment where nothing else existed, where it was impossible to tell if it was tears or just the water from the shower running down her face. She slowly came back to reality, washed, and reluctantly stepped out

of the shower. She dressed slowly and deliberately, forcing herself to focus on each motion, stopping her thoughts from running wild.

Dinner was equally relaxing. Adora savored the food, grounded herself in the reality of things, kept the conversation light. Yes, it had been a long time since she'd had good food. No, the rations weren't terrible, they just got old after a couple of days. Yes, she'd been very lucky someone had found her and brought her to that settlement. No, she didn't know who (*why am I lying? "Because you promised to keep them out of it, remember?"*).

At the end of the meal, Queen Angella folded her hands and smiled. "We are glad to have you back, Adora. I'm sure you're tired, so I'll not keep you here with more questions - but before I forget, we have some representatives from one of our larger settlements visiting tomorrow. If you're feeling up to it, I'm sure they'd love to meet the mighty She-Ra."

Adora knew that she didn't really have much of a choice in the matter, and for the first time in a long time, that thought bothered her. She smiled, nodded, and said that of course, she would make the effort to be available. Lonnie's voice echoed in her head. "We'd just be tools for another cause," she'd said. *Is that what I've become?* Adora thought. *Am I just a prop?* She excused herself, claiming exhaustion, and headed back to her room. Sleep came quickly, and when she woke, Adora almost felt like she was back to normal.

The feeling lasted until she had to transform to She-Ra and meet the representatives from the settlements. Queen Angella had implied, politely, that appearing as She-Ra was far more effective in building relationships rather than appearing as Adora, because many would still distrust a former Horde soldier no matter how many years she'd been fighting for the Rebellion. From almost the first moment she felt the rush of power flowing into her limbs, something felt *wrong* to her. More than ever, she felt the split between herself and the She-Ra… program, she supposed. The wound in her side disappeared, leaving only a phantom pain that reminded Adora of the fact that at one point, for one moment,

she'd fought like she'd been trained, using her own skill instead of this *thing* that took over and used her as a host to programs of combat expertise. These victories were not her own. Her body wasn't her own in these moments either, not even when she was striding about shaking hands and mouthing pleasantries to representatives, listening patiently as they complained about deserting troops and low morale.

"We really must insist that you *do* something, your majesty," one was saying, "our border administrator was *murdered* , in his room, while guards stood outside the door and did nothing! Now the townsfolk are saying they will not accept a replacement, and have already elected their own leader!"

"If the people have already found a new leader, why would they need a new administrator?" Adora asked, forgetting for a moment that it was not her place to do so.

The representative who'd been speaking, an odious looking man with pasty skin and matted hair, smiled thinly. "Princess, if we allow the people to choose their own leaders, they may choose the wrong leader. They lack the ability to see the big picture, and could even be a Horde sympathizer!"

"But they would likely know what the needs of their community were a lot better than an outsider, wouldn't they?"

The smile grew even thinner. "The needs of their community are secondary to the needs of the Rebellion. Surely you understand."

Adora opened her mouth to respond, when Glimmer suddenly appeared at her side. "She-Ra! I'm sorry to interrupt, but something's come up and we need your input."

Nonplussed, Adora nodded. "Of course. Excuse me, gentlemen."

The two teleported away, reappearing in the hallway outside the reception hall. Glimmer looked a little embarrassed. "Sorry, I thought you were about to kill that guy."

“What? Don’t be ridiculous.”

“You’re still making a fist so hard your knuckles are white.” Glimmer pointed out.

“Oh.” Adora said, looking down in surprise. “Thanks, I guess.” She shook her head and, after a second, dropped She-Ra’s form. “What did he mean, ‘they lack the ability to see the big picture?’”

“He means that it’s not someone he has influence over.” Glimmer said, a little acidly. “The administrator was one of his people, which gave him greater say in what went on in the region.”

“So all that about possible Horde sympathizers and ‘the big picture…’”

“Was bullshit, yeah.” Glimmer shrugged.

Adora frowned. “I don’t understand. What does more influence get him?”

“People giving him gifts to gain his favor.”

Adora discovered a newer, deeper level of frown than she’d previously known existed. “So he’s just looking to keep power so he can get more stuff.”

“Pretty much.”

“And we can’t replace him because…?”

“Because,” Glimmer said, in a patient tone, “he has a lot of trade agreements with other settlements, which we need in order to keep our troops supplied. Like I said, politics.”

An unpleasant conclusion was forming in Adora’s head. “So… does that mean we’re going to send in more troops to ‘pacify’ the settlement and put someone else in control there?”

“I don’t know. Maybe. It depends on how big of a stink he raises with my mom. If he threatens to pull out of the Rebellion over it, we might have to.”

“If he tries to use us to attack our own people, I’ll kill him myself.” Adora said, feeling a sudden ferocity that was, perhaps not entirely her own. “I won’t let us become the tool of some would-be strongman.”

Glimmer tried, unsuccessfully, to hide her shock at Adora’s statement. “Hey, don’t worry. I’m sure it won’t come to that. We could even send you there to check things out and make an assessment. The word of She-Ra does carry a lot of weight, after all.”

“Of course,” Adora said, managing to keep the bitterness she felt out of her voice, “she’s a valuable propaganda tool.”

“Right!” Glimmer nodded, unwilling or unable to catch Adora’s hidden meaning. “I’ll talk to my mom about it once this stupid meet and greet is over.” She gave Adora’s shoulder a reassuring squeeze. “Come on, I think we can probably get out of here. You’ve put in enough of an appearance, and I know how much you hate this stuff.”

Adora smiled, feeling relieved. “Thanks Glimmer. I don’t know what I’d do without you.”

“Punch visiting dignitaries, apparently.” Glimmer said, giggling. “How about we punch some training equipment instead, huh?”

“You know me so well.” Adora said, feeling her mood lighten.

For the next few weeks, Adora avoided training as She-Ra.

Chapter End Notes

I apologize for the absolutely *shameless* Metal Gear Solid quoting in this one. I'll do better next time.

Which, speaking of next time, I guess we'd better see what Catra's up to, huh?

Someone (namely me) has to set these two on a collision course, after all.

Ground Rules

Chapter Summary

Catra explains things to some of the recruits. Lonnie gets a surprise.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The sound of shouting woke Catra from what had been a fairly restful sleep for once, and it took her a moment to realize she'd fallen asleep in her office, rather than in her bedroom. This had the benefit of meaning she didn't need to put her arm on before she dashed out to see what the hell was going on. It was, unsurprisingly, a fight between a few of the newer recruits - a former Horde and Rebellion soldier were fighting. The ferocity between the two combatants indicated whatever the fight was about was likely personal, but Catra didn't care. She was between the two in a flash, and quickly had both combatants dazed on the ground within seconds.

"Enough!" She roared, feeling her anger flare. "Your old conflicts and allegiances mean *nothing* here." The assembled soldiers looked at her, wide-eyed. "The price you paid to join me was to leave everything behind. You are not Horde, nor are you Rebellion. You are soldiers with no loyalty to any kingdom, any nation, any empire. The Horde and Rebellion took things from everyone here - myself included - but it no longer matters."

Catra paused, looking around the group which had swelled in size. She strode over to where the Rebellion's soldier still sat on the ground and offered her hand to pull them to their feet. "Your only loyalty is to one another. You are not here to fight each other. You are here to fight *for* each other. No soldier here will undertake a mission they do not wish to take. No soldier needs to undertake a mission at all. You will not need to serve under me, but you may

serve with me, if that is your desire. If that is not, you can still have a place here, provided you abide by our code and leave your old loyalties behind. That is my only requirement. Now," she said, breathing heavily, "if you still have a score to settle with the Horde, or with the Rebellion, settle it with me. I'll be at the training grounds for the next two hours. After that, your anger and your old loyalties are dead."

Without bothing to wait on any responses, Catra strode off. She arrived at the training grounds and began running through various warm-up exercises. Eventually, a small group of four soldiers arrived. They were, Catra knew, all former soldiers of the Rebellion. She walked to face them, utterly unafraid.

One, an older-looking man with a close-cut beard and a haunted look in his eyes, stepped forward first. "My wife died in a Horde raid. I was working as a personal bodyguard for a Princess and couldn't even make it back to our village in time for the funeral."

Catra nodded. "What was the name of the settlement?"

"Colonia."

"I remember the raid." Catra said, after a moment. "It was not meant to be so… aggressive. No," she said, holding up her hand, "I know it doesn't help to say so. Come, then. Take your revenge."

The fight did not last long. Catra allowed him to land a few blows before she took him down with a series of jabs that left him on the ground. She knelt with a surprising gentleness on his throat, and asked, "Enough?"

With a glare, the old man nodded. "I yield."

Catra stood, and helped him to his feet. "I expect the same aggression and fire against all other combatants you face."

The old man staggered off the field, and Catra turned the other soldiers. "Who wants to be next?"

Another soldier stepped forward. The process repeated itself. Catra fought, and fought, and kept fighting. She drew on what felt like a bottomless well of energy, powered by her own rage at herself, at Hordak, at Adora, at the First Ones. By the time the fourth fight was over, Catra was bloodied, but still standing. A crowd had gathered to watch, but nobody else seemed willing to step forward.

Then, just as Catra was beginning to think that was actually it, Scorpia walked forward. Catra couldn't stop herself from grinning.

"You know," she said, "I wondered if you'd show up."

Scorpia grinned, and gave a somewhat sheepish shrug. "The Horde took everything from me. It took me a long time to realize that. Then they tried to take *you* from me."

"I know." Catra said. "Are you ready?"

Scorpia looked concerned. "Are you? You don't have to do this, you know. It's not on your shoulders."

"I know," Catra said again, "But I made the offer knowing you might do this, and here we are."

Scorpia nodded, and then charged with a ferocity that almost caught Catra completely off guard. Catra knew that Scorpia was deceptively fast - her bulk was complemented by a speed that was just short of terrifying. Still, Catra had the edge in agility, which allowed her to duck under and out of the way of the first few blows. Catra took her time, carefully watching for any openings - knowing that Scorpia's claws gave her an enormous defensive advantage. Catra would need to act fast to get any solid hits in. For a while, neither managed to land a hit at all, although Catra did manage to use one of Scorpia's arms as a boost to somersault over her. Unfortunately for Catra, she'd briefly forgotten about Scorpia's tail, and wound up having to dodge that rather than take advantage of Scorpia's exposed back. It was around then that the four previous fights caught up to her, and for

a split second she faltered just long enough for Scorpia to land a solid blow that rattled Catra's teeth. She flew backwards into the dirt, but was quickly back on her feet and circling.

"Feel like giving up yet, Commander?" Scorpia grinned, evidently having a wonderful time.

"Please, that was barely a love tap." Catra replied with a grin of her own, and closed to attack once more. This time, she managed to get in under Scorpia's arms and landed a few blows to her midsection that caused the ex-princess to double over. A vicious uppercut snapped Scorpia's head back, but she used the momentum to execute a backflip that whipped her tail up and scored a hit up Catra's side. Catra winced and staggered back, with Scorpia closing to finish her off. Catra's stagger turned out to be a feint, however, and as soon as Scorpia reared back for a haymaker to finish the job, Catra dove between her legs, rolled, and then pounced right on Scorpia's back, putting her into a headlock. One foot stamped down on Scorpia's tail to keep it from moving, while the other kicked out one of her knees, forcing her down.

Scorpia, however, was not so easily defeated, and drove her elbow into Catra's already-injured side, freeing herself. The battle went until Catra was barely able to stand, having exhausted every ounce of energy. Scorpia went for a finishing blow, then pulled up short.

"Sorry Commander, but I'm going to have to call this off. It wouldn't be fair to win this way. Besides, I think Entrapta's already going to kill you for letting yourself get so hurt." She frowned. "Probably gonna kill me too, honestly."

Catra bent over, breathing heavily, and flicked her gaze upward into Scorpia's sheepish face. "Fair enough. How about you and I help each other to the infirmary and we call it a draw, huh?"

"Sounds good to me, commander."

The crowd of soldiers departed, a few pausing to congratulate Catra on her fights. Catra waved them off. “It wasn’t about winning or losing,” she said to one such comment, “it was about continuing to fight regardless.”

A familiar voice called out as the duo made their way down the hall. “Catra? Shit, I thought you were dead!”

Catra looked around and, still leaning heavily against Scorpia, waved to the just-arrived Lonnie. “Sorry to disappoint. I’d give you a tour, but I think Scorpia and I have a date with the infirmary and her sure-to-be-angry partner. You can come yell at me for being alive later.”

Scorpia called over a few soldiers and had them show Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio to the barracks. Entrapta was, as suspected, fairly annoyed by Catra’s decision to fight recruits.

“I know you had a successful mission and all, but you’re still technically recovering. Plus, I *just* patched you back up.” She rummaged through the supplies for a needle and thread. “I’m more of a machinery person - all this blood makes my skin crawl.”

Catra rolled her eye. “You know we had some medics arrive recently. You could have them patch me up if you dislike it so much.”

“Nonsense! This is excellent practice!” Entrapta waved her hand dismissively. “And it will remind Scorpia not to do this again, because I'm going to do her stitches without anaesthetic.” When Scorpia blanched noticeably, Entrapta added, “That was a joke. Although, I am going to kill you if you do this again. I know the common wisdom is that women are into scars, but I'm not that into them so stop collecting them, got it?”

Scorpia gave a sheepish nod, which seemed like the response Entrapta was looking for. Catra winced as a deep cut was sewn up, but the process was over fairly quickly. Entrapta stepped back, looking satisfied with her work.

“How did the hand work out for you? Any damage to that?”

Catra raised the hand in question, offering it for inspection. “Seems fine to me. Probably a good thing I didn't have the clawed version on for this, to be honest.”

“The claw variant is *made* for hand to hand combat. Honestly, I would've preferred it. This one's not as sturdy.” Entrapta peered closely at the hand. “Run through the routine for me, please.”

The routine was a series of finger motions which Entrapta had taught Catra for diagnostic purposes. Catra performed it dutifully, one round slow, one fast.

Entrapta hummed to herself. “Ring finger's a bit sluggish. Maybe some minor servo damage. I can take care of that in a jiffy. Scorpia, can you grab the - ah, yes, that's it. Thanks.” Entrapta made some adjustments to the knuckle joint and seemed satisfied. “Okay, run through it again.”

Catra obliged, noticing Entrapta’s delighted expression as she did so. “Better?”

“Yep! You’re lucky I’m so good at this.”

“Good.” Catra stood up from the table, still feeling a little shaky. “I’ve got some job offers to look over. Scorpia? See me once Entrapta’s had a look at you.” She headed for the door, then, because she couldn’t resist, added, “Entrapta? Try not to spend too much time ‘investigating’ her, if you could.” A look back at the blush on Scorpia’s face was enough to cause her to burst out in laughter as she exited the infirmary.

As she rounded the corner, Catra almost ran straight into a scowling Lonnie. “Well I’m glad *someone* finds this shit funny, because I sure don’t.”

Catra raised an eyebrow. “You're going to have to be a little more clear, Lonnie.”

“You’re supposed to be dead!” Lonnie said, jabbing a finger into Catra’s chest. “We mourned you! All of us! The whole fucking Horde! And you’ve been alive this whole fucking time?”

Catra batted Lonnie’s hand away irritably. “I didn’t have much of a choice, Lonnie. Hordak wanted me *dead* , you think I was gonna just walk back into the Fright Zone and ask how everyone was doing?”

There was a long pause. Lonnie blinked in surprise. “Hordak wanted you dead?”

“Yeah, he did. Entrapta heard him giving orders to a tank crew to take out my command vehicle. Said I was a threat to the stability of the Horde, and they bought it.” Catra seemed a little confused. “I kind of figured that was why you came here.”

“No, I just… didn’t trust the changes you made to stick around.” Lonnie said. “Heard there was a place where we could go, and off we went.”

“Well, I’m glad you’re here regardless.” Catra said, grinning. “For starters, Entrapta could probably use Rogelio’s help in the infirmary. Plus, you know, I didn’t *completely* hate you guys.”

“Speaking of people you didn’t completely hate,” Lonnie said, casually, “We ran across your girl while we were leaving the Fright Zone.”

“She’s not ‘my girl.’” Catra snorted, trying to ignore the way her heart jumped. “The hell was She-Ra doing running around the Fright Zone?”

“No idea,” Lonnie said, “But she wasn’t She-Ra, and she’d killed a squad of scouts. She was wounded, too. Rogelio patched her up.”

Catra made a mental note to thank Rogelio later. “Interesting,” she said, somehow managing to keep her voice from shaking, “did she give any indication as to what she was doing there at all?”

“Whatever she’d done, she was leaving the Fright Zone when we ran into her. We helped her get out and left her at a settlement near the border after she collapsed on us.”

Catra realized she’d been digging her claws into her palm to stay calm as she listened to Lonnie, and covered up the fact by bringing her hand up and coughing into it. “A shame she didn’t say what she was up to. We could use any information on Rebellion activities we can get.” Deep in thought, she almost forgot Lonnie was still standing there. “Maybe one of our intel teams heard something…”

“Uh, what?”

“Hmm?” Catra snapped back to reality. “Oh, uh, don’t worry about it. Do you have any ideas on what you want to do here?”

“Figured I’d maybe join up with the foraging and farming team.” Lonnie seemed almost embarrassed to admit. “Not for nothing, Catra, but I’m not much of a fan of fighting.”

“Hey,” Catra said, laying a hand on her shoulder reassuringly. “We don’t make anyone fight here. Your contribution to the cause is appreciated no matter what it is. Now, if you’ll excuse me, I’ve got some more work to do.”

With a sort of half-wave, Catra strode off the hallway. Just as she was about to round the corner, Lonnie called after her. “She asked about you, you know. Wanted to know if the rumors were true or not. Took it pretty hard when I told her you were, well, you know.”

Catra froze, and stood there for a while. After a few seconds, she sighed heavily. “Probably for the best. I don’t think she’d understand what we’re doing out here.”

If Lonnie thought differently, she didn’t say so.

Chapter End Notes

A little shorter chapter, mostly because the scenes all flowed together and then I got to the last line and was like "well that seems like a good place to stop" and tried starting a new scene and it just felt like a *bad plan*. So you get this chapter instead, and we'll stick with Catra and the gang for another chapter.

A lot of cool ideas floating around there in the comments! Fun conversations! It's where all the cool kids hang out! I am legitimately flabbergasted by the amount of comments and kudos and general support for this thing I'm doing, which is to say 'writing very conceptually silly fanfic that takes itself seriously.' Like, legitimately I am deeply flattered and humbled and boy it's a good thing nobody's drawn fanart of this because then I might Actually Die.

I'm going to go play through Ground Zeros again now, I think, because I beat MGS4 over the weekend and man, I love Peace Walker but I hate having to boot up my PS3.

Organization

Chapter Summary

> Scorpia has some ideas. Catra gets a little catharsis. The recruits prove useful.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“Remind me again why I decided this was a good idea?” Catra groaned as she attempted for the hundredth time to focus on the supply report sitting on her desk.

A noticeably rumpled-looking Scorpia grinned in what, Catra assumed, was meant to be a reassuring manner. “Because destroying Hordak and rubbing his defeat in the Rebellion's face will be delightful?”

“Hmmm, you've got a good point there.” Catra took another look through the supply report. “So… I don’t actually know what any of this stuff means.”

Scorpia laughed. “It means that currently, we’re bringing in more than we need. That said, we’ve got a fair few people making their way through our vetting process, so I don’t know how long that will last.”

“Still mostly ex-Horde soldiers?”

“Mostly. I don’t think the Rebellion really knows we’re a going concern at the moment. Well, apart from that settlement you went to.”

“Hmm. I guess we can’t exactly go handing out business cards, huh? We’re not strong enough to hold off any attack yet, and we don’t have good enough intel on the Rebellion side yet to give us any advance warning.”

Scorpia looked thoughtful. “You know, some kind of calling card might not be the worst idea… I mean, the only reason we got that assassination contract was a recruit passing through heard some of the villagers talking and made the deal.”

“Enterprising of them. Maybe we send some people out, have them look for work?”

“Way ahead of you there, Commander. Speaking of which,” Scorpia flipped over a few other papers on Catra’s desk. “Here’s a couple job offers we’ve received. This one,” she pointed at one of the papers, “could probably use your personal touch.”

Catra grabbed the paper and scanned its contents. “Are we sure this is real?”

“I had the intel team look into it. I’m reasonably confident it’s not a trap.”

Catra shrugged. “Not like I’ve ever bothered avoiding a trap before anyway. Seem to remember a few attempts by the Rebellion that weren’t particularly difficult to get around.”

“Horde traps might be a little more sophisticated,” Scorpia said, “but I get your point. Either way, the pay’s an awful lot.”

Catra looked over the job description again and shook her head. “I’m surprised the Rebellion’s even willing to hire us. Figured they’d send in some princesses and call it a day.”

“The Rebellion isn’t hiring us. The settlement administrator is kind of doing it behind their back.”

This caught Catra’s attention. “Does the Rebellion even know about the raid?”

“Apparently they do, but they don’t have the resources, or so our client was told, to mount any kind of rescue operation.”

“Guess that means they didn’t tell the right person.” Catra said, snorting. “Adora would have already run off and gotten herself killed or captured by now.”

Scorpia gave Catra a knowing look, but chose to ignore her comment. “At any rate, our intel team has the basic layout of the camp, and there’s supposedly a squad of ten wrangling the ‘recruits.’”

Catra rubbed her chin thoughtfully. “A group like that is likely to be all fiercely loyal to Hordak. We’ll need to be careful to make it look like a Rebellion attack if we don’t want to risk exposing our operation.”

“Would it be so bad to let Hordak know what’s coming?” Scorpia said, unexpectedly. “Give the old bastard something to worry about, and maybe cause some more Horde soldiers to head our way.”

“The point was to work for whoever would pay us, remember? If we make it clear we’re out for revenge, I doubt we’ll be getting any jobs from the Horde.” Catra frowned.

“In that case, you’ve got two options, as far as I see it: Go in and sneak the recruits out without anyone seeing you, or go in and leave no survivors to report back.”

“Sneaking out seems unlikely. We’re talking about kids, after all.”

“So it’s a no survivors situation. Might be wise to bring along some backup.”

Catra grinned. “Are you volunteering?”

Scorpia chuckled. “I was hoping you’d say that. I’ve got a few others in mind too - I figure a team of five ought to be able to do the job, right?”

Catra nodded decisively. “Right. Assemble a team, Scorpia. We’ll hit them tonight.”

The rest of the team consisted of two former Horde soldiers and a former Rebellion soldier - the same one, as it turned out, that Catra had offered a job to during her first mission. Currently, that soldier (*Aethina* , she reminded herself, *her name is Aethina*) was bleeding from a gut wound while Catra dragged her into cover. She used one hand to apply pressure to the wound, while the other (her 'good' hand, as she thought of the flesh-and-bone hand) took aim with her rifle. Glancing down at Aethina's face, which was drawn tight with pain, Catra did her best to provide some kind of reassurance. "You're not permitted to die, soldier. Is that clear?"

Gunfire whizzed overhead as Aethina gave Catra a look that seemed to communicate immense pain and annoyance. "I've had worse, Commander."

"Glad to hear it. You keep pressure on that wound, got it? I'll send the medic back to see to you."

Aethina nodded, then grimaced. "Go get those bastards, Commander. Pretty sure there's not many of 'em left at this point."

The attack had gone about as well as Catra could have hoped. The skiff had come in low, pulled a dangerous swoop right next to the holding facility, and the five had executed a textbook-perfect combat drop. They'd downed the two guards on duty almost immediately, but the other eight had been a little faster to respond than Catra had expected and were dug in. Scorpia had taken one of the soldiers (*Leo* , Catra thought to herself) and was in the process of flanking them. Catra had taken Aethina and Cadence to mount enough of an assault on the front to keep Scorpia and Leo from being discovered until it was too late. They'd picked a few off before a lucky shot had caught Aethina and Catra had left Cadence to keep the fight up while she got her to safety. Now Catra charged back, furious that one of her soldiers had been injured.

Cadence grinned back as she saw Catra approach. "Commander! Got another two while you were away. Should only be three left in

there now."

A scream of surprise echoed from inside the building, and Catra grinned. "Two." Another scream. "One."

Then, Scorpia's voice on the radio, urgent. "Commander, the last one's holed up in with the kids. Says he'll kill them if we don't let him go."

"I'll deal with him." Catra said, simply. "Tell him I'm coming."

Cadence looked at her questioningly. "You're not going to let him go, are you Commander?"

Catra shook her head. "No. No I'm not."

The two strode into the facility, where the bodies of the other guards lay where they'd fallen. Leo was bandaging up a wound to his leg and looked up as they came in. Catra nodded to him. "Aethina's back by the gate entrance. Go patch her up as best you can and call for evac. I'll be out with the kids shortly."

Leo saluted and, after a moment's hesitation where he glanced back in the direction of the holding cells, headed out. Catra continued down the hallway, ignoring the freshly-stained walls, her mind drawn inexorably back to memories she'd long ignored.

A young, terrified girl, still not quite comprehending what was going on, surrounded by strangers who all smelled different from her family. Nothing but shouting of orders, her arms cruelly bound, shoved down a corridor and deposited in a room with other, equally-terrified and confused children. Unsure of where her parents were, but some small part of her mind comprehending that she would never see them again. She cried herself to sleep that night, and the next morning, when she realized the situation was real, she cried again. Then the training had begun, and tears had only brought punishment, and she'd learned how to keep from crying, how to build a wall between her and the world to keep herself safe.

Until she'd met Adora, anyway. Adora had broken down her carefully constructed wall with little to no effort, and Catra had been so grateful, almost comically so, to have someone that she didn't have to keep her defenses up around. Adora, who became Catra's whole world, who didn't ask questions when nightmares woke Catra up choking back screams, who offered her bed as refuge. The two kept each other sane as their training grew harder, up until the moment Adora left and Catra found herself alone again. Her anger had been so great it had almost consumed her completely, but upon becoming Hordak's second she'd almost been able to let it go, taking the opportunity to keep others from being the terrified kid in a dirty holding cell.

As Catra's footsteps echoed down the hallway she felt something dark and angry uncoil in her gut. She'd called a halt to recruiting children almost immediately upon her promotion, and the fact they'd so quickly reinstated the practice was like a slap in the face. Hordak had been waiting, she knew now. How many in the Horde had he let in on his plan? How many had been waiting to go back to their old ways as soon as she was out of the way? Almost unconsciously, Catra's hand gripped the handle of the knife she wore on her belt.

Scorpia waved Catra over at the end of the hallway. "Commander? He's through there. Don't get too close - he's got one of the kids at gunpoint."

Catra nodded and stepped inside. The soldier in question looked fairly confident, but that confidence turned to confusion as soon as he saw Catra step in the room. "You? But you're dead!"

Catra ignored him and directed her attention to the boy who was standing at gunpoint. "Hey kid," she said, in a soft tone, "You okay?"

The boy looked back over his shoulder at the gun, then back at Catra, and said nothing. Catra nodded understandingly. "Don't worry," she said, "you'll be fine."

“Good.” The Horde soldier seemed to think Catra had been talking about surrender. “You all lay your weapons down, and-*” He never got the chance to finish, as Catra’s knife appeared in his throat as if by magic. His voice became a series of wet chokes and toppled backwards, losing his grip on the boy. The boy staggered forward, somehow knowing that it would be best if he didn't look back. Catra stood frozen with her hand extended, surprised by her own action.

Scorpia appeared behind Catra and lay a hand on her shoulder. “Wow,” she said, not bothering to keep the admiration from her voice, “nice throw.”

Catra knelt down and beckoned the boy over. “Come here, kid. Where are the others?”

The boy pointed behind him wordlessly, where another cell door stood shut. Catra gave him a pat on the head and walked by him. She swung the door open and was immediately forced to duck as a boot flew over her head.

A young girl who seemed to be the oldest among them seemed responsible for the throw, standing defiantly in one boot with her fists up. “You won’t take them! I’ll fight you!”

Catra took the scene in, feeling for a moment unsure whether to laugh, cry, say something reassuring, or some combination of the three. She settled on raising her hands in surrender and speaking in what she hoped was a reassuring voice.

“Hey, easy kid. Your parents sent me to get you guys out of here.”

The girl’s eyes blazed defiance. “Liar! How can I trust you?”

Catra crouched down, putting herself on the girl’s level. “Because,” she said patiently, “I know you’re smart enough to have heard the sounds of battle outside, and you also can see I’m not dressed like the guys who brought you here. So, what do you think that tells you about who I am?”

Catra could see the girl digesting this information and calculating. "You're… whoever was attacking?"

"Smart cookie. Now, here's another question for you: are there any more of you here?"

The girl nodded. "He took one with him. The rest are here. Is… is he gone?"

"Yeah, he's gone. Your friend is safe, too. I need you all," Catra addressed the other children cowering in the room, "to come with me as fast as you can, okay?"

One of the kids was clearly not up to walking, so Catra scooped him up. "Everyone ready? Let's go."

A group of six children (not counting the one with Scorpia, or the one Catra carried) followed Catra closely. They moved quickly, with only the older girl pausing for a moment to stare at the bodies of the Horde soldiers still slumped in the halls. Catra hoped desperately that Aethina was still alive, as the thought of going back to the base with a dead body in the skiff was thoroughly unappealing. Cadence waved to Catra as she approached.

"Commander! We'll take it from here. Scorpia's got an idea she wants to run by you."

Catra handed the boy off and nodded. Scorpia was inside the facility, digging through an office. "Commander! I've got an idea."

"Cadence said as much. What are you thinking?"

"Well," Scorpia said, indicating a set of papers, "there's a good set of intel reports here, including - you'll like this - an unsent report on a possible sighting of a group of Horde defectors. Looks like we'll need to tell our recruiters to be a little more circumspect…"

"Scorpia…" Catra said in a warning tone, "You're rambling. What's the idea?"

“Right! Well, we’ve already got an intel group out looking for work, right? But what I’m thinking is, maybe we have them try to pick up stuff like these reports here from time to time. Give us a better idea of what the Horde and Rebellion are up to, and maybe help us stay a couple steps ahead of them, you know?”

Catra nodded, looking thoughtful. “How likely is it we end up with dead intel personnel if we do something like this? Having them vet our job offers is dangerous enough; I don’t want to put anyone at risk unnecessarily.”

Scorpia shrugged. “Honestly, intelligence gathering wasn’t my department. Entrapta might be a better person to ask. But it’s probably worth doing, right?”

“Can’t hurt to know what our enemies are up to... “ Catra mused. “We’ll run it by Entrapta, talk to the intel team, see what they think. Now…” she looked around the room, “let’s burn this fucking place to the ground.”

If not for the urgency of having a wounded soldier (who was blessedly stable for now), Catra would have stayed to watch the facility burn to the ground. She satisfied herself with watching until the flames burst out of the roof, then turned and walked calmly back to the skiff. The children were all watching the fire too, although whether they just thought the flames looked cool or they took satisfaction in watching their brief prison be destroyed was anyone's guess. Catra couldn’t help but look back as the skiff shot away, the flames dancing in her eye, feeling an old weight she didn’t realize she’d been carrying lift from her shoulders. She took a moment to savor it before turning her attention back to the mission.

Kneeling in front of Aethina, Catra inspected the job Leo had done on her bandages. Aethina’s eyes fluttered open. “Feeling alright, soldier?”

“Not really, Commander. Can’t believe this is how my first outing went.”

Catra chuckled. “Look at it this way: You’ve gotten it out of the way at least. When you’re back on your feet, you’ll be twice as careful as before.”

Aethina gave Catra a surprisingly piercing look. “That what you did? Came back twice as careful?”

For a second, Catra thought about all the wounds she’d taken in service of the Horde. About the scars that criss crossed her body and the still-healing scars where Entrapta had dug pieces of the command tank out of her body. About the other, deeper marks the Horde had given her, that she’d started to pay back as soon as she’d put flame to the holding facility. Then, mastering herself, she winked. “Didn’t see me get shot, did you?” Aethina laughed, then winced. Catra patted her shoulder reassuringly. “Don’t go anywhere on me now. I’ve got to check on the others.”

It didn’t take too long for the skiff to reach the Rebellion settlement, where a group of villagers warily approached with weapons at the ready. Weapons in this case being primarily repurposed farming tools. Catra couldn’t help but shake her head in disbelief - was the Rebellion really not providing any arms to their settlements? As the skiff touched down, Catra hopped over the side without waiting for the boarding ramp and strode across the field to the group. She pointed to the one who looked most likely to be the leader.

“We have your children. Do you have our payment?”

The leader nodded, and waved over a group of villagers carrying crates. Catra looked over the contents - medical supplies, food, and a few pieces of unidentified First Ones technology - and nodded in satisfaction. She signalled the skiff, and the boarding ramp lowered, allowing the children to rush down into the arms of their (very relieved) parents.

A few villagers seemed to recognize Catra and began whispering to one another. Catra kept her eye on them, unsure if they would make a scene or not. Eventually, one strode in her direction with a

stern expression on his face. Catra folded her arms and waited patiently, wearing an expression of indifference.

“I know who you are.” The villager said, in a low tone. “I know what you’ve done.”

Catra stared him down, weighing her response carefully. “Do you?”

“This doesn’t make up for everything you did to us.” The villager said, fiercely. “It doesn’t make up for the friends your attacks killed.”

“No,” Catra agreed, “It doesn’t. But I’m not doing this for redemption.”

Her response seemed to confuse him. “Then… why?”

“Someone needed to,” Catra said, simply, “and I decided it would be me.”

She turned and headed back to the skiff, leaving the loading of their payment to the others. Aethina looked up as Catra boarded, and nodded. “What we did today, Commander... It felt good. I don’t know if I’d ever get the chance to be the hero sticking with the Rebellion.”

Catra snorted. “We’re not heroes, kid. We just happened to look like them today.” *I’m certainly no hero* , she didn’t add.

“Try telling that to the kids we saved.” Aethina said, rolling her eyes.

“That’s because they’re kids.” Catra pointed out. “Things are simpler when you’re a kid.”

“They weren’t for you, were they? I heard you were recruited like these kids were.”

“Yeah, I was.” Catra said, thinking about how she’d adapted to life in the Horde. “Wouldn’t say things were any more complicated, though.”

“How so?”

“Well,” Catra said, “you either obeyed, or you died. Pretty simple.”

Aethina gave Catra a look, then, one of respect mingled with pity. “Well, I’m glad we were able to spare these kids that kind of simplicity.”

“Yeah,” Catra said, her voice soft, “me too.”

Chapter End Notes

> And then there are chapters that just kind of go and go and go, I guess.
>
> Almost wanted to have Catra do the full "I'm no hero. Never was. Never will be" but they were on a rescue op, and she's not that old, so the end of the line wouldn't have made much sense. I think we'll check in with Adora next. Assassinated administrators might be easy to write off as a Horde op, but a rescue mission run by someone who was recognized as Catra? That might cause a bit of a stir.

Rumors of the Past

Chapter Summary

> Adora hears a rumor, and finds something she doesn't understand.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

It was pure chance that Adora happened to be walking by the throne room when she heard Angella speaking to a messenger in a low and urgent tone. “Adora is *not* to hear these rumors, understand? They would be an unnecessary distraction.”

There was a time when overhearing something like this would not have bothered Adora, and she would have gone about her day. After all, Queen Angella was the leader, and therefore could be trusted to make the right decisions. Today, however, Adora walked into the throne room and asked, “What rumors?”

Queen Angella looked up sharply at the intrusion, but her expression betrayed no annoyance. “Ah, Adora! I was just about to send for you. Our researchers have finished examining the plans you retrieved.”

“Interesting,” Adora said, not willing to let the matter drop that easily, “what rumors?”

Angella sighed, and turned to the messenger. “Would you excuse us?” The messenger bowed and left, and Angella turned back to Adora wearing a patient expression. “There are reports of increased Horde raiding parties. The rumor is that they’ve been trying to carry off children again.”

Adora stiffened. “There’s been no proof?” There was only a flicker across Angella’s face, but it was enough for Adora, who immediately adopted a stronger tone. “Where? When?”

"It's already been taken care of, Adora." Angella rushed to reassure her. "The villagers were able to get their kids back, and apparently burned the camp down to boot."

Adora blinked, surprised. "They did *what?*"

"I confess," Angella said, maybe a little too casually, "that I was surprised myself. I had some troops in the area sent to confirm the story, and, well, they found precisely what you'd expect. The children were back, and the base was a burning ruin."

Adora frowned, thinking. "That doesn't make sense," she muttered, "those facilities were guarded by the Horde's elite. Well-defended. A group of angry villagers with sticks shouldn't stand a chance."

"Stranger things have happened, Adora." Angella said, with a pointed look at the Sword of Protection slung across Adora's back. "Now, as for those plans you found…"

"Wait," Adora said, quietly, "why didn't you want me to hear about this?"

"Because I know your history." Angella said, soothingly. "I know you were… similarly recruited by the Horde. I did not want you distracted by what is likely not an actual issue."

"Not an actual issue?" Adora's voice carried a note of disbelief. "The Horde is possibly stealing children, and you think it's not an actual issue?"

"It's not an actual issue because there's a good possibility it wasn't the Horde." Angella said, finally. "You said it yourself - a group of villagers against a fortified Horde facility? It was probably just bandits."

Adora thought about this, her mind running through possibilities. "With permission, your Majesty," she said, after a moment's consideration, "I'd like to inspect the remains of the facility myself.

I know the Horde. I know how they operate. If it was bandits, I'll be able to tell."

Angella sighed in resignation. "If it will ease your mind to confirm it yourself, I will allow it. But after your last solo effort, I believe it would be better if you took some company with you - bring Glimmer and Bow along with you. Now, if that's settled, we still need to talk about those plans you brought back."

"Of course. What have they found out?"

"Nothing good, I'm afraid." Angella tossed a thick-looking set of papers to Adora. "According to their analysis of these plans, it could completely change the course of this war. If they really manage to build a working version of what's here, it would completely negate our advantage in a stand-up fight. We'd be forced to fight them conventionally, something we're just not equipped to do."

Adora frowned. "I've said we rely too much on our powers before -"

"And we were wrong to ignore you," Angella said, cutting her off, "but regrets will get us nowhere. Our first priority needs to be finding out exactly when and where this weapon could be deployed, and stopping it from happening."

"Any leads on where that might be?"

"Unfortunately, nothing yet. What we need is some kind of deployment plan."

"Any Horde outpost would have deployment plans in its command center." Adora said, matter-of-factly. "But we'd need to get in there fast, because policy is to destroy everything at the first sign of defeat."

Angella leaned back, thinking. "Another infiltration mission, perhaps?"

“It’s our best option.” Adora said, shrugging. “I would recommend a distraction to make insertion easier - draw off some of the forces there to reduce the risk of detection. The only problem is, that might also cause them to increase security - and if they know we’ve gotten their deployment plans, they’ll scrap them.”

Angella hummed to herself. “So someone needs to get in, copy the plans, and get out without being detected?”

“That’s about the shape of it.”

“I’ll work with our commanders to come up with a target and plan of action while you’re gone.” Angella said, nodding decisively. “Go conduct your investigation.”

Adora nodded and exited the throne room to find Glimmer and Bow. A few hours later they were on their way to the settlement. Adora rode on Swift Wind, while Bow and Glimmer rode in a wagon pulled by a horse who, Adora had assured Swift Wind, volunteered for the job.

“So what’s the story here Adora,” Glimmer called over, “you think it was just bandits?”

“I doubt it,” Adora said, “though your mother is probably hoping that’s what we’ll find. The alternative is… I don’t know what. Horde soldiers shouldn’t be so easily defeated.Things can’t have gone downhill that fast after… after Catra.”

Glimmer frowned, thinking. “Our intel team has heard rumors about there being an increase in deserters. Maybe it was them?”

“That doesn’t make any sense,” Bow piped up, “what would deserters want with a bunch of kids? Unless… are they cannibals?”

“No Bow, they aren’t cannibals.” Adora rolled her eyes. “I feel like I have this conversation with you every week.”

“It's part of my charm!” Bow said, defensively.

“Asking the same question every week is part of your charm?”

“It's a sign of intellectual rigor.”

“More like a sign of a lack of intellect.” Glimmer said, brightly.

“Glimmer! I am *wounded,* and may never recover.”

Adora laughed, and felt a lightness of spirit for the first time in what felt like a month. Being back on the road with her friends after far too long was good for her - it provided a useful distraction from the lingering grief of Catra’s loss, along with a distraction from the increasing doubts about the way in which the Rebellion was conducting the war. This far along, Adora was increasingly frustrated by the unwillingness of the Rebellion to train more actual soldiers in favor of relying on the princesses.

It felt, to her, like handing the Horde an easy guide on what to do to win: disable the Princesses and the Rebellion would fall apart - the first battle of Brightmoon had nearly proven that. This was in part why Adora had stopped putting in as much training time as She-Ra, preferring instead to train with the palace guard. Her hope was that the skills she passed on to the palace guard would make their way through to the rest of the rank and file, as many of the palace guard eventually was sent to provide training for new recruits. Adora wished she was allowed to do the same, but her place, she’d been told, was at Brightmoon.

The settlement was, as Adora expected, a poorly-defended town without even a basic defensive perimeter. She tried not to frown as the three approached, though she did begin compiling a list of recommended fortifications in her head.

“Hey Adora! You gonna do the She-Ra thing before we get there?” Bow asked, noticing Adora making the face she usually made when she was trying to solve a difficult problem.

“Huh? No, I uh, I think I’d rather go incognito for this, to be honest.” Left unspoken was the fact that if She-Ra showed up, it

would bring too much attention and - if the Horde was really operating this far out - it was probably best not to paint a huge target on the settlement again. Left even *more* unspoken was Adora's desire to not have to play the symbol of hope for just a little while longer. "I've got the sword, if She-Ra's needed, I'll be ready."

Glimmer looked at her friend with a flash of suspicion, as if she'd already guessed Adora's reasoning. "You sure? Having She-Ra around might make them a little more willing to open up to us if there's something they're not saying about the attack."

"What, you think they'll lie to the Princess of Brightmoon?" Adora snorted. "I think you can handle the diplomacy end of things, Glimmer. I want to get a look at the remains of that Horde outpost before they know what we're doing here. Swift Wind probably wants to stretch his wings anyway, don't you?"

"I wasn't going to say anything," Swift Wind said, "but walking is *incredibly* boring compared to flying. I only put up with it because you asked so nicely."

"And gave you all those apples." Adora added.

"That too. But mostly it was you asking nicely! I promise!"

Glimmer sighed. "Ugh, *fine* , I'll do the diplomacy part. But only if you promise to come save me from bland pleasantries if you find anything interesting! Or if you get in a fight!"

"Don't worry," Adora said, grinning, "I'll be back here before dinnertime."

"Oh sure, leave us to sit through a meeting and show up for the food. Typical!" Bow struck an aggrieved tone.

Swift Wind spread his wings and leapt into the sky. "The Horde outpost is ten miles to the east of here." Adora said, pressed close against Swift Wind's mane as they shot upwards, "Think you can get there within an hour?"

“Oh please, kid, look who you’re talking to!”

They touched down in front of the gates to the facility, which seemed to be the only parts of the structure that weren’t blackened with soot. Adora patted Swift Wind’s neck almost absentmindedly and walked through the gates. She recognized the design of the facility immediately.

“Well,” she said to herself, “if they *were* just bandits, they picked the right kind of base to bring kids.”

“What’s that, Adora?” Swift Wind piped up from behind her.

“This place,” Adora said, feeling an unexpected heaviness in her chest, “it’s… it’s a holding facility. For new recruits.” *It’s where they broke us in,* she thought. *Got us used to taking orders, and not talking back. It’s where I met Catra.*

Swift Wind, possibly noticing Adora’s expression, trotted up behind her and nudged her with his snout. “Uh, Adora? You okay?”

Adora seemed to come back to herself. “Yeah, I’m fine. Come on, help me look around.”

The dirt crunched under Adora’s boots as she shoved down the ghosts that threatened to overwhelm her and began focusing on the area. The walls were pockmarked with evidence of gunfire, and Adora approached them curiously. She looked at the impact sites, then back at the entryway, then back at the wall.

“Hey, Swifty.”

“Yeah?”

“If you were fighting a defensive action against an attacker, would you leave the building and fire into it?”

“I’ve got hooves, Adora. I can’t shoot anything..”

“Yeah, but if you could, that would be stupid, right?”

"Yes."

"Just checking." Adora muttered, making another circuit of the courtyard. "How did the guys Angella send *miss* that?"

"Miss what?"

"Guns, Swifty." Adora said, as if it was obvious. "The people who attacked this facility had guns."

"Oh!" Swift Wind said, and then, after a moment, "So what?"

"So," Adora said, patiently, "either the villagers are hiding a weapons cache in their settlement, or…"

"Or?"

Adora frowned. "Or… I'm not sure. Someone else did this, but who, or *why* , I don't know." She knelt to inspect the ground, then looked at the entrance to the building. "Stay out here. I don't know how stable the building is, so I might need you to go get the others if it collapses."

"That's… not reassuring." Swift Wind said, but did not make any motion to follow her.

The building was in bad shape, but the walls, while blackened, still bore signs of battle. Adora wandered slowly through the corridors, pausing to mark where a body had fallen. The bodies were, courtesy of the fire, little more than bones and ash - and all of the dead, as far as she could tell, had fallen while defending the base.

"No casualties for the attackers…" she muttered to herself. Eventually, she found herself standing outside the entrance to the holding cells. She took a deep breath, steadied herself, and walked through the door.

She was pleased to see the fire had, apparently, burned hottest here. The bars on the cells were melted piles of slag, and the roof had collapsed in from the heat of the inferno, leaving a view of

the sky above. There was the shape of what might have been a body before the fire which seemed to crumble away as she walked towards it, the remains of something metal all that appeared to endure the flame.

Curious, she crouched down to examine it - the metal was warped by the heat, but had maintained its shape well enough that Adora recognized it almost immediately. A Horde knife, usually given to recruits who made it through to Force Commander training. Adora stared at it for a while, thinking. There was a flutter of wings, and Adora looked up to see a crow settle on the edge of the hole in the roof. It stared down at her with what she thought was almost curiosity, then cawed loudly and flew off again, sending some debris tumbling down into the room. Adora took it as a sign that she wouldn't find anything else, apart from more bad memories, and made her way back out of the building. Something - instinct, maybe - made her pause in the hallway outside what would've been the commander's office, and she poked her head in to have a look around. The furniture was charred, though the desk seemed to have weathered the fire surprisingly well. Thinking back to the Rebellion's need for more intel, Adora decided to see if any documents had survived the fire. She was surprised to see the desk drawers had already been opened, and even more surprised to see a complete lack of any documents to speak of. Not even a scrap of paper to indicate something had been there remained.

Someone is fighting the Horde, Adora thought to herself, *and they aren't us* . She wasn't sure what to make of that, yet.

Swift Wind was waiting for her in the courtyard. “Come on Adora, let's get out of here. This place gives me the creeps.”

Adora looked back at the building one last time, remembering, and then nodded. “Yeah, me too.”

Chapter End Notes

How very kind of you all to wait so patiently for me to actually figure this sequence out. I sat on this one for a couple days, I'll admit, because I couldn't quite figure out if it worked or not. I'm still not 100% positive I did it right, but then again, I think that about all the other chapters too so what else is new.

Anyway, we'll get a chance to see how Glimmer is at playing diplomat next chapter. How's that sound?

EDIT: Oh fuck me how is this over 30k words what am I even doing with myself

Diplomacy

Chapter Summary

> Adora interrogates. Glimmer practices diplomacy. Things get complex.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The look of relief in Glimmer's eyes when she spotted Adora landing on the back of Swift Wind was a good sign of how much she'd enjoyed talking to the administrator of the settlement. Adora dismounted and waved to Glimmer, who dashed over and gave her a hug.

"They're hiding something." Glimmer whispered, before pulling back and saying a bit more loudly, "Glad to see you back in one piece! No trouble at the outpost, I take it?"

Adora didn't react to the news at all, mostly because it was entirely unsurprising, but also because she knew better than to react to this sort of news when they were being watched. "None at all. You and Bow would've been bored out of your minds."

"As opposed to entertained here?" Bow called down from the roof of a building he'd scaled in a desperate attempt to find something to do. "Hey, apropos of nothing, we should probably see about building some actual defenses here."

"I was thinking something similar." Adora replied. "At the very least some kind of stockade or fallback position."

"Now that your friend is here, Princess," the administrator interrupted, "would you be interested in joining us for dinner? I'd feel a poor host otherwise."

Glimmer bowed low. “Our profound thanks, Administrator Laurence. I must insist, however, that you do not go to any extra trouble for us. We are, after all, only servants of the Rebellion.”

“Nonsense! I insist. You and your guards are most welcome.”

At this, Adora made a sign to Glimmer, indicating that she did not wish for Glimmer to clarify just who Adora was. The two had long since realized that it was useful for them, on occasion, to allow Adora to travel incognito. In spite of Adora’s relative openness as to who she was, most people only recognized her as She-Ra. The group made their way into the administrator’s house, where they soon found themselves being served a fairly elaborate dinner.

“Administrator, I was curious.” Adora said, after a few minutes, “The attack on your village - how did it start?”

“Well,” Laurence said, looking briefly surprised at the question, “It was conducted in the middle of the night. Horde soldiers rounded us all up and took the children who didn’t manage to stay hidden.”

“There was no resistance?”

This earned her a glare from the Administrator. “When you wake up with a gun in your face, resistance is not the first priority.”

“I apologize,” Adora said, not actually sorry in the slightest, “I only wondered whether you had guards to put up any sort of resistance.”

“We are a simple farming settlement. We do not have any guards apart from what the Rebellion chooses to send. Thus far, they have not chosen to send any.”

“And for that I must apologize, Administrator.” Glimmer broke in, “I will see to it that your settlement is better-protected in the future. It is unacceptable that a settlement so near the borderlands should be left so open to raiding parties.”

“We could also offer training to the men who saved your children.” Bow added.

At this offer, the Administrator shifted slightly in his seat before answering. “Ah, yes, that would be… most appreciated.”

“Could we meet them?” Glimmer asked, innocently. “I would like to thank them for their assistance - and to apologize that they were forced to take up arms in the first place.”

“Ah, I do not know if it would be… that is to say, they are focused on spending time with their children at present, and perhaps would not wish to leave them.”

“Oh, they wouldn’t have to.” Adora said, brightly. “When I’m not… guarding the Princess Glimmer, here, I help train the Brightmoon guards. It would be no trouble to at least meet them and give a few pointers.” She paused, debating whether or not to go further. “Their shooting is sloppy.” she finally added, ignoring the way Glimmer’s eyebrows threatened to jump off her head, “Although perhaps they just need training on how to sight their weapons properly. Either way, we’re here to help.”

To his credit, Administrator Laurence managed to not immediately break down into a stuttering mess. To his detriment, he’d apparently decided that the best option was to pretend he didn’t know what Adora was talking about. “I beg your pardon? We have no rifles of any sort here.”

“Ah,” Adora said, feigning confusion, “perhaps they stole them from the elite trained Horde soldiers when they attacked their facility?”

Laurence was all too eager to agree. “Surely that’s what happened.”

“Of course…” Adora went on, ignoring the administrator, “that wouldn’t explain why they clearly had weapons when they approached the facility. Nor would it, I suppose, explain where all the Horde documentation went before the fire was set, or the

remains of a Force Commander knife I found in the neck of who, given that I didn't see any funeral arrangements or mourning here, was clearly a Horde soldier."

Glimmer drew upon years of being interrogated by her mother to produce perhaps the most piercing stare Adora had ever seen and deploy it squarely in the direction of Administrator Laurence. "Administrator, perhaps it *is* best if we talk to the men who went on that rescue mission after all."

Laurence wilted. "I'll… have them summoned."

Roughly fifteen minutes later a group of four villagers trooped into the house. One in particular stared back at the group defiantly, and Adora immediately focused on him. "When you attacked the outpost," she asked, "were there sentries on duty?"

"None." The man replied defiantly. "They didn't expect us."

"Slipped right in the front door before they knew what was happening, I expect." Adora said, nodding.

"That's right. We can move quiet when we need to."

"So all the gunfire that erupted outside the building," Adora said, airily, "I expect that was just an earlier attack from someone else?"

The man's frown deepened, and he took a step forward. "Are you saying I'm a liar?"

"That," Adora said, completely calm, "is precisely what I'm saying."

He advanced, hands balled into fists, shouting angrily. "How *dare* you! We sent word for help and were told none would come! You don't get to come in here and act high and mighty, like we've done something wrong by taking matters into our own hands! We did what we had to do to get our children back!"

Adora whirled on Glimmer, an angry rebuke on her lips, but at the sight of her friend's equally shocked face Adora reined her anger in and turned back to the villager. "And what did you do? You certainly didn't go rescue them yourselves." Her voice softened. "Nobody's in trouble here, we just need to know what happened. *I* need to know what happened."

The man stared back defiantly. "Not with Princesses in the room."

"Glimmer," Adora said, quietly, "can you excuse us?"

Glimmer's lips set in a thin line, and Adora could tell that she was angry, but she nodded and teleported out, along with Bow.

"Now," Adora said, "What happened?"

"After your *gracious commanders* decided we weren't worth the resources," the man spat, "we despaired of ever seeing our children again. I advocated going after them, but we all knew it would be suicide. Then, Administrator Laurence intervened."

Adora looked over at Laurence steadily. "Did he?"

"I had been approached about a week ago," Laurence said, "and given the means to contact a mercenary group. They claim to be able to help with problems the Rebellion deems… not worth looking into."

"He means problems the Rebellion refuses to help with." The man helpfully supplied, a sour look on his face.

"So you contacted this mercenary group." Adora surmised. "Who are they? If they're allies against the Horde, we could work with them."

"I can't tell you." Laurence replied, simply. "Part of the terms of our deal was not to reveal anything about them. Which is easy, as apart from clearly being soldiers, I've no idea where they came from."

Adora frowned. “Why wouldn’t they want to work with us?”

“Don’t be ridiculous,” the angry villager scoffed, “the Rebellion has other priorities that don’t include settlements like ours. What?” He said, in response to a warning look from Laurence, “If she doesn’t know now, she should! The Rebellion isn’t concerned with us, or any other settlement along the border. We’re *expendable* . *They* were willing to help when you people wouldn’t.”

“For a price.” Laurence added. “Food and medical supplies, which we were only too happy to provide. For our children’s return, there was no cost too high.”

“There shouldn’t have been a cost.” Adora said, with a sudden vehemence. “I’m going to fix this. You have my word, Administrator. If it takes me staying out here myself, I’ll see this settlement defended.”

“Quite the promise from a royal guard,” the (now less-angry) settler said with a smirk.

“Trust me,” Adora said, all confidence, “Princess Glimmer listens to me.”

While Adora conducted her interview, Glimmer had teleported out into the streets with Bow and was trying not to sulk too much.

“Hey, look at it this way,” Bow said, after deciding a sufficient amount of time had passed, “Adora will get the information she’s looking for, and we can make sure the place is defended properly next time.”

“I know,” Glimmer groaned, “it’s just… don’t they realize everything we’ve done for them? The Rebellion has been taking the fight to the Horde for so long now, but we can’t be everywhere at once!”

“Honestly Glim, I’m not sure we’d ever have come here if Adora hadn’t overheard your mom talking about it. We’re expected to stay focused on the big picture of the overall war - places like this

can get left out of the equation." Bow did not add, and did not *need* to add, that his fathers were from places like this.

"Ugh, you're probably right." Glimmer sighed. "But shouldn't we be defending settlements like these?"

"Probably! But we're going to have to fight with the rest of the war council it's worth spending resources here."

"Who cares about *resources?* They almost lost their *kids* , Bow! And the Rebellion wasn't going to do anything about it!" There was an almost anguished note in Glimmer's voice. "How are we supposed to call ourselves the good guys after that?"

Bow shrugged. "Hey, I agree with you. I don't want to see stuff like this going on anymore than you do. But we've been ignoring the problem until now - we're gonna have to take some heat for that."

"I didn't even know there *was* a problem until now!" Glimmer said, a little defensively. "It's not like mom told me 'Oh hey dear, by the way, our larger military planning apparatus is only too willing to sacrifice *children* in the name of managing our military resources.'"

"I'm not blaming you!" Bow hastened to soothe her. "It's just… we've kind of been kept away from this stuff, and we've been happy not to question it because we're busy fighting. Maybe it's time to start asking more questions, is all."

Glimmer opened her mouth to respond, but was cut off by a soft, shy voice. "E-excuse me. Are you a *real princess* ?"

The voice belonged to a small boy, who carried a look of awe on his face. Smiling gently, Glimmer crouched down to his level and nodded. "Yep, that's me. We came to ask about the people that saved the kids who got taken away. Were you one of them?"

The boy nodded seriously. "There was a bad man holding me, and I thought he was going to hurt me, but then the furry lady saved

me."

Somehow, Glimmer managed to not react with anything more than a look of innocent confusion. "Furry lady?"

"Yeah, the furry lady! She had big ears and a tail and she threw a knife right into the bad man's face! She told me not to look, but," dropping his voice to a whisper, "I looked."

"I bet that was pretty gross, huh?"

"Yeah, I only looked for a second! But then she helped us all get out and all the bad guys were dead, and she *set the place on fire* ."

"Sounds impressive!" Glimmer said. "Did she bring you back here too?"

"Yup! We got on this thing that was like a boat, except it could *fly* . And it took us back here, and then I got to see my mom and dad again!"

"Well, it's a good thing she was around, huh?" Glimmer couldn't help feel a little jealous. *We should have been the ones rescuing our own people.* "You think she'll come back?"

The boy shrugged. "I dunno. Dad says she was a bad person, but he thanked her anyway because she brought me back."

"Do you think she was a bad person too?" Bow asked, curiously.

"No. She was really nice, and she told us all we were brave to survive, and that she wished she could have been as brave as us when she was our age!" The boy seemed like he had more to say, but there was the sound of someone calling and he looked back over his shoulder. "Gotta go! My dad's looking for me. We're playing hide and seek, and I still have to hide!"

Glimmer nodded seriously. "Alright, we'll be sure to tell him we didn't see you then, okay?"

The boy laughed delightedly and ran off, pointing behind him. "Tell him I went that way!"

"Deal!" Glimmer said, laughing a little herself. Then, as soon as the boy was out of sight, she turned to Bow and gave him a look. "Furry lady, huh?"

"Yeah." Bow said, frowning. "We have to tell Adora, right?"

Glimmer chewed her lip worriedly. "What if it's… I mean, lots of people have fur, right? What if we just get her hopes up and it's not her?"

"Glim, come on. You can't seriously be considering *not* telling her."

"What? No, of course not!" Glimmer shook her head. "I'm just… Adora's been so *distant* since Catra died. This trip was the first time she's actually seemed to relax in ages, you know?"

"Yeah, I know, but still, if there's a chance it's… *her* , she's got to know."

"I know, I know." Glimmer groaned. "We'll tell her as soon as she's done in there. I just hope it doesn't end up giving her false hope."

At that moment, Adora strode out of the Administrator's house and made a beeline for them.

Bow spoke first. "So? How did it go, Adora?"

"I think," Adora said, slowly, "things have gotten complicated."

"Oh, Adora," Glimmer said, struggling not to laugh at the absurdity of it all, "you've got *no* idea."

Chapter End Notes

Man, this one was hard to do. I think I scrapped about three different versions of how this all played out - including have

someone explicitly refer to Catra as the leader - before deciding to deny Adora complete certainty. Then again, how many furry soldiers has Adora known anyway?

I feel like I've said this a lot recently but boy do I have no idea what the next chapter is going to look into. There are things, obviously, to get to - it's just a matter of which one I want to focus on.

What if I just skip to them banging in Catra's quarters and we call it good?

Don't answer that. I've got too many Metal Gear references to shoehorn in before we get to that.

Recon

Chapter Summary

> Catra gets sick of staying hidden, and acts a little more openly. The Horde lays a trap. The Alliance makes a move.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Why are you here?" Catra asked, her eyes wide with surprise.

The light from the hallway framed Adora, standing with a nervous look, one arm crossed nervously over her chest and clutching her elbow. She worried her lip with her teeth a little (and Catra did *not* focus on her lips, thank you very much) before speaking. "I came to find you. I had to."

"*Had* to?" Catra raised an eyebrow, crossing her arms over her her chest and adopting a decidedly authoritative air. "You've never *had* to do anything. You never even had to *try*."

The hurt on Adora's face was everything Catra thought she wanted to see. Eyes downcast, Adora quietly murmered, "I'm sorry - for everything. I should've seen what Shadow Weaver was doing to you. I should've brought you with me from the beginning instead of leaving you behind and then not coming back. I should have... I should have done a lot of things."

"But you're *sorry*, right?" Catra could feel her whole body shaking with rage. "You're sorry and so it doesn't matter, never happened, I welcome you back with open arms?"

"No," Adora said, shaking her head sadly, "I don't think that's how this goes. I didn't come here to ask for forgiveness, I just... I had to see you again. I know," she raised a hand to cut Catra's outraged exclamation off, "It's shitty and selfish of me. But I've gone so long without you, and I can't do it anymore. I just need

you to know that in spite of everything, all the pain we caused each other... I never wanted to lose you."

"Why not?" Catra said, knowing the answer but desperate to hear it anyway.

"Do you really not know?" Adora said, softly. "Catra, I love you. I've loved you for... who knows how long."

Catra advanced slowly across the room, purposefully. Adora held her ground, holding Catra's gaze fearlessly, with only a slight tremor in her posture betraying her nervousness. Catra's hand reached behind Adora's back slowly, and her breath hitched. A smirk grew on Catra's face as she grabbed the doorknob and shut it, leaving Adora sandwiched between the door and her. Their faces were impossibly close, and Catra was briefly dizzied by the smell of Adora - precisely as she remembered her. Taking a deep breath, Catra closed the distance between them even further, until she could feel the moisture from Adora's breath dancing across her own lips.

"You love me?" Catra whispered, her voice low and almost dangerous. The hand that had shut the door was now wrapped around Adora's waist, the other weaving its way through Adora's hair, pulling back ever so gently.

She had to strain to hear Adora's answer, a half-whimpered "Yes" as she stared into Catra's mismatched eyes, pupils blown wide.

"Show me." Catra said, and closed the final distance between them, kissing Adora fiercely, sending lightning racing through her body as Adora kissed back. It was everything she dreamed it would be. It was more than she dreamed it would be. It was too much.

The speed with which Catra lost control of the situation surprised even her, as suddenly she seemed to be naked on her bed, at Adora's mercy. Adora locked eyes with Catra as she loomed over her, golden hair spilling down and tickling Catra’s nose. Catra

stared back reverently, eyes taking in every detail of Adora's body as if it would disappear without constant observation. Her heart pounded in her chest as she felt the brush of Adora's hand ghosting down the side of her face, and she leaned into the touch instinctively. Adora's other hand sunk into the mattress just above Catra's shoulder, and there was a smirk on her face that Catra wanted nothing more than to wipe off. She moved to kiss Adora, but suddenly Adora's hands were pinning her to the mattress. Slowly, torturously, Adora brought her face down just next to Catra's ear, her breath tickling as she whispered to Catra.

"You asked me to show you. Let me show you."

Adora's mouth moved down to nip at her neck and all Catra could think of was how much she needed Adora to not stop what she was doing. A sound that might have been "please" and might have been "Adora" escaped her throat, and she gasped. She reached out to grab something for support, and felt one hand come in contact with the familiar texture of Adora's hair as she worked her way industriously down Catra's torso, pausing here and there to deliver a nip or soft kiss that made Catra's back arch and a groan escape her mouth. When, after a delirious eternity, Adora finally reached her destination and Catra felt Adora's tongue flick against her, one hand fisted into Adora's hair, while the other flailed around and eventually settled on grabbing the metal bars that served as her bunk's headboard - except she couldn't, because her hand merely passed through, because she didn't have a hand. As soon as the thought flitted through her mind, Adora vanished as if on command, and Catra woke, sweating and unsatisfied, with a curse.

At Scorpia's insistence, she'd sat out the last several ops. The Rebellion seemed to have realized there was a third player in the war, and Scorpia suspected they would be aggressively seeking its rumored leader. There was, in other words, a risk of Catra's capture, and so, Scorpia argued, they needed to be careful.

"After all," she argued, "this operation falls apart if you're captured. You're our leader!"

“I don’t *want* to be a leader, I want to be in the field!” Catra exploded, slamming her prosthetic fist into the wall. “I don’t want to just be some symbol on the sidelines, watching *my* people take the risks. I’m not fucking Hordak.”

“We’re not making you Hordak, Commander, but you have to understand, we’re still in our infancy. Our numbers are growing, but the men are coming here because of *you* . They’re fighting for *you* .”

Catra sighed. “I know, I know. But you can’t expect me to just sit here behind a desk and occasionally train the men.”

“Hey!” Entrapta stuck her head in the office. “You’re not going to believe what just came in.”

“Another contract?” Catra said, rolling her eyes.

“Oh. Yeah.” Entrapta looked crestfallen for a moment, but then brightened up again. “But you won’t believe who it’s *from* .”

“A Rebellion settlement?”

“Nope! A *Horde outpost*.”

Catra raised an eyebrow. “What’s the job?”

“Assassination! Except like, more of an assault.”

Catra blinked slowly. “I don’t follow.”

“Neither do I.” Scorpia added helpfully.

“Okay so, the job is from some low level soldiers. They want their entire command structure gone, but they can’t afford to have it look like any kind of assassination, so they want us to stage a Rebellion attack on the base, during which the command structure will suffer from unfortunate fates.”

“What’s the problem with their command structure?” Scorpia asked, cocking her head to one side.

“That’s where it gets *interesting* .” Entrapta said, grinning. “You see, the outpost is full of people who don’t like the direction the Horde’s been going since you ‘died,’ Commander. The outpost commanders, though, are all loyal to the core - and what’s more, they’ve been talking about how the outpost is going to serve as the testing ground for a new weapon.”

Catra whistled low. “New weapon, huh? Like, the sort of weapon we could steal?”

Entrapta nodded enthusiastically. “Exactly! Plus, I think it’s probably just one of my old designs.”

“Which old design, exactly?” Catra asked, trying not to appear too troubled by the prospect.

“That’s something you can find out for me! I don’t know how much progress they could have made on the cannon, but maybe the proposed mobile platform?”

Catra sighed. “The walking tank?”

“That’s the one!”

Another sigh. “Well, great. Great!” Catra looked over to Scorpia. “Hey, do I have your permission to go on this one? It seems like the sort of thing I should go on. None of the other men are really… you know, *good* with Entrapta’s experiments.”

Scorpia didn’t look thrilled, and it was difficult to tell if it was Entrapta’s cheery admittance that she’d left the plans for the walking tank when she left, or it was Catra’s cheeriness at the idea of heading out into the field where there was a good chance she’d be killed or captured. Then again, Scorpia was smart enough to realize that the longer Catra was cooped up, the greater the odds of her doing something *really* reckless would be.

“Of course, Commander. You know you don’t need my permission, right?”

“Yeah, but I know it makes you feel better.” Catra grinned, already heading out the door to begin assembling a strike team.

Several hours later, Catra was riding an out-of-control Horde bot as it careened in the general direction of a group of Horde soldiers, laughing wildly. At the last second, she sprang off the bot’s back, allowing it to crash into their ranks, landed in a roll, and sprang up already firing her rifle. The rest of the strike team was pressing hard, and the Horde soldiers - who Catra assumed were her clients - were putting on a good show of resistance while still falling back to the command center. Once their backs were against the wall, the soldiers threw down their weapons, leaving the entrance to the center open.

“What defenses are in the command center?” Catra demanded of one of the soldiers.

The soldier wordlessly handed over a set of schematics. “Standard procedure is to fall back to this location.” he said, pointing on the floor plan. “They’ve probably triggered the lockdown - the code to lift it is 0451.”

“Pleasure doing business with you.” Catra drawled, and signalled to a squad to enter the building with her. Another two squads remained outside - Catra had given instructions to watch their clients in the event things turned out to be a trap.

It did not, as it happened, turn out to be a trap. The command crew was downright flabbergasted when their supposedly impregnable doors slid open and Catra’s squad opened fire. To their credit, Catra thought, the idea of surrendering never seemed to enter their minds. She waved over one of her soldiers.

“Search this area - they might not have had time to destroy their intel yet.” The soldier saluted smartly and gestured to the others, who moved in and began systematically tossing the area.

Something itched at the back of Catra's mind. Yes, the majority of the soldiers had been putting up only token resistance, but the whole base seemed understaffed to her - particularly one that was meant to serve as a test site for a new battle platform. Frowning, she headed back out to where the Horde soldiers were waiting.

"Hey," she said, pointing her finger at one of them, "where's the rest of your people?"

"All those loyal to our cause are here," the soldier replied, "those more loyal to the cause were uh, 'volunteered' for special detail. They departed two days ago."

"What special detail?"

"Plans to capture a Rebellion spy. We leaked reports of a new battle platform we know the Rebellion to be interested in. There's an increased guard presence throughout the area that should funnel any intruders into an area where the detail will pick them up."

"So the weapons platform was never coming here?"

"Come here? That damn thing can't even walk upright yet, if the rumors are true."

Catra hummed to herself. "All this trouble to catch a spy? I didn't even know the Rebellion *had* spies."

"You've been away," the Horde soldier said, giving her a look, "but the Rebellion has not been idle. There was a spy slipped into Horde high command not too long ago - killed a full squad of trackers who were on their trail, to boot. There's even a rumor it was a *princess* ."

Catra kept her face impassive. "Took them long enough to start valuing espionage operations. Pity about the platform, though - it would've more than covered our fee."

“Fortunately for you,” the soldier said, smiling, “we still have the other equipment and supplies we promised instead.”

Catra grinned back. “Good. Have your people bring it around and we’ll load it ourselves.”

“Commander,” the soldier said, hesitantly, “we’d love to have you back, you know that?”

Catra sighed. “That isn’t an option anymore, and you know it. Your men are free to join me, if they wish, but I’m only coming back here one way.”

“Dead?”

“Standing on Hordak’s corpse.” Catra clarified. “After that… we’ll see.”

The soldier didn’t seem like he particularly liked the answer, but he nodded in understanding. “When the time comes, Commander, I hope we’re not facing you.”

“Me too. I would hate to have to fight a former client.”

“Fair enough.” The soldier nodded, and gestured to the others to begin retrieving Catra’s payment.

The outpost became a swarm of activity, as the remaining Horde soldiers and Catra’s people began hauling out crates of medical supplies and other materials. Catra watched the proceedings, trying not to fret. There was no doubt that Lonnie’s encounter with Adora - and the dead scouts - meant Adora was likely the spy in question. What’s more, if Adora happened to have scoped the plans for Entrapta’s battle platform, and the Rebellion was now interested in it, she’d probably be the one leading any sort of effort to find out more about it, which meant that Adora was, in all likelihood, going to walk into a trap - if she hadn’t already done so. Sighing, Catra headed for one of the skiffs, where she grabbed the communicator and contacted Scorpia.

“Commander! Something you need?” Scorpia’s voice crackled over the headset.

“No, the mission was a success. We’re loading our payment and should be headed back your way shortly. There’s something I want you to have the intel team look into.”

“What’s up?”

“One of the soldiers here told me the Horde’s got a counter-espionage operation going on. I want to know about the results - if they capture or kill any Rebellion operatives, that’s a need we can fill for them in the future.”

“You think we should contact the Rebellion leadership directly?”

“Hell no! But there’s sure to be some industrious Rebellion commander out to prove themselves that might not look down their nose at assistance from an outside source.”

“Not bad, Commander. You’re starting to show good business sense.” Scorpia sounded almost *proud* of Catra. “I’ll make a Commander out of you yet.”

“Gods, I hope not.” Catra said, grimacing. “Just get the intel team on it, could you? I feel like time is going to be a factor. If the Rebellion’s got any smarts, they’ll make a move sooner rather than later.”

“So on the Rebellion’s timetable, that should be sometime in the next couple of months, right?” Scorpia laughed. It had been a running joke among Catra and her that the Rebellion’s command structure was ridiculously slow to act on obvious threats.

Catra snorted. “Probably. We should keep an eye out either way.”

“Of course, Commander. I’ll contact our people before you get back.”

The sound of excited shouting drew Catra's attention away from the comms, and she looked back at the base in brief confusion. The soldiers she'd directed to search the command center were heading in her direction, calling urgently.

"Commander! We've got to get moving, now!" Leo was charging in the direction of the skiff. "There's a phalanx of Horde reinforcements on the way!"

That got Catra moving. She shouted orders to the other two skiffs, then sprinted down to help load the last of their payment as the engines began to spin up. Within a few minutes, they were airborne.
"What happened?" Catra asked, "Did they get off a distress call?"

"No," Leo said, still breathing hard, "looks like we weren't the only ones who had the idea to launch a strike today. The Rebellion is moving on a Horde border outpost."

Catra frowned. "That's unusually aggressive for the Rebellion." Her mind worked for a few moments, and she suddenly laughed. "There's no *way* they'd be that clever."

Leo looked at her, confused. "Commander?"

Catra turned to Leo, eyes bright with merriment. "They're finally starting to act like a real army! I'd lay even odds the attack's a distraction to get an agent across the border headed for this facility."

Leo didn't look convinced. "Could be they're just retaliating for the kidnapping thing, don't you think?"

"It's possible," Catra allowed, "but if they weren't willing to send their own soldiers to get the kids back, I don't think they'd launch any kind of retaliatory strike over it. They *are* , apparently, interested in some of Entrapta's old research - enough to have already sent a spy across the border once before. We knew about the rumored battle platform, it's a sure bet the Rebellion heard the same thing. Which means, of course, their spy is going to run

into a trap.” *Adora is going to run into a trap* , Catra thought, with a sudden uncomfortable jolt.

“Is that… do we want that?” Leo asked, raising an eyebrow. He’d been a Rebellion soldier before joining, and the concern in his voice - possibly for old comrades, Catra assumed - was audible.

“We don’t get involved unless someone’s paying, Leo.” Catra reminded him (and herself). “Besides, if the description of the Rebellion’s spy is anything to go by, they can take care of themselves.” *Adora,* Catra thought, *you’d better be able to take care of yourself.* She shook the thought from her mind and went to the pilot to make sure the skiffs gave the fighting a wide berth.

A few days later, Catra found herself piloting a skiff at dangerous speeds, racing back to the Fright Zone.

Chapter End Notes

> God damn but I am torn about leaving that beginning bit in. For starters, I've done a similar thing in a different fic before, and I do so hate repeating a trick (he said, writing his third fucking Catradora fic). For another thing, I'm not sure it fits the tone? I dunno, y'all tell me. I reserve the right to come back and rip it out later. If you are reading this and it's already gone, just *think* about what it might have been. UPDATE: Well, I didn't rip it out, but I *did* end up adding more to it so that it fits the tone a bit better and does what I wanted it to do a little more. If you happen to have caught the earlier version, let me know if the new version is better?
>
> Anyway, I am fully back on my time jumping bullshit, so obviously we're going to get Adora's experience with the Alliance attack next chapter, and we'll discover what has Catra so riled (as if there was any doubt?), most likely. Might take a couple chapters to get there, it depends.
>
> Also in my endless quest to accrue more bullshit ideas, I have fallen down a Battletech hole (and also been reading the

Lancer RPG sourcebook) so if I end up doing a mech-focused AU at some point y'all will know who to blame (I really think mechs are cool, okay). This is not - I repeat, *not* a promise to write anything like this. I've just had some thoughts, is all.

Operation

Chapter Summary

> Adora, Glimmer, and Bow execute an operation. Catra visits. Octavia gets theatrical.

Chapter Notes

> Hey so I don't know if this makes a difference or not but there's some Violence in this one of the interrogation variety? It isn't particularly graphic (nothing in this fic really is) but for some reason I'm including a warning here and not elsewhere. Also, on the off chance you missed it, I did in fact go back and fiddle with the first part of the last chapter to make it work better. I think it's much improved, and if you haven't seen it, you should go read it! Go! This chapter will still be here when you're done.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora felt strange, dressed in normal Rebellion soldier fatigues and carrying a rifle. A pack slung on her back contained a Horde uniform and helmet, which was kept secret from everyone - even the soldiers she was traveling with. Her face was also obscured, and she'd cut her hair short to be less recognizable. The Rebellion, officially, was conducting a retaliatory strike on the Horde to avenge the sacking of several settlements that (if you asked Adora) should have been better protected in the first place. Still, even getting the leadership to agree to *this* had been an effort, and if not for Adora's own special mission, it never would've been approved in the first place. Adora didn't like that fact at all, but she had precious little say in the matter.

Bow and Glimmer were at the front of the column, as the two were in charge of the whole operation. This was something Glimmer had insisted upon, being completely unwilling to allow Adora to strike out on her own again.

“I’ll bring the Sword of Protection with me,” Glimmer had argued, “so that if you need it, we can get it to you this time.”

“The Horde will notice you leaving the battlefield!” Adora had argued back, but Glimmer had smiled confidently and assured her that this was, in fact, not going to be the case.

“Once we start pushing the Horde back, they won’t expect the Princesses to stay around for the mop-up.”

Adora had frowned in the way she’d been doing more and more recently, but there wasn’t time to get into it, so she’d dropped the subject and trusted that Glimmer was right. The transport, one of several that the Rebellion had rebuilt from Horde scraps, bounced over the ground, and Adora braced herself along with the rest of the soldiers as the transport rocked. Their commander, a gruff older man, stood at the front and barked the mission briefing to the troops. Adora didn’t have the heart to listen along, as she knew she would just be leaving them behind to whatever fate had in store for them. She tried to remind herself that getting Horde intel was worth the sacrifice, but as she looked over the other Rebellion soldiers, she couldn’t help but wish they knew what they were about to fight for.

“Get ready to hit the ground running, men! We’re almost to the rally point!”

The distant rumble of Horde cannon fire echoed over the sound of the transport engine, and Adora saw one of the younger soldiers flinch. She reached out and gave him a reassuring pat on the shoulder.

“First battle?” She asked, unable to stop herself.

The soldier swallowed, then nodded. “Joined up six months back, after my Gran passed away. She wouldn’t have approved of getting involved, but… I can’t just sit back and do nothing, right?”

“Sometimes you have to go against the ones you care about to do the right thing.” Adora said, thinking of Catra. She gave a

reassuring smile. “Just trust your squadmates and you’ll get through fine.”

“How long have you been with the Rebellion?”

Adora shrugged. “Five, maybe six years at this point? I joined up back when She-Ra reappeared.”

The young soldier’s eyes went wide at the mention of the legendary She-Ra, just like everyone’s eyes always did. “Really? Have you ever fought with her? Is she as powerful as they say?”

Adora laughed. “She’s pretty powerful, but… I don’t think she’s like everyone thinks. She needs people like us, maybe more than we need her. She can’t win the war on her own, you know?”

The soldier seemed to consider this. “But she’s a Princess. The Princesses are the only ones who can beat the Horde.”

“If they’re the only ones,” Adora said, shaking her head, “then why are we the ones fighting? The Princesses are powerful - no doubt about that - but there aren’t enough of them. Soldiers like us need to be able to pick up the slack.” She almost added, but did not say, *and woe to the Princesses if they forget that.*

If the soldier had any reply, he didn’t get the chance to say it, as the transport was suddenly rocked by a near-miss from a Horde emplacement. The transport skidded to a stop.

The commander’s voice boomed through the smoke. “Everyone out!”

Adora followed the other soldiers out the back of the transport, and immediately she began following the mission plan. The Horde was, for now, content to rely on their turrets to keep the Rebellion forces back - they were fortified enough (or so they would think) to ride out any real attack. That was where Glimmer came in - her job was to teleport in and drop some Bow-designed explosives to take out the turrets and force the Horde to engage. The trouble was, the turret operators needed to be distracted, which meant

the Rebellion soldiers would need to draw their fire. So the soldiers were rushing to dig in and take cover, trying to stay safe long enough for Glimmer to come through.

The transports provided good cover, but it meant sacrificing what was valuable equipment. Manpower was considered more valuable to the Rebellion (for a change, Adora thought sourly), so the transports were to be sacrificed if necessary. As Adora's transport rocked in response to heavy fire, she found herself thinking the "if necessary" part had been a bit optimistic. She took up a position near the front end, taking potshots at any Horde soldier foolish enough to stick their head over the wall, along with shots that splashed harmlessly off the turret surfaces.

One of the other transports crumpled with a dull whump, followed by a roaring explosion. Screams rent the air and Adora shut them out. She had to focus on the mission, now. There would be plenty of time to concentrate on the fallen later. Another dull whump, followed by another explosion split the air - but this time, the explosion came from one of the turrets, causing a cheer to go up from the Rebellion soldiers. The second turret went up shortly thereafter, and Adora cheered along with the other soldiers as they began the second phase of the operation.

A second force of Rebellion transports, these ones reinforced to become battering rams, of a sort, wheeled forward, trailed by the rest of the Rebellion's forces. As Adora watched the first of the transports slam into the Horde gates, she glanced around to see if she could see Glimmer and Bow anywhere as she moved forward. The Horde soldiers, who had previously been content to let the turrets do the work, were now taking shots over the wall at the charging Rebellion forces. Adora felt a few bullets whizz overhead, and in spite of her training she felt her heart-rate increase. Not out of fear, but out of the thrill of knowing she was as mortal as any of the other soldiers with her, that her skill and luck were all she had. No She-Ra construct to save her, not here, not now. It felt fair. It felt *right* .

A few of her squadmates fell, and she kept going, snapping off shots that cut down some of the Horde defenders. One screamed as she fell off the wall top, and Adora felt a dark satisfaction at the sound. When she reached the wall, she cut right, and began heading into the forest that marked the limit of the Rebellion's territory. It stung to leave the battlefield, but it was necessary, and she'd already made her peace with it.

After less than an hour's walking, the sounds of battle faded, the chatter of gunfire and shouted orders replaced by the sounds of birds and Adora's own tread on the forest floor. She paused to consult her map and confirm she was headed in the right direction, and picked up the pace. Glimmer and Bow were, if they were following the plan, already waiting for her at the rendezvous point. The sunlight shone down through the trees, casting dappled shadows on the ground that made Adora relax ever-so-slightly.

When she reached the rendezvous point, Bow dropped out of a tree next to her. "Adora! How'd the battle go?"

"Looked like we were close to breaking through the wall when I left. Whoever's in charge of that outpost got complacent - I don't think they had a backup plan for if the turrets went down." Adora couldn't quite help the tone of contempt coloring her voice.

"Lucky for us, huh?" Glimmer said, appearing in a poof of sparkles as usual. "Bow and I had a chance to do some looking around, by the way. Doesn't seem to be anyone nearby. Our target's a little further off, but I admit, I'm kind of shocked we didn't see any patrols."

"They're getting sloppy." Adora said, with a wry grin. "Catra kept them all on their toes in a way whoever replaced her hasn't."

"And while they're getting sloppy, your old friend is running around waging her own private war." Glimmer said, frowning. "I think I would've preferred it if she'd stayed with the Horde."

Adora snorted. “That’s *if* it’s really her, and not just some other disgruntled Horde soldier. She had the loyalty of some fairly talented commanders who might have left if they suspected foul play.”

“I don’t know Adora,” Bow chimed in, “didn’t you say they held a trial and everything for the people who blew her tank up? Seems like it was an actual error or some rogue element in the Horde to me.”

Somehow, Adora didn’t roll her eyes. “Lying and manipulation is how the Horde functions. If anyone loyal to Catra thought for a second it was anything but an accident, a show trial and execution wouldn’t convince them otherwise.”

As they got closer to their destination, the light began to dim. A heavy fog began to roll in, causing Glimmer to shiver involuntarily. “You usually get this kind of weather in the Fright Zone, Adora?”

Adora, who’d become lost in thought, suddenly noticed the fog herself. “No,” she said, peering at the fog, “this is new.” There was, she thought, a strange color to the fog. It almost seemed to have a reddish tinge, seeming almost familiar. A similar fog had occasionally rolled through some of the hallways of Horde Command when she was a cadet, usually as a result of...

Adora’s blood ran cold. “This is a trap.”

“Good thing I brought your sword, then.” Glimmer said, tossing the Sword of Protection to Adora.

Adora caught it easily, but hesitated to transform. If they could take care of whatever was coming without the lightshow of her transformation, there was a chance they could still salvage the mission. Bow had an arrow readied and was scanning the area for signs of approaching soldiers.

“See anything?” Glimmer asked, staff at the ready.

“Nothing yet,” Bow replied. “Maybe we should just start heading back where we came from? Away from the creepy fog?”

“Yeah,” Adora said, slowly, “I think you’ve got the right idea.”

“I’ll teleport us out of here.” Glimmer said, and turned to wave Bow over, when the first gunshot ripped through his shoulder and spun him around. Glimmer screamed and immediately teleported to his side, teleporting again just in time to avoid the second gunshot.

Adora whipped around in the direction of the gunfire and saw a group of four soldiers emerge from the fog, wearing strange uniforms - breathing masks connected to tanks, and moving with a terrifying aura of inevitability. She’d spoken the words and transformed into She-Ra before she was even conscious of doing it, and charged the soldiers. It was reckless, and she was off-balance, and she should not have been as surprised as she was when two of the soldiers seemed to disappear into thin air, only to reappear behind her to deliver a pair of swift blows to her head. She-Ra stumbled forward, directly into the swung stun baton of the third, and she grunted as electricity shot through her, and her vision briefly went white. Glimmer, meanwhile, had teleported Bow out of danger and reappeared back to help fight, drawing two of them off.

She-Ra gritted her teeth as the fight continued, and ran some calculations in her head. Bow was, most likely, bleeding somewhere in the woods and would be a liability. Glimmer probably could not teleport the three of them more than a few times before she was worn out, and her effective distance was reduced. If she were only teleporting *two* , and pursuit didn’t immediately follow….

“Glimmer!” She-Ra shouted, “You have to get Bow out of here!”

“We can’t! These guys will just follow!” Glimmer shouted back, ducking a swipe from one of the soldiers.

“No they won’t!” She-Ra shouted, and threw the Sword of Protection at Glimmer.

Glimmer caught the sword almost by reflex, and stared back at Adora, who had pulled out a set of daggers again and was somehow still managing to hold her own. Her knuckles whitened around the sword hilt. “We’ll come back for you! I promise!”

“I know you will,” Adora said, grunting as another blow landed, “now get out of here!”

As soon as Glimmer disappeared, the two who had been fighting her circled around Adora, effectively surrounding her. Adora spat blood on the ground, still standing, as the four stared at her.

“Well?” Adora snarled, twirling a dagger in her hand, “Come on, then!”

The four closed on her simultaneously, swinging in a synchronized motion. Adora blocked three of them, but the fourth hit home, spinning her around. Adora let the momentum carry her around, and one of the daggers flashed. One of the soldiers staggered back, blood fountaining from his neck. He fell without a word. The remaining three continued their onslaught. Adora felt a rib break, and then her knee exploded in pain and she twisted and fell to the ground. The blows came thick and fast, and darkness closed in around Adora’s vision.

When her consciousness returned, she found her arms and legs had been restrained and were stuck into metal cylinders. It hurt to breathe, and her right knee felt like it was at least twice its size. Her head pounded, and she couldn’t suppress a groan of pain.

“Awake already? You always were quick to recover, weren’t you Adora?”

Adora turned her head to find the source of the voice and was greeted unpleasantly by the smug face of Octavia, standing next to a control console. Rather than respond, Adora chose to spit blood at her.

"Ah, still rebellious, huh?" The force captain smirked. "Let's see if we can solve that problem. You *betrayed* us, Adora. Now, you're going to help us by telling me exactly what the Rebellion's planning."

The sound that came out of Adora's mouth was half-laughter, half-groan. Laughing, as it turned out, did not exactly make her ribs feel particularly good.

"Have it your way." Octavia said, and threw a switch.

Adora screamed as red-tinged electricity coursed through her. Her muscles tensed, making her injuries feel even worse. Black spots appeared in her vision again as the pain became blinding. Just when Adora felt like she was about to collapse, Octavia flipped another switch and the electricity died, leaving Adora breathing heavily.

"Not bad!" Octavia said, smiling wider. "I see life in the Rebellion hasn't made you *too* soft. I wonder how much of this you can take? Or maybe, you can just cooperate and this will all be over."

A glare from Adora provided all the answer Octavia needed. She shrugged carelessly. "Have it your way then. Have another dose."

Somehow, the pain managed to be worse. Adora felt like her body was being torn apart. She screamed again, long and ragged. Her vision narrowed to a single point, and she felt herself losing consciousness again. She welcomed it.

When she woke up again, it was to Catra's hand caressing her cheek gently. Adora leaned into the touch, sighing.

"Always the martyr, huh, Adora? You know, you could have just let Bow die."

"You know I couldn't." Adora muttered.

"Yeah, I mean… I'm you, so obviously I know that."

The room was empty. Adora was still secured in the torture device, Octavia having apparently decided to just leave her there rather than bothering to move her to a proper cell. Catra was sitting on the control console, staring at Adora with a worried expression.

"Those soldiers… they were enhanced, somehow. Like a princess."

"Yeah," Adora said, nodding weakly, "I noticed."

"That was Black Garnet energy they used. The electricity powering this thing too - that's like what you saw when Shadow Weaver would punish us. Well, me. She only touched you a couple of times."

"I know. I should've done something about it."

"My point is," Catra said, ignoring Adora's guilt, "I think we know what that means."

"Yeah," Adora said, feeling a rush of despair, "Shadow Weaver's running things again."

"She's probably on her way here now, honestly."

"I know."

"She can rip your mind apart. Turn you back into an obedient Horde soldier."

"I know."

Catra scratched her chin and looked out a window. "You think Sparkles will come through and pull your ass out of this one?"

"I hope so. The alternative isn't exactly pleasant."

"Yeah." Catra shuddered. "Not really something I want to think about."

"You mean not something *I* want to think about."

Silence descended. Catra paced back and forth, and then stopped in front of Adora and looked up at her with a frown. “You’re not going to give up, are you?”

“No.” Adora said. “What if you’re still alive? I’ve got to at least find you and kick your ass for making me worry.”

Catra laughed. “Good. Hold on to that, if nothing else.”

“Hey, Catra?”

“Yeah?”

“I’m scared.”

“I know.”

Chapter End Notes

Featuring the Parasite "SKULLS" Unit

Well, sort of.

The breaks between chapters are getting longer, I know. Sorry about that. I'm trying not to burn myself out, but hoo boy work has been busy and I have been tired. Got some travel coming up soon that'll probably introduce further delays - but you'll have a new season of She-Ra to focus on between now and the next chapter, most likely, so I'm sure you will survive.

See you soon enough!

Also, on an unrelated note, I cannot believe Homestuck suddenly updated in the year of our fucking lord two thousand nineteen are you fucking *kidding me* with that shit?

You Again

Chapter Summary

> Catra mounts a rescue. Adora hallucinates. Two words become proof.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

It had been chance, as it turned out. One of the members of Catra's intel team had been stationed at the Horde facility attacked in the Rebellion's feint, and shortly after the base had fallen, Glimmer had appeared in the aftermath, carrying a severely wounded comrade and shouting that she was taking volunteers for a rescue operation. This was until, of course, the wounded comrade had pointed out that they didn't know where Adora would be - and upon hearing the name Adora the intel member immediately snuck off and send a high-priority message to Scorpia. Upon arriving back at the base, Catra had been informed, and almost immediately began planning for a rescue operation.

It was around this time that Scorpia pointed out the obvious - rescuing Adora was not a job - and Catra had angrily replied that she'd do this one herself then, thank you very fucking much.

"Commander, you know I trust your judgment on this one, but remember what this will mean. You're going to confirm to Adora you're alive. Are you sure you're ready for that?"

Catra had paused, at that. She hated that she'd paused, but she'd paused. She hadn't been laying particularly low, and the intel team had definitely reported that the Rebellion leadership was at least aware of a group of mercenaries, but apart from rumors nobody seemed willing to confirm Catra's existence. She shook her head, banishing those thoughts. Adora was in trouble. Adora would save *her* . Catra would be damned twice over if she let Adora hold that over her head. "Yeah. If the Horde manages to

get rid of She-Ra, I don't know that the Rebellion manages to hang on. No Rebellion means Hordak's free to hunt us down. Can't have that."

Scorpia gave Catra a long look that said she had her own opinion as to why Catra was so set on saving Adora, but nodded. "Alright Commander. You want support on this op?"

Catra shook her head. "The fewer of us involved, the better - any larger force would get noticed. I'll take the modified skiff, get across undetected, grab Adora, bring her out somewhere safe."

"You think you know where she's being held?"

"Yeah, there's a holding facility near where they came from - you remember, it's where I sent Octavia to get her out of my goddamn hair."

Scorpia whistled low and made a face. "Octavia, huh? Better get to Adora before Octavia gets too enthusiastic about interrogating her."

Catra felt a stab of guilt. "All the more reason to get moving."

"I'll be on comms. If you think you're in trouble, we'll send in the calvary." Scorpia held up a claw to forestall any objection. " *You're* important too, Commander. If it means the Horde knows we exist afterwards, so be it."

After another moment's hesitation, Catra nodded. "Fine. I'll just have to not get caught then, huh?"

"That would be preferable."

Shortly thereafter, Catra was airborne. As she neared the Fright Zone border, she flipped a few switches on the control console and the skiff shimmered and vanished from sight. Catra knew the way to the holding facility by heart. They'd kept one of the Princesses there, once - Catra couldn't remember her name - something ice-related, she thought. It had hurt Catra, to see

someone that young in chains. If she'd made it a little too easy for the Rebellion to get in and set the girl free, well, nobody had noticed at the time.

She got as close as she dared to the facility and set the skiff down. The number of guards had been increased, Catra thought, but she wasn't too concerned. The Horde would be expecting a larger force - something on par with the attack that had gotten Adora into this mess - and their focus was on watching the main approach. Catra, on the other hand, had circled around and was approaching from behind; closer to the Horde's presence. She took a moment to consider her options for entry: over the wall, through the back gate, or, if she was feeling particularly stealthy, there was a drainage tunnel she could use. Given the increased security, Catra elected to take the drainage tunnel.

After a few seconds of crawling through the damp and muddy tunnel, Catra regretted her decision, but she was fully committed to her plan now and refused to back out on principle. She crawled until she was well beyond the perimeter wall and found a relatively un-occupied section of the courtyard, then popped up and moved to cover. There were, as expected, a greater amount of guards than usual, but Catra had been sneaking around Horde facilities since she was barely able to walk. It was child's play, really - the facility layout was, fortunately, largely unchanged, barring a few alterations to the doors that she'd ordered after the last breakout. She was surprised to discover the door codes had remained unchanged, and shook her head at the sloppiness of the operation.

When she reached the holding cells, Catra was surprised to find them empty. A sickening feeling washed over her - had she been too late? Was Adora already on her way to the main Horde facility? It seemed awfully fast, even for a prisoner as valuable as She-Ra. An opportunity to find out what was going on presented itself in the form of a very surprised guard who chose that moment to pass through the area. Catra moved so quickly she surprised herself - the guard was suddenly spun around with Catra's knife at his throat.

“The prisoner,” Catra’s voice rasped, “where is she?”

The guard almost sounded smug. “The captain’s been giving her special attention in the interrogation room. Once Shadow Weaver gets here, she’ll tell us anything we want to know.”

Catra felt the beginnings of a snarl. “Too bad the prisoner won’t be here when she arrives.”

“Oh please,” the guard said, “you Rebellion soldiers are all alike. You haven’t got the strength to get past a building full of Horde soldiers.”

“A shame I’m not a Rebellion soldier,” Catra said, and drove her knife down. The guard gave a single reedy gasp and died. Catra stood for a moment, feeling a deep rage begin to build. Shadow Weaver, coming here? Going after *Adora* ? A fierce protectiveness (or was it possessiveness?) ignited in her chest, and Catra sheathed her knife in favor of shouldering her rifle. She would teach the Horde a *lesson* .

The sound of screams and gunfire filtered into the interrogation room, slowly bringing Adora back to consciousness. Octavia had been back twice, and with each session Adora could feel her body breaking down. Her throat was raw from screaming and the pain in her wounded knee had gone from being unbearable to not being something she could feel at all, and Adora wasn’t actually certain which was worse. Catra, or, she supposed, her delirious hallucination of Catra, appeared between sessions, begging Adora not to give up.

“Wh...what’s happening?” Adora managed to croak. One of her eyes was swollen shut, and she could feel dried blood on her face.

Catra walked over to the door, looked out, and came back. “I can’t actually tell you. You know that. I’m not real, remember? But if I had to guess, it’s your friends. Or Force Captains fighting over who gets credit for your capture. I guess it could be that too.”

The sounds of gunfire got louder, and then stopped completely. A solitary set of footsteps echoed eerily down the hallway. Adora was suddenly gripped by the fear that maybe it wasn't the Rebellion, maybe Shadow Weaver had decided to take Adora for herself. She made one last effort to struggle against the bindings securing her to the machine, but she only accomplished sending a wave of pain through her body that caused her to black out again.

There was a creak as the door swung open, and Adora looked up to see… Catra. Catra, except this Catra wore an eyepatch, and had a rifle slung over her back, and was covered in blood.

"Wh… what?"

Catra's eye widened in shock but she seemed to pull herself together pretty quickly. "Are you okay? Can you talk?"

"Ha!" Adora laughed, a dry, painful sound. "You're talking to yourself."

Catra cocked her head to one side in a movement that was so *familiar* , Adora became absolutely certain she was still hallucinating. "Talking to…?" She shook her head to clear it. "I'm getting you out of here." She strode to the control console and looked over it. "I can never remember how this thing works…"

"You can't do anything, remember?" Adora called over. "You're in my head. Said so yourself."

Catra ignored her. "Ah, right. It's this one." She flipped the appropriate switch and the restraints popped open. Adora, suddenly lacking in any support and still held upright, toppled forward gracelessly to the floor. Catra hissed in sympathy. "Shit, sorry, I forgot that…"

Adora lay on the cold floor, breathing slowly, eyelids fluttering as her body sent new and interesting signals of protest regarding her new position. Her thoughts were jumbled and disorganized, but one thing came through to her.

“Oh fuck,” Adora breathed out in a tone of voice that managed to convey fear, relief, and utter disbelief at the same time, “this is really happening.”

“Obviously.” Catra snorted, crouching down and beginning an inspection of Adora’s wounds. Her hands moved almost automatically, probing Adora’s legs (Adora bit back a cry of pain when Catra reached her injured knee, and Catra briefly felt like her heart was breaking), then her arms, and finally, with a care that Adora had forgotten her to be capable of, Adora’s face.

Adora leaned into the touch unconsciously, almost forgetting her injuries and the fact that Catra was covered in blood and, apparently, had a metal arm now. These new observations were drowned out by one thought which stood out among all the others, a thought so preposterous that she could barely bring herself to say it out loud. “It’s really you, isn’t it?” she whispered, putting one trembling hand over Catra's.

Catra could hardly stand to look at her. She'd crawled out of the wreckage of a burning tank, become a one-woman army and damn near annihilated an entire Horde prison camp's staff, faced down Hordak on an almost daily basis for *years* - and yet she felt her heart beat faster, and her mouth dry up. Adora’s gaze was so piercing, so *focused* on her and only her, like Catra was some kind of goddess, like Adora was about to swear eternal fealty right then and there, like she, Catra, was the Entire Goddamn Universe. When she answered, her voice was thick. “Yeah, of course it is. Come on, you think I’d leave you here?”

No , Adora suddenly realized, *no I didn’t.* Catra had, after all, been who she’d been thinking of during her captivity. That Catra was alive - *in front of her right now* , no less - had remained a wild hope in spite of the ‘furry lady’ Glimmer had told her about. Still, she had to be sure. “Say it.” Adora said, suddenly. “If it’s you, say it.”

“Say what?”

“You know exactly what. Or… or if this isn’t one of Shadow Weaver’s tricks, you know what.”

Catra looked confused for a moment, before she rolled her eye. *Of course* , Catra thought. She lifted Adora’s chin so that the two were looking at one another and flashed a quick, incredibly self-satisfied grin that made Adora’s heartbeat stutter for a moment. “Hey, Adora.”

Chapter End Notes

A short one, because I liked ending it on "Hey Adora" way too much. When you have a good final line, stick with it! That's my excuse.

Anyway I devoured all of Season 2 and was *absurdly* pleased by the little detail that Adora sleeps with a dagger close to hand - thus totally validating my decision to have her favor them as weapons instead of the Sword of Protection when she's without it. Clearly I am a mind reader.

Next chapter will pick up more or less where this one leaves off (obviously). I thought about having a whole confrontation between Catra and Octavia, but I think it's actually better to just have Catra show up having Wrecked Everyone's Shit. It gave me an excuse to shift to Adora's perspective, too! As for when it goes up, well, I'm flying back to the US tomorrow for a bit of vacation (I have a train to catch in about uh... seven hours, so I should go to bed) so writing time might be limited.

As always, your kudos and comments and whatnot are PURE FUEL FOR MY EGO, and also I really just kind of like reading and replying to them. Now if you need me, I'll be over in the corner obsessing about the metatextual/metaphysical implications of the Homestuck Epilogues or, you know, just hollering about how Catra is clearly going to end up forming her own army in season 3, which will bring this whole fanfic

FULL FUCKIN' CIRCLE and place me on the throne as fuckin' Nostradomus.

Reunion

Chapter Summary

> The trip back to base. Catra and Adora attempt to make conversation.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The feel of wind on her face and the low hum of a skiff engine brought Adora back to consciousness slowly at first. As her mind slowly kicked into gear, two important pieces of information jumped to the forefront of her mind:

1. She was no longer being held prisoner
2. She was apparently flying...somewhere.

She tried to sit up, but doing so made her dizzy and she felt herself losing the battle to stay upright. Her eyelids fluttered shut. There was an annoyed snort and she felt a set of hands guide her gently back down to the floor. For a moment, Adora kept her eyes closed, waiting for the dizziness to pass.

“Take it easy,” a voice said, achingly familiar, “I think you’ve probably had a long couple of days.”

Adora opened her eyes to see Catra looming over her with undisguised concern. “Catra?”

Catra’s expression showed a deep relief which she quickly hid behind a wry grin. “That’s me.”

“What… what happened?”

“You collapsed as we were leaving, so I carried you out.” Catra couldn’t help the smirk that crept across her face. “Too much excitement for you, I guess.”

Adora let out a huff of laughter, and then winced as her broken rib reminded her of its existence. The shift in Catra's expression from mocking to concerned happened so quickly it almost caught Adora by surprise. It seemed like it caught Catra by surprise as well, as she hastily recomposed her expression back to something more neutral.

"Guess I'll have to reign in my natural charm to keep you from hurting yourself, huh?"

Adora winced again as she chuckled. "Guess so." There was an awkward pause before she spoke again. "Where are you taking me?"

Catra looked away, her tail whipping back and forth nervously. "Somewhere safe where we can get you healed up."

"You could just drop me in a Rebellion town, you know." Adora said, before she could stop herself.

"Yes." Catra agreed, "I could." She stood and turned to look over the landscape, and apart from a slight tension to her shoulders she didn't seem to be giving the matter any further thought. Just as Adora was about to say something to break the silence, Catra spoke in a forced casual tone. "Would you like me to?"

"No!" Adora said, too quickly, too forcefully. "No, I just… I don't want to trouble you. You didn't have to -"

"I *did* ." Catra cut her off.

Adora looked like she wanted to respond, but Scorpia's crackled over Catra's earpiece and she snapped into a businesslike mode almost immediately. "Commander, any progress?"

Catra keyed the transmitter. "Package secured, Scorp. She's in bad shape, but she's alive. Have a medical team standing by - her leg's pretty bad and she's got some damage to her ribs, but otherwise she's okay. Make sure the Rebellion knows they don't need to mount a rescue of their own, while you're at it."

“Already done, Commander.” There was a pause where Catra could almost hear the wheels turning in Scorpia’s head before she spoke again, a little more hesitantly. “You sure about bringing her here? As soon as Adora knows where we are, it’s a sure thing the Rebellion will know the same thing as soon as she goes back.”

“I’m sure.” Catra said, looking back over her shoulder at Adora, who mouthed ‘package?’ at her and rolled her eyes. Catra looked away before the fond smile on her face became too noticeable and whispered. “I need to be sure she’s...”

“I know, Commander.” Scorpia said, doing an admirable job of keeping the knowing grin out of her voice. “What’s your ETA?”

“Shouldn’t be more than a couple hours.” Catra said, stretching. “Home in time for dinner.”

“Well then, I’ll leave you two to chat. You’ve likely got some catching up to do.” There was a brief pause, and then she added, “Good luck, Commander.”

Catra snorted. “See you soon. Catra out.” She flipped the radio off and took a moment to organize her thoughts. It suddenly hit her that she was alone, with Adora, in a situation where they weren’t trying to kill one another, for the first time in years. She’d been running on adrenaline and an instinctual need to get Adora out of danger, and now the thought of what she'd actually *do* once she'd got Adora out was new and utterly terrifying. For years, Catra had an entire speech of sorts planned out, where she’d tear into Adora for everything, but when she went looking for the anger that would have fueled her speech, she couldn’t find it. Instead, she just felt relieved to see Adora alive, along with a growing nervousness about what to say.

Fortunately, Adora saved Catra from having to think too much further. “So uh, Scorpia’s with you?”

“Huh? Yeah, yeah, she and Entrapta kind of saved me.” Catra held up her prosthetic hand by way of explanation. “I wasn’t

exactly in good shape."

Adora seemed to notice her hand for the first time, as well as the eyepatch. "What… what *happened* to you?"

"Souvenirs from the tank explosion." Catra said, shrugging with an exaggerated carelessness. "Entrapta managed to save what she could, but…" She trailed off, a pained expression flashing across her face that she couldn't suppress.

"I'm sorry." Adora said, all in a rush of emotion, "I tried to find you but… There was an army between me and you, I couldn't, I should have tried harder, I thought -" at some point she wasn't talking about the battle, and she knew it.

Catra was not, later on, able to quite recall how it happened. Some instinct she didn't realize she possessed, perhaps. All she knew is that suddenly she'd wrapped her arms around Adora and pulled her close. "It's alright," she murmured, not quite knowing what she was forgiving - Adora's failure to be the one to get her out of the burning wreckage, or Adora's abandonment of her when they were younger, or maybe *everything* . "I'm here." she said. "I've got you."

Adora clung to Catra like a lifeline, too worn out to really care that she was incredibly vulnerable right now, that if Catra wanted to she could kill her easily. She knew, with a certainty that went down to her bones, that she was safe. It was such an absurd thought that she started laughing in spite of herself.

Catra's grip loosened, and she pulled back to give Adora a questioning look. "Adora? You okay?"

"It's just-" Adora said, torn between laughing and sobbing, both actions which only served to aggravate her broken ribs, "look at me. Look at *us* . Did you ever expect… I mean…"

"Not exactly how you thought seeing me again would go, huh?" Catra chuckled a little to herself. "If it makes you feel better, it's not how I thought it would go either."

There was a sudden twist in Adora's stomach that had very little to do with her wounds. "And how did you think it would go?"

Something about her voice made Catra nervous, and she found her mouth had gone unreasonably dry. She swallowed, and opened her mouth to joke, do something to change the subject, but instead said, "I thought you'd probably end up killing me."

"Oh Catra," Adora said, smiling and bringing a hand up to stroke Catra's cheek with an aching familiarity, "I could never kill you."

Logically, Catra knew, she and Adora needed to work through everything. They'd hurt each other almost more times than they could count, been fighting on opposite sides of a global war since they were teens, been traumatized by an abusive mother-surrogate, had the weight of the world placed on their shoulders… there was a lot. They needed time to adjust to a world in which they weren't trying to kill each other, figure out what they were to one another - if they were anything. Logically, Catra knew all of these things. She knew that she needed to put some space between them, focus on getting Adora safely back to base and figure out how she was supposed to convince Adora to keep their location secret.

These thoughts all ran through Catra's head as she stared down at Adora, feeling her thumb softly trace her cheek. For her part, Adora had already made up her mind - there was no telling when she'd ever get this chance again, and Catra had been blown halfway to hell once already. So when Catra opened her mouth to say something, she only got as far as "I-" before Adora was moving to meet her with a small, desperate sound and then they were kissing and logic went directly out the fucking window.

Catra's arms moved of their own accord, one wrapping around Adora's waist, the other snaking up her back to provide support, part of her mind at least still conscious of the fact that Adora was, after all, injured. From the way Adora was enthusiastically nibbling at her lower lip, she apparently wasn't too concerned about potential injury. The kiss deepened of its own accord, like it was a

creature with its own ideas - neither sure who was taking the lead, though at least for the moment neither seemed inclined to stop either. They paused, pulled back from one another to stare into one another's eye(s), their breaths mingling for a moment.

"This doesn't… this doesn't fix things between us, does it?" Catra murmured, some semblance of control returning to her.

"No," Adora agreed, moving to close the distance between them again, "but that's okay for now." Her lips ghosted against Catra's. "I missed you so much."

A soft, adoring noise escaped Catra at this and she pulled Adora back into a kiss. Adora felt like Catra was trying to memorize every detail of her mouth (she was, and to be fair, Adora was doing the same), while also feeling like she had just fallen off a cliff. There was only the dizzying rush of falling, except she felt like the ground in this case was Catra, which she wouldn't mind falling on.

Catra was finding herself unable to think of anything much at all that wasn't just Adora, the way Adora smelled, the way her lips tasted, the way that Catra's heart felt like it was going to beat directly out of her chest. It was nothing like she'd expected. Catra knew, with a soul-deep certainty, that this was it - she was Adora's forever now. She was exposed, utterly vulnerable, at the mercies of the woman who had, until very recently, been The Enemy. If, in that moment, Adora asked her to abandon everything and come with her, she would do it. She'd walk right into hell if Adora asked her to - shit, she'd walk backwards. It was a dangerous thought, but Catra didn't care.

It wasn't until Catra pulled Adora a little closer that the matter of Adora's ribs reasserted itself, and she hissed in pain. It was like a gunshot had gone off. Catra sprang backwards like she'd been electrocuted, an apology already on her lips, a rushed "oh shit I'm sorry are you okay?"

Adora, meanwhile, hadn't taken her arms from where they'd settled around the back of Catra's neck, and in spite of the pain it caused had *followed* Catra, was smiling reassuringly. "I'm fine, it's okay."

Catra's more professional instincts reasserted themselves and she slowly, carefully put Adora back into a more reclined position. Adora still hadn't let go, and Catra even more slowly, even more reluctantly ducked out of her grip.

"We uh…" she said, and coughed, unsure of what to say. "That is, I shouldn't have…"

"Catra."

"I mean, you're still hurt and there's a war and you have to go back and I have to -"

" *Catra* ."

Catra was pacing now, talking faster and faster. "And you've probably got like, a concussion and you aren't thinking straight and I *took advantage* of you, gods, I'm…"

" *Catra!* "

Catra's head snapped up to stare at Adora, who was smiling at her with an almost saintlike patience. "It's okay you don't have to-"

"Catra, *it's okay* . Come back here before I have to come to you." There was a moment's hesitation from Catra, and Adora added, " *please* " in a pleading tone that, perhaps, was not entirely intentional.

Immediately, Catra was back to Adora's side, where she gave her another once-over to make sure Adora wasn't hurt any worse. "Adora, I just.."

"How far until we're at… wherever you're taking me?" Adora asked, surprised at how even her voice was. It suddenly occurred

to Adora that Catra did have a point of sorts - there was a war , and she needed to get back to the Rebellion as quickly as possible, Shadow Weaver was back in power, she needed to find out who those soldiers that captured her were - but by the First Ones, she wanted to forget all that for just a few moments.

Catra thought for a moment. “Two hours, give or take. The skiff’s on autopilot, it’ll sound an alert when we get close.”

“Okay,” Adora said, pursing her lips and thinking (and pretending not to notice the way Catra’s eye snapped to her lips). “then until the autopilot sounds,” she suddenly reached up and pulled Catra down next to her, “you stay here. Next to me. And we just… we stop thinking about all the shit going on outside.”

Catra had given a small yelp of shock at the strength with which Adora had pulled her down, but had quickly recovered. Fussily, she rearranged their positioning so that Adora was now in a comfortable sitting position, leaning against her. Her good arm wrapped protectively around Adora’s shoulders, and Catra gave into the urge to nuzzle against Adora’s neck and whisper, “Fine. But only because you asked so politely.”

Adora couldn’t quite suppress the shiver that ran through her. She hummed contentedly and turned to kiss Catra again, slowly, like she had all the time in the world. A million conversations that they needed to have ran through her head, but then her hand found its way under Catra’s shirt and she was too busy running her fingers through the fur of Catra’s back to really think of anything else. She traced over a patchwork of scars, causing Catra to shiver and cling to her even tighter.

“Promise me something.” Catra said a few moments later, having allowed Adora to pull her so that she was now more or less sitting in her lap.

At this point, Adora was sure that she’d promise Catra anything, and said so.

“We don’t go back after this.” Catra said, maybe a little shakily. “We talk about this, later. When there’s more time. I don’t - I can’t - just drop you off healed and go back to how it was.”

“We won’t.” Adora said, certain as stone. “I want - I want you. Er, with me. And also,” her fingers dancing up Catra’s back and her face aflame, “I uh, *want* you.”

Catra’s eye widened a little, and there seemed to be no other course of action to her that she could fathom other than to kiss Adora again, so she did. The insistent beeping of the autopilot broke the two apart. With no small amount of reluctance, Catra stood back up on slightly shaky legs and caught her breath. Adora looked up at her, looking disheveled and, frankly, gorgeous.

“The medical team’s standing by,” Catra said over her shoulder as she took control of the skiff again. “Although I suppose I can assure them that you’re not *that* injured, huh?”

Already Adora could see Catra slipping back into something like a professional mien, putting up the walls that she needed to in order to function effectively. It broke her heart a little, but she knew it was necessary. Still, she couldn’t help herself from a slightly teasing reply. “Well, we didn’t really test my strength and flexibility yet, did we?”

Catra coughed and felt her entire body heat up. She shot a glare back at Adora, who was smiling innocently. “You’re the worst.”

Adora *cackled* in a very Catra-like manner before her ribs reminded her again they were broken. “Ow. You know you love me.”

“Yes,” Catra said softly to herself, reaching to contact Scorpia again, “very much so.”

Chapter End Notes

> Well they *were* going to have a long talk, but... you know, it's always weird to me when an author is like "well the

characters had their own ideas" because I mean, we're not fucking magicians, we aren't creating *intelligent life*, it's all stuff we come up with in the end, right? Yet while I sat here writing their conversation, I kept thinking "you know what, these two should probably just go for it, it is the sort of thing two people would do in this kind of a situation, with adrenaline still running high and such" and so with *very* little preamble the two got to smoochin'.

Once upon a time, I had cause to say something like Catra does at the end there. I throw this anecdote in because it is a corny-ass line, but it is literally something that came out of my mouth in a real life situation once and that's my defense for corniness in this here situation.

Don't worry, we'll get back to the Metal Gear Solid bits next chapter. I know y'all didn't come to this for multiple chapters of Adora and Catra gettin' all sappy over one another (if you *did* come to this for multiple chapters of Adora and Catra gettin' all sappy over one another, well I have some *great news* for you: I'm sure that will happen too).

Weird, I'm putting a chapter up and it's not like three am. How about that, eh?

Meetings

Chapter Summary

> The group gets some breathing room. Entrapta performs medicine. Catra freaks out. Scorpia has an idea.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Scorpia and Entrapta stood flanked by several soldiers as Catra brought the skiff in for a landing. Catra looked over her shoulder where Adora sat propped up against the side of the ship. Given the events of the last few days, nevermind the last few hours, she had unsurprisingly fallen asleep. Catra crouched down in front of her again and reluctantly shook her awake.

"We're here. Can you stand?"

There was a soft hum from Adora as she woke up, and then she stared up at Catra as if seeing her there was the best thing that had ever happened. It took a few seconds for Catra's question to fully process, and with a grunt, Adora stood (a little shakily) on her feet.

"Looks like it."

Catra ducked under Adora's arm to support her, like they'd done a million times before. "Alright," she said, nodding in the direction of the welcoming committee, "Let's get you looked at."

The two made their way down the skiff's ramp, and Scorpia hurried forward to greet them. "Commander! Welcome back!" There was a brief pause where she took in Catra's bloodstained appearance. "You both look uh…"

"Like shit! Er, speaking purely from an aesthetic standpoint." Entrapta chirped. "Hi Adora! Long time no see!"

Adora laughed, then winced. “Hi Entrapta. Good to see you’re still doing okay.”

“Better than you’ve been doing, huh?” Entrapta clucked sympathetically. “Commander, if you’ll bring Adora to the medical bay, I need to look over the both of you.”

Something in Catra wanted to point out that she was fine and didn’t need looking over, but Entrapta shot her a warning look before she could even open her mouth to protest. Instead, Catra nodded and began helping Adora. The guards, who had until this point been looking with no small amount of curiosity at this apparent Alliance soldier their commander had considered important enough to go off in pursuit of, snapped to attention and saluted as Catra walked by.

“At ease, men.” She said, nodding at them and pointedly ignoring the way Adora looked at her in surprise. The path to the medical bay was blessedly devoid of further soldiers, any one of whom might have recognized Adora for who she was. The last thing Catra needed was for some Horde soldier to realize the Great Betrayer was sitting around the infirmary.

Adora looked around the facility in no small amount of astonishment, surprised to see signs of construction here and there as the facility expanded. She hadn’t recognized the guards who’d greeted them, though that meant precious little - the Horde and Rebellion armies were both enormous, after all. What did surprise her was the sight of Rogelio hunched over an injured soldier as they entered the infirmary. The lizardman seemed oddly unsurprised to see Adora, giving her a nod in greeting and almost immediately returning to his work.

“Rog,” Catra called over, “don’t forget I need the numbers on our medical supplies before the end of the week. I know you get grumpy if you don’t have enough supplies.” At his hiss of assent, Catra turned her attention back to Adora. “Alright, we’ll put you in this bed over here.”

With an amount of care that was still surprising to Adora, she helped the wounded soldier into one of the beds. Adora settled back with a barely contained wince and a sigh that was either exhaustion or disappointment that Catra almost immediately stepped back to allow Entrapta space to look Adora over.

"Okay Adora, let me just give us a little privacy here," Entrapta said, drawing a privacy curtain around the bed and gently shooing Catra away, "and we'll see what there is to see here. Is it going to freak you out if I take your shirt off?"

Adora shook her head, suddenly glad Catra had been shooed away. She helped Entrapta and sat up, trying not to wince too much. Entrapta kept her expression neutral as she looked over Adora's torso, which was a mottled mess of bruises and more than a few lacerations. She produced a pair of rubber gloves and began probing Adora's ribs, pausing whenever Adora seemed to be in pain. After a few minutes, Entrapta seemed satisfied with her investigation and nodded to herself.

"Right. Pants next."

This investigation took slightly longer, as Entrapta ran through a series of tests on Adora's knee before she was fully satisfied. Eventually though, she smiled reassuringly at Adora.

"Congratulations! You aren't going to die. Well, not any time soon I don't think. I'll need to run some more tests to be sure. But you do need rest. Like, kind of a lot of it. As far as I can tell you've got three broken ribs, and as for your knee, well…" Entrapta trailed off and seemed a little uncomfortable.

Adora felt a brief stirring of panic. "As for my knee?"

"Well, it's still a little too swollen to tell for sure, but I think you probably tore most of the muscles around it. That and, you know, there's a good chance the kneecap itself is cracked or broken. Once the swelling goes down I'll know for sure, but uh, you might need a cane for a while. Or, you know, permanently. Though most

likely once you transform into She-Ra again you'll heal up." Entrapta shrugged. "Unfortunately the precise capabilities of the She-Ra powerset aren't quite my area of expertise. I don't know if it would stay healed once you reverted."

"It would." Adora said, feeling a little sick. "It just takes some time."

"Oh, also you're suffering from exhaustion. Which you probably already know - given the stresses your body's been under, it's honestly kind of surprising you're still awake!"

"I slept a little on the skiff."

"Yeah, but you also…" Entrapta seemed to catch herself. "Er, nevermind. The point is, you need sleep, and you're going to stay in this bed and get it! I'm going to bandage your knee and give you some painkillers for your ribs and, you know, everything else. I'm also going to get you an IV drip going just to be safe - you're showing some signs of dehydration and while I'm sure Catra was smart enough to give you something to drink on the way here, it wasn't enough. Lay down and I'll be back with everything in a minute, okay? Okay."

When she stepped out from behind the curtain, she nearly ran into Catra, who'd been quietly lurking just outside. "Commander! I thought I told you to sit and wait for me to take a look at you."

"How's Adora?" Catra said, ignoring the question entirely.

"She'll be fine, Commander. I've just got to get some supplies to treat her injuries." Entrapta said, a little brusquely, and then, seeing Catra's expression, relented slightly. "Look, if you aren't going to sit down, come help me carry this stuff. I always drop the damn IV bags. They're too squishy and I hate them."

Catra followed along obediently. "So she's okay?"

"Well, to be honest she shows all the signs of extreme exhaustion and whatever the hell Octavia was doing really did a number on

her, but she's remarkably resilient. Some rest and she'll be healthy enough to get back to her people. Assuming that's still the plan." She shot a significant look at Catra. "I noticed curious bruising around her neck too, but I don't think it was particularly life-threatening."

"So you needed me to grab a couple IV bags, right?" Catra said, suddenly very interested in changing the subject.

Entrapta, mercifully, was willing to let the matter drop for the moment. "Yeah, the stuff we use for dehydration and maybe a couple syringes of something to help her sleep. It depends on how much her ribs bother her. She's demonstrated a remarkable toughness even when she's *not* running around as She-Ra in the past though, so odds are pretty high she won't require it."

"She won't admit it if she needs it. Soldiers don't admit when they're hurt, it's a sign of weakness." Catra said, half to herself. "Something Shadow Weaver taught us early on. Some of us more than others."

"I'll keep that in mind." Entrapta said, then gave Catra another significant look. "I certainly hope that you don't share the same instinct."

Catra chuckled dryly. "You saw me after the tank exploded. Pretty sure there's no face to save when it comes to you."

"Good. Now, once you drop these IV bags off and get out of my way, I'm going to patch up Adora, and you are going to wait patiently for me to take a look at you, because some of that blood is probably yours."

Catra became aware of just how tired she was, and just how much she'd put her body through in the last day. As a result, she was quite suddenly too tired to bother arguing, though she did stubbornly march right behind the curtain to drop the IV bags off. Adora had, in the few minutes Entrapta'd been away, fallen asleep. If not for the numerous cuts and bruises covering her

torso, or the way her breathing sounded labored and uncertain, she almost looked peaceful. The sight was almost too much for Catra to take in - something Entrapta, surprisingly, noticed immediately.

"Commander," she said in a lowered voice, "go wait for me. It's better than it looks, I promise."

Numbly, Catra nodded and forced herself to leave. She sat down heavily on one of the available beds and finally allowed herself to relax the slightest bit. *She's safe* . Catra repeated to herself. *I got there in time, and she's safe, and that's all that matters.* The thought of all the soldiers she'd gunned down on her rampage through the facility flashed unpleasantly through her mind. When Entrapta arrived a few minutes later, Catra was shaking uncontrollably.

"Commander?" Entrapta looked deeply concerned.

"I killed them all, Entrapta." Catra said, in a small voice. "I marched from floor to floor of that facility and gunned them all down." She looked at Entrapta with an almost confused expression. "They were my men, once. I probably assigned them there."

Entrapta was, as a general rule, still not completely comfortable with physical contact - Scorpia excepted. Still, she made an effort to wrap her hair around Catra's shoulders in a gesture of comfort. "It was you or them. Do you think you would have been able to get Adora out of there in her condition if you hadn't cleared the way beforehand?"

"I don't know. Maybe. But that's not why I did it." Catra took a deep breath. "I just… snapped. They took her, and I couldn't… I couldn't allow them to keep her. And they needed to pay for taking her in the first place. But that's not… that's not right, is it?"

"I… have no idea." Entrapta admitted. "Maybe you should talk to Scorpia about this. After I make sure you're medically sound,

anyway. But if it helps, uh, in some way, I think it's probably for the best you cleared the facility out. From a tactical standpoint. Now, let's see what state you're in."

There were, as it turned out, more than a few fresh cuts and at least a few patches of singed skin from a discharged stun baton. Entrapta cleaned the wounds and handed Catra some bandages before turning her attention to Catra's arm.

"How'd the melee functionality for this one work out?" She said in an curious tone, pulling a rag out and beginning to apply a cleaning fluid to it.

Catra had managed to at least stop shaking and took the opportunity to focus on something other than the lingering feeling that she was a monster. "Held up nicely. The claws performed better than expected - I got through some light armor with them, even."

Entrapta seemed quite pleased by this news. "I'd *hoped* the new alloy would have a little more strength! I amaze myself sometimes, you know?" The rag was now dancing across the surface of Catra's hand, busily cleaning dried blood and the occasional bit of grime from the joints. "Was there any discomfort? Too tight, too loose, chafing, that sort of thing?"

"No," Catra said, shaking her head, "the fit's good. The new insulation got a little sweaty, but that's to be expected."

"Hmm…" Entrapta nodded thoughtfully. "I'll see if we can figure out a lighter material, but you'll probably just have to deal with it. Make sure you let the arm breathe tonight, got it? Er, and wash it. Obviously. Oh, and wait until after you've gotten cleaned up to put those bandages on, got it?"

"Obviously." Catra said, sighing and running her good hand over her face. "Tell Scorpia to come meet me in my office in an hour, would you? We need to figure out how we're going to deal with our new guest."

“You can use her name, you know.” Entrapta said, matter-of-factly. “It’s not like she’s a secret.”

“I know, it’s just…” a pained expression crossed Catra’s face, “I need to get some distance from this. All of this. *Her* . I can’t ever think clearly when she’s involved. You know that.”

Entrapta nodded. “That is true, yes. But we trust your judgment, even when Adora’s involved.”

“I wish I did too.” Catra said, standing up to leave. “Scorpia. One hour. And let me know when Adora wakes up.”

“You got it, Commander.” Entrapta said, saluting with her hair.

Catra made her way to her quarters, where she stripped out of her soiled clothing and marched directly into the shower. She watched the water run red and brown as it washed down the drain, and closed her eye, willing her mind to stop racing without much success. Adora was here. Adora was *here* . She was here and she loved Catra, apparently, and Catra was going to have to act like that didn’t matter. She was here and Catra had slaughtered a building full of soldiers - her old soldiers - because they’d stood between Adora and her. She’d been beaten and tortured and something had managed to take her down and Catra needed to know what, because something that could take down two princesses and their weirdly competent archer friend could probably be a significant threat. That meant talking to Adora to find out what happened, which meant asking Adora to relive trauma, and also actually *talking* and not doing what Catra really wanted to do, which was to throw Adora over her shoulder, march into her bedroom, and not leave until they’d worked through the last five years worth of emotional and physical tension - or until they needed something to eat.

She shook her head, clearing it. This was getting her nowhere. She stepped out of the shower, dried off, and retrieved a clean set of clothes before heading to her office to wait for Scorpia. She

didn’t realize she’d fallen asleep until Scorpia’s knock on the door startled her awake.

“Commander? You in there?”

Catra sat up, shoving her missing hand in her pocket. “Come on in,” she said, taking a deep breath.

Scorpia entered, looking immensely pleased. “Well Commander, looks like the mission was a resounding success! Entrapta tells me Adora’s a little worse for the wear but recovering, and you don’t look too roughed up yourself.”

Catra shrugged. “Took a few hits but they were nothing serious.” She couldn’t quite keep the dark expression from her face as she added, “I got lucky.”

There was a thoroughly unsuccessful effort on Scorpia’s part to not snicker. “Yeah, Entrapta mentioned some interesting marks on Adora -”

“Oh my gods shut up.” Catra brought her hand up and dragged her fingers down across her face, her dark mood somewhat alleviated. “I meant I was lucky I didn’t get shot.” Her poor mood returned. “I was too reckless, and then I was...” *I was a demon* , she thought, but couldn’t bring herself to say it, instead settling for “too harsh.”

Scorpia frowned. “What do you mean?”

“I *slaughtered* them, Scorpia. All of them. So the Horde would know not to take Adora again.” Catra took a deep breath. “I could have left some alive. I lost control - I haven’t…. It was like the old days, when Adora first left.” Her voice dropped to a whisper. “Except I’m a lot better at killing now than I was then.”

“Commander,” Scorpia said, in a gentle tone, “not to sound too harsh, but… those soldiers would have killed you if given the chance. You *know* they would have, because you put them in charge of the detention facility specifically because they were the

sorts of people who would kill anyone who tried to break someone out."

"But I could have been more subtle," Catra said. "It would have kept the casualty count low."

"Any soldier you left alive was a potential problem for you on your way out." Scorpia said firmly. "You knew we'd have to kill comrades when we started this. You *knew* . It's the nature of this business. Make your peace with it, Commander."

"It's not something I want to do again," Catra said.

"Then make sure Adora doesn't get captured again." Scorpia said, a little sharply. "Or stay away from her entirely if you think she's such a bad influence on you, but frankly, I think we both know that's not going to happen."

Catra gave a defeated-sounding chuckle. "No, I guess it isn't."

"A few other things," Scorpia said, deciding to let the subject of Catra's guilt go for the moment. "We've spread news in a few Rebellion outposts that Adora's escaped Horde custody, but I didn't think it wise to openly declare ourselves her rescuers. Currently we're framing it as Rebellion sympathizers in the Horde who arranged the escape."

"Are they buying it?"

Scorpia shrugged. "Too early to tell. A contact in Bright Moon says the Princess Alliance all arrived to discuss the situation, but the meetings are high security and we don't have anyone on the inside."

Catra frowned. "Would be nice to get a source in there."

Scorpia thought it best to not mention that Adora could be that source, and instead suggested, "If we keep up the appearance of Rebellion sympathizers, when our people hand Adora back they can 'defect' and get us access to more intel on the Rebellion side."

For what was probably the hundredth time, Catra found herself surprised by Scorpia's cleverness. "Are you *sure* you shouldn't be the one running this outfit?"

"I'll leave the rousing speeches and derring-do to you, Commander. I'm just here to make sure we keep getting more business."

"And to keep your Commander from going crazy, right?" Catra said, only half-joking.

"Someone has to keep an eye on you," Scorpia said with a shrug, "and Entrapta, for all her numerous qualities (which I can list for you, if you have time), has never been great at talking feelings."

Catra laughed, and felt a little lighter. "Thank you, Scorpia. That'll be all for now."

"You should get some sleep, Catra." Scorpia said, using her name so that Catra knew she was serious. "It's been a long day for you. Entrapta will wake you if Adora wakes up before you do."

Catra gave a mock salute. "Yes ma'am."

Scorpia laughed and exited the office. Catra headed back to her quarters, where she surprised herself by falling asleep almost instantly.

Chapter End Notes

> Things slow down a bit here, but there's stuff I wanted to cover so *deal with it*. I don't know why this took so long to write, but it did! I would've had this up last night, but I was at a Punk Rock Show, pretending that I was not an old man by rocking out to Jawbreaker, a band who Fucking Rules and You Kids Today just Don't Understand. Please stand by while I find a cane to shake demonstratively while I continue. Why do I mention this? I dunno, it was a real fucking good time and I can't shut up about it. If it helps, at least one track

works as a pretty good summary of Adora's feelings toward Catra (and vice versa).

Anyway we'll get another chapter up at some point. Adora and Catra still owe each other a conversation, there's still a bipedal weapons platform in development (to say nothing of the cannon), and oh right, Shadow Weaver is skulking about with weird sort-of-princess soldiers. Lots to deal with!

EDIT: Oh, and if you're wondering why Adora doesn't seem stunned that Entrapta's alive, it's because I sneakily retconned the Alliance thinking she was dead in response to Season 2. It really only came up in one chapter, so I tweaked a line. I have become George Lucas.

Conversation(s)

Chapter Summary

> Adora wakes up and says hello to some old friends. Catra makes a suggestion. Entrapta works on her sense of timing.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora woke with a start from what had been a blessedly dreamless sleep and almost immediately regretted it. Her mouth was dry and she was laying in an unfamiliar bed surrounded by what seemed to be some kind of curtain. A quick once-over revealed her leg had been wrapped with a tight bandage, while the rest of her body was covered in various other poultices and, in a few spots, she'd received stitches. Her ribs were in pain, and she winced audibly as she attempted to sit up. It was then she noticed the needle in her hand, and tried very hard not to freak out.

There was a sudden *whoosh* as the curtain was pulled back, and Adora instinctively pulled the thin sheet she'd been sleeping under up higher, suddenly conscious that she'd apparently been allowed to fall asleep in only her smallclothes. She found herself staring into the calm, implacable gaze of Rogelio, who, without much in the way of formality, removed the needle from Adora's hand and began checking her vitals.

"So," Adora said, as Rogelio checked her pulse, "This is where you and the others were heading when I ran into you last time?"

Rogelio gave an affirmative grunt.

"How'd you get here? And uh, where… exactly is here, actually?"

A shrug was her response.

"Can't tell me, huh?"

A shake of the head.

"Is that because Catra told you not to, or because you don't think you can trust me."

Rogelio held his hand out flat and tilted it from side to side.

Adora nodded. "Ah. A bit of both, then. I guess that makes sense."

Nod.

"Are Kyle and Lonnie with you too? They're also part of… whatever this is?"

Another nod.

"How's Kyle? Same as always?"

Rogelio started to nod, then apparently reconsidered and made another 'so-so' gesture with his hand.

There was one last question on Adora's mind. "Did you…" Adora hesitated for a moment before continuing. "Did you know she was alive when you found me?"

Rogelio rolled his eyes and shook his head. He clucked at her and pulled the sheet aside to look at her knee, then shot her a look which perfectly communicated that she should probably stay where she was and not go walking around.

"Well," Adora said, feeling slightly awkward, "I'm glad you found your way here. I should probably make sure the next time I see you it's not in a situation where I've been beaten to shit, huh?"

That earned her an affectionate pat on the head and a dry, hissing chuckle. As he continued to check Adora's wounds, her stomach rumbled. Rogelio shot her a look, laughed to himself again, and

left, leaving Adora alone. A few minutes later, he returned with a tray of food, which he set down in front of her. Adora's stomach rumbled even louder and she realized that she couldn't actually remember the last time she'd eaten. She moved to dig into the food with gusto, until Rogelio placed a warning hand on her to slow her down.

"Guess I don't want to make myself sick, do I?"

Nod.

It was difficult, but Adora managed to force herself to eat at a slower pace. Rogelio watched her for a bit, and then, with another affectionate pat of her head, took his leave. Adora finished eating and found herself wondering what the hell she was meant to do now. Lay back and rest, she supposed, except now that she'd slept and had something to eat, her mind was free to go back over the events of the last few days with something approaching clarity.

It was not something she was eager to think about. Octavia had been only too happy to have Adora, the former golden child and - more damningly - shield for Catra when it came to Octavia getting vengeance for her missing eye. By the time Adora left, Catra was damnably untouchable - a Force Captain with equal footing. That Adora had somehow managed to keep her eyes intact through all of it had been a minor miracle. Even so, her whole body ached with the memory of whatever current Octavia had been running through her body, with the numerous blows and cuts inflicted seemingly at random.

Adora had, she realized, started to resign herself to her fate. Shadow Weaver would come, and she would wipe her memory - assuming she wasn't to be killed - and Adora would go back to being an obedient soldier of the Horde. If not for Catra… who was a whole other topic Adora didn't know she was ready to delve into.

It wasn't that Adora didn't know how she felt about Catra. She loved her with a fierceness that bordered on the dizzying. The longer the war had dragged on, the easier it had been for Adora to see Catra as less of an enemy and more of someone who just happened to be on the other side. Their fights had become no less vicious, but for Adora they'd become somehow impersonal - they were professional soldiers, and they were - once - friends. Adora had watched Catra rise to power in the Horde with a strange sort of pride. It was the sort of potential that Catra always had but never been allowed to fulfil. Shadow Weaver had seen to that.

There was another topic altogether. What had allowed Shadow Weaver to come back into power? Catra had disgraced her and cast her down early on in her rise to Force Commander, but seemingly Hordak had seen fit to bring her back. It made no sense. Something had happened in the Horde, something that had caught Catra off guard and nearly killed her. It had resulted in whatever those soldiers were that had nearly killed Bow - using magic that was unambiguously out of Shadow Weaver's school. Had that been in development while Catra was in command? Had Catra *known* ? One more thing to add to a long list of questions Adora had, not the least of which was *what the hell were they going to do now?*

They wouldn't go back to the way things were. She'd promised Catra as much, but what that meant was still something she hadn't thought about. The Alliance needed She-Ra in a way that Adora understood, but Adora didn't need She-Ra. She was more than willing to keep up the fight without She-Ra's powers if that's what it took, but… her friends in the Alliance needed her. She knew that Catra did not. Catra might *want* her, and certainly Adora knew she wanted Catra, but there was no scenario Adora could think of in which they got what they wanted. Not while the Horde was still a threat.

At some point, Adora fell asleep again - or she assumed that she'd done so, because she seemed to blink and suddenly Catra was sitting next to her bed, giving her a once-over.

Adora startled slightly, and then after a pause, asked the first question that came to mind. “You’re not a hallucination, right?”

Catra raised an eyebrow. “Should I be?”

“No, it’s just…” Adora looked closely. This Catra had one eye covered by an eyepatch, and was dressed in what seemed to be a uniform without any markings of rank or affiliation. “Nevermind.”

“Been dreaming about me, huh?” Catra said, a little too pleased with herself. “I didn’t know I had that kind of effect on you.”

“I thought you were dead.” Adora said defensively, before rubbing her forehead with a sigh. “In fact, I got *confirmation* you were dead from some Horde soldiers I heard while I was in the Fright Zone on a uh, unrelated matter. It… I didn’t handle it well.”

“If it makes you feel better,” Catra said, with a surprising sympathy, “I don’t know that I would have dealt with hearing you were dead any better.”

“Aw,” Adora said, falling back into their old teasing routine, “I didn’t know you cared.”

“Well, I do.” Catra said, surprising Adora with the bluntness of her response. “That’s why you’re here - even if I did sell Scorpia on it by making a tactical argument that I don’t think she bought for a second.”

Adora, because she couldn’t quite bring herself to talk about what they really needed to be talking about just yet, took the bait. “And what precisely was your tactical argument?”

“The Princess Alliance breaks apart if She-Ra’s gone.” Catra said, shrugging. “And if the Alliance breaks apart, that’s the end of the Rebellion. And if the *Rebellion* falls, then Hordak has all the time in the world to hunt us down with the full might of the Horde - which is not something we are currently equipped to stand against. So, it was in our best interests to get you out of Horde custody as quickly as possible.”

Adora shrugged. “Seems pretty convincing to me.”

“Yeah, but Scorpia knows that I can’t think clearly when it comes to you.” Catra said, matter-of-factly. “I’ve never been able to. You,” she said, pointing with a metal finger, and a crooked smile, “were always my weakness.”

Adora drew her good knee up to her chest and used it to help herself sit up a little straighter. Catra had the decency to pretend very hard not to notice that Adora had never put a shirt back on. “If it makes you feel better,” Adora said, “you’ve always been my weakness too.”

“I’m aware.” Catra said with a rather guilty look. “I took advantage of it pretty often, as you’ll recall.”

“Well don’t worry,” Adora said airily, “I don’t expect an apology or anything.”

“Too bad.” Catra said. “I’m sorry. I’ve done… so many things that hurt you. Hurt your allies. It was the job, but… I know that’s not much of an excuse.”

“Was I any better?” Adora replied, cocking her head to one side. “How many of your men have I killed or injured? Former comrades of mine, too. It’s… war. We’re on opposite sides. It was impossible *not* to.”

“Not anymore.” Catra said, quietly. “But…”

“But we still aren’t on the same side, are we?” Adora said, with a sad smile.

Catra was quiet for a few moments, looking at the floor. “No,” she finally said softly. “We aren’t.”

“What... “ Adora started to say, and then paused, uncertain. “What side are you on, exactly?”

“My own.” Catra said, as if the answer was obvious.

“What does that mean?”

“It means,” Catra said, shrugging her shoulders, “that I don’t fight for anyone anymore. Nobody here does. We just fight for ourselves. We fight for what we believe needs to be done, but we don’t swear fealty to any princess, or kingdom, or organization. We’re free of all that.”

It seemed like Adora was trying to think through a difficult problem. “But… everyone here follows you, don’t they? I mean they call you Commander and everything.”

“I don’t ask them to.” Catra said. “They follow me because they want to. Everyone is free to leave, should they want to. The only thing we ask from those who make that choice is they don’t reveal our location.” She shrugged. “Then again, so far nobody’s asked to leave. This is… my family. Our family. We’re a haven for soldiers that exists outside the power struggle of Horde vs Rebellion.”

Adora felt a pang at the word family. “Is this the part where you ask me to stay?” Her voice was almost a whisper.

Catra’s grin was a mixture of heartbreak and gentle chiding. “I try not to ask questions I already know the answer to.”

“And what’s my answer, in this case?” Adora asked, challenging.

“Your answer is that you want to, but you can’t. Because She-Ra is too important, and you can’t just give her up and leave the Rebellion high and dry. Because you’re a *hero* ,” her expression went slightly bitter for a second, and Catra turned her head so that Adora couldn’t see her good eye anymore, “and heroes don’t belong here.”

An uncomfortable silence descended, broken only by an annoyed sniff from Catra as she angrily brushed at her unseen eye. Adora looked at her friend, sitting in profile, struggling to keep a self-imposed distance between them that hadn’t been there the day before, and felt her heart break. She wanted to tell Catra that she’d drop She-Ra in a second if Catra asked - she knew even as

she thought it that it wasn't true, but she wanted to say it anyway. Then she remembered promising Catra they'd always look out for one another, and how *that* turned out, so instead she asked, "You don't think you're a hero?"

"Never was," Catra said, her voice sounding rough, "never will be."

"You've given all these people a home. You saved those kids," Adora argued back. "You saved *me* ."

"Scorpia and Entrapta gave these people a home. I saved those kids because they came to us and offered payment. I saved you because…" a huff of a laugh escaped her, "well, because I wouldn't be able to live with myself if I lost you. I've also assassinated Rebellion officials, sent men on missions of sabotage to force evacuations of settlements, and I'll keep doing it as long as the work pays and gives my people more security to work with."

"And that doesn't make you a hero to your people?" Adora said with a crooked grin.

Catra snorted. "Surviving isn't heroic. It's just surviving."

"If you were just surviving, you wouldn't have built all this. Yes," she said, holding a hand up to forestall Catra's rebuttal, "even if it was mostly Scorpia and Entrapta's doing. You really think they would have put this together without you? You're their leader. They'll follow you anywhere." The next phrase seemed to catch Adora by surprise. "I would too."

That got Catra's attention. "You what?"

Adora smiled in that infuriating way of hers she did whenever she'd made her mind up about something. "I'd follow you. If you'd let me."

Catra shook her head. "Don't joke, Adora."

“I’m not joking.” Adora said, her mind suddenly racing. “She-Ra belongs with the Rebellion, that’s true. But I’m not She-Ra.”

“But you have to be.” Catra said, patiently. “You know as well as I do the Rebellion needs you more than…”

Adora laughed. “Than you do?”

Catra stood, her eye blazing. “I don’t *need* you, Adora.” She advanced to the bed, a sudden surge of anger getting the better of her for a moment.

Adora’s eyes sparkled with something as Catra loomed over her. “You don’t?” She reached a hand up and stroked Catra’s cheek. Her voice took on a register Catra didn’t know she possessed. “Are you sure?”

The anger that had briefly roared to life was replaced, quite suddenly, with the realization of what Adora was doing. Catra smirked. “There’s a difference between need…” she said, bringing her hand up behind Adora’s head and making a fist, tugging her head back slightly.

Adora’s pupils widened and her breath hitched as Catra brought her lips closer, whispering in a low growl. “And want.” Catra released Adora’s hair and stepped back, taking a moment to compose herself again before shooting a smug look Adora’s direction.

“That,” Adora said in a trembling voice, her skin flushed, “was mean.”

“Sorry,” Catra said, her own voice also a little unsteady, “but you and I both know this isn’t the time. Certainly not the place.”

“Oh I don’t know,” Adora said, gesturing to draw Catra’s eye to her state of dress, “it could be the time.”

“Still not the place.” Catra said, looking and hating that she was looking because it just made things more difficult. “At any rate,

my point is…"

Adora's eyes were boring a hole through Catra. "Is?"

With an effort, Catra looked up and away. "You have to go back. You would regret staying here. Your friends need you. The Rebellion needs you."

"Maybe I'm tired of She-Ra being needed." Adora said with a sudden fierceness. "Maybe I'm sick of being a tool for the Rebellion. I had to give you up once - why should I have to give you up again?"

Catra was speechless for a moment. This was not the first time Adora had apologized for leaving her, but she'd never heard Adora sound so *bitter* about the decision. It had not really occurred to her before now - not in all the years of her own anger and feelings of betrayal - that Adora had resented having to leave her behind. Suddenly, she wanted nothing more than to tell Adora she could stay, but she knew it was an impossibility. Even so, she found herself saying, "What if you don't have to? I mean…" she growled, frustrated, "what if we still stay together? You go back, but we stay in touch, and I tell you what we're doing, and you tell me what you're doing, and we… meet in the middle, somehow."

"Meet in the middle?"

"We're both fighting the Horde." Catra said, deciding not to mention that she would also fight the Rebellion when the situation arose, "There's no reason we can't coordinate with one another when the opportunity arises. But it would need to just be you. You *can't* tell anyone where we are, or who we are."

Adora, of course, pointed it out. "You also fight the Rebellion sometimes, don't you? Who's to say we don't end up on opposite sides of a battlefield again?"

"If that happens," Catra said, heavily, "then you'll have to fight me. You can't afford not to."

The look on Adora's face was heartbreaking. "I don't know if I could."

Catra hurried to reassure her. "Fortunately for us both, I think if that happens it will mean one of us needs to be put down anyway, because one of us will have taken the wrong side. Probably me."

Adora laughed in spite of herself. "Fortunately." She sighed, and her shoulders slumped. "You're right, of course. I have to go back."

"But," Catra said, "we have some time before then. There are some things I want to show you, and some questions I need to ask you first."

Entrapta threw open the curtain and bustled in. "And you can ask that after I've had a chance to look over her knee, Commander! Not before! She's only had a single night's recovery and I won't have you wearing her out with questions or anything else, is that clear?"

Catra held her hands up in surrender, already stepping backwards out of the area. "Clear as crystal, doc. Guess we'll have to finish our conversation later, Adora."

"I'll come find you, if I'm allowed out of this bed." Adora said with a grin, bottling back up the various emotions that had been swirling around the two for the duration of their conversation.

"Rogelio informed me the swelling on your leg has gone down, which is a good sign." Entrapta said conversationally, sweeping the curtain closed. "It means I can take another look at it and see about fitting you for a brace. Also I can probably get a better idea of how bad the damage is." She moved the sheet aside and began unwrapping the bandage on Adora's knee, then hesitated for a second. "Er, one thing. I'm led to believe this might hurt, so consider yourself warned. I mean, you need to tell me when it hurts, because if you don't then I won't know what's wrong."

Adora nodded, and then almost immediately bit back a cry as Entrapta slowly began bending her knee. Entrapta gave her a guilty look and backed off, then began a series of other tests, nearly all of which hurt. After what felt like far too long, Entrapta let Adora's leg go and stepped back.

"Good news first! I think your kneecap is intact."

"Well," Adora said, sounding strained, "I guess that's something. What's the bad news?"

"I'm pretty sure your major tendons are shredded. Now, I *could* go in and fix them, but it would involve a long recovery process and I don't know how long you planned on staying with us." When Adora didn't immediately reply, she continued. "I guess it doesn't matter. I can fix it, but your sword can also probably fix it, so even if I did go in and fix it you wouldn't necessarily need the full recovery time. Either way it'll hurt less if you let me fix it. I've never done it before but I'm very interested to try and, you know, you can take a couple days to decide. We'll get you a brace in the meantime."

"Er, thanks." Adora said, a little overwhelmed by Entrapta's patter. "For everything."

"Of course! You're a friend, after all." Entrapta said, smiling. "Even if you and Catra spent a lot of time trying to kill each other."

The question was out of Adora's mouth before she realized that she wanted an answer to it. "How… How is she? Catra, I mean. Since the explosion."

"Hmm," Entrapta said, seemingly choosing her words carefully, "That's a good question. We got all the shrapnel out after we got here safely. It was a little close before that - I never really admitted to her *how* close, actually, because honestly it wouldn't have been helpful if she knew, and Scorpia would've gotten even more worried than she was, so… I didn't. The Commander's a

tough one though, so she was back on her feet way before I expected."

"Was that because she healed fast, or because she can't stand to be bedridden?"

"Well, part of it was because we had to run away from a kill squad, but I like to think she would have been back on her feet quickly either way." A guilty look crossed Entrapta's face and one of her twintails covered her mouth. "Er, don't tell her I told you that."

Adora's eyes had widened at the accidental admission. "A kill squad?"

"Don't worry! We got away, and nobody got hurt too badly. Catra wasn't even really in that much danger, because she was in the skiff with me providing cover fire. She even got a few hits in, which I didn't really expect her to because she'd barely had time to adjust to having only one eye. It might've been luck, but I can't be sure."

Adora looked around the facility, suddenly feeling worried. "So this was… *before* you came here, I assume?"

"Oh yes, of course." Entrapta nodded enthusiastically. "I hadn't even had time to give her a prosthetic yet, but she rose to the occasion to help save Scorpia. She's quite impressive, you know."

"Yeah," Adora said, a fond look crossing her face, "I know."

Entrapta noticed the look and grinned. "If you're careful, you know, you could probably recover somewhere else. Assuming you eat and drink properly, and don't push yourself too much. I'm sure that the Commander would share her quarters if you asked nicely. And if you refrained from any strenuous physical activity while you were there. Your ribs are still healing, after all."

Adora felt her entire body go red. "I don't know what you're talking about." She said in suspiciously high voice, "but I won't

deny it would be nice to not spend another day stuck in bed.”

Entrapta clapped her hands together, seeming almost gleeful. “Great! I’ll have a brace for you shortly. Then I’ll take you to Catra and she can give you the tour.”

“Does Catra really have time to be giving tours?” Adora asked, not because she didn’t need to see Catra again, but more because she felt the need to at least *pretend* that she didn’t.

Entrapta snorted - actually *snorted* - as if Adora’s question were the dumbest thing she’d ever heard. “I’m sure she’ll make time for you. Now, put some clothes on and I’ll be back in a minute with something to help you walk. Oh, and some food too. You should eat again.”

With a wave, she ducked out, leaving Adora behind to discover that, at some point, someone had delivered what looked like a repurposed Horde uniform to her. Her own clothes seemed to be gone - whether they were being cleaned or they’d taken too much damage and been discarded was a mystery she could solve later. She put the new uniform on, giving herself a once-over.

It suited her, Adora decided.

Chapter End Notes

> Good god, you ever have a chapter that just refuses to end? Because this one just kept on rolling. Every time I thought I'd come to an ending spot, I'd think "oh I should cover this bit too" and, well, here we are.
>
> I don't say this often enough: Y'all are *fucking fantastic*. I love reading and responding to the comments, as you've probably noticed, and it's a delight to see new people discovering this thing and commenting and kudos-ing and what have you. By all means, tell all your friends who are both into She-Ra and I guess Metal Gear, although the second one is less important than the first. Wholly unnecessary, one might even say!

Anyway, next chapter Adora gets the Grand Tour, and Catra gets some valuable intel. Coming... eventually. I don't know when.

EDIT: Holy shit this is over 50k words now? Ridiculous. I'm a ridiculous human being for writing this.

A Tour

Chapter Summary

> Catra makes a call and takes a chance. Adora takes a tour and provides some intel.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra was in the middle of a conversation with Scorpia in her office when Adora found her. "How many search parties are currently near Horde territory?"

Scorpia shrugged. "We're not sure, Commander. Intel says the Alliance is devoting a significant amount of resources to the search, but we don't have anyone with access to their actual deployment plans."

Catra frowned. "We need to do something to convince them she's okay. Otherwise they're going to end up getting themselves killed."

"With respect, Commander, we're under no obligation to keep Alliance operatives alive unless we're being paid to do so."

Catra's expression was tense. "If anyone dies, Adora is going to blame herself for it, or worse, she'll blame *me* for it, and I couldn't-"

Adora decided she'd heard enough. "You won't. I'll contact Swift Wind, let him know I'm okay."

Catra whirled around, eye wide with surprise and took in the sight of Adora. She was wearing the plain uniform Catra had left her, and leaning on a cane. Her knee was encased in a brace which kept it straight. She looked much better than the day before, but there was a leanness to her face a faint sheen of sweat on her

forehead that spoke to how much the trip from the infirmary to the office had taken out of her.

"It's uh… it's a She-Ra thing. He's my uh, 'destined steed.' I can't like, *talk* to him, but I can... " Adora frowned, trying to find a way to describe it. "Bend my mind to him and he'll know where I am and how I'm doing? It's like… he sees through my eyes, and I through his, if I will it."

Scorpia immediately wore an expression of concern. "Is that an either/or thing, or a both/and thing? Because if he knows where you are, what's to stop him bringing the entire Alliance along with him?"

"He won't." Adora said, quietly. "Not if he knows who I'm here with. More than anyone else, he knows who you are, Catra. He knows how I feel about… everything. He won't put you at risk."

Scorpia still looked doubtful, but looked to Catra. "It's your call, Commander."

Catra was quiet as she turned things over in her mind. Adora wasn't lying - she knew that much. Certainly *Adora* thought her horse - unicorn - pegasus - whatever he was - to be trustworthy. Still, he was another potential informant. Catra had no doubt Adora would keep their location secret - particularly after their last conversation - but if Swift Wind thought it was in Adora's best interest for the others to know, would he go behind her back to tell them? On the other hand, it would be a disaster if the Alliance's search teams ended up getting themselves killed. *Last time you trusted Adora, she abandoned you* , a voice said in the back of her head, *can you really risk it?*

"You have to promise me." Catra said, staring a hole in Adora. "Your friends can't know where we are. They *can't* . You, I can trust. If Swift Wind gives our location up, that's the end of us. We end up on the run and get hunted down by one or both sides."

Adora's first instinct was to defend her friends. They would understand - she could convince them, she was sure - except the more she thought about it, the less certain she was. Neither was good at keeping secrets, especially not from Angella. "Swift Wind won't talk. You don't have any horses penned up here, do you?"

Catra looked immensely confused. "I… what? No?"

"Then you're fine." Adora said. "Your secret is safe with me. Er, and him too."

Catra nodded. "Alright. Call your… mystic steed, or whatever the hell he is."

Adora shut her eyes and reached out to Swift Wind. An image formed in her mind of flying over the plains just west of the Horde outpost the Rebellion had attacked. *I'm over here* , Adora thought, *I'm safe.* Then she opened her eyes and looked at Catra. *Come alone* , she thought, and then closed her eyes again. The vision shifted as Swift Wind wheeled in the air and changed direction.

"He's on his way." Adora informed Catra. "Dunno how long it'll take for him to *get* here, but…"

"Well, while we've got time," Catra said, forcing down a wave of disappointment at the thought that Adora would be leaving so quickly. "I'll give you the tour. Once your friend gets here, I'll need to talk to talk to him." She offered her arm to Adora with a rakish grin. "Shall we?"

Adora gave an exaggerated bow and linked their arms together, tucking the cane under her free arm. "Lead on, Commander."

Scorpia did a surprisingly good job of not squealing in delight at the scene and instead merely nodded. "See you later, Commander. We still need to discuss the new intel I mentioned earlier, when you have the time."

Catra nodded and led Adora out of the office. “Gotta admit Adora, I’m surprised you made it to my office without any former Horde soldiers talking to you. You’re something of a uh, celebrity back in the Fright Zone.”

“‘The Great Betrayer.’” Adora said with a lopsided grin. “I’m aware. Fortunately for me, I’m still pretty good at avoiding notice, even with a ruined knee.”

“I’ll have to have a word with the troops on alertness, is what you’re saying.” Catra said with a frown.

“Oh, I don’t know. It could be that I’m just very good.”

Catra glanced sideways at the smug look on Adora’s face, and couldn’t help but smile. “Whatever you say, princess.” She stopped, and turned to Adora with a serious expression. “Are you up for this? There might be some folks that want a word with you during the tour.”

Adora shrugged. “I’m used to it. Part of being She-Ra involves a lot of…” there was a pause as she searched for the right phrase, “public relations.”

Catra shuddered theatrically. “Sounds awful.”

“It’s part of the Princess Alliance package.” Adora admitted. “She-Ra is a great warrior, but she’s also a *valuable* political tool.”

The way she spat out the last few words was unmistakable. “Not really what you had in mind when you decided to fight the Horde, huh?” Catra said, not without sympathy. “If it makes you feel better, there’s a lot more paperwork involved as Horde Commander than I thought there’d be. It wasn’t my favorite part of the job. Still isn’t.”

“And what is your favorite part of the job?” Adora asked, curiously.

Catra grinned. “You’ll see in a moment. We’re nearly there.”

“Nearly where?”

“The training grounds.” Catra said, pushing open a door and ushering Adora outside.

Adora’s eyes widened as she took in the sight before her. Two groups of soldiers were arrayed in rows, each running through a series of martial drills. A few instructors stood at the front of each group, offering advice and making corrections where necessary. In another area, she saw a ring in which two soldiers were engaged in a hand-to-hand battle, while the distant crack of gunfire spoke to the presence of a shooting range somewhere out of sight. Catra helped her to a set of benches arranged near the drilling soldiers and sat her down.

“Most of our instructors are Horde,” Catra said, idly, “but we’ve had a few Rebellion recruits willing to help out too. Scorpia and I evaluate them and assign them to classes, and we sort our recruits into groups based on skill level. You wouldn’t believe it, but Kyle’s got a real talent for it.” She chuckled. “I guess he had to be good at *something* .”

Before Adora could respond, one of the instructors finally noticed their presence and immediately snapped to attention. “Recruits! You’re in luck! Our Commander is here to observe your performance. Don’t worry,” he said with a dry chuckle, “she won’t go easy on you.”

All activity stopped and everyone present quickly snapped to attention. Catra gave Adora a sideways glance that seemed almost apologetic, and stood. “At ease, men, I’m just passing through. I see some new faces - welcome aboard. If we haven’t had time to meet one-on-one, we will soon enough. Train hard. We’re building something new here, and we need all your help to make it happen. We’re going to get our revenge on the Horde and all other entities that have treated us as disposable pawns. We’re going to fight for a world where we aren’t needed anymore - even if we’ll never live to see it.” She paused for a moment, letting it

sink in, and grinned. “Now get back to work, I’ve given you enough of a break.”

Adora had watched the whole thing with a strange look on her face. Suddenly she could understand what had drawn so many people out here - Catra’s presence was undeniably magnetic, even though she didn’t seem to realize it. There was a sincerity to her words that could not be denied, and Adora knew then that there was no question the soldiers here would follow Catra to whatever end. It was something Adora hadn’t fully grasped until seeing the looks on the faces of the newer recruits - her own willingness to follow Catra to the ends of the earth notwithstanding. In the hands of someone else, Adora might consider it dangerous - Catra’s dedication to ending the war seemed sincere but if she decided she wanted to rule instead, she’d have a fiercely loyal army at her back. *She said she’d want me to put her down if we were on opposite sides again* , Adora thought. *I don’t know if I could* .

Catra sat down heavily next to Adora with a cocky grin on her face, breaking the grim train of thought. “So, that’s our training grounds, anyway. I try to drop in here later in the day, usually, when it’s not so crowded. If you weren’t so banged up, I’d ask you to spar.”

“I’d consider it anyway if I didn’t want Entrapta to kill me.” Adora said, with a grin of her own.

The two sat in silence, watching the training. A few of the recruits noticed Adora, and did a poor job of covering up the shock on their faces. Catra chuckled. “Looks like at least a few people might know who you are, Adora.”

Adora pretended not to notice. “There’s not going to be trouble, is there?”

Catra snorted. “Maybe you’ll have to sign an autograph, but that’s about it. You think anyone who defected from the Horde is still buying into that whole ‘Great Betrayer’ line Hordak was feeding

them? It's more likely your own people will swarm you once they realize you're here."

"'My own people,'" Adora said, rolling her eyes for effect, "don't know who I am unless I'm about two feet taller and dressed like a magical princess."

This caught Catra completely off guard. "Wait, really? I would've thought the Alliance would go all-in on having a high-ranking Horde defector on their side."

"Nah, they like to pretend that Princesses are only ever Princesses. I think they're worried that if the people found out that I wasn't *born* a princess they'd lose their minds." Adora snorted.

"That's bullshit." Catra said, shortly. "You're so much more than just She-Ra."

"Honestly, I kind of like the anonymity." Adora said, smiling at Catra's protectiveness. "It lets me be myself without having the weight of everyone's expectations on me."

"Wait, so where do they think She-Ra goes when you're not transformed?"

Adora shrugged. "The Princesses as a whole are really only seen if they're fighting or holding court. It's generally assumed that She-Ra is princess of a fallen kingdom, and she goes back there when she's not, you know, out fighting." She looked sideways at Catra, who was staring at her with a dumbfounded expression. "What?"

"I can't believe we never managed to beat you. You're in charge of a bunch of idiots."

Adora shrugged. "I think it's a magic thing. Everyone knows all about magic, and so they just… accept that She-Ra disappears between battles."

“So who are you, then? Like, obviously people see you running around with Glitter and whatshisface all the time, right?”

“I’m just one of *Glimmer* ’s confidants and guards, obviously.” Adora said, emphasizing Glimmer’s name but otherwise letting Catra’s refusal to say her name properly slide. “I just kind of fade into the background.”

Catra hummed thoughtfully to herself. “So the fact that you’ve been missing for days doesn’t mean shit, huh? Not to the rank and file - they just think She-Ra’s off doing something somewhere else?”

“More or less.” Adora shrugged. “I don’t know if She-Ra’s appearance is a universal constant or anything, but in theory if someone else could use the sword, nobody could tell the difference.”

There was a tone to her voice that rubbed Catra the wrong way, but she didn’t think it was the place to get into it just yet. Instead, she stood up and offered her arm again. “Ready to see something else?”

“What’s next on the tour?”

“Figured you might want to see our operations center. Then I can show you our canteen and barracks, and then… well, if your horse or whatever isn’t here by then, there’s some other things we can discuss.”

“Other things, huh?” Adora raised an eyebrow suggestively.

Catra rolled an eye. “You’ve got a one-track mind, Adora. There’s some developments happening in the Horde we want your opinion on.” This was, of course, half true. They *did* want Adora’s opinion, but they wanted her opinion on what had happened to her - and while Catra felt a little bad for not coming right out and saying it, she figured it would be better to make the actual request in private, where Adora could feel safe saying no.

Adora seemed to actually be a little disappointed, but nodded anyway. “Alright. Lead on, Commander.”

Catra led Adora back inside, and the two made their way down another set of hallways in relative silence, broken only by the presence of a few staff members who greeted Catra as they moved by. Catra was beginning to think they’d make it without anyone recognizing Adora when there was a sudden commotion behind them.

“Commander, with respect, what’s the Princess Glimmer’s consort doing here?”

Catra turned around slowly to see Aethina staring in disbelief at Adora with something that could have been anger and something that could have been confusion on her face. Adora turned, a little slowly, and straightened up slightly.

“Consort?” She laughed, shaking her head slowly. “The Rebellion rumor mill never disappoints.”

“Adora here,” Catra said, with an edge of warning in her tone, “was brought here from a Horde prison facility to recover and, potentially, to join our organization. Is there a problem, soldier?”

“She’s-” Aethina seemed to be searching for the right words. “She’s fiercely loyal to the Princess Alliance. Princess Glimmer is rarely seen without her. I would doubt her sincerity to our cause, Commander.”

Catra nodded. “Your heart’s in the right place, but there’s some information you don’t have - which you can’t have known - is that Adora is an old friend of mine, and I trust her completely.”

Aethina’s eyes widened. “Commander, what do you mean?”

“She means,” Adora supplied, a little wearily, “that I defected from the Horde and joined the Rebellion years ago - before she became Force Commander.”

“Does that mean…?” Aethina frowned, paused, and muttered, “some of the Horde recruits were talking about a Great Betrayer…”

Catra watched the gears turn behind Aethina’s eyes, and stage-whispered to Adora. “She’s about to figure it out.”

“Holy shit.” Aethina said, taking a step back. “You’re her. You’re She-Ra.”

“How do you figure that?” Adora said, concealing her surprise well.

“The Horde has this… story, I guess is the word, that they tell about the Great Betrayer. A loyal Horde soldier and Force Captain who abandoned the Horde years ago, back when She-Ra first showed up. And She-Ra just kind of… shows up when she’s needed, usually in the company of Princess Glimmer.” She pursed her lips, thinking some more, and gasped in surprise. “That’s what did it, isn’t it? You became She-Ra and left the Horde.”

Catra glanced sideways at Adora to see whether or not she would confirm the story. Adora was quiet for a bit, and then gave a small grin and looked over at Catra. “Well, Catra, you still think the Rebellion’s full of idiots?”

“Hey,” Catra said, feeling slightly relieved but also noticing a tension in Adora’s posture. “Aethina joined up here. She doesn’t count.” She turned to Aethina. “You’re allowed to have your doubts, but I hope you trust my judgment in this matter. If Adora says I can trust her, I can trust her.”

“Of course, Commander.” Aethina said. “You haven’t led us astray yet.”

“Glad to hear it.” Catra said. “Now, I seem to remember you being expected for combat training soon?”

“Shit! Sorry, Commander.” Aethina saluted and started to walk off, only for Catra to stop her once more.

“Don’t push yourself too hard now. Entrapta tells me you’ve still got some healing to do before we can have you back in the field.”

“Of course, Commander.” Aethina said, and walked off.

“There is,” Catra said quietly to Adora, as the two continued on their way, “another part to the story the Horde tells - but fortunately Aethina was too polite to add it.”

“What’s that?” Adora asked, somewhat dreading the answer.

“That the Commander loved the Great Betrayer more than anything, and her betrayal is what drove the Commander to such great heights. It was the duty of every good Horde soldier to avenge the Commander’s broken heart. Not, of course,” Catra said with a grin, “that this was part of the *official* story that Hordak promoted. But soldiers, as you’ve probably found, are fond of gossip - being the *consort* of Princess Glimmer and all.”

“Oh gods, shut up.” Adora said, groaning. “If I have to hear one more rumor about which Princess I’m currently bedding, I’ll turn myself into the Horde and let them execute me. You know there’s even a rumor that I’m sleeping with She-Ra?”

“Now that,” Catra whispered with a wicked grin, “I might want to watch.”

Adora coughed and flushed crimson. “So,” she said in a voice several octaves higher than usual, “Operations is nearby?”

Catra cackled and received a shove for her troubles, which, as Adora had her arm around her shoulder for support, actually ended up pinning Catra against the wall. Catra found herself looking up into Adora’s eyes which went from annoyed to mischievous in an instant.

“Oh look,” Adora whispered low, “the Great Betrayer has the Commander at her mercy.” She leaned in closer, and Catra felt her breath catch in her throat. “What *will* she do with her, I wonder?”

Catra thanked whatever deities that were listening for the hallway being, at least for the moment, devoid of soldiers and surprised Adora by pulling her in for a kiss. Adora let out a delighted sound, and moved her arm to cup Catra's face. Catra shuddered and wrapped her tail around Adora's leg, and the two stayed that way for a little while. Much sooner than she would have preferred, Adora allowed Catra to pull back and break the kiss.

"Gods," Catra said, catching her breath, "I've waited all day to do that."

"How uh, how important is the rest of this tour?" Adora asked, feeling suddenly very disinterested in the workings of Catra's organization.

"Sorry, Adora." Catra said. "I'm afraid we've got a schedule to keep."

Adora's pout nearly made Catra reconsider her answer. "Fiiiiine."

"You know, once upon a time, *you* were the responsible one." Catra said, with a snort.

"What can I say?" Adora said, shooting a look at Catra that was best described as *heated* , "I seem to have fallen in with a bad crowd."

It took almost every ounce of Catra's self-control to respond with nothing more than a laugh and a "Alright, we're nearly there." If they gave out medals for not shamelessly fucking in a hallway, Catra thought, she'd more than earned one. By the time they reached the doors to the operations center.

Adora whistled, impressed. A bank of stolen Horde communications arrays lined the wall, staffed by operators speaking in low tones. A map of Etheria hung on the wall, with various pins indicating job offers and deployed resources adorning it. Scorpia sat at a desk in the center of the room, looking over some intel reports. She looked up with a warm smile on her face when she saw Catra and Adora.

“Commander! Adora! Welcome to the heart of our operation.” She made a sweeping gesture around the room. “All our operations are run out of here - and we interview all our recruits in the room adjoining this one.”

“Isn’t that giving someone you may not be able to trust yet too much credit?”

“If someone makes it all the way here,” Catra said with a smile, “we can trust them.”

“We have a very thorough vetting process.” Scorpia added. “If we have any reason to doubt the loyalty of a recruit, they never make it here.”

For some reason, Adora felt the need to press the issue. “I’m here, aren’t I?”

“And if we had any doubts,” Scorpia said cheerily, “you’d stay here. But the Commander vouched for you, which is about as good of an endorsement as you can get.”

Adora looked over at Catra, who shrugged. “I feel honored.”

Catra gave a huff of laughter and indicated a door at the back of the room. “Anyway, as you’re our newest recruit - er, sort of - I figured we’d have a chat in the meeting room before we grab something to eat.”

“Oh?” Adora said, grinning. “Are you going to-”

Catra held up a hand in warning. “I swear to gods Adora if you make a debriefing joke I’m kicking you out.”

“-ask me about my experiences, is what I was going to say before you so rudely interrupted with a tasteless and completely unnecessary joke?” Adora said, grinning even wider.

Catra groaned and looked at Scorpia. “You see what I have to put up with?”

Scorpia appeared delighted. “I think it’s cute, Commander.”

A faint blush appeared on Catra’s face, and she scowled to make up for it. “Alright you’re both terrible. Great. Come on, Adora.”

The second the door to the meeting room shut, Adora felt herself growing nervous. It wasn’t being alone with Catra, it was being alone with Catra in a situation where she’d doubtless have to talk about Octavia and the forest. Neither were topics she wanted to revisit, particularly not when they were so recent, but she felt like she owed Catra that much at least for rescuing her. Catra’s organization was, if nothing else, a valuable ally in the fight against the Horde (even though neither Catra nor the Princess Alliance would necessarily see it that way).

Catra noticed the shift immediately. “Hey, Adora, it’s okay. We don’t have to -”

“I know, I know. I want to.” Adora took a deep breath. “Can I sit down?”

“Yeah, of course.” Catra said, with a slightly puzzled look. “This isn’t an interrogation. You don’t have to answer anything, but I’d be lying if I said we couldn’t use the intel. How’d they capture you?”

Adora grinned, a little cocky.. “I let them so that Glimmer and Bow would have a chance to escape.” She sighed. “Wasn’t my best plan, to be honest.”

“Bow - he was pretty badly wounded, according to our people.” Catra said. “What happened to him?”

“Squad of four came out of nowhere. Like, literally nowhere - we didn’t see them or hear them until they’d already shot him. There was this mist, like a shadowy fog. You know the type. The stuff that used to always cling to Shadow Weaver?”

Catra felt a chill run down her spine, but kept her face composed and nodded. “Yeah, I know.”

“It rolled in, and Glimmer tossed me the sword but I didn’t want to go all She-Ra and potentially blow our cover. Which was *stupid* , because I could have shielded us and Bow would have… he wouldn’t have…” Adora’s hands were balled into fist, and she was shaking slightly. Catra reached out with her good hand, and Adora felt a little more grounded. She took a shuddering breath and continued. “Anyway, with him hurt I figured, ‘better if they get out alive,’ so I transformed back, tossed the sword to Glimmer, and hung back to fight the squad. Managed to take one down, but they were *fast* , Catra. So much faster than I’m used to dealing with. She-Ra could have held her own, maybe, but… I wasn’t sure, and it was more important that Glimmer and Bow got away clean.”

“Yeah, but why give up the Sword?” Catra asked, still a little confused.

“If I die, the sword finds a new user - theoretically.” Adora said, quietly. “She-Ra isn’t replaceable, but *I* am.”

“No you aren’t.” Catra said with a vehemence that surprised her. She’d let the comment slide the first time she’d heard it, but she refused to again. “Not to me, and not to the Rebellion - even if they don’t realize it.”

There was a flicker of some emotion on Adora’s face before she continued. “At any rate, I knew that Glimmer and Bow would come for me eventually, and I figured I would be able to hold out until they did, so it was an easy decision to make.” A flash of pain flitted across Adora’s face, then. “If I’d known… I might not have done it if I’d known Shadow Weaver was back in command.”

Catra felt her missing hand ache. “Yeah. I found that out myself when I interrogated one of the guards. Not exactly the sort of news I wanted to hear.”

"Had Entrapta been working on something to adapt the powers of the Black Garnet to soldiers?" Adora asked, the question having

been on her mind from the beginning. "The way they moved… they were like Shadow Weaver, but without quite as much magic."

"If she ever looked into it, I wouldn't know." Catra said, feeling a little worried. "But Entrapta has always been more interested in the mechanical and not the biological." As if to punctuate her point, Catra unconsciously flexed her own mechanical hand. "What did they look like? The soldiers, I mean."

"They had… masks connected to these tanks on their backs - kind of like the underwater breathing equipment we were trained on, remember?"

"I hated underwater training. Of course I remember." Catra said, frowning. After a moment, she added, "I'll have my intel team look into it, see if they can dig anything up."

"There was something about that thing they strapped me into, too." Adora said. "It wasn't electricity that thing used. It was like what Shadow Weaver used to do when she'd..." she swallowed, forcing herself to continue, "punish you. And me, a few times."

That Adora had ever found herself on the receiving end of one of Shadow Weaver's 'lessons' was news to Catra."That's…" she breathed out, "that's new." She hesitated, and then added, because better Adora heard it directly from her, "We uh... we just used electricity when I was running things. Entrapta was against using the Black Garnet at all, really, after the first battle of Brightmoon."

"I know. Frosta told us." Adora said, and Catra felt a stab of regret. "She also told us that you'd been through the facility and left with most of the personnel there on some specialized mission, leaving them short-staffed when we came through."

Catra shrugged, looking uncomfortable. "Coincidence. It doesn't make it better."

"No." Adora agreed. "But it helped. It showed me you were still… you. You'd go as far as you thought you needed to go, but you

weren't completely heartless."

"Never sat right with me that you let her out on the battlefield." Catra said, maybe seeking to divert some of the conversation away from what she'd done. "Even if she wanted to be there, you and I *know* what it's like to be that young and go to war."

"It wasn't my decision." Adora said, a little defensively. "You think I didn't fight to keep her out of it? But she was - is - a ruler, and I'm just… someone with a sword. My word didn't carry much weight in those arguments."

"Sorry, I didn't mean to imply…" Catra sighed, rubbing her hand over her face. "No, I take it back. I definitely meant to imply. Seems like I go for your throat even when I don't want to."

"Yes, well," Adora said, sensing that Catra was close to losing herself in an all-too-familiar spiral of self-loathing, "Sometimes I don't mind you going for my throat."

Catra laughed. "You know Entrapta noticed that, right? I'm never going to hear the end of it."

Adora shrugged carelessly. "Small price to pay, don't you think?"

A knock at the door kept Catra from responding, and Scorpia stuck her head in the room. "Perimeter guards just reported a uh, flying horse?"

"Guess lunch will have to wait," Catra said, forcing down a sudden feeling of loss. "Let's go meet your 'fated steed' or whatever the hell he is."

Chapter End Notes

> Happy fourth, I guess? It takes some time to get these out, as it turns out, because I get all caught up in fiddling with dialog and thinking up new ways for Adora to deliver sub-par innuendo. It's her new job. Also, trying to have Catra reckon with the fact that she was in charge of interrogations without

like, getting too far down the rabbit hole was... Fucking Difficult. I don't think that's the last time she'll do it!

Anyway, hope you enjoy it! If you do, by all means hit the kudos button or leave a comment. If you don't, I guess don't hit the kudos button because that would send mixed messages, but comment anyway and let me know what doesn't work for you. I probably won't tailor things to fit your specific desires, but I will keep it in mind, at least.

We'll see how long it takes the next one to come out, eh? Swift Wind and Adora will have a discussion, and depending on how I'm feeling, Catra might catch a break. Also at some point I'll remember this was a Metal Gear-flavored story and we'll get back to that. Think I said that last time too, didn't I?

Complications and Catharsis

Chapter Summary

> Adora's departure gets delayed. Scorpia runs interference. Catra gives Adora a distraction. Adora provides Catra assurance.

Chapter Notes

> Once again I find myself feeling the urge to provide some sort of content warning, even though there's not much different from what we've already done in this particular tale. So instead of getting into the nitty and/or gritty of it all, I'll just say this:
>
> Depending on your mother's opinions on certain subjects, this might not be a chapter you want to read with your mother in the room.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

A screaming cut across the sky. Soldiers in the middle of training stopped, looking in the direction of the base with wide eyes, while inside the base other personnel dashed to the armory. The security team was already mobilized and sprinting in the direction of the screams. It was Scorpia who finally appeared outside the doors to one of the outbuildings that had yet to be renovated into something useful, gave a few curt orders that nobody was to enter, and then, perhaps out of pity, assured the few nervous soldiers that everything was under control. The soldiers would probably not have believed her if not for the fact that the screaming quite suddenly cut off. Those who knew Scorpia well would have noticed that she quickly covered up a look of relief on her face before heading back inside.

Adora was unconscious on the ground, and Catra was crouched next to her with a frantic look on her face. Swift Wind loomed over the two of them, looking confused. The Sword of Protection

lay forgotten in the corner where it had landed after Catra knocked it out of Adora's hand.

"Adora! Hey! Wake up!" Catra's voice had an edge of panic. "Come on, I need you to wake up. I need you to -"

Adora's eyes suddenly shot open and she sat up with a gasp. She looked around in confusion before her eyes focused on Catra. "What… what happened?"

"You took the sword and came in here to transform into She-Ra - you know, to heal up?" Swift Wind said, looking a little confused. "But something weird happened - you transformed like normal, but then it was like you were being electrocuted. You started screaming, Catra knocked the Sword out of your hand, and you collapsed and changed back to your normal self."

"It's like…" Catra frowned, "something interfered with your power. Like that corrupt program Entrapta found that one time, except instead of driving you crazy it just… tried to kill you. I don't know." She shuddered involuntarily. "It reminded me of… you know, *her* ."

Adora shook her head again, trying to clear it. "Electrocuted, you said?"

"Yeah," Swift Wind said, nodding, and would have snapped his fingers if he had them instead of hooves, "you know what? It was like… remember when Glimmer's powers weren't working? After you pulled her out of the Fright Zone?"

A cold feeling settled in Adora's gut. "So. It *was* her powers."

"How did Glimmer fix her powers?" Catra asked.

"She didn't." Adora said, shortly. "She kind of powered through it in the end, because her mom was in danger."

"I remember." Catra said, quietly.

Scorpia spoke up. “But that’s fine, then, right? It will pass eventually, and then you’ll be back to your old self?”

Adora’s shoulders slumped. “I don’t know. It’s not… It hurt so much, I don’t know if I can push through it - and She-Ra’s already been out of commission for nearly a week. There’s gotta be a treatment or something that can fix it quicker.”

Catra put a reassuring hand on Adora’s shoulder. “Entrapta might be able to figure something out.”

“It was Entrapta’s research that probably caused this in the first place!” Adora said with a sudden vehemence, shaking Catra’s hand off her shoulder.

“So let her make up for it.” Catra said, refusing to be baited into a fight. “You *know* she’s probably the only one who knows anything about runestones interacting with each other. She can check you out, see if there’s a way we can treat you here. If not…”

“If not,” Adora said, sighing, “I’ll have to see Light Hope.” A flicker of the anger that had briefly animated her flitted across her face again.

Catra noticed the tension and quickly came to a decision. “So, blinding pain aside… did it work? Are your injuries...better?”

Adora stretched, then prodded at her ribs experimentally and stood up, testing ler leg. She brightened up a little. “Seems like it! That’s… that’s good.” Her tone of voice seemed to suggest she did not necessarily consider the development all that good.

With a nod, Catra grabbed Adora by the arm. “Good. Follow me, then.”

“Where are we going?” Adora asked, a little surprised at Catra’s brisk pace.

“You said you wanted to follow me.” Catra said, not looking back at her. “There’s something every new recruit gets the chance to

do.”

“Which is what, exactly?” Adora asked, raising an eyebrow.

Even though Adora couldn’t quite see her face, Catra smiled as she opened the doors to the training grounds. “Catharsis.”

The grounds were still busy, and Catra quickly dismissed the salutes of the soldiers training there, making for the sparring grounds. Adora, still slightly confused, allowed herself to be pulled along. When they reached the arena, Catra let go of Adora’s hand and continued walking to the center, then turned to face Adora.

“Everyone who joins up,” Catra said, sounding a little rehearsed, “makes a commitment to let old grudges and loyalties die. But before they do, I give them a chance to vent their frustrations. To face a suitable avatar of the cause of their pain and the leaders who abandoned them, neglected them, considered them little more than pawns.”

Adora nodded, suspecting the answer to her question before she asked it. “Which is?”

“Me.” Catra said, then shrugged. “So. How about it, Adora? I’m responsible for your current situation. I brought Entrapta to the Horde, turned her against you, caused you to lose your connection to She-Ra. I spent years fighting you, trying to kill you and your friends. I’m the Horde.” She took up a fighting stance. “Defeat me.”

Adora looked somewhat reluctant. “Are you sure? I forgave you for all that a long time ago.”

“Absolutely.” Catra said, smiling dangerously. “Unless you’ve forgotten how to fight without turning yourself into a giant princess.”

That seemed to spark something in Adora, and she narrowed her eyes and dropped into a fighting stance. “Fine. One more time.”

The two circled each other warily, each looking for an opening. Catra struck first, feinting a strike before whirling around into a spinning kick that Adora only barely managed to block. Catra smirked, only to dive backwards a second later as Adora responded to her attack with a swift backhanded strike that Catra dropped to the ground to avoid. Adora followed up with a kick that Catra pushed herself off the ground to dodge, propelling herself up into a backflip. She landed on her feet, and it was Adora's turn to smirk.

Then, they really started fighting. Adora found, quite astonishingly, that she'd been wanting to do this for what felt like forever. Catra had been a focus for Adora's frustrations for so long, and to have the chance to meet in hand to hand combat again, without the fate of the world hanging in the balance, with just their own skills and training to determine the victor, was freeing. Catra was equally surprised, but for different reasons. Most of the time, Catra considered the recruiting fights to be part of a long, bloody penance that she'd never see the end of. Every fight was a chance for one of the people she'd wronged - directly or indirectly - to take it out on her. On more than one occasion, it had been very nearly a fight for her life.

Fighting with Adora, however, felt different. She'd thought, initially, that it would feel the same way - and give her the opportunity to work out her own frustrations for a change. When she reached for her anger, however, she couldn't find it. Instead, she just felt exhilaration. It was almost like they'd never stopped - like the last several years of Catra vs She-Ra had never happened, and they were sparring cadets again, competing under the watchful eye of a feared, hated, loved guardian.

Adora managed to land the first blow, a vicious punch that caught Catra in the jaw and twisted her body to the side. Catra used the momentum to spin around and land a kick that caught Adora in the ribs, and the two briefly broke apart, breathing heavily. Catra wiped a trickle of blood from her mouth and grinned.

“Ah,” she said, “I remember *that* punch.” She laughed, bared her teeth, and moved back in to attack. “Let’s see if you’ve learned anything new.”

This time, Catra began to use her advantage in speed to get around Adora, keeping her on her back foot. She managed to land a hit or two on Adora’s shoulders, throwing her momentum off. Adora, to Catra’s delight, adjusted her stance accordingly and with a surprising suddenness was not just using the momentum of Catra’s blows to turn faster, she was launching counterattacks to boot that landed blows on Catra’s ribs. Catra stumbled in an outward spiral, getting distance from Adora to catch her breath before darting back in, attempting to catch her off guard. There was another flurry of blows, until Adora reared back to deliver a haymaker just as Catra ducked low to deliver a brutal uppercut. Both blows landed, sending the two sprawling backwards into the dirt.

For a moment, neither moved. Then, Adora started laughing and sprang back to her feet. Catra did the same, except that while Adora laughed, Catra took the opportunity to tackle her back to the ground, where she perched on her chest with a satisfied look.

“Got you.” Catra crowed.

Adora had not stopped laughing, but twisted and flipped, causing Catra to give an undignified shout of surprise as she found herself suddenly on her back. This, Catra thought, clearly would not stand - and quite suddenly the two were grappling on the ground, trading position until they finally came to rest - with Catra in control - at the edge of the arena. The two were both exhausted and breathing heavily, drenched in sweat. Catra looked down at Adora and grinned before sitting back on her heels and standing up. She held a hand out to help Adora up.

“Feel better?”

“Yeah,” Adora said, before giving Catra a searching look. “Do you?”

Catra's grin widened and she nodded. "Yeah, I really do."

It was at that point the two realized that a sizeable crowd had formed during their fight. Catra was about to say something when Scorpia appeared and did it for her.

"Don't you lot have training to be doing? Back to it!"

The crowd dispersed, a few snatches of conversation which all seemed to relate to how evenly-matched the fight had been (as well as a few Horde vets explaining who the Great Betrayer was) echoing in the open air. Adora and Catra were left (relatively) alone in the arena. Scorpia approached the two, waving cheerily at them. "Hey Commander! Thought I might find you two here."

Catra shrugged. "I figured Adora would want a chance to see how well her leg healed. Plus, all the recruits get to fight me if they want, and she's…" she cast a sideways glance at Adora, "Well, she's close enough."

Scorpia nodded. "Of course, Commander. Anyway, I came here to tell you that Entrapta says she's busy with some wounded who came back this afternoon so she won't be able to take a look at Adora until tomorrow."

"Sounds fine." Catra said. "Adora, do you mind sticking around a little longer?"

Adora grinned. "I think I can probably make some time."

"Oh right!" Scorpia clacked a claw, remembering something suddenly. "She also wanted to remind Adora about their discussion this morning? Something about not having to stay in the infirmary?"

Adora looked sideways at Catra and smiled. "I think I've got a plan for that."

Catra kept a completely neutral expression and nodded thoughtfully. "Anything else, Scorpia?"

“I don’t think so. Our recon patrol near the Fright Zone border is set to check in with us by nightfall, and uh, the horse?”

“Pegasus.” Adora said, absently.

“Right, that. He said something about needing to get word to the others and took off.” Scorpia shrugged. “I couldn’t think of a reason to keep him here so I let him go.”

Catra frowned, a little worried. “Would’ve liked to have a serious discussion with him about the value of not telling anyone where we are, but…”

“It’ll be fine.” Adora said, trying not to show her own annoyance at Swift Wind leaving without saying goodbye first. “He already knows.”

Catra nodded and began walking. “Well. come on then Adora. I’ll show you the barracks and you can pick a place to stay.”

Adora waited until they were walking down an empty hallway before she spoke up. “Hey Catra, I was uh, thinking…”

“Hmm?”

It was ridiculous, Adora thought, that she was suddenly so nervous. It made no sense. They’d kissed in the hallway that very morning, and if not for Catra breaking things off, might have very well gone further. By comparison, this should have been simple. Things were, she thought, clearer between the two of them than they’d been in ages. “If uh, well, I mean…”

Catra looked at her with a confused expression. “Spit it out, Adora. Something wrong?”

“No no, it’s just um. I feel like I’d get a lot of questions that I don’t want to answer if I stayed in the barracks. So can I just… can I stay with you? If.. if that’s okay?”

Catra stared at Adora like she'd grown two heads. "I thought that was obvious. Did you really think... did you think I wouldn't say yes?"

"I just… didn't want to assume?"

Catra started laughing. "You," she said, "are an idiot."

Adora grumbled something about being polite and blushed. Catra chuckled and grabbed Adora by the hand again. "Come on then, Great Betrayer. I'll show you your quarters."

The two made their way past the barracks to the officer's quarters. Catra shoved the door open, muttering a curse. "This door always sticks a little. Part of the problem of basically renovating a ruin is that some things don't quite get fixed the way they used to be."

Adora shrugged. "That just gives it a little more personality, right?"

"Ha! Maybe so." Catra said. "At any rate, you can see there's not much here apart from a bed and a desk - I'd rather the men not think that I'm in some lavish digs while they sleep in an open barracks. We're hoping to build some proper dormitories eventually, get them their own rooms, or at least something a little less open." Catra was rambling now, and she wasn't quite sure why. "We're just kind of waiting for some more supplies. Oh, and some recruits who are a little more experienced with construction and the like. Surprisingly, we haven't gotten a lot of engineers joining up yet." She shrugged, and was going to continue when the feeling of Adora's arms wrapping around her waist distracted her.

Adora rested her chin on Catra's shoulder and breathed deep. "You smell terrible."

Catra snorted. "You don't exactly smell like roses either, Adora. That's what tends to happen after y-"

Adora pressed a kiss, feather-light, right at the juncture between Catra's neck and shoulder, which caused her breath to catch and completely derailed her train of thought. "Perhaps," Adora said, faux-thoughtfully, "we should do something about that."

Catra hummed thoughtfully, but there was a sudden tension in her posture that Adora did not fail to notice. "Perhaps." she agreed, "You can go first. Since I'm trying to be a good host, and all."

Ignoring the stab disappointment that Catra wasn't going to join her, Adora placed another kiss on Catra's cheek. "You're a fine host. I'll have to think of a way to thank you later."

"Just don't hog all the hot water." Catra said, a little distractedly. "Oh, there's a change of clothes for you too on the bed. Figured you might ask to share a room."

"Am I that predictable?"

"Well," Catra said, looking a little embarrassed, still with a growing tension in her posture, "I'd be lying if I said I wasn't kind of hoping you'd ask."

Adora laughed and walked into the bathroom, leaving the door half-open in what was a blatant invitation. Catra, for her part, walked out of sight so that she could freak out in private. She'd been thinking about getting Adora alone for most of the day - but now that they *were* alone, she was suddenly aware of all the scars and missing fur on her body, to say nothing of her missing arm. How could Adora be anything but repulsed?

By the time Adora finished her shower and walked out of the bathroom, wrapped in a towel and still damp, Catra was close to skipping a shower completely just to avoid the possibility of Adora seeing her. Adora gave Catra a curious look. "Hey, you in there?"

Catra startled a little, before suddenly coming back to herself. "Huh? Yeah, yeah I'm… yeah."

“Shower’s free.” Adora said, pointing over her shoulder. “I even left you some hot water.”

“Aw, you really do like me.” Catra said, quickly attempting to pretend everything was fine (and, though she didn’t know, failing to fool Adora for a second). She hopped in the shower and tried very hard to stop thinking. It was not much of a success. Growling in frustration, she flipped off the hot water entirely and welcomed the shock to her system, because *that* , at least, kept her from thinking more for a little while.

As she was drying off, there was a soft rap at the door. Adora cleared her throat on the other side and spoke quietly. “Hey, Catra. Are you okay in there?”

“I’m…” Catra tried to finish the sentence with ‘fine,’ but suddenly something in her rebelled against the notion. She swallowed and tried again. “It’s… it’s nothing,” she managed, but then sighed and slumped against the wall. “No, that’s not true.”

Adora nodded decisively. “I’m coming in.”

Catra felt a flare of panic and scrambled to wrap herself up in a towel, then, looking frantically for her arm, settled for merely folding it behind her back once she realized she couldn’t possibly get it on in the few seconds it would take the door to open. Her eye met Adora’s with shock, as Adora stood framed in the doorway with a look of deep concern on her face. She approached Catra slowly and gently but firmly pulled her into a hug.

“It’s okay.” Adora said, quietly. “You’re okay.”

Catra was caught between the desire to cling to Adora and the desire to push her away and try to recover. Adora loosened her grip to give Catra the option to back out if she wanted to and murmured, “I’m here. I’m not going anywhere. I promise.”

It was the promise that did it, breaking down whatever was left of Catra’s resolve and the urge to cling to Adora won out. “I’m sorry,” Catra whispered, “You shouldn’t have to…” she wasn’t sure what

she was trying to say. “I’m not who you knew,” she settled on, “I’m just the wreckage of what was.”

Adora shook her head, and Catra allowed herself to be pulled forward out of the bathroom, leaving her eyepatch and arm behind. As she led Catra over to the bed, Adora spoke in an almost chiding voice. “You’re wrong, Catra. You aren’t wreckage. You’re a survivor. You survived everything, and you put yourself back together, and you *rescued me* . You’re stronger than before.”

She guided Catra into a sitting position, and traced a hand over the jagged scar running across Catra’s ruined eye. Catra pulled back from the touch, and Adora let her, but continued talking in the same tone, with a steel certainty. “Your eye wasn’t you. Your arm wasn’t you. The prosthetic, the eyepatch, they’re as much you as everything else. They’re symbols of your survival. The survival of the strongest person I know. The survival of the woman I love more than anything else.”

Catra couldn’t meet Adora’s eyes. It was too much to take in. How could any of this be true? How could Adora look at her broken body and see anything but a horror? Summoning what little courage she had left, she finally managed to turn and face Adora, only to be confronted by an expression that was so full of adoration it took her breath away. Catra tried to find something she could say in response, but settled for pulling Adora into a kiss that annihilated all doubt as to who Adora was to her. Adora was almost staggered by it, driven backwards into the mattress. Catra loomed over her, a fire in her eye, the towel long since forgotten - had it even made it out of the bathroom? - neither of them had noticed. Adora’s eyes traced the scars running across Catra’s torso, the missing chunks of skin replaced by knots of scar tissue, the places where fur could never grow again. Then her fingers began doing the tracing, the dull pressure of Adora’s fingers on scar tissue contrasted by the sensation of her fingers on healthy skin sending sparks across Catra’s body. Catra scooped Adora up with her missing hand, her good hand grabbing the hem of Adora’s shirt and, quite insistently, rucking it upwards, which

Adora was only too happy to help her accomplish. Catra found herself momentarily speechless, and suddenly nervous.

“Hey,” Adora said, looking up at Catra, “It’s just me, okay?”

That’s the thing, Catra thought to herself, *it’s* you. Adora was breathtakingly beautiful, no way around it, and the idea that she was giving Catra permission - *encouragement* , even, to explore her, took a moment for Catra to process.

Perhaps sensing this, Adora pulled Catra into another searing kiss, guiding Catra’s good hand down her side to her hip, then slowly helped with the removal of her shorts. Once that final bit of clothing was out of the way, it really just became a race to see who could memorize the topography of the other first. Adora’s back arched up, an invitation Catra took full advantage of, marking Adora as hers, undeniably hers, relishing the way Adora’s breath hitched as she urged Catra on. Then, quite suddenly, Adora decided she needed to leave some marks of her own, and she reversed their positions, pinning Catra down.

Catra found herself paradoxically unprepared for the assault in spite of having dreamed of exactly this for the gods knew how long, feeling the way Adora’s long hair tickled as Adora traveled inevitably downwards, until, with her good hand fisted in her hair, she came with a ragged shout and a curse. In surprisingly short order, Adora found herself spouting equal swears and curses in the language of the First Ones as she rode Catra’s face to a climax of her own that felt as if it went on for an eternity. When she finally came back to herself, she levered herself off of Catra’s face and wrapped Catra up in her arms again.

For a while, neither spoke, though whether it was because they weren’t sure what to say or because they were both still trying to catch their breaths was unclear. Adora spoke first.

“That was…”

“Yeah.”

“I’m… I want you to know,” Adora said, “that I meant every word I said. Every word.”

Catra smiled and kissed Adora, sweet and slow and taking her time. “I know you did. And I’m… I believe you. Even if I’m not always sure it’s true.”

“It is.” Adora said. “You’ll realize that eventually. And when you aren’t sure, tell me so I can provide assurance.”

“I think,” Catra replied, her fingers already starting to trace a rather daring pattern on Adora’s skin, “I could get used to your particular method of assurance.”

Then, because Catra knew her meeting wasn’t for a few more hours, they did it again.

Chapter End Notes

> Well I'm sure I fucked this one up. Like, 100%, absolute bone-certainty that I've flown too close to the sun. Yet in spite of that I'm putting it up anyway. No word of a lie, since bringing the post new chapter page up I've already gone back and re-worked it *twice* in between writing the note at the beginning and this note here.
>
> Three times.
>
> This is where things pay off, really. It's also where we get into some of the other things Catra has to deal with, and give Adora a chance to really lay it all out on the table.
>
> You know, that and shoehorn in both a Gravity's Rainbow reference and another Metal Gear Solid line.
>
> Four times.
>
> I was going to do more stuff with Swift Wind, but then I just had Adora and Catra fight instead, and once they'd done *that* (five) the next part kind of insisted upon me writing it, and I

actually forgot he was supposed to be there at all, really, until Adora was already in the shower, so I just had Scorpia take care of it for me (six). Sloppy writing, I know.

As always, thanks for reading, commenting, telling your friends, and everything else. Seven times. Okay that's enough revising for now. Time to click publish and ride this nuke right into history. Although I reserve the right to remove the whole thing later.

Next chapter will, most likely, not show up until after season three drops. I'm sure you will all manage to survive, somehow, especially because you'll have a season's worth of She-Ra to watch, which I can guarantee will be better than this.

Domesticity

Chapter Summary

Adora wakes up. Lonnie loses a bet. Catra cooks.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora woke up alone in Catra's bed, the fading rays of the sun coating the room in a deep orange. She was, she realized, *starving* . Stretching, she hopped out of bed and looked around the room for any sign of Catra. Disappointingly, there was only a note left on the desk.

Hey, Adora. Had to meet with Scorpia. Come be my excuse to cut the meeting short and we'll grab dinner, okay?

In place of a signature, there was a tiny doodle of Catra's face. Adora smiled fondly and hopped into the shower, where she noticed several scratches which, she presumed, were a result of their earlier activities. She filed that away as something to tease Catra about later and pulled on a fresh uniform. It appeared that Catra had made arrangements to have multiple sets of clothing delivered, which brought another smile to her face. Clearly, she wasn't the only one who'd hoped to stick around for a while.

Opening the door, Adora headed in the direction of the Commander's office, or at least where she thought the Commander's office was. This time was surprised to see the hallways seemed a bit more crowded - presumably down to training sessions finishing up or soldiers returning from operations. Adora recognized one soldier from the training grounds, an older man whose hair carried a few streaks of grey. He stopped as she approached.

"That was impressive out there," he said. "The only other person I've seen fight the Commander to a standstill was Captain Scorpia,

and that was after she'd fought four others. You're pretty good."

Adora shrugged. "I got a few lucky hits in, that's all. She's a formidable fighter."

"Ha! Formidable doesn't begin to describe it." The soldier laughed. "She had me on the ground in something like thirty seconds. I've been in a lot of fights in my day, but I've never faced anyone like her before. There's something about the way she fights that I've never seen before - the way she uses your own momentum against you…" he gave Adora a meaningful look. "I was surprised to see someone else use a similar technique."

Adora had a decision: either admit that she and Catra had sort of developed the style on their own, which was as good as saying precisely who she was, or try to avoid the matter and maintain a little anonymity - however long that would last. "Oh, well, you know…" she said, rubbing the back of her head awkwardly, "I'm a fast learner, I guess." It was only after she said this that it occurred to her that if he'd watched the fight he knew exactly who she was, as multiple Horde soldiers had been very excitedly talking about seeing the Great Betrayer fight the Commander, and she winced in embarrassment.

The old man gave her a sympathetic look. "You're not very good at lying, are you?"

Adora gave a rueful chuckle. "No. I'm not."

"It's not a bad thing, you know," he said, "to desire anonymity. I'll spare you the questions about which stories about you are true."

"Most of them probably aren't." Adora said, sighing. "But I appreciate your restraint."

"Well," the old man said, "I did have one question."

"Which is?"

"What made you leave?"

“I saw what the Horde was doing.” Adora said, shrugging. “Once I saw that, I couldn’t stay.”

“And the Commander? Why didn’t she go with you?”

“Because,” Adora said, with a sigh, “I didn’t ask her to come with me until it was too late.”

The soldier nodded thoughtfully. “I see. It must have been quite the sacrifice to leave her behind.”

“Yes.” Adora said. “It was.”

Perhaps realizing he’d overstepped some boundary, the soldier inclined his head in a polite bow. “Thank you for indulging an old soldier’s curiosity. I’m sure you’ve got things to do.”

“It’s no trouble,” Adora said, not entirely truthfully, “but thank you all the same.” She nodded in dismissal and continued on her way.

Catra’s face lit up in absolute delight at the sight of Adora sticking her head into the doorway, a wide grin splitting her features. “Hey, Adora. Come to save me from this paperwork?”

Adora knew that she was probably smiling in a manner best described as ridiculously smitten, and she didn’t really care. “Hey, Catra. What kind of paperwork?”

“Report from our scouts along the Fright Zone border. Sounds like your horse did the job - the Rebellion forces have pulled back and are no longer putting themselves in danger looking for you. Oh, and there’s this too,” she said, indicating another paper, “regarding the rumors that got you and your friends to walk into a trap.”

“The walking tank thing?” Adora asked, curiosity raised. “What about it?”

“Well,” Catra said, feeling strangely pleased about being able to provide assistance, “it turns out there’s some element of the

control systems they can't quite figure out. The uh… gyro stabilization in particular."

Adora gave her a blank look. "Meaning?"

"It can't walk." Catra said, resisting the urge to cackle. "Entrapta had been working on it for a while, but she took her notes with her when she left. It's basically a worthless platform at this point."

"What about the cannon?" Adora asked, "Do you have anything on that?"

"Cannon?" Catra sounded confused. "What cannon?"

"Something I found when I infiltrated the R&D labs - it was a hybrid of Horde and First Ones tech that was meant to neutralize runestone powers."

"Ah," Catra said, "that." She looked uncomfortable. "Yeah, I don't know what the status on that is. Hordak kind of… kept me out of the loop on that one. Entrapta worked on the theory of it, but I don't know how involved in the actual manufacture of it she was - you can ask her about it when you see her tomorrow."

"I'm surprised Hordak kept you out of the loop." Adora said, a little taken aback.

Catra gave a crooked smile. "The tech side of things were never my strong suit, if we're being honest. As for Hordak, he was less concerned with the day-to-day operations and spent most of his time working on tech. As long as I stayed out of his way as far as tech was concerned, I had run of the rest of the Horde's operations." She sighed, a little wistfully. "It was a pretty good arrangement, until he decided to have me killed."

Adora gave a huff of laughter and decided not to voice the thought that immediately jumped into her head, which was that she was actually kind of glad Hordak decided to have Catra killed. It was, after all, that decision which had contributed to the

current state of affairs. “I don’t mean to distract you from your work, but I believe you mentioned something about dinner?”

Catra stood up from behind her desk decisively. “Ah, so you *did* get my note. Yeah, you ended up sleeping a little longer than I planned, but fortunately for us the kitchen stays open to all provided you document what you take between the scheduled meals.”

“Wait,” Adora said, suddenly seeming nervous, “you mean you’re going to *cook* ?”

“Hey,” Catra said, with a grin that walked right up to the edge of salacious, “I’ve got all *kinds* of talents you don’t know about yet.”

To her immense satisfaction, Adora blushed. As the two made their way to the mess hall, they ran into Lonnie, who seemed to be covered in dirt.

“Oh hey Adora,” Lonnie said, casually, “heard you were around.”

“Lonnie!” Adora said, bounding up to her and wrapping her up in a hug, “Great to see you again! Rogelio told me you and Kyle made it here.”

Lonnie, never one for physical contact in the best of times, gently pried Adora’s arms off her. “Yeah, we made it no problems. Heard you took kind of an unconventional route to get to us.”

“Oh you know Adora,” Catra said, unable to resist, “always making things more complicated than they have to be.”

Lonnie snorted. “Don’t I know it.” At Adora’s offended “Hey!” she chuckled. “Don’t worry Adora, the Commander’s just as bad as you are.” A grin crept across her features. “Guess I should offer some congratulations to the two of you, huh?”

Adora looked confused. “Why?”

“Because y’all finally hooked up.” Lonnie said, as if it was obvious. “Honestly, I had a bet with Rog’ that it would take longer, but I guess he knew something I didn’t.”

“I don’t know what you could possibly be talking about.” Adora said, her voice sounding strangled.

Lonnie laughed. “Must be my mistake. I think I’ll probably pay up to Rogelio just to be safe, though.”

Catra’s first instinct was to lie - but then she thought, *who cares?* and grinned, shaking her head. “Should’ve known Rogelio would take the under. That dude’s a romantic at heart.” She suppressed a laugh at the way Adora’s head whipped around to stare at her in shock.

“I’m sayin’, right?” Lonnie shook her head in wonder. “Anyway, I gotta get out of these clothes - you’ll be glad to know, Commander, that we got a new field cleared and planted today.”

“That’s great news!” Catra said, looking thrilled. “We’re ahead of schedule now. We should be self-sufficient by the time harvest season rolls around.”

“Looks like it.” Lonnie said, with a hint of pride. “Beats the hell out of patrol duty any day.”

There was an almost motherly look in Catra’s eye as she gave Lonnie’s shoulder a squeeze. “Glad to hear it. You let me know if your team needs extra manpower, we’ll see about rounding up some more volunteers.”

“Oh don’t worry,” Lonne said. “I’ll let you know. Loudly. Repeatedly.” She waved. “See you around, Adora.” There was a pause, and with a wicked grin, she added, “Don’t keep the Commander up *too* late, now.”

Adora’s response was lost in the sound of Lonnie’s laughter as she walked away. Catra threw her arm around Adora’s shoulder, pulled her in, and laughed, overcome by a sudden feeling of joy. “Come

on, Adora, who cares who knows what we've been up to? I've got this stir-fry that'll change your fucking life."

True to her word, as soon as they arrived in the mess hall and made for the kitchen, Catra started pulling out various vegetables and directed Adora to slice them up while she began collecting some spices and other cooking implements. It was so unlike anything they'd ever done before, Adora thought as she worked, but at the same time there was a familiarity to it, like they'd been waiting to do something like this their whole lives. A sigh escaped her, causing Catra to cock her head in concern.

"Something wrong?"

Adora shook her head. "No, it's just…" she hesitated slightly, then gathered her strength and continued, "when I infiltrated the Fright Zone, and I found out you were dead - or at least, the Horde at large thought you were dead - I uh, I started to hear your voice in my head. You know, thinking what you'd say and whatever. Then on the way out, I got wounded and maybe hallucinated you a little."

Catra winced in sympathy. "God, Adora, I'm sorry."

"No no, it's just…" Adora smiled crookedly, "well okay it *did* suck, but when I was in the worst of it, all I could think about was how I wanted to see you again, and just go somewhere away from everything to figure our shit out and then just… live out my days with you in peace." Her expression softened, and she whispered, "Right now feels kinda like I imagined it could if we did."

Catra felt a rush of a feeling she couldn't quite place, a mixture of love for Adora and sadness because she knew deep down that the dream would have to stay a dream. Even if the war ended, both of them would have so much to do yet - Adora would doubtless need to be around to keep the peace, and Catra… well, she'd have to figure out how to deal with what would surely be an influx of Horde soldiers with nowhere to go, and the possibility that with the Horde no longer a threat, the Alliance would finally give some

thought to bringing in the Force Commander behind so many attacks on Brightmoon.

“Well,” she said, in an equally soft voice, “guess we’ll have to make sure we keep an eye out for a suitable spot.”

Adora’s smile could have outshone the sun. “Yeah,” she said, “we will.”

Chapter End Notes

A little shorter, because once again I couldn't bring myself to continue after the last line. It felt too right!

I've been watching Evo all weekend instead of devouring Season 3 of She-Ra, but I hear tell there's some Heavy Angst to be had, so have some absolutely shameless adorable dorks being domestic. Consider it the calm before the storm - after all, She-Ra's still locked away, the Horde is still under new (old) management, and Hordak, like Dracula, is still a threat.

Thanks for reading, thanks for commenting, thanks for the kudos, thanks for making the world slightly better by being around. See you next time.

Twins

Chapter Summary

> Adora is tested. Catra is tormented. Entrapta learns something she wishes she hadn't.

Chapter Notes

> So uh, the warning from last chapter also applies to this chapter.
>
> Oh let me also add that I really, quite strongly suggest you watch Season 3 before you read, because I took some information revealed there and used it here, mostly because it gave me a great excuse to bring in some more stuff from the Metal Gear series.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“Are you ready?” Entrapta called out.

Adora was laying on a bed, holding the Sword of Protection. A series of leads ran from the sword blade to a bank of computers, along with another series of leads attached to Adora’s head and chest. Catra was leaning against the wall watching her like a hawk and trying to resist the urge to start pacing nervously. She caught Adora’s eye and smiled in what she hoped was a reassuring manner. Adora seemed to relax a little.

“Ready.” She said, in what Catra thought was a remarkably calm voice considering what she was about to do to herself.

Entrapta clapped her hands excitedly, caught herself, and took a deep breath. “Okay, we’re recording data - initiate transformation.”

“For the honor of Greyskull!” Adora said, and her body became a brief supernova as she shifted into She-Ra’s larger form.

There was a brief second where she seemed okay, and Catra felt a wave of relief. Then, the golden light was replaced by flashes of red. She-Ra's body convulsed, and Entrapta started yelling something about Emergency Shutdown Procedures and Emily's familiar bulk heaved into view, shooting a cable that wrapped around the sword and pulled it out of She-Ra's hands. There was, as before, another explosion of light as She-Ra's form shrank back down into Adora's now unconscious form.

Catra rushed forward and immediately began checking Adora over. "Is she-?"

"She'll be fine, Commander, she's just unconscious." Entrapta said, reassuringly, "The transformation being blocked puts considerable strain on her body, but the regenerative properties of the She-Ra construct compensate. As long as we don't overdo it, she should be fine. Also, I got some great data!"

Catra felt a flare of anger at Entrapta's seeming nonchalance toward Adora's condition and reminded herself that Entrapta was *helping* . "That's… good."

"Oh, sorry. I get carried away sometimes." Entrapta placed a reassuring hair tendril on Catra's shoulder. "She's going to be okay. If it's Horde tech causing the problem, I'll figure it out."

"And if it isn't?" Catra said, feeling suddenly sick. "If it's… if it's… Shadow Weaver?"

"I'll still figure it out." Entrapta said, a little stubbornly. "Magic is just technology we don't understand yet, after all!"

Catra felt some of the tension in her shoulders loosen. "Thanks, Entrapta. I owe you one."

"No, I owe Adora." Entrapta said, a look of regret flickering across her features. "It's my research that caused this."

"It's your research that will *fix* it." Catra said, firmly.

"Probably!" Entrapta said, brightening back up. "It's a shame that my lab partner couldn't help with this problem. Research went faster when we were working together." Her expression darkened. "Then he tried to kill you. I should have seen it coming. I could have talked him out of it."

This time it was Catra who placed a hand on Entrapta's shoulder. "Hey, you *saved my life* , remember? I should've seen it coming too - if I'd kept an eye on Shadow Weaver maybe she would've let something slip." *Or if I'd come with Adora to begin with instead of obsessing over feeling sorry for myself, maybe* none *of this would have happened* , she didn't add. *If I'd just tried for a minute to do anything that didn't involve lashing out and blaming the world for everything I did. If…*

A groan from Adora broke Catra's quickly spiraling train of thought and swiftly redirected her attention. "Adora?"

"Hey, I didn't scream this time." Adora said, sounding pained. "Does that count as progress?"

"It does keep us from having to reassure the troops that we're not running a torture outfit." Catra said, covering her relief with a wry smile. She stroked Adora's head gently. "You did great. Entrapta got some good data to work with."

"It's *fascinating* , Adora!" Entrapta said, waving a tablet around. "The amount of potential energy stored in that sword of yours is downright incredible! You could power the whole base using it and still not even come close to stressing its limits! I don't like using the same word again so soon but this is *fascinating!* "

"And the interference?" Adora asked, trying to bring Entrapta back on task.

"I'm less sure about that. It's an energy signature I'm not familiar with."

"So it's not coming from the Black Garnet?"

"Not unless the energy signature of the Black Garnet has changed significantly. Maybe…" Entrapta trailed off and seemed to think. "I need time to sift through this data."

Adora took a deep breath, and nodded. "How long do you need?"

"I don't know. Science takes time! Maybe in the next few days if I don't sleep? Scorpia is pretty firm about me sleeping, but if I *pretend* to sleep until *she's* asleep, then I can -"

Adora cut her off. "No, sleep when you need to. If you go without sleep you'll just raise the possibility of overlooking something important." She looked over at Catra, who nodded in agreement.

"Adora's right, Entrapta. No pushing yourself past the point of exhaustion. That's an order." Stepping close to Entrapta again, she added in a whisper, "Promise me you won't blame yourself for this."

Entrapta gave a salute with both hand and hair and stepped back. "You've got it, Commander. Now shoo! I've got work to do! Tell Rogelio that he's in charge of the infirmary, okay?"

Catra seemed surprised. "Really? You think he's ready for that kind of responsibility?"

"Commander, he was almost running the Horde medical wing by the time we left."

"Must've been a Scorpia thing…" Catra muttered, half to herself. "Well, okay then. I'll let him know. I'll send Scorpia by later today to make sure you're eating, alright? And contact us as soon as you've got something!" She turned to Adora. "Come on, I'll take you back to my room. You look like you could probably use some rest."

Adora nodded gratefully and the two left with Catra supporting Adora.

“Thanks.” Adora said, as they made their way down the hallway. “That stuff takes it out of me.”

“Least I can do,” Catra grunted, something else clearly on her mind, “it’s my fault you’re in this mess.”

“It’s hardly your fault that we wandered into a trap, Catra.” Adora said, snorting.

“Hmm.” Catra said, clearly not convinced, but also clearly not willing to argue at the moment. Instead, she changed the subject. “How long do you think you can stay? I don’t want your friends to worry.”

“I’ll call Swift Wind back and ask how they’re doing, but probably… probably not for more than a few more days.” Adora said, clearly unhappy at the fact. “The only problem is that if Entrapta hasn’t figured it out by then…”

“If she hasn’t figured it out, we’ll contact you as soon as she does. We…” Catra coughed, a little embarrassed, “er, we have some people in Brightmoon that can reach you. Actually, we were originally going to send some people with you.”

“Oh?”

Catra looked even more embarrassed. “Well, more accurately, I was going to try to convince you to let us send some people with you.”

Adora smirked. “I’m sure you had a plan on how to persuade me and everything, huh?”

“Nah, I was gonna just seduce you.” Catra said, waggling her eyebrows suggestively.

That earned her an amused snort from Adora. “Well,” she said, pulling Catra in close and running her tongue over her lips in a quick motion that Catra did not fail to notice, “mission accomplished, Commander.”

Catra wasn't sure exactly what she'd done to be so lucky as to have Adora kissing her, but she decided that it didn't matter that much. A rumbling purr escaped her throat and her tail wrapped around Adora's waist possessively. Adora's sense of timing had been good - the door to Catra's room was right next to her, and she quickly fumbled it open and pulled Catra back into the room with her. Catra pulled back for a moment, thinking about how she had work to do, she needed to talk to Rogelio, she needed to review the latest intel reports, she needed - but then Adora's hands were hot on her skin, pulling her shirt up and over her head, and her mouth was on her chest, and Catra stopped thinking about anything for a while.

"Don't - don't you need rest?" she finally managed to say, pinned against the wall with one leg hitched around Adora's waist.

"I have to give you up in three days," Adora said with a growl, "I can sleep later." As if to emphasize her point, Catra suddenly felt the muscles in Adora's back and arms flex, and quite suddenly she was lifted off the ground. Almost instinctively, Catra's other leg came up to join the first around Adora's waist as she slowly and steadily marched to the bed and lay her down. Catra's back hit the mattress with a whump and Adora followed her down, pulling back only to shuck her top and toss it carelessly to the side. Catra's metal hand hesitantly ran up Adora's side, and Adora let out a gasp at the cool metal on her skin.

Catra recoiled. "Sorry, I-"

"No, I uh," Adora's eyes were blown wide and her skin was covered in goosebumps, "do it again."

Catra's eye widened. "Oh. *Oh* . Okay." Her hand came up again, as gently as she could manage, and traced the outline of Adora's breast. She sat up to get better access, leaving Adora on her lap.

Adora hissed and pressed into the touch, which only encouraged Catra. "Please," Adora said, panting now, "please don't stop."

Catra obliged, running her hand over and, eventually, down. Judging from the way Adora reacted, this had been a good idea. It didn't take long. Perhaps emboldened by this display, just as Catra felt Adora begin to tense up, she bit down on her shoulder, hard. Adora's climax was loud enough that, a hazy part of Catra's brain supplied, it was probably for the best that it was mid-afternoon and the barracks were relatively deserted. Catra gently held Adora as she shuddered and twitched through the aftermath and was rewarded for her efforts by a sloppy kiss that quickly turned into yet another heated exchange. Adora pinned Catra's arms lightly over her head, and Catra felt her heart rate and breathing quicken as a sudden spike of fear shot through her.

Adora reacted immediately. She let go of Catra's wrists and pulled her into a gentle embrace. "I'm sorry," she whispered. "I wasn't thinking."

Catra shuddered against her and took a deep breath. "It's fine. I'm… It's fine." She was crying, she realized. There was a spike of anger. "It's not fair." She said, fiercely. "It's not fair that this is still…that *she still* -"

"Shh," Adora hushed, "She's not here. You survived. Remember that. You'll keep surviving."

Catra felt herself relax, slowly but surely. "Sorry," she said, quietly, "I guess I ruined the mood."

Adora laughed. "We've got some time."

Catra glanced at a clock on the wall and sighed. "Not enough, unfortunately for me. I've got work to do."

Adora pouted and pressed a kiss to Catra's collarbone. "Damn you and your responsible mind."

Catra's discipline was stretched to its limit and she groaned. "Ugh, I know. I'd love to just… stay here, but *apparently* I've got an army of mercenaries to help run."

“Well,” Adora said, tracing patterns up and down Catra’s back and looking at her with a soft smile, “when you need a break, you know where I’ll be.”

Catra drew Adora in for a kiss. “Thanks. I’ll be sure to take you up on the offer.”

“Good.” Adora said, and then seemed to remember that she was currently sitting on Catra. “I’ll just… get off you so you can get back to it.”

“Wish you were *getting* me off.” Catra muttered, half to herself as she stood up on shaky legs and went looking for her shirt and then, after considering for a moment, found a fresh pair of pants as well.

Adora snorted with laughter and nearly fell off the bed. “Come back soon and I’ll see what I can do.”

“I’ll hold you to that.” Catra said, smiling.

Adora laughed again and fell back on the bed as the morning’s exertions suddenly caught up to her. By the time Catra finished putting herself back together, Adora had fallen asleep. Catra tiptoed over and placed a kiss on her cheek before heading for her office.

Entrapta was waiting for her. “Commander! How’s Adora?”

“Resting.” Catra said. “Have you figured something out already?”

“Well, yes and no.” Entrapta said, her hair making a so-so motion. “The energy readings - they’re tailored to Adora’s genetic signature.”

Catra’s brow furrowed. “What does that mean, exactly?”

“Oh, a genetic signature is… it’s something that makes up who you are. It’s completely unique to every person.”

“So the energy was meant to disable Adora from the start?” Catra asked.

“That’s the thing. I think the energy would’ve hurt anyone, but the effect it’s having on Adora’s transformations was built in. It’s inherent to the nature of the energy.”

“Can you fix it?” Catra asked.

Entrapta shrugged. “Well, maybe. I took a sample of Adora’s genetic signature earlier, and with a clean sample of it I might be able to work up some kind of countermeasure to neutralize the interference. That’s not what I came here to tell you, though.”

Catra was confused. “No?”

“No. See, the Horde couldn’t have made this without access to Adora’s genetic code.” Entrapta said, shifting nervously. “And if I had to guess… they’ve only developed this recently, because Hordak never mentioned anything about this when I was… when we were working together.”

“So the Horde had her genetic code?” Catra said. “That’s not too surprising. They probably have everyone’s, right?”

“Most likely - but they’d need a constant supply if they were developing something like this. Any testing would destroy the sample.”

Catra felt a chill run over her body. “A constant supply?”

“From a living being, most likely.”

“But Adora was… she was only captive for a few days. And they already had this ready when they caught her.”

“Yes.” Entrapta said, looking nervous. “Do you remember what I told you about Hordak? About who he was?”

“A clone of Horde Prime.” Catra said, nodding. There was a sickening moment of realization. “You can’t mean -”

Entrapta slid a file across the desk. “When I was leaving, I grabbed a bunch of files related to my projects. This one isn’t one of mine, but it seemed important so I grabbed it too. I never got a chance to look at it, what with everything going on, but while I was looking for any notes on the energy readings, I went back to look at it.”

“‘The Children of War?’” Catra flipped the file open and felt her stomach fall through the floor. “This can’t be. This *can’t* be. I should have noticed this. How did I never see this?”

“The project started up just after you became Force Captain.” Entrapta explained, “And given… well, given the subject and your relation to it, I find it easy to believe Hordak wanted it kept from you.”

“She’s doing it again.” Catra said, her voice shaking. “She’s *doing it again* .” Her metal fist slammed on the desk, leaving a dent in the surface. “Get Scorpia in here. I need to… fuck, how do I tell Adora about this?”

“Well…” Entrapta said, a little hesitantly, “occasionally in order to keep someone from being hurt, you have to keep information from them. This… could be one of those situations. At least until we’re sure.”

Catra was standing up. She didn’t remember standing up, but she grabbed Entrapta by the shirt and drew her in close, snarling. “ *No* . I’m not going to keep this from her. I *can’t* keep this from her, do you understand? I just… we *just* ….”

Entrapta raised her hands in surrender. “I’m sorry, Commander. I only thought-”

Catra seemed to realize what she was doing and let go. She stepped back and composed herself. “No, Entrapta, I’m sorry. You’re just looking out for me, I know.” She took a deep breath,

and continued, “But I won’t keep this from Adora. I know it’s probably not the correct decision, but I have to let her know. Would you please send Scorpia here, and… and return to working on the energy interference. Let Adora know if you need her for any further tests.”

“Should I tell her?” Entrapta asked, hesitantly. “Er, about the project?”

“No,” Catra said, firmly. “I’ll tell her myself later. I just need some time to process it myself, first.” She placed a shaking hand on Entrapta’s shoulder and squeezed. “Thank you. For telling me.”

“You’re the Commander.” Entrapta said, simply. “And you’re my friend. I don’t like keeping secrets from my friends.”

“Isn’t Adora your friend too?” Catra asked.

“Adora and I have barely talked in years.” Entrapta said, shrugging. “The data doesn’t support us being friends anymore. Maybe we will be again sometime soon, but right now I wouldn’t feel bad about keeping this from her.” She saluted smartly. “It’s up to you, Commander. I’ll get Scorpia.”

Catra nodded, her gaze drawn back to the file on her desk. She didn’t even notice Entrapta leave, and collapsed into her chair, looking at the attached pictures in the file. Two young girls, one with short blonde hair scowling into the camera, the other all fangs and fur, captured hissing at whomever had taken the photo.

Her hand tightened into a fist. *Not this time,* she thought fiercely to herself, *I won’t let you do this to us this time.*

Chapter End Notes

> I will now declare myself Nostradamus, as at the very least I got the part about Catra making her own little army right in Season 3 (even if they didn't last too long and got pretty quickly brought into the Horde, I'm fucking *counting it*, okay).

Am I also going to draw on some of the additional insights into Catra's mind and use them in this? Well, judge for yourself, since I basically flavored some of Catra's internal monologue with that here.

Damn Season 3 was *good* though, huh?

Damn I really went full les enfents terribles, huh? Full disclosure: I'd already decided I was going to do something to mirror the Eli arc from MGSV before watching season 3, and then they went and gave me cloning facilities! They just *handed that shit over* like "hey here you go, here's a big old plot thing for you" and now here we are. Shit got METAL GEAR up ins, and I shan't apologize for it.

Next chapter, I'm afraid, is going to be a rough one. Sorry in advance?

Reaction

Chapter Summary

> Adora deals with the news. Scorpia helps. Catra makes her intentions clearer.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora stared at Catra as if she'd just been told Etheria wasn't real and was, in fact, created to sell toys to impressionable youngsters. "Run that by me one more time?"

Catra looked at Adora with concern in her eye. "I know, I didn't believe it either. But it's true. They cloned you. Me. *Us* . Some kind of back-up plan of Shadow Weaver's, in case… well, in case you defected or died, I assume."

"That… that can't be true." Adora felt like the ground had become unsteady. "If they were doing this before I even left, that means…" Her voice sank to a whisper. "They knew. They knew all along who I was. Shadow Weaver *knew* ." She was shaking. "They planned all of this. *Everything.* I never had a chance. I never had a *choice* ."

The look of concern in Catra's eye only grew. "Adora, listen, I know…" She shook her head. "No, I guess I don't, huh? The whole destiny thing has always been your deal."

"Except," Adora said, giving Catra a strange look, "they cloned you too."

"Typical Horde thinking," Catra said with a shrug, "go with the strategy that works. I was only ever a means to an end - a way to control you. Maybe they'll treat clone me a little nicer, make sure there's less resentment."

Adora didn't feel so sure, but she shoved the thought to the back of her mind as there was a bigger problem. "We have to save them. We can't - *I can't* - let another you go through this." She met Catra's somewhat surprised look with a pang of guilt. "I fucked this up once already."

Catra reached out, then, and grabbed Adora's hand to ground her. "Hey, I forgave you for all that, remember? And don't worry - the intel team's already working to find their location. We'll get them out no matter the cost."

Adora looked at Catra then, looked at the expression of stone-cold certainty on her face, and let herself believe it. The decision was easy to make, then. "As soon as you find them, I need to know. I'm coming with you."

"Don't worry." Catra said, with a reassuring grin, "I think if I'm going to have to go in and potentially face down Shadow Weaver again, I'd like to have you by my side. Come on, we'll do some training. Get your mind off this for a bit."

Something in the way she said the last sentence made it clear to Adora that Catra needed the distraction as much as she did, so she nodded. "Yeah. Let's go."

Eventually, Catra had to stop training and vanished to take care of some more daily operations, leaving Adora on her own. She spent another hour practicing shooting with the rifles favored by Catra's troops, letting the noise of gunfire drown out the thoughts that kept threatening to pull her under. No matter what she did, however, she kept circling back to one thought.

I never had a choice .

She focused on the target, pulled the trigger.

They knew the whole time who I was.

The texture of the gun's grip dug into her hand as she gripped it tighter.

They knew the Sword would find me.

She focused on the weight of the rifle, her arms steady and sure.

Why didn't they tell me?

There was a *ping* as her shot went slightly wide. She paused, refocused. Breathed.

They used Catra to try to control me .

Target. Breathe. Trigger.

They hurt her because they knew it would control me.

Her sight blurred and she shook her head to clear it. Another shot.

They hurt her and I left her anyway.

She angrily wiped her eyes. Refocused. Breathed.

Why her? Why me? What connection did they see between us?

Target. Trigger.

If they'd never brought me here, would she have been better off?

The next trigger pull only resulted in a dry click. Adora dropped the rifle and went to look for more ammunition, almost running directly into Scorpia.

"Hi Adora! I think you've probably done enough shooting for one day, don't you?"

Adora barely noticed her. "I'm…" she started to say, and then, impulsively grabbed Scorpia's shirt and looked at her pleadingly. "I've destroyed so many lives just by *being here* . If I'd never been found, everything would have been better off. Catra would have been better off."

Scorpia gingerly placed a claw on Adora's shoulder. "Oh no, Adora. Not at all."

Adora could feel herself starting to break down. It was too much. There was too much going on, she couldn't transform, she wasn't even sure she *wanted* to be able to transform anymore, she had Catra again, somehow, there was *another her* , and her entire life seemed to have been planned out by forces beyond her control.

Scorpia wrapped Adora up in a hug, making an occasional shushing noise. After a few minutes, she spoke up thoughtfully. "You know, if it wasn't for you putting the Princess Alliance back together, I don't think I'd ever have met Entrapta. Which," she hastily added, "I know only happened because you guys thought she was dead, and Catra lied to her about you abandoning her, and it was… you know, it was bad, really, like, a lot of people got hurt, and we tried to hurt you, and you tried to hurt us… but *I met Entrapta!*" She laughed, almost as if she still found the event miraculous. "So sure, there's been a lot of bad stuff. But there's good stuff too, and I don't think anyone would trade the good stuff for anything."

"But what if it could have been better without me?" Adora said, hopelessly. "What if-"

"Adora," Scorpia said, patiently, "it doesn't matter what if. There's no changing the past, but we can influence the future."

But my future's been determined for me , Adora thought. *It's my destiny to be She-Ra and either restore balance or go mad like they claim Mara did* . She sighed. *I guess you can at least stop another you from going through the same thing* . That thought made her feel slightly better. "Thanks, Scorpia."

"Hey, any time. I know we've been on opposite sides for most of this, but you were always pretty okay in my book. I'm glad we can be friends now!"

Adora couldn't help but grin at Scorpia's declaration. "Yeah, me too."

That seemed to please Scorpia, and she beamed. "Come on, let's get something to eat. You've been out here long enough."

The mess hall was full, as for once Adora was eating at a regular meal time. She looked around for Catra, and was disappointed not to see her. Scorpia noticed, and explained it was because Catra was meeting with some of the intel team to discuss what she referred to as 'that whole uh, you know, situation.'

"How much of a chance do they have of finding them? I mean, if Hordak managed to keep them hidden from Catra this whole time…"

Scorpia shrugged apologetically. "Honestly? No idea. It helps that we have a project name to look out for, but it's likely there's only a few people involved with it. That means we need to find out who those people are before we can think about getting information out of them. We've got a pretty large presence in the Horde, but even so…"

Adora sighed. "I was afraid of that. Maybe I can have the Rebellion look into it too - except then I'll have to explain how I know about it…"

"Don't worry about that," Scorpia said, waving a claw dismissively, "we can give you a cover story that's close enough to the truth so you won't be *completely* lying."

"I can't *lie* ," Adora insisted, "I'm terrible at it."

"On that," Catra's voice interrupted, "we're in total agreement."

The way in which Adora so visibly perked up at Catra's voice made Scorpia smile. "Catra! Hey!"

Catra draped herself over Adora's back and planted a kiss on her cheek. "Hey, Adora. How're you feeling?"

Adora attempted to arrange her features into something that seemed, if not *completely* okay, at least in the neighborhood of okay. "I've been better," she admitted, "but I think I just need some time to process everything."

"Yeah," Catra said, sitting down next to her, "I think that's about where I am. Our people are looking into it now, it's just a matter of time."

Adora didn't seem to be particularly reassured. "I was talking to Scorpia about maybe having the Rebellion's resources look for info on it too before you got here. Do you think that would help?"

Catra hummed thoughtfully. "Well, it certainly couldn't hurt to have more people looking. My only concern is if the Horde catches wind that we're looking for them they'll set another trap - or worse."

Adora's teeth ground together audibly. "They'd better not. I'll rip the whole place down with my bare hands."

"You'd have to race me." Catra said with a grim chuckle. "Fortunately for both of us, I don't think that's likely. Hordak's a lot of things, most of them bad, but he's also not one for wasting resources."

"And that's what the…" Adora struggled visibly for a moment, "what *we* are to him, right?"

"That's what *you* are." Catra corrected, an old bitterness creeping into her tone. " *I* , clearly, was not." At Adora's wince, she hastened to add, "Then again, they do seem to have thought to keep a spare of both of us around. That counts for something."

"I'm sorry." Adora said, quietly miserable. "It seems like all I do is make things worse for people."

"What," Catra replied, "just because I caught hell from Shadow Weaver to keep you in line? Adora, I would have gone through worse for you in those days. I still would."

“But you should never have *had* to.” Adora insisted. “If I’d never been found, you could have -”

“If you’d never been found I would have died as a cadet.” Catra said, bluntly. “You think the others would have put up with me if you hadn’t been around to glare them into submission? Or that Shadow Weaver wouldn’t have killed me if it wasn’t so obvious you were motivated by my continued existence? Look, I didn’t have the best childhood, but the good parts of it? Those were the parts with *you* . I wouldn’t give them up for anything, got it?”

There was an audible sniff from Scorpia. “Sorry,” she said, wiping a tear from her eye, “I’m just… not used to the Commander being so emotionally honest.”

Adora seemed to have forgotten they weren’t alone for a second, because her reaction was to jump in her seat, but she recovered quickly and laughed. “I don’t know if I am either.”

“Yeah well don’t get too used to it.” Catra said, grumbling a little. “If I’d known it was going to get me nothing but sass I would’ve kept it to myself.” A few of the soldiers looked over in surprise as laughter echoed through the canteen.

Later that evening, Catra perched on the end of the bed, watching Adora carefully as she prepared for bed. Adora moved slowly, deliberately, falling back into the routine drilled into her as a Horde cadet. It was obvious - to Catra, at least - that in spite of how she’d come alive a little in the canteen, she was still deeply troubled.

“You know I meant what I said earlier.” Catra said, quietly.

It took a moment for Adora to come back from wherever her mind had wandered off to, and she looked up at Catra. “I know. I just wish… I wish we’d had a choice in *any* of this.”

“We did.” Catra said, firmly. “Look, you chose to leave - you *did* ,” she insisted as Adora opened her mouth to protest, “and I *chose* to stay. It wasn’t the right choice, maybe, but it was *my choice* .

Everything that's happened since then has been under your own steam, prophecies and destiny and whatever be damned. It's still been *your choice* , all along. And for what it's worth?" Catra reached up and undid the straps holding her prosthetic, letting it fall to the ground, "This was my choice too and I would do it all again if it meant we ended up here together."

At some point, Catra had stood up off the bed and put her good hand on Adora's shoulder. Her other arm was wrapped around the back of Adora's neck, and Catra stared fiercely into Adora's eyes. "We're going to find those kids, Adora, and we're going to give them the same choice we had - more of a choice than we had. I'm going to give them an opportunity to get away from the war and grow up like normal fucking kids, whatever those are. Then we're going to figure out a way to end this war, and I'm going to throw you over my shoulder and ride off into the fucking sunset, to a cabin somewhere in the middle of nowhere, and we're going to live in something like peace. I'm going to walk away from all of this, if I can."

Catra was breathing hard, and her eye widened in surprise at what she'd just said. She stepped back suddenly, breaking contact with Adora. "I - I'm sorry. I know you can't-"

Adora's mouth was suddenly on hers, kissing her fiercely. After a moment, Adora pulled back and looked Catra in the eye. "It's my choice to make, isn't it?" She asked, a smile on her face. "I said I wanted to go off somewhere alone with you first, anyway."

"Yeah." Catra said, the memory of their earlier conversation coming back to her. "Yeah, you did. But I mean it, Adora. I'll need to leave it all behind when it's over. I've done too much to too many people. I'm already a demon. The world won't have a place for people like me."

"Your place is with me." Adora said, with an equal firmness. "And my place is with you. Wherever that is, we'll go there together."

Later, Adora would catch herself wondering if they'd ever stood a chance.

Chapter End Notes

Well this took its sweet time didn't it? Apologies, August was a Dark Time for your old Skeleton chum, because, well, brains are weird. We got there in the end though, and in the interim I even wrote some other nonsense (partially to work through something of an existential crisis, partially because I found myself with an appetite for weird shit because I've been playing Control) which if you really feel like it, you can read - just bear in mind it is very much Not This, and proceed accordingly.

Thanks for your patience, I don't *think* we'll have that long a gap until the next chapter's ready - something about the fall always puts me in the mood to mess around in Metal Gear Solid again, so my mind will be in the right spot for this stuff again. Alas! I fear we'll have to bid farewell to the vaguely domestic fluff soon.

Homecoming

Chapter Summary

> Adora returns. Bow and Glimmer get brought up to speed. Sort of.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Adora! I'm so glad you're okay!" Glimmer threw her arms around Adora's neck. "We've been so *worried* , I should have come back sooner, I'm-"

"Hey, hey," Adora said, sniffing back a tear and patting Glimmer's back, "you did what you had to. I knew what I was getting myself into, promise."

"Also Swift Wind, so glad to see you, so glad you let us know Adora was okay!" Swift Wind said, reminding everyone he was there.

Glimmer hiccuped and laughed. "Yes, Swift Wind, but I haven't seen Adora in…"

"A week." Adora said. "Feels like it's been a lot longer than that, honestly."

Glimmer stepped back and gave Adora a serious once-over. "Looks like you had the chance to heal a little, at any rate. How bad was it?" She winced. "Wait, you don't have to answer that if you don't want to."

"What Glimmer's saying," Bow said with a wry grin that masked his relief at seeing Adora again, "is that we've been very worried about you, and we're glad you're okay." He hugged Adora and she could tell he was trying not to cry.

“It’s okay, Bow.” Adora said. “How’s your shoulder?”

“Just about healed,” Bow replied. “Castaspella sent some healers from Mystacor to support us after the attack.”

Adora was visibly surprised. “Breaking neutrality again? I thought they’d written us off.”

Glimmer looks a little defensive. “She was just being cautious. The last time they openly helped us the Horde nearly found them. They lost a lot of people.”

“I know,” Adora said, not wanting to fight. “I’m just glad they reconsidered.”

“At any rate,” Bow said, playing peacemaker, “the point is they were able to undo most of the damage. I’ve got to do some strengthening exercises to get it back to 100%, but at least I’m not stuck in a sling - and I can fight, if we need to.”

“Which hopefully we won’t.” Glimmer added. “Our scouts have reported the Horde’s sent out search parties looking for you, but they don’t appear to be interested in re-taking territory for the moment. They’re still biding their time for… something.”

Adora’s heart sank. “Yeah, I’m afraid I’ve got a few ideas on what that is.” She sighed deeply. “Catra’s replacement is Shadow Weaver. I don’t know how she got back into Hordak’s good graces, but…”

The look of concern on Glimmer’s face said it all. “Are you sure?”

“They told me as much, when I was…” Pain flitted across Adora’s face against her will. “In their company.” she finally said. “They told me part of the reason they moved so quickly to get me out was because she was on her way to ‘collect’ me herself.”

“‘They?’”

“The Horde defectors who set me free.” Adora said, “and took care of me until Swift Wind was able to get the Sword to me.”

“Oh right.” Glimmer said, and then frowned. “Where are they now?”

“Well,” Adora said, “they don’t have a flying horse. So they’re still a few days out. After… the other trouble, they decided it was best if I got back as soon as possible.”

“What ‘other trouble?’” Bow asked, sounding worried. “Other trouble sounds… bad.”

“It’s probably better if I show you.” Adora said with a sigh. “But not out here. If your mom doesn’t mind waiting, Glimmer, can I head to my room first? Maybe freshen up a bit?”

“She can wait.” Glimmer said, forcefully. “If you need to rest, she’ll understand.”

“Okay.” Adora said, grabbing the sword off Swift Wind’s back. She gave him an affectionate pat on the snout. “Thanks for the ride, Swifty. You mind letting my rescuers know I got back safe?”

“Can I rest first?” Swift Wind said, a little annoyed. “You’re not exactly *light cargo* , Adora.”

Both Glimmer and Bow burst out laughing, while Adora spluttered. “Of course! There’s no rush. I didn’t mean you had to go right now.”

“Good. Because I wouldn’t go right now. I’m tired.” Swift Wind huffed, before nuzzling Adora. “Call me if you need me.”

Adora gave Swift Wind’s snout an affectionate pat. “Will do, Swifty.”

Glimmer and Bow both followed behind Adora as she headed for her room. Adora closed the door and took a deep breath, preparing herself mentally. She’d had a lot of practice the last two

days before leaving Catra and the others, but she knew it was going to hurt.

"Okay," Adora said, "just brace yourselves, and believe me when I say that I'll be fine and you shouldn't panic. *Promise me* , okay?"

Worried looks crossed both her friends' faces, but they nodded uneasily. Adora lifted the sword, said the words, and fought back the urge to scream as pain lanced through her. She held it for as long as she dared, then shifted back and collapsed on the floor. When she regained consciousness, she was on her bed and Glimmer was looking worriedly down at her.

"How long was I out?" Adora groaned.

Bow appeared in her field of view. "About five minutes, I think."

Adora sighed and, with a little difficulty, levered herself into a sitting position. "Hmm, a new record. I think I must be getting used to it."

Glimmer put a hesitant hand on Adora's arm. "It's… it's like what happened to me, isn't it?"

"Yeah." Adora sighed. "It's some kind of… magical interference, I guess. Some spell devised by Shadow Weaver, maybe, but I don't know for certain. I need to see Light Hope and see if she can provide insight."

This was *partially* true - Light Hope would in fact be able to provide some insight, as far as they knew - but then again Adora already knew what the problem was, and had someone working on a solution. It was just a matter of time, which was the only reason Adora felt even slightly comfortable keeping things from her friends. That, and she knew that Bow and Glimmer told each other everything - and Glimmer was maybe worse at lying to her mother than Adora was at lying to anyone.

The look on her face must have shown her frustration, because Glimmer immediately reassured her, "We'll get through this Adora.

I was able to get my powers back, and you've come so far since then! We'll get through this no problem."

Adora sighed. "I know, Glimmer. I just don't like having She-Ra sealed off." This was *also* partially true. If Adora was honest, she liked the idea, at least, of having an excuse for doing more training without the Sword of Protection - and for getting the Princess Alliance to maybe rely a little less on She-Ra.

Which was selfish of her, and went against so much of what she'd grown up believing - but then she thought about walking away from everything with Catra, and how they aren't able to do that because of… *everything* , and she started thinking that weaning the Princess Alliance off of She-Ra might not be the worst idea in the world. She found herself wishing - not for the first time - that Mara had kept a journal or something for her to find. Mara's current reputation as a monster notwithstanding, Adora felt Mara was the only one who really would understand the pressures of being She-Ra - that, and she had long had doubts as to the accuracy of Light Hope's explanation of events. That, however, was a conversation for another time entirely. Right now Glimmer was busy fretting, and Adora was too tired to really engage that much.

" - we can call down Mermista and Perfuma to pick up any slack while She-Ra's out of commision. Plus I found some of my Dad's journals on magic in the library and I've been working on learning more about it so, you know, it's no big deal! It'll be *fine* ." Glimmer was pacing back and forth.

Adora held out a hand to block Glimmer from walking back in front of her. "You're right. It *will* be fine. You guys are strong enough to handle things without She-Ra - and I'm no worse for the wear otherwise, so it's not like I won't be able to help in a fight. The magic was able to heal me, at least."

"What if we asked the healers from Mystacor to take a look at you?" Bow suggested. "They might know of a way to undo whatever Shadow Weaver's creepy magic did."

“Sure, it’s worth a shot.” Adora said, shrugging. “It would be nice to be able to transform and not pass out afterwards.”

Glimmer looked like she wasn’t sure whether or not Adora was being serious. “I’ll reach out to my aunt, then. Make the necessary arrangements.” She put a reassuring hand on Adora’s shoulder. “Grab some rest and a shower - I’m sure it’s been a while.”

Adora winced at the comment. She was wearing her old, bloodied clothes again - and she had spent the morning before leaving the base essentially rolling around in dirt to make it seem like she’d been trudging through the woods for days. It was something Catra had suggested - and it seemed to have done the trick.

Glimmer seemed to think Adora’s reaction was embarrassment, and quickly added, “Not that you uh, you don’t smell *that* bad!”

“Yeah I do.” Adora said, laughing. “I’ll grab a shower before I face down your mom.”

“Hey, I was serious, Adora. She can wait until tomorrow if you want.”

“No,” Adora said, feeling suddenly very tired, “might as well get it over with. Better she sees I’m okay with her own eyes and gets the news about Shadow Weaver direct from me anyway, right? Just give me some time to get cleaned up.”

Glimmer nodded. “Of course. We’ll give you some privacy.” She began ushering Bow out of the room. “Drop by my room when you’re ready to go.” She paused, and then teleported over to Adora and hugged her again and whispered. “I’m so glad to see you’re okay.” With a flash, she disappeared, leaving Adora alone.

She sighed and stripped off her old clothes. To her credit, she made it all the way to the shower before the stress of leaving Catra and lying to her friends caught up with her and her body started shaking uncontrollably. She leaned against the wall for support and, not for the first time, let the noise and sensation of

the water drown out thought. She dressed shakily in clean gear, then made her way to Glimmer's room.

Adora's breakdown in the shower seemed like it was obvious to Glimmer, as she gave Adora a long look when she opened her door. "Are you sure you're up for this?"

"Yeah." Adora swallowed, then nodded. "Yeah, let's do this."

There was relief on Angella's face when Adora stepped into the throne room. "Adora! I'm glad to see you safe." She smiled, a little wryly. "You're making a habit of worrying us, it would seem."

In spite of her nervousness, Adora laughed. "My apologies, Your Highness. I'll be more careful in the future."

"You made a noble sacrifice." Angella said, firmly. "You saved my daughter. That alone more than makes up for a little worry."

Adora sighed. "I only wish I were coming back with better news. During my captivity, I learned a few things: namely, that Shadow Weaver has taken over as Force Commander in the wake of Catra's…" she swallowed, "loss."

A troubled look crossed Angella's features. "That *is* bad news. That she managed to work her way back into Hordak's good graces alone is a sign of how dangerous she can be."

"That's… not all." Adora said, looking sideways at Glimmer. "She's found some way to transfer her powers to Horde soldiers. It's how they managed to ambush us in the forest." She turned to Glimmer. "That mist that came in - it was Shadow Weaver's magic. The defectors who rescued me confirmed it. There's some specialized training program she started up, and those soldiers are apparently the product of it."

"Is this related to the plans you brought back to us earlier? The anti-magic technology?"

Adora shook her head. "No, I believe this is a separate initiative. Shadow Weaver's magic has also been… *adapted* to their interrogation equipment. I experienced that first-hand."

There was compassion in Angella's eyes. "Oh, Adora. I'm so sorry we couldn't get to you more quickly."

"There's one more thing." Adora said, brushing by Angella's expression of pity for the moment. "Something about Shadow Weaver's magic is blocking my access to She-Ra. I was able to heal the worst of my injuries, but… I can't maintain the form."

"We'll have Castaspella look into it." Angella said decisively.

"Ahead of you there, mom." Glimmer spoke up. "I've already sent word to her."

Angella sat back on her throne, looking impressed. "Very good, Glimmer." She looked to Adora. "These… Horde defectors who rescued you. Can we trust them? What are the odds this is some plot to infiltrate our ranks?"

Adora pretended to think for a moment before answering. "They saved me. Killed their former comrades to do it, too. I think it's unlikely."

Angella nodded and sank deep into thought. "Very well. When they arrive, assuming they arrive, we will extend them hospitality. Doubtless they have valuable intelligence on Horde activities we could use, and we owe them for saving your life at any rate."

"Can I…" Adora hesitated. "Can I request one thing?" When Angella nodded, she continued. "When you talk to them - if the subject of Catra comes up... I'd rather not be around. I've had to hear it once. I don't want to hear it again."

The look of pity on Angella's face sent a surge of guilt through Adora. "Of course. I'm sorry, Adora, I know you've been through a lot."

Adora’s gut churned as she looked at the trusting face of her leader and thought about all the ways in which what she was doing counted as a gross betrayal of the Princess Alliance. “You don’t know the half of it.”

Chapter End Notes

I was torn between spending more time with Adora and Catra, and getting things moving. I'm a monster at heart, so I obviously I decided to get things moving. We'll see how Catra's dealing with Adora's return to Bright Moon next chapter.

Have I been playing Metal Gear Solid Peace Walker and MGSV (and also MGS3, a little, on my Vita) again recently? Look, *maybe*. Maybe I have a Sickness. You can let me know in the comments, or you can say nice things, or you can say nothing at all and just make vocalizations of dread when you think about what I might have planned! I won't tell you how to live your lives.

Traps

Chapter Summary

Things get a little complicated.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Commander, we've got a new job in that calls for your particular uh, delicate touch."

Catra had her feet up on her desk and had been staring at the ceiling for the last hour. "When you say 'delicate touch,' I assume you mean assassination?"

"Er, yes and no." Scorpia said, waggling a claw from side to side. "There's a small Horde outpost that's been having some issues with supply deliveries. Specifically, they seem to believe someone's been siphoning off supplies somewhere else. More specifically, they've been siphoning them off to run a thriving black market."

"Huh, let me guess. They don't want to have to tell anyone higher up in the command chain they have a problem."

"Exactly - it's way easier to explain someone just disappeared."

"Easy enough.." Catra said thoughtfully. "Why do they need someone else to do it?"

"Well, that's what makes it interesting." Scorpia said, grinning. "See, the man we've been hired to kill happens to be co-commander of the outpost. Meaning that when he disappears, there's going to be an investigation."

"So they need clear evidence of a third party to keep their hands clean." Catra sighed. "Fucking politics."

"Hey, it's well-paying. Although…"

Catra raised an eyebrow. "Although…?"

"Well," Scorpia said, a sly look on her face, "someone who knows how to navigate the black market might possess useful skills in acquisition of materials. And, you know, as long as he *disappears* …"

"Ah," Catra said, a grin spreading across her face, "so if he were to *disappear* to our organization…?"

"We'd still get paid, as far as I know."

Catra laughed delightedly. "Great! Tell Aiofe to start prepping the skiff for departure. She's been agitating for some action lately. This will be a good shakedown mission for her."

Scorpia raised an eyebrow. "The new kid? Are you sure?"

"She's a good pilot, and I'll feel better with someone on station rather than just the autopilot." Catra argued, feeling a little grumpy at being questioned. "This is deeper in Horde territory than we've been before, if this location's accurate."

"All the more reason to maybe bring someone a little less green." Scorpia responded, even though she knew it was a lost cause. "But if you think she's ready…"

"She's been training with Adora." Catra said. "I think she's ready enough."

Scorpia sighed. Of course it was because Catra wanted to see how well Adora had managed to train someone up. Which wasn't to say that Adora was incapable of being a good trainer, just that… well, it didn't matter. "Hmm. Fair enough. Don't get her killed, Commander."

"Hey," Catra said, with a flash of cockiness, "it's *me* ."

A few hours later, Catra was beginning to regret her decision. Not because Aoife wasn't up to the task - no, she knew that Aiofe was ready for field work - it was because she didn't expect Aiofe to talk so damn much. Worse, she was *inquisitive* .

"Commander, what did Adora mean when she told me that you two tried to kill each other on a regular basis?"

Catra rolled her eyes. "It means exactly what she said, soldier. I mean, she's an Alliance soldier like you were - and I was the Horde Commander. We basically had to try to kill each other whenever we met."

"But you're friends!"

"We…" Catra trailed off, frowning. Did she really want to get into the whole messy history between her and Adora? No, she decided, she really didn't. "We weren't at the time. Adora picked a side, and I didn't agree with her decision. Eventually I understood why she did what she did, but we were still on opposite sides of the battlefield."

Aiofe frowned. "I don't understand. If you were friends, didn't that make it hard to fight each other?"

"Maybe at first." Catra said, honestly. "Eventually, we got used to it. It stopped being personal and became… just part of the job." A suspicion struck her. "You might find yourself in the same situation sooner or later."

"I hope not." Aiofe said with a shudder. "I'm not sure that I could."

Catra shrugged. "Sooner or later, you'll have to choose where your loyalties lie. You're either loyal to the mission, or you're loyal to your friends. They won't always ask the same thing of you."

"What would you choose now?" Aiofe asked, curiously. "If you ran into Adora on a mission and had to fight?"

“We’d fight.” Catra said, without a moment’s hesitation, surprising herself. “I’m loyal to my purpose. If that means Adora and I fight, then we’ll fight.” Then, because it was true, she added, “Hopefully we manage to avoid that.”

That seemed to put an end to conversation for the moment, and instead of going over the mission details in her mind like she should, Catra spent the remainder of the flight wondering about just what she really would do if, in fact, she ended up on the opposite side of a battlefield from Adora again. Would she really fight her? If the Rebellion found out about her, and decided to come calling, Catra knew she would fight *them* to keep her soldiers safe without a moment’s hesitation. But would she fight *Adora* ? If Adora sided against Catra’s soldiers, then it would mean Adora did not understand what Catra was trying to build, what she was trying to do for her soldiers - for all soldiers. It would mean that, as she’d joked, one of them had gotten on the wrong side and needed to be taken down. Yes, Catra thought, she would fight Adora if she had to. She just hoped Adora would understand if the time came.

“Commander? We’re coming up on the drop zone.”

Shaken out of her thoughts, Catra smiled and clapped Aiofe on the shoulder. “Excellent flying. No signs of any Horde patrols?”

Aiofe made a show of checking the sensor screen and shook her head. “Negative, Commander. You should have a clear approach to the target.”

“Good. Set us down in the clearing there, and then I want you flying low on a patrol. You see anything that looks like it could be trouble, contact me and withdraw to the secondary LZ. At no point are you to engage with the enemy force - if they start shooting, you get the hell out of there. We don’t have many skiffs, so their preservation is a priority.”

“Can do, Commander.” Aiofe saluted sharply and brought the skiff in for a landing. “Good luck!”

Catra waved farewell and jumped over the side of the skiff, landing softly on the ground. She made for the treeline immediately, moving out of line of sight as quickly as possible. There was a dull roar as the skiff engine flared up again, and Aiofe was quickly out of sight. Catra gave her equipment a quick once over and struck out for the outpost.

As she made her way to the outpost, she went over everything she already knew about it - which, as it was one of the supply waystations for the Horde, was quite a bit. While she'd generally been willing to leave the finer points of the Horde's day-to-day logistics up to Scorpia. What she *had* been familiar with was the guard rotation and the layout of the facility, which she was hoping hadn't been too largely altered since her… departure. Then again, if Shadow Weaver was still as overcautious as usual (and with the recent Rebellion (and her own) attacks, that seemed likely), it was a sure bet there would be extra security to deal with. Catra drew the small pistol Entrapta had given her before leaving and checked it over.

"A tranquilizer gun?"

"You seemed like maybe you didn't want to kill everyone after bringing Adora back. The darts are enough to put anyone down for a couple of hours."

Catra looked askance at the gun in her hand. "The hell's in *these things?"*

Entrapta shrugged. "Just a little something I've been playing around with. There's all sorts of interesting plants around here!"

"Well," Catra muttered to herself, "let's see what we can do with you."

A few short minutes later and there was a quiet thud as a guard collapsed in a heap on the ground. Catra approached cautiously, and nudged the guard with her foot. No response. Catra nodded approvingly to herself and moved on. The base was, perhaps due

to its location fairly far from the Fright Zone borders, relatively open - patrolling guards formed the perimeter rather than walls. Catra's target - the officer with the sticky fingers - would most likely have been given a bunk in the officer's quarters, so she headed in that direction. Something didn't seem right to her - there should have been more guards, certainly more than the one she'd taken care of. It was *possible* , she considered, that her client had wisely reduced the guard in anticipation of her arrival, but she wasn't so sure.

Trap . She thought to herself. *Gotta be.* Her eyes flitted around the outpost. *If I can find a good spot to keep watch, maybe I can suss out the trap and avoid it.* She grinned to herself. *Or spring it on purpose.*

It didn't take long for Catra to find a suitable observation point: the roof of a warehouse was high enough, and she was relatively sure she could stay hidden from sight. She scrambled up without effort, and was quickly in position. Then, she looked for signs of a trap. It didn't take long. A few soldiers walked on patrol, chatting idly.

"You got any idea what we're supposed to be keeping an eye out for?"

"Single intruder. We give them access to the commander's building, let 'em sneak by us, and the team in the building takes them down."

"What happens if the intruder completes their mission, though?"

"Captain's under heavy guard. Nobody's gonna get through to him. Besides, it was all his idea to begin with. If they make it to him, he'll handle it himself."

Catra found that she was shaking with anger. The smart move, she knew, would be to scrub the mission - which, obviously, wasn't a mission at all, but a trap. Then she could get back to base and see if the intel team had an explanation as to why they

hadn't seen this coming. What she *wanted* to do, on the other hand, was make it clear that attempts at subterfuge against her people would result in bloody retribution. That was the risky, reckless, and (if she was being honest) downright irresponsible move. It was also the move she would have definitely made if a sudden explosion on the other side of the camp hadn’t distracted her. Soldiers dashed toward the source of the explosion, shouting, and Catra watched them curiously. Was the Rebellion making a move this far into Horde territory? She had to know.

Carefully making her way toward the source of the commotion, Catra caught sight of a slight movement near the warehouse. She changed course immediately and headed right for it. She was rewarded by the sight of a small figure darting into the building, and quietly followed it inside.

It was experience, perhaps, combined with reflexes and a little luck that led to her catching the knife that came flying at her face. Her free hand drew her pistol and she quickly sighted in on the culprit, shortly before the shock caused her to nearly drop her gun. She was staring at herself. Younger - considerably so - and with slightly different markings on her fur, but unmistakably *her* .

There was no time for a decision. Catra pulled the trigger.

Chapter End Notes

> Go ahead, admit it. You thought I was dead.
>
> But no! I'm not. I'm just moving slowly as we hurtle toward the end of the year and, as it turns out, my job starts to demand a lot more travel and *effort*, which makes me tired. Kind of means that only one of the three (at the moment) writing projects gets any thought at one time, and frankly I'd neglected one of them and the other had the zest of the New Idea all over it which meant that poor Catra spent a very long time on a skiff before I got back to her. But hey, I got back there eventually, as I always expect I shall until I bring this

thing in for a landing. Hopefully it will not be too rough of a landing.

Speaking of Catra, she kind of made a decision at the end there, huh? Wonder how that'll turn out!

Thanks for reading, and leaving kudos, and commenting, and generally being lovely people. We'll get through this (whatever this is) together, eh?

A Drop

Chapter Summary

> Catra hears something she didn't know she wanted to hear. Aiofe flies. A girl figures something out.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“Commander, that kid looks like-”

“I’m *aware* , Aiofe.”

“But that can’t-”

“Obviously it *can* .”

“But that’s-”

“Just get us back to base!” Catra snapped, looking down at herself with an unreadable expression. “Actually, no. Wait. Take us around north of the base. I need to take a look around before it’s too late.”

Aiofe nodded. “Got it. What about-”

Catra cut her off again. “She’ll be out for a while, but keep an eye on her just to be safe. Keep the engines spun up and *get the hell out* if the scanner picks anything up that isn’t me. Got it?”

The skiff skimmed across at tree level as Catra directed Aiofe in a pattern that would take them around any patrols. Aiofe spotted a suitable landing spot and brought the skiff in.

“What are you looking for?” Aiofe finally asked, unable to contain her curiosity any longer.

"I'm not sure." Catra responded, "But she wasn't acting alone, and I need to know who was helping her and why."

Aiofe nodded. "Good luck Commander. I'll keep an eye on this one."

Catra hopped over the edge and headed back in the direction of the base, which was easier to spot now that there was a giant cloud of smoke hanging in the air over it. She moved slowly and cautiously through the woods, keeping an eye out for signs of anyone's passage. There was no real rhyme or reason to her search - Catra knew deep down that she was looking for a needle in a haystack, without even knowing the size of the needle or what it looked like, or if it even really was a needle at all. Yet she had to try to spot what she knew - gut feeling knew, *instinctively* knew - would be signs of another child. A child with blonde hair, and steel grey eyes. A child without whom the kid lying unconscious in the skiff would most likely prove difficult or outright impossible to control.

Or , a voice in her head said, *you could wait for her to wake up and just* ask *her instead of looking for a way to control her like everyone else. Give her a chance to make the decision to trust you.* The thought brought her up short for a moment, before she banished it from her mind. Whoever the girl's allies were, they were in danger. Horde soldiers would doubtless be flooding the woods to search for the culprits of the attack soon, if they hadn't already, and if whoever was helping the girl was waiting for her return before leaving… well, better Catra found them than the Horde. *Besides* , she thought to herself, *what better way to establish trust than to pull her allies out of a jam?*

The sound of approaching footsteps jolted Catra into action. She scaled a tree almost without thinking and perched, waiting. It didn't take long for the source of the noise to appear: two Horde soldiers, sweeping the area in search of, Catra assumed, their attacker. She readied her pistol and was taking aim at one of the soldiers when the other gave a gurgling cry and collapsed into a heap on the ground with what looked like an arrow sticking out of

his throat. His partner whirled around in a panic, squeezing off a few shots with his rifle and sending bullets whizzing into the underbrush. Catra fired, and the soldier quickly collapsed. Then, in a move she was certain would get her killed, she dropped down from her hiding spot with her hands up.

"I'm a friend." She said aloud. "I can get you out of here, but I need you to trust me."

Silence. Catra kept her hands up and kept her breathing calm. Her fur prickled and she knew without a doubt that someone was watching her.

"I've got your friend with me already." She said. "I can take you to her, if you want. Then you can both go wherever it is you're planning to go."

There was a rustling in the underbrush to Catra's left. She turned slowly to face the source of the noise, hands still raised. Catra thought that she'd be ready to face who she knew it had to be, but even so the sight of a small girl with blonde hair and striking blue eyes was almost too much for her to bear. It helped that the girl was aiming a bow and arrow at her.

"Hey kid." Catra said, keeping her voice surprisingly steady. "Could you maybe point that thing somewhere else? Not that I don't trust you to keep a good grip on that arrow, but…"

The girl considered Catra for a long moment, then lowered the bow slowly. She stepped over to where the two Horde soldiers were laying on the ground and expertly withdrew the arrow from the dead soldier's throat. Then, in an equally practiced motion, she pulled a knife from her belt and drove it into the unconscious solder's throat before Catra had a chance to stop her.

Catra couldn't stop herself. "What the hell, kid? He was neutralized already!"

The girl fixed Catra with a look that seemed equally parts confused and annoyed. "We don't leave witnesses. Commander's

orders."

"Commander, huh?" Catra snorted. "Your *Commander* should have told you that if you take someone down without them seeing you, that means they aren't a witness."

"My *Commander* ," the girl said, baring her teeth a little, "knows it's better to be safe than dead."

"Good thing that I disagree," Catra drawled, "or your Commander would probably be dead."

Something like a snarl tore out of the girls throat and she lunged at Catra with impressive speed, knife flashing. Catra, however, had years of experience and better reflexes, and quickly had the girl disarmed and pinned on the ground. The girl squirmed and spat, biting and snarling. Catra was, honestly, a little taken aback at the ferocity of the girl, but kept her cool.

"Settle down kid - you think those were the only two soldiers out there? We've gotta get moving, and I'm not going to carry you, so you can either follow me to your commander, or you can take your chances with the rest of the Horde hunters here."

The girl seemed smart enough to know when to give up, at least. She stopped struggling. "Fine. But if you've hurt the commander, I'll kill you."

Catra stood up and extended her hand to help the girl up. "Fair enough, kid. You've got a deal."

The girl angrily batted her hand away and stood on her own. Catra suppressed a chuckle at the girl's defiance and started heading back toward the skiff. She keyed her radio as they walked.

"Commander to Falcon, returning to LZ with an additional passenger in tow. How's our guest?"

“Still asleep.” Aiofe’s voice crackled over the earpiece. “Should we expect any more passengers?”

Catra glanced backwards at the girl, who scowled back at her. “I don’t think so. I doubt she’d leave anyone behind.” Still, she paused and addressed the girl. “You have any other operatives active in this area?”

The girl seemed to appreciate being addressed as a soldier. “No.”

Catra nodded. “Awfully lean operation.”

“Fewer points of failure.” The girl said, as if relating a report to a superior. Catra hated how much it reminded her of herself. “Besides,” the girl continued, “there’s only-” She cut herself off with an angry look.

So it’s just been the two of you , Catra thought to herself. *At least I don’t have to worry about more kids* . She pretended not to hear the comment, figuring it was better to spare the girl the embarrassment of having slipped up. Instead, she grunted “Smart move” and continued walking. Soon enough she spotted the skiff through a break in the trees and quickened her pace slightly.

Catra keyed her radio. “Eyes on you now, Falcon. Spin it up.”

There was an answering whine of engine noise from the skiff and Catra looked back at the girl. “Your commander’s on the skiff. Time to go.”

This seemed to cause something in the girl’s demeanor to snap, and she sprinted forward, dodging around Catra’s feet. She vaulted over the side, and Catra heard a shout of surprise from Aiofe. When Catra reached the skiff a few seconds later, the girl had already found her commander and was crouched in front of her prone form, knife out in a defensive stance. Aiofe looked back at the two and raised an eyebrow.

“This our extra passenger, Commander?”

Catra nodded. “That’s the one. Get us out of here.”

There was a lurch as the skiff took to the sky, just as the girl scooped her commander up and made to jump off the side. Catra moved swiftly and tackled them both to the ground. “Don’t be stupid, kid. You’re going to end up a smear on the ground and then you’re no good to anyone, least of all your commander.”

“Death before slavery!” The girl shouted back, struggling. “That was our promise!”

The statement almost made Catra scramble backwards in dismay, but she managed to control herself. “Is that what you think this is?” She asked, some of her surprise bleeding into her voice. “You think I’ve come on a hunt for kids to take into my army?”

“That’s how the Horde operates.” The girl replied, cradling her commander’s head in her lap and glaring up at Catra. “Commander C’yra and I swore we wouldn’t be caught.”

Catra felt a dull pressure in her skull at the sound of the name. A face, not even *half-* remembered, that filled her with such a sudden feeling of loss that she was thrown off-balance. “C’yra?” She repeated the name thoughtfully, her voice rough. “And your name?”

“Mara.” The girl said, defiantly.

“Okay, Mara.” Catra said, already recovering from her… whatever that had been. “I promise you there’s no slavery in your future. I just need to ask you and your commander some questions about where you came from and what you were doing, and then… then I can take you wherever you want to go.”

“And we’re supposed to trust *you* ? The Commander of the Horde Army herself?”

Catra snorted. “Kid, do I look like the Commander of the Horde army? I just ran around the woods to get you *away* from the Horde army.”

Mara considered this, and narrowed her eyes suspiciously. “Could be a feint.”

“Yes,” Catra said, snapping, “I gouged my eye out and cut my hand off to con the kids *I didn’t know existed* into coming back to the Horde.”

Catra was caught off guard by the sudden movement of C’yra, who darted across the deck and lunged at her with a scream. Catra fended the attack off easily enough, leaving the girl swinging at empty air. “Liar!” C’yra shouted, her claws scoring a hit on Catra’s arm. “You knew we existed. We got regular reports on how *disappointed* you were with our progress, that you and the Great Betrayer had been *so much better* than us. That if you’d had your way, we would have never been *born!* ”

Catra held C’yra off, a million different thoughts rushing through her head. The only one that she managed to articulate was a quiet, “You’ve been lied to, kid. I’m sorry, but I didn’t know you two existed. I only just found out.”

“ *Liar!* ” C’yra shouted. “You *had* to have known! If you didn’t-”

“Then everything you did to try to gain my favor means nothing, right?” Catra sighed deeply. “Let me guess. Shadow Weaver told you all this? Trained you? Took care of you? Patched you up when you were hurt, right?”

Mara nodded, but C’yra just glared at her.

“But,” Catra continued, “she also was the one to punish you. Never *willingly* , of course. It was always for your own good. She had no say in the matter, right?”

The fire blazing in C’yra’s eyes dimmed as Catra watched her slowly put the pieces together. “She had to pit us against you.” The girl said slowly, her tail twitching. “We were meant to replace you and the Great Betrayer.”

“Smart kid.” Catra said, with a ghost of a smile on her face.

“That *fucking* bitch.” Mara spat, trembling in a rage. “We should’ve killed her before we left.”

Catra laughed, a dry chuckle. “Afraid I’ve got dibs on killing her, kiddo.”

Aiofe’s voice drifted back from the front of the skiff. “Commander, there’s something-”

The sentence was cut off by the sound of a tremendous impact as a bolt of energy slammed into the skiff’s nose. Catra moved instinctively, strapping the two kids to the benches running along the skiff sides. The skiff spun sickeningly, sending Catra flying over the side. Her shoulder wrenched painfully in its socket as she made a desperate last effort to save herself. Her body impacted the skiff exterior and she scrambled to get back in and up to the front where Aiofe was slumped over the controls. Catra’s hands flew over the controls, trying to keep the skiff in the air, or at least guide it somewhere relatively safe to land.

They *almost* made out of the woods. A treetop caught just above the skiff’s belly, causing it to roll. Then the skiff impacted one tree, then another, then another before plowing into the ground. Catra bounced off of the windscreen with a crack and then crashed to the ground, her vision fading to black.

Chapter End Notes

> So, how's *that* for a wee bit of a cliffhanger, eh? If there's one thing I love doing, it's placing children in peril!
>
> We're in that time of year - well, we're close to that time of year anyway - where I have to do a stupid amount of travel. So like I say every time I post a new chapter, "I don't know when the next one is going to go up but don't worry this ain't dead or nothin'."
>
> I don't actually say that but there's always some variation on it, isn't there? One day you'll learn not to listen to me.

This update's weird fact: For some reason, now that I am *dangerously* close to my mid thirties, I've suddenly become a fan of prog metal act Gojira. None of their tracks have particularly contributed to ideas for *this* thing, but man this fucking slaps.

Thank you, as always, to each and every one of you for reading, commenting, kudos-ing, and generally being just the fucking best. It is my very great delight to write this stuff for you. I think I'd probably write this nonsense without an audience, but having such a group of rad people following along is a nice bonus.

Now time to see what Adora's up to, don't you think?

The Truth, This Time

Chapter Summary

> Adora comes clean. Glimmer tries to understand. Bow tries to keep the peace.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora could feel herself starting to crack as she sat under the gaze of Castaspella's scrutiny. Glimmer was nearby, as she had been every day since Adora's return and subsequent admission that she couldn't become She-Ra anymore. Adora knew that Glimmer blamed herself for not being strong enough to get Adora and Bow out - that she was the weak link and should have done more. Adora knew this because Adora had these thoughts about herself all the time, and it was comically easy to see when someone else was having those same thoughts. She wanted to tell Glimmer that it was going to be okay, but without the ability to tell her *why* it was going to be okay she was lost.

"I don't understand…" Castaspella's voice carried an undeniable tone of frustration. "The nature of this magic… I've never seen anything like it. Not even from Shadow Weaver. It's been completely tailored to you in every way."

"Wait," Glimmer broke in, "you mean Shadow Weaver made a curse for you specifically?"

"Catra did always say I was her favorite:" Adora said in a tone that was far too light for the situation. "Guess she was right after all."

There was a stiffening of Glimmer's posture that happened any time Adora mentioned Catra, like she wasn't sure whether or not Adora was going to break down sobbing or not. Catra's death had at the very least been confirmed by the Horde defectors who had

rescued Adora, and Glimmer had not stopped beating herself up for telling Adora about the 'furry lady' and giving her false hope just yet. That Adora seemed to be strangely okay with the news and had on numerous occasions told Glimmer that it was fine, *really* , with a sort of desperation in her voice had unsurprisingly failed to improve Glimmer's feelings on the matter. It was one more thing about the current state of affairs that was weighing on Adora.

"Is there a way to fix it, Aunt Casta?"

Castaspella, usually a fount of unending chatter, was reduced to a shrug. "I'm not sure. There's got to be a way to reverse-engineer the spell, but it will take time to find it. And that doesn't explain *how* it happened. Routing that kind of a spell through the… device you were hooked up to cast remotely to suggests a level of control over the Black Garnet runestone which is very troubling."

Adora suppressed the spark of fear at the mention of her torture and spoke in a dismissive tone. "Power has never been the danger with Shadow Weaver - just her cunning. She leads from the back, always has. If we can make her think the tide's turned against her even for a second, she'll run and hide."

"But she's got the resources of the Horde behind her -"

"She doesn't really." Adora said, curtly. "Not the way that Catra did. Shadow Weaver sees soldiers as resources to be spent. Those defectors that rescued me are proof enough there's dissension in the ranks. She'll spread their forces too thin, just like she did back before Catra took over."

Glimmer didn't seem entirely convinced. "Even if they aren't, there's still the bots to consider - and those soldiers that attacked us in the woods. They're still a problem."

"We can handle it." Adora said, firmly. "I won't let them catch us off-guard again." Her fists were clenched.

Glimmer looked concerned. “I just… they were dangerous, Adora. They took you down.”

The memory of her knee being broken sent an ache through her leg, but Adora shook it off. She couldn't let Glimmer start to spiral into despair. She owed her that much for keeping Catra a secret, at least. “I know their capabilities now, and they won't get the drop on us this time. Against the three of us, they won't stand a chance"

From the look on Glimmer's face, she hadn't been successful. “You don’t *know* that for sure Adora, without She-Ra-”

“We don’t *need* She-Ra.” Adora snarled, with an anger that caught Glimmer by surprise. “ *I* don’t need She-Ra. I need-” She stopped just short of saying Catra’s name. Catching sight of Glimmer’s shocked expression, Adora felt a pang of guilt. “I’m sorry, Glim. Castaspella, can we have a minute alone?”

Castaspella, blessed with the ability to read the room, nodded almost a little too enthusiastically. “Of course, dear. I’ll just… leave you to it then.”

As soon as the door shut behind her, Glimmer approached Adora tentatively, like she wasn't entirely sure whether or not Adora would attack her. Adora felt sick. "What's going on, Adora? What *happened* to you? Really?"

Adora wasn’t sure how to respond, initially. She needed to at least get *something* off her chest, let Glimmer know that she would be okay, that there was an answer to the She-Ra problem. "I was tortured, Glimmer. I was tortured and *she was coming to collect me* ." She couldn’t stop talking, the stress of the situation, the whirlwind of meeting Catra again, it had all been too much - was still too much. "She could've wiped my memory clean. Turned me back into a good Horde soldier. If… if she hadn’t-” Adora cut herself off again, biting down on her lip so hard she drew blood.

Glimmer placed a hand on Adora's shoulder and gently ran it down her arm. "Hey, you're here, okay? You're safe." Adora felt herself relax at the touch, and Glimmer gave her a soft, encouraging smile. "You know you can tell me anything, right?"

The statement broke Adora completely, and she flung herself around Glimmer's neck, burying her face in the crook of her shoulder. "I'm sorry," Adora said, her voice muffled, "I never should have…"

Glimmer hushed Adora soothingly, but there was a hint of confusion in her voice when she responded, "What are you apologizing for? You went through so much to keep Bow and I safe."

I can't do this, Adora thought to herself, *I need Glimmer and Bow. I hope Catra understands that.* "I've been… keeping something from you." Adora said, haltingly. "Something that happened."

Glimmer didn't seem to understand. "Hey, if you don't want to relive all that stuff, I don't blame you-"

"No, it's…" Adora pulled back from Glimmer to look her directly in the eyes. "Can you keep a secret? I don't… I don't want your mother to know. Not yet."

Glimmer nodded. "Of course! My lips are sealed."

Adora took a deep breath. "Deserters didn't get me out of that prison facility. Catra did."

If it were possible, Glimmer's eyebrows would have not only flown off her head, they would have entered into low orbit and joined Etheria's twin moons. "I'm… sorry, what?"

Adora couldn't stop the grin that crossed her face as she said the words aloud again. "Catra's alive. She rescued me and… Glimmer, she's *alive* ."

“So the ‘furry lady’ was really her? Catra’s alive and she’s running a fucking *army of mercenaries?* ” Glimmer was doing her best to keep from shouting, with moderate levels of success.

Adora winced. “Yeah, kind of. She’s working with Scorpia and Entrapta too.”

“This has got to be a trap.” Glimmer said, frowning. “Some kind of long con.”

“No,” Adora said, sure as stone. “No trap. No trick. Hordak tried to kill her - she’s got the scars to prove it. She lost her hand, and one of her eyes. I know that Catra’s been pretty devious in the past, but she wouldn’t cut her hand off just to get one over on me.”

Glimmer still didn’t seem convinced. “It could just be makeup, or a fake-”

“Glimmer, I’ve seen her handless. The eye too. You’ve got to trust me, I would know if it was fake.” Adora felt herself starting to get angry, defensive. “Catra wouldn’t lie to me.”

“Catra’s done nothing *but* lie to you!” Glimmer responded. “Every time you fought she tried to work some angle.”

“Well she wouldn’t lie to me *now* .” Adora said. “Not after -” She stopped herself, but it was already too late.

Glimmer’s eyes lit up. “Not after *what* , Adora?”

Adora tried, and failed, to prevent a blush from appearing. “It’s… nevermind. She just… wouldn’t.”

Whatever anger had been building in Glimmer’s posture was almost completely replaced by something else entirely. Curiosity, coupled with deep amusement. “You and her…” She said, a grin beginning to crawl across her features.

“Glimmer…”

“When she rescued you,” Glimmer said, her voice taking on a singsong quality, “how did you show your *appreciation?* Did she sweep you off your feeeeeeeet?”

“Actually,” Adora said, a little sourly, “I thought she was a hallucination and passed out.”

Glimmer radiated smugness. “Oh, but when you woke up… I bet you had a lot to talk about.”

Adora was now *very* red. “ Wedidn’treallytalk ”

Glimmer’s grin grew even wider. “What’s that, Adora? I didn’t quite hear you.”

“I said we didn’t really talk!’ Adora said, covering her face.

“Wait.” Glimmer said, and disappeared in a burst of sparkles. A few seconds later, she reappeared with Bow in tow. “Okay, tell Bow what you told me.”

Adora sighed. “Glimmer…”

“Oh no,” Glimmer said, “he gets to hear this too.”

“Adora?” Bow said, curiously. “Why does Glimmer look like she’s about to explode?”

You knew you’d never keep this from both of them, didn’t you? Adora thought. “Catra’s alive. I’ve seen her. She uh, she’s the one who got me out of the prison camp.”

There was a teasing look on Glimmer’s face as she leaned in close to Bow. “Isn’t it *romantic* , Bow?”

“It kind of is,” Bow agreed, grinning. “But wait, if Catra rescued you, who are those Horde soldiers we took in?”

Judging by Glimmer’s reaction, this thought hadn’t occurred to her. Her voice lost its teasing edge and became harsher. “Yes,

Adora. Who are they?"

"They're members of Catra's… group." Adora said. "We thought… I didn't know what would happen if your mother found out about Catra, so they volunteered to be part of my cover story."

"Plus," Glimmer said, eyes narrowing, "I'm sure Catra wouldn't mind having *spies* running around the Rebellion's heart."

Guilt flooded through Adora. Had she been so willing to betray her friends? "Just to keep an eye out for potential jobs! And… and they're afraid of being discovered by the Rebellion."

Understanding mixed with betrayal appeared on Bow's face. "Because they're not just leading attacks and raids on Horde outposts." He was quiet. "Adora, tell me you weren't okay with this. Tell me you aren't okay with Catra attacking Alliance outposts."

"It's… it's more complicated than that." Adora says, pleadingly, feeling the situation beginning to turn. "They're trying to help the people we can't. That… that we *won't* , for one reason or another."

There was an edge to Glimmer's voice. "What do you mean that we *won't?* "

"For political reasons, or tactical reasons, or *resource reasons!* " Adora said, her voice raised. "Like those kids who were left to fend for themselves, or some settlement that's being raided by bandits we never hear about, or maybe - *maybe* - they end up taking out some administrator we've kept around because they're willing to say the right things about opposing the Horde, even if they're hardly better! Gods, Glimmer, don't tell me you haven't noticed how our hands are tied!"

"Our hands are tied because we're the *good guys* , Adora!" Glimmer's voice was equally raised now. "We can't just *murder* people we don't agree with!"

“We don’t have to murder them, but we could take away their power!” Adora shouted. “Which we can’t do because it wouldn’t be *politically wise* ; because they have resources we need for the war, or because hey, they’re always so *polite* to *us* , the *Princesses* .” She was shaking, years of biting her tongue, nodding and trying to be the perfect hero the Rebellion wanted her to be finally giving way to something else that Catra had stirred up. “We call ourselves the protectors of the people, but we’re only there when we need something from them. Catra’s people are *there* when we aren’t.”

“‘Catra’s people’ are *mercenaries* , Adora! Whatever noble speech she gave you is just an excuse. You’re *She-Ra* , you’re a Princess! You have to be *better* than her!”

Adora stepped back like she’d been struck. When she spoke again, her voice was low and calm. “Well maybe I don’t *want* to be.” She started walking for the door to the chamber.

“Adora, wait,” Bow spoke up, reaching for her shoulder, “you know what Glimmer meant.”

Adora shook Bow’s hand off and continued walking. “Yeah, I know what she meant.” She put her hand on the doorknob and looked back over her shoulder. “I love her. I can’t abandon her again. Not even for you.”

Glimmer’s eyes were wide with shock, and she opened her mouth to speak, but Bow spoke first. “Where are you going, Adora?”

“To talk to Light Hope.” Adora said, shortly. “I… I think she might be able to help get She-Ra back. Entrapta’s been looking into it as well.”

“What?”

“Glimmer can tell you.” Adora said, feeling her anger begin to dissipate. “I’m sorry. I need time to think. I’ll come back after I see Light Hope. I promise.”

“Don’t.” Glimmer said, sounding more wounded than Adora had ever heard her. “Don’t come back unless you’re still on our side.”

“Glimmer-” Bow started to say, but Adora cut him off.

“I’m still on your side.” Adora said, firmly. She opened the door and stepped into the hallway. As she walked away, she quietly added, “For now.”

Chapter End Notes

Okay well, that happened. I guess season four inspired me to lean into some friction between Adora and Glimmer a little more, even if this was always going to happen. The ol' Best Friend Squad has some uh... well, they've got some things to do. And Bow and Glimmer have some choices to make while Adora's away. Too bad this only bounces between Adora and Catra's viewpoints!

God bless season four for giving me Double Trouble, aka the perfect person to use for all manner of stuff I wanted to do but wasn't sure how to do (did I briefly consider using them to *really* follow the plot of MGSV before thinking otherwise? Oh yes, I definitely did. If you don't know what I'm talking about, well, don't worry about it. It's not going to happen for a multitude of reasons, one of which is that I like Double Trouble too much to do that to them).

Anyway, thanks for reading, thanks for commenting, thanks for the kudos, thanks for being generally great people, and we'll see if I get the next part up any time soon. Chances are... good(?) that we'll get something up in time for Christmas, but we'll see how it goes. A lot of the next chapter is already mapped out in the ol' brainbox, at any rate. We're going to see what Catra's been up to. Which is uh, well, you'll see.

EDIT: Because I have the best timing, I tried to post this just as the Archive went down, which means there were like four

versions of this up. Apologies if you got very excited by notifications of multiple chapters and raced to see it, only to be CRUSHED BY DISAPPOINTMENT that there's just this one.

Extraction

Chapter Summary

> Catra tests her team's extraction protocol. Mara passes judgment. C'yra gets a new conversation piece.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The sound of an electrical short was the first thing that Catra noticed as she came back to consciousness. Her head was pounding, and her shoulder was killing her. The blood on her face was sticky, which meant she'd been out for a while. Memory of the crash came flooding back to her, and she immediately jumped up to check on Aoife.

She tapped the pilot on the shoulder. "Still with me kid?"

Aiofe didn't respond. Catra peered closer and found herself staring into the rookie's clouded eyes. A piece of glass was lodged in her chest, and Catra felt bile rise in her throat, along with a cold fury. She closed Aiofe's sightless eyes and sighed. "Sorry, kid."

Her attention shifted to the back of the wrecked skiff, where the forms of C'yra and Mara lay motionless in their seats. Time seemed to slow down as she approached, dreading what she might discover. When Mara groaned and opened her eyes (*Adora's* eyes), Catra couldn't quite suppress a sigh of relief. Mara, on the other hand, was immediately unstrapping to check over her companion.

"C'yra! Wake up! We've got to get out of here!"

"She still breathing?" Catra asked, not wanting to get between Mara and her commander.

Mara shot an accusing look back at Catra. "No thanks to *you* ."

“You can hate me later, kid. Get her out of the skiff and into cover.” Catra indicated the treeline. “I’ve got to see to this here and I’ll join you.”

Mara didn’t need to be told twice. She picked C’yra up as if she weighed nothing and dashed for the treeline. Catra watched her go and found herself missing Adora deeply. She grabbed her equipment pack which had miraculously stayed in the skiff during the crash and tossed it over the side. Then she went back up to where Aiofe’s body sat strapped into the pilot’s seat and flipped the switches which - assuming the system hadn’t been damaged, would perform two important tasks: first, it sent a message to the Intel team with the skiff’s location, and second, it primed a self-destruct mechanism to destroy any salvageable technology. It would also, in this case, serve as a suitable funeral pyre for Aiofe.

Catra had a few minutes before the self-destruct activated, which she spent arranging Aoife’s body into something more like repose. “You were a good soldier, Aiofe.” She said aloud. “You were a good soldier and you died a soldier’s death, and it’s my fault. You deserve a better send-off than this, but it’s all I can give you. You aren’t the first soldier I’ve lost, and I wish like hell you would be the last. Rest easy. I’m sorry.”

She was surprised, as she turned to hop out of the skiff, to see Mara standing nearby. “You were supposed to stay with C’yra.” She said, feeling a little annoyed.

“I was going to kill you.” Mara said, simply. She had a knife in her hand. “Take C’yra and fall back to one of our hideouts.”

Catra nodded. “Why didn’t you?”

“You cared about your pilot. Shadow Weaver said soldiers are resources to spend and nothing more - and Shadow Weaver is wrong about everything, so you can’t be that bad.” Mara’s logic was a child’s logic, which made sense.

“I guess that’s good enough for now.” Catra said, with a shrug. “Let’s go. This is gonna be loud. Where’d you hide C’yra?”

“This way.” Mara said, and took off running.

Catra followed behind, and a few moments later there was a dull whump as the skiff burst into flames. She knew they were in danger, and in a hurry, but Catra couldn’t stop herself from stopping and watching the flames consume Aiofe’s body. She let out a long breath and buried her anger and grief. There would be time for that when she got back to base. Hopefully that wouldn’t take too long. Mara had stopped too, and Catra forced herself to look away and usher the girl into the forest.

C’yra was still unconscious when they reached her. Catra took the opportunity to give her more of a once-over. There was blood dripping down her face from a deep cut that went up her cheek, and Catra winced in sympathetic pain. She rummaged through the equipment pack she’d recovered and pulled a few bandages out. Mara looked like she was about to stop her, but apparently had decided to trust Catra for now and settled for hovering nearby. Gently, Catra wiped some of the blood off of C’yra’s face, which caused the girl to groan.

Her eyes snapped open and she moved to rise, but Catra held her down. “Easy there kid, you’ve got a nasty cut and a concussion, but we’re gonna be okay. Cavalry’s on its way, we just have to go meet it.”

“Mara,” C’yra said, looking around, “Where’s Mara?”

“Here, C’yra.” Mara said, stepping forward, body tense and worried. “Are you okay?”

C’yra held out a hand which Mara immediately knelt and held like C’yra might break at any second. There was a patient expression on C’yra’s face which made Catra think of Adora, somehow. “I’ll be fine. Promise.” She glanced up at Catra. “Where’s the cavalry, and why can’t they just come to us?”

“The cavalry can’t come for us, because I don’t send rescue missions into areas which will be crawling with Horde soldiers as a general rule.” Catra said, shouldering her pack again and giving the two girls space. “We head ten klicks north from the wreck. That’s procedure. Still dangerous, but less dangerous than the immediate surroundings. How are you feeling?”

C’yra, with Mara’s help, stood up. She swayed a little, but mastered herself quickly by digging her claws into her palm, which seemed to help her focus. “Good enough to get out of here.”

“Alright. Let’s get moving.” Catra said, then shot Mara a look. “If the urge to assassinate me strikes again, do me a favor and wait until *after* we’re at the rendezvous point, okay? You can tell my people that a hunter got me and they’ll at the very least patch you up.”

C’yra looked over at Mara in shock, and Mara shrunk in on herself a little guiltily. “I told you,” she said, if a little petulantly, “I decided not to.”

C’yra sighed. “I apologize for my companion. She can be a little impulsive sometimes. It used to get her into trouble back when…” she trailed off. “Anyway, she’ll behave herself now, I promise. Right Mara?”

“Yes Commander.” Mara muttered, face burning with embarrassment.

Something about the interaction made Catra regret bringing it up. “Don’t worry,” she said, addressing C’yra but looking at Mara, “I trust her.”There was a flash of gratitude on Mara’s face, and Catra felt another stab of familiarity. “Okay,” she said, increasingly conscious of the time they were wasting, “move out. Any sign of the enemy, you’re both to get to cover and leave any fighting to me, got it? You’re not in any shape to fight.”

C’yra gave Catra a skeptical look, as if to say *neither are you* , but nodded. Catra had them move along the treeline to the west, not wanting to risk cutting across open ground too close to the skiff wreckage, which was still burning. After around thirty minutes, they headed northeast into the grass, using what was by now a faint wisp of smoke to orient themselves. They crouched low to the ground, nearly crawling, to minimize the chances of someone spotting them. Catra would have preferred to stick to the trees, but they’d left the forest behind - the rendezvous point was always north, and north was, unfortunately, nothing but grassland in this part of the Horde’s territory.

Catra was by now painfully conscious of her own wounds - her entire torso felt like one big bruise, and her head ached dully where she’d hit it. If they *did* run across any Horde soldiers, Catra thought, she’d probably not fare too well - but she could at least give the two kids a fighting chance of getting away clean. It was, she thought, the least she could do for being partially responsible for their existence in the first place. She called a halt after another thirty minutes, after noticing the way that C’yra was clearly struggling to keep up.

“Take a breather. We’re making good time.” She dug a few small ration bars out of her pack and tossed them to the two. “We’re just about halfway there.”

“Shouldn’t we have seen a patrol by now?” C’yra asked. “This area seems deserted.”

No sign of whoever shot us down either. Catra thought. *But the shot came from south of the crash site, so that’s not too surprising. Aiofe managed to put us down in a fairly good spot.* She kept that to herself, though. No use worrying what were already two very worried kids. Instead, she responded, “Outposts out here don’t tend to bother with patrols. The terrain’s open enough that you can spot most things from guard towers - plus, it’s not worth the manpower to patrol so regularly this far from the borders.”

“That’s stupid.” Mara said, swallowing a bite of ration bar. “All someone has to do is get across the border and avoid a couple guard posts to get right up to the capital?”

“I don’t know if you’ve noticed,” Catra said dryly, “but one of those outposts are probably responsible for us walking away from a wrecked skiff at the moment.”

“Actually,” C’yra said, in a tone of voice that seemed to indicate she was thrilled to have a chance to show her knowledge, “it was probably an automated air defense system. Otherwise a Horde patrol would have gotten to the wreck before we got out. We weren’t airborne for that long after the hit we took.”

“Automated air defense, huh?” Catra said, frowning. “Guess that means Hordak finally got the damn thing working. Entrapta never managed to get it to reliably recognize friendly aircraft. Best we ever got was a 75% chance it wouldn’t fire.”

“That,” or Mara said in a sour tone of voice, “or they’ve decided a 25% chance a friendly gets shot down is acceptable.”

“The Horde wouldn’t do that!” C’yra said, a little taken aback.

Mara looked at C’yra like she’d grown two heads. “You really *did* take a blow to the head in the crash. Have you forgotten that we left the Horde specifically because they’re terrible?”

“25% losses are a poor use of resources.” C’yra said stubbornly. “Even *Shadow Weaver* would think so.”

“Hate to say it kid,” Catra said, “but I’ve known Weaver a lot longer than you, and I doubt she would consider *50%* losses a poor use of resources as long as she got what she wanted.” She stretched her legs and got back up into a low crouch. “Time to go. Our ride should be arriving soon.”

The group set out again, moving a little faster this time as the brief rest seemed to have been particularly good for C’yra. She was still clearly in some pain - Catra had covered up enough

injuries in her time to be able to see when someone else was doing it too - but there was a little more sureness to her movements. Catra, on the other hand, felt like her legs would give out any moment. Her thighs ached from moving in a permanent crouch - the kids had the benefit of already being lower to the ground, but Catra's height - while never quite Adora's height - was still enough that she couldn't move normally. Still, she'd be damned if she let some kids show her up, so she pushed onwards.

Adora, she thought, would probably say something about her being ridiculous. That or she'd be even more determined to come across as the mature one and set a good example for the two kids. *Our clones* , Catra reminded herself - though she was curious about the difference in C'yra's fur patterns. If they were clones, shouldn't she have looked the exact same? Something to ask Entrapta, she supposed.

Her thoughts were interrupted by the faint sound of an engine coming from the west. Catra threw herself on the ground, and a pair of thuds indicated the girls had done the same. She produced her scope from a hip pouch, and rolled to her back to take a look at the sky. The sound of the engine grew louder, and Catra scanned the horizon with an anxious fluttering in her stomach. They weren't far from the rendezvous, so it was *possible* that it was just their ride back to base, but it was far more likely to be a Horde scout on their way to see what the air defenses had managed to bring down.

Unfortunately for Catra, she was completely right. A Horde skiff flew low over the horizon, buzzing over the grasslands. C'yra watched the skiff with wide eyes, while Mara quietly drew a knife. This in turn prompted Catra to hiss quietly, "Remember, *you take off running* if they get close. I'll handle the fighting."

Mara rolled her eyes and scowled, but she put her knife back in its sheath. The skiff howled by, the sound nearly deafening. Catra held her breath, listening to the sound of the engine fade into the

distance. After what felt like an eternity, she waved to the two and they started moving again, this time in a crawl.

By the time they reached the rendezvous point, Catra's head was pounding and she could barely move her shoulder. C'yra's head seemed to be bothering her as well, but she was clearly hiding it. It wasn't long before the sound of another engine announced the arrival of the extraction team. Two soldiers fastroped over the side, weapons drawn.

"Commander!" One called out. "You okay?"

Catra stood up. "Alive. Got two other soldiers for extraction as well."

The other looked around. "Your last transmission said there were two kids - what about the pilot?"

Catra's voice was steady. "Didn't make it." She motioned to the two girls. "Get these two on board, and when we get to base, have Entrapta check them out, make sure they're okay."

Scorpia was waiting when the skiff touched down. She rushed to Catra's side immediately. "Commander, you're hurt!"

"I'm fine." Catra said through gritted teeth. "C'yra, Mara, this is Scorpia. She'll take you to get checked out by the medical team, then we'll find you a place to rest."

C'yra looked back at Catra defiantly. "I'm not hurt."

Catra rolled her eye. "Kid, that cut on your face is going to get infected if it's not properly seen to, and you've been gritting your teeth because of your headache. There's no shame in accepting help."

Scorpia leaned in close and whispered in Catra's ear. "Good advice, Commander. Maybe you should take it."

“I’m not…” Catra started to say, before a wave of dizziness washed over her. She reached out and grabbed Scorpia’s shoulder to steady herself. “Get word to Adora. I’ll meet her at the Crystal Castle tomorrow to go over… these two. Entrapta have a solution for whatever’s blocking the transformation yet?”

“She’s worked something up, but it’s got to be administered the same way the block was.” Scorpia replied. “Which… basically means it’s going to hurt. A lot. And uh, she’ll need to be restrained.”

Catra nodded. “One other thing. Aiofe - she joined up in a group, right?”

“Yeah, her and a couple friends.”

“Tell them…” Catra took a deep breath to steady herself. “Tell them to come see me in my office as soon as possible. It’s best they hear the news from me first.”

Scorpia nodded. “As you wish, Commander. I’ll send Rogelio by to check you out too. You look like you’ve been through a lot.”

Catra thought of Aiofe’s sightless eyes staring at her accusingly. ”Nothing I didn’t deserve.” she said, and headed for her office.

Chapter End Notes

> This came together pretty quickly! Sometimes it does not and we have long pauses! This is not one of those times.
>
> We're back to Adora's point of view next chapter, where she'll have a serious talk with a hologram, and maybe get a hint of the bigger picture while we're at it. Who knows? I haven't written it yet so I couldn't possibly say.
>
> I almost put like, an email signature here because my job has involved a shitload more emailing people in the last like two weeks than it has in ages. This is doubtless a sign of my brain turning to absolute fucking mush! I need to go to sleep!

Thanks as always for reading and commenting, even when the archive gets all bogged down and refuses to work properly. Tell your friends if you like this! Maybe they will also enjoy it! Who knows? On the off chance that this is the only chapter I get up this month, everyone enjoy the holidays as best they can - even if you think your family sucks, or the holidays in general suck for whatever reason, imagine that somewhere a big skeleton is raising a glass and drinking to your health, specifically. Because I am! I think y'all are cool people, and we'll muddle through this incredibly dumb and beautiful world while also writing fanfic about sad lesbians together, okay? Okay!

This concludes the vaguely emotional part of the notes. Also the note itself. See you next time!

Another Test

Chapter Summary

> Light Hope tries to help. Adora takes a nap. Catra delivers some news.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The path through the Whispering Woods was far less difficult to navigate this time, Adora thought. She suspected it had something to do with her state of mind, or maybe it was just the Whispering Woods deciding to be convenient for once in their blighted existence. Either way, it felt like she reached the Crystal Castle far faster than usual. That or she'd been distracted by her thoughts repeating variations on *you've ruined everything* the whole time. She didn't know how she was going to fix things with Glimmer. She wanted to believe it was possible - she knew, somewhere deep down, that Glimmer wasn't unreasonable, that they'd fought before and managed to patch things up. What she'd done this time, however, was declare her loyalty to something that wasn't the Princess Alliance.

She hadn't even *intended* to do it, not really. She just wanted to come clean about how she'd been brought back, and to let Glimmer know that Adora had been okay, and maybe have someone to talk to about how she was terrified about this thing that was between her and Catra now, about messing it up, about losing Catra, about how the Princess Alliance would take the news if they found out Catra was still alive. She wasn't even sure now whether or not Glimmer would keep Catra's existence secret like she'd promised.

Something in her wanted to trust that Glimmer would, if only because Bow would probably stress the importance of not doing anything until Adora returned. Except the look on Bow's face

hadn’t been particularly promising either, once he’d realized the nature of some of Catra’s work. Adora needed to make him understand - needed to make *Glimmer* understand - but she’d been so angry in the moment. She was sick of the weight of expectation She-Ra placed on her, sick of her supposed destiny to bring balance to Etheria, sick of *everything* . It was a mercy, she thought, that she at least didn’t have to keep up the lie of Catra’s existence any longer. That was *one* thing she could be honest with someone about - and in truth, she wanted to shout about Catra from the rooftops, to tell everyone she knew that she’d found the woman she loved again, that they were going to figure out a way to end the war and live out their lives together. It was pure fantasy, she knew, but… if there was even the slightest chance, Adora would fight until her last breath to make it happen.

Light Hope appeared almost as soon as Adora stepped through the door. “Welcome back, Adora. It has been some time since your last training session.”

“Yeah,” Adora said, feeling a flicker of guilt, “I’ve uh, been kind of busy.”

The hologram flickered, and the lights in the castle suddenly went red. “Adora, your structure has been compromised.”

“That’s none of your-” Adora suddenly realized what Light Hope meant and coughed. “Er, that is, yes. Something’s blocking the She-Ra transformation, but it’s nothing to do with the sword, this time. It’s… Glimmer’s aunt called it a curse.”

Light Hope’s expression was unchanged. “Unusual. The Sword of Protection is the source of the She-Ra construct. It should overwrite any physical maladies.”

“This one’s apparently tuned to me specifically. They said it’s something to do with my… genetic code?”

This gave Light Hope pause. She flickered, which was usually a sign she was accessing her database. “I’m sorry, my records do

not have any indication this should be possible." In an unusual turn of events, she frowned. "Perhaps information on remedies for this situation are in corrupted files. There is much knowledge sealed away that I can no longer access due to damage."

"Are there repairs I could make?" Adora asked. "Some way to fix whatever damage happened to your hardware?"

"Possible, but I do not know if that is a productive use of resources. You are the She-Ra. You can overcome the curse with sufficient strength of will."

"I've already *tried* that," Adora said, exasperation in her voice, "I just lose consciousness."

"This is a problem." Light Hope states. "Perhaps there is a way for me to help. The Crystal Castle can supercharge the Sword of Protection, which could help the She-Ra construct overcome the curse."

As much as Adora did not want to admit it, there was a certain temptation in refusing. She-Ra was like a weight around her neck, and having her sealed off had been almost nice. Adora knew, however, that if it became apparent she wasn't working to get She-Ra back as quickly as possible, that it would only give Glimmer more reason to doubt her loyalties. Getting She-Ra back would serve as reassurance that Adora was still loyal to the Princess Alliance - or at least the Rebellion - and maybe serve as an apology to boot.

"Okay." Adora said, drawing her sword. "Do it."

"I cannot." Light Hope replied.

"But you just said you *could* ."

"Yes, but you need to place the Sword of Protection in the control console for me to supercharge it. I cannot do it remotely."

"Ah." Adora said. "And the console is… where, exactly?"

“Follow me.” Light Hope instructed, and began moving through the hallways of the Crystal Castle.

Adora followed. The hallways echoed eerily as Light Hope led her further into the bowels of the castle, into areas where, Adora guessed, nobody had set foot in centuries. The console was in what looked like a command center. A giant table sat in the center with what looked like a map of the planet sitting on it. Adora peered closely at it and was surprised to see that the Crimson Wastes were not marked. Instead, there was a vast forest marked as the Kingdom of Halfmoon. There was also no Fright Zone - instead there was an area marked as Scorpion Hill. The map included the locations of each kingdom’s runestone, and a note jotted down on the margins mentioned something about increasing defenses against sabotage attempts from guerrilla fighters. Adora would have looked more closely, but there was a flash from the back of the room as a console sprang to life.

“This is the console.” Light Hope said, gesturing in its direction. “Please insert the sword and I will attempt to increase its output.”

Adora did as she was told, and the lights dimmed slightly. There was a growing hum, and the sword began to glow. Light Hope’s hologram shifted colors briefly, flashing to a softer shade of her usual harsh purple.

“You can attempt to transform now, Adora.” Light Hope said. “Grab the hilt, but do not remove it from the console. I may need to stabilize the power output as you go.”

Adora nodded, took a deep breath, and did as she was instructed. Immediately, she felt the shift begin to happen, but it felt like it happened faster. Unfortunately, the backlash from her curse also happened faster - and with a viciousness that drove her to her knees. Light exploded from her eyes, and the foundation of the castle felt like it was shaking - or maybe that was just the violent spasming of every muscle in her body. She heard herself scream. Light Hope watched impassively. Her vision began to go dark. She could feel her grip on the sword loosen. Light Hope’s expression

shifted to one of concern, and the last thing Adora saw was the lights go out.

Adora's eyes snapped open and beheld a seemingly endless expanse of darkness. Shakily, she stood, noticing as she did so that she'd reverted back to being just Adora again. "Light Hope? Are you there?"

In response to her call, she caught sight of a guttering blue light out of the corner of her eye. With nothing else to navigate by, she headed in its direction. Her footsteps echoed hollowly in the vast space, and she began to suspect she was in some kind of cave. The blue light grew steadily brighter, and as she drew closer Adora began to hear a clanging sound, accompanied by the occasional low growl of frustration.

"Is someone there?" she called out. There was no response - whatever was making the noise either could not hear her, could not respond, or didn't care. A scene began to come into view.

A circular cage, reminiscent of a birdcage, stood in the center of a room. The bars of the cage were the source of the blue glow - First Ones writing ran along the base, but Adora couldn't focus enough to read it. Inside the cage, Adora was surprised to see She-Ra - Adora as She-Ra, as it turned out. She-Ra stomped in a circle, occasionally pausing to batter at the bars of the cage, which sparked and clanged and otherwise stood firm. As her efforts continued to prove unsuccessful, it became clear the growls were coming from She-Ra.

"What is this place?" Adora asked.

She-Ra paused, looking at Adora. The Princess' eyes clouded, and she shook her head to clear them, then resumed pacing her cage and battering the bars.

"Hey, I asked-"

"She can't hear you, Mara." A familiar voice said. "I've told you that before."

Adora whirled around at the source of the voice. “Madame Razz?”

Razz peered up at Adora through her enormous glasses. “Who else would I be? Honestly, Mara, you can be *so* scatterbrained.”

“I’m not-” Adora sighed, reconsidered. “Nevermind. Why can’t she hear me? Is it because of the curse?”

Razz seemed confused. “Curse? What are you talking about?”

“The spell that keeps blocking my transformation.” Adora said, exasperated. “The reason I can’t become She-Ra!”

That earned her a closer look from Razz. “Hmm,” she said, rubbing her chin, “no, that’s got nothing to do with this. You’ll have no trouble overcoming *that* .”

“How?” Adora pressed. “How do I get over the curse?”

“With time, Mara! Always with time. Your friend from Halfmoon will help you. Isn’t she here?” Razz looked confused.

“I don’t have a friend from Halfmoon!” Adora said, exasperated. “Halfmoon doesn’t even *exist* anymore!”

“That can’t be right, dearie.” Razz pursed her lips in thought. “She *is* your friend, Mara, even though you started out fighting all the time.”

“No I mean there’s no Half-”

“Of course there is! You just haven’t ever visited it.”

Adora felt herself losing control of the conversation, if she could be said to have ever had control of it to begin with. “If the cage isn’t the curse, then what is it?”

“How many times have we had this conversation?” Razz said, exasperated. “Your friend from Halfmoon told you all about it.” At Adora’s continued look of confusion, she threw her arms up in

frustration, rolling her eyes skyward as if seeking benediction. "The sword! The sword is the key and the lock! Honestly Mara, sometimes I think you don't listen."

"What does that even *mean* ?" Adora shouted, and then promptly felt a wave of pain wash over her. She collapsed to the floor, eyes screwed shut in agony.

"-dora? Are you still functional?"

When she opened them, she was on the floor of the control center. The scent of ozone was in the air, and Light Hope was looking down at her with a worried expression. Adora groaned and sat up. "Did it work?"

"I am afraid not." Light Hope said. "The strain would likely have killed you if I had not aborted the attempt."

"I had…" Adora shook her head, trying to clear her disorganized thoughts, "I had a vision. She-Ra. She was in a cage. She said… the sword was the key? And the lock?"

Light Hope's voice carried the slightest note of confusion. "I am sorry, I do not know what that could refer to. Perhaps it merely means the sword is needed to break the curse." She thought for a few moments longer and added, "I am not sure I would recommend taking cues from dreams at any rate."

Adora wanted to point out that it was dreams that led her to the Sword of Protection in the first place, but she was too exhausted to argue. "So, supercharging the sword didn't work. Any other ideas?"

"I was able to collect data during the transformation." Light Hope said, helpfully. "I can cross-reference the energy readings using the data I have access to and potentially find a solution. In the meantime, you could continue training without the She-Ra form."

Adora wanted to say that she'd already been training without the She-Ra form, but something told her that would only earn her a

lecture about keeping up with her training, or, if Light Hope was feeling particularly vindictive that day, another lecture about severing her attachments. Instead, she stayed quiet and levered herself to a standing position with a grunt.

"I think I might need a little time to recover from that before I start training, Light Hope."

"Of course. I did not mean to imply that you should begin training right away. Rest is important. Will you be staying here, or will you be returning to Brightmoon?"

Adora grimaced. "I think I'll be staying here for a day or so. I…" she sighed, "got into a fight with Glimmer and Bow. It's probably for the best that we have some time to uh, cool down a little."

Light Hope raised an eyebrow. "I am… sorry to hear that. It is often useful to talk about these things with a third party. Perhaps you can tell me what happened?"

"I… I made a judgment call." Adora said, talking around just what it was she'd done. "I decided to trust an old friend of mine who left the Horde, but it meant bringing other people into Brightmoon under… less-than-accurate circumstances."

"I do not understand the phrase 'less-than-accurate circumstances.'"

Adora took a deep breath. "When I was cursed - or whatever this is - I was rescued by an old friend who wanted to keep her involvement secret. I kept her involvement secret by bringing a group of people allied to her into Brightmoon and claiming they were the ones who rescued me."

"I see." Light Hope said, with a note of vague disapproval. "Your friends discovered your subterfuge and reacted poorly?"

"No," Adora said, "I came clean to them. I don't like lying to my friends, and I thought they would understand why I did, but…"

“They did not understand.”

“Well they *did* , kind of, but they don’t agree with it.”

“I am afraid that I do not have sufficient information to provide any advice. Why did they not agree with your decision?”

“I’m not sure.” Adora admitted. “I thought they would understand - she’s just trying to protect the people more like her and less like… them.” She frowned. “Plus, they want to place her on one side or the other, and I don’t think that’s possible.”

“Ah.” Light Hope said, processing this information. “I am sorry that you are experiencing strife. However, I must ask that you do not let it interfere with She-Ra’s mission: you must bring balance to Etheria.”

“Don’t worry,” Adora said, somehow managing to keep the annoyance out of her voice, “I’m aware of the importance of bringing balance to Etheria.”

“The Princesses must come together,” Light Hope said for what felt like the millionth time, “so that the planet can be balanced, and your enemies defeated.”

“We’ve fought before,” Adora replied, “and come back together stronger than before. I just need some time to think.”

“I believe in your ability to bring your friends closer together.” Light Hope said, in a tone of voice that was meant to be reassuring. “I am certain that your relationships are strong enough to- ALERT! UNAUTHORIZED PRESENCE DETECTED IN MAIN ENTRYWAY.”

Adora groaned and began heading in the direction of the entryway. “Don’t sic the spiders on them, it’s probably just Glimmer.”

“The unauthorized presence does not conform to known appearance of Princess Glimmer,” Light Hope said, “The presence’s

appearance matches that of a hostile entity from several years ago."

Adora frowned, thinking. "Can you show me the intruder?"

Light Hope nodded. "Of course." She shimmered, and a projection of Catra appeared, currently in the process of riding a robot spider while firing a rifle into a cluster of several others.

"I said no spiders!" Adora shouted. "Call them off, I formally authorize her presence."

"Are you certain, Adora? Past interactions with this presence have resulted in physical and psychological damage."

"Yes, I'm sure." Adora said, a little testily. "She's the one that rescued me. I trust her."

"Very well." Light Hope said, and Adora watched the spider eyes shift from red to blue and begin retreating. Catra hopped off her mount and began walking further into the facility. "Shall I let her know that you are on your way?"

"If you could." Adora said. "It'll keep her from getting into any further trouble."

"Of course." Light Hope said, and vanished, leaving Adora to make her way to the front hall on her own.

Adora found herself smoothing down her hair as she moved on, painfully aware of how terrible she probably looked. She took some small comfort in the fact that Catra probably wouldn't mind. While she moved, she also couldn't help but wonder what Catra was doing here, and how she'd found her, and - more importantly - whether or not the reason she was here was because of what Adora had done. Had Glimmer already moved against the agents who'd come with Adora? If she had, how did Catra know about it? Were there other agents in Brightmoon she didn't know about? Did that matter?

All these thoughts were quickly silenced as soon as she saw Catra, who was giving Light Hope an annoyed look which gave way to one of relief as soon as she saw Adora. Adora rushed forward, taking in Catra's exhausted posture, the twinge of pain as she turned to face Adora, and the bruise on her face. She wrapped Catra up in a hug.

"What happened to your face?" Adora asked, running a hand down her face gently.

Catra pulled back a little from the touch. "Had to deliver some bad news to some of my soldiers. They uh, didn't take it well."

Adora's eyebrows shot up. "Oof, sounds like it was pretty bad news."

"Yeah, uh…" Catra looked down and away, and there was a sudden tension in her posture. When she spoke again, her voice was a whisper. "Aiofe's dead. I brought her on a mission with me. It's my fault."

"Oh, Catra." Adora pulled Catra back into a hug. "I'm so sorry."

"That's not all." Catra said. "Entrapta's got a cure for you, but it's not going to be a pleasant experience."

Light Hope spoke up. "Adora, I suggest you implement the cure as soon as possible."

Adora held up a hand. "I will, Light Hope. But Catra and I need some time to rest, first."

"One last thing." Catra said, taking another deep breath. "I found them. Our uh. Them."

"You were supposed to tell me before you-"

"I *know* , Adora but… it wasn't on purpose. They were out." A curiously proud look crossed Catra's face. "Your clone was planning to kill me."

“She *what?*”

Chapter End Notes

Figured I would try to get one last chapter up before the holidays begin in earnest, but lucky you, I had a solid day and a half of very little to do in the office and oh look, is that Google Docs on my work laptop? So I got this done instead of doing actual work.

Don't worry, I'm actually very responsible.

This chapter was a little more She-Ra and a little less Metal Gear Solid, which I mean, was bound to happen eventually. We'll give Adora and Catra a chance to have a little more of a conversation next chapter, but this was another one of those situations where I just thought it was funnier to stop the chapter with Adora's reaction. Forgive an old man his self-indulgence this close to the holidays.

In between these chapters, I also wrote other, unrelated She-Ra thing in response to the trailer for Hellblade 2, which *slaps*. What can I say, I've got a weakness for both primal chanting and angry sword ladies. I don't have any plans to take it any further, although the idea of putting a second part up has entered my mind. Now you're up on all the news that's fit to print about uh, the bullshit I do.

Oh, and that not-fanfic thing I do is still humming along, of course. If you have the urge to read some cyberpunk superhero nonsense, you can find it in spades over here.

Thanks for reading and commenting and telling all your friends about this incredibly silly thing I do.

Just Visiting

Chapter Summary

> Adora makes another confession and learns some things about Catra she didn't know before. Catra comes to a realization, and finds a mystery.
>
> The clones are discussed. A proposal is made.

Chapter Notes

> Some very, very, mild references to self-harm in this one. Careful as you go.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra woke up slowly, her brain expressing a general reluctance to fully come to grips with the situation. Much better to float in a semi-conscious state, her brain argued, where she was only conscious of something soft under her head that smelled like home and the steady pulse of Adora's heartbeat in her ears, the rise and fall of her chest as she breathed. Catra had one leg slung possessively over Adora's waist. One of Adora's arms was wrapped under Catra's waist with an equal possessiveness, a gentle motion of her fingers in Catra's fur the only sign that Adora was going through a similar thought process to Catra's.

Catra pressed a soft kiss to her sleeping surface and was rewarded with a shiver and an approving hum from Adora.

"Good morning to you too." Catra said, smiling into Adora's skin.

"I hate to be the voice of reason," Adora sighed, "but… we've got a lot to do today, don't we?"

"Yeah," Catra said, planting another kiss and enjoying the way it gave Adora goosebumps, "we do, but I think it's important to

make sure we don't push ourselves, given all we've been through the last few days, don't you?"

"Commander? You wanted to see us?"

"Yes, it's about your friend, Aoife. I'm sorry to be the one to tell you this, but…"

Stars danced across her vision and her head snapped back from the blow.

"We were supposed to keep her safe! We promised *we'd keep her safe! And you took her into the fucking* Fright Zone *?"*

"I'm sorry. I know that you're angry, but she came of her own free will. And she… she died saving me and two others. I know that's not much comfort, but she died a hero."

"Where's her body?"

"We were deep in hostile territory. I couldn't-"

" Fuck *you, Commander."*

Angry footsteps receded. One of the others spoke up.

"Sorry about him. He and Aoife were…"

"It's okay. There's…" Catra reached into her pocket and withdrew a small patch that Aoife had sewn onto her flight jacket. "There's this, if he wants a memento of her. It's all I had time to recover."

"Thanks, Commander. It's better than nothing."

Adora looked down at Catra, who had gotten a far away look in her eye that was all-too familiar. Gently, she ran her fingers through Catra's hair. "Hey, come back to me."

Catra took a deep breath and looked up at Adora. "Sorry. I just…"

“I know.” Adora said, her fingers not ceasing their movement. “It’s okay.”

In response, Catra felt herself overcome by a feeling of gratitude. “Thank you.” She said quietly. She pressed another kiss to Adora’s chest. “Thank you.” She said again, and shifted so that she was now astride Adora, looking down into eyes filled which had widened a little in surprise, a face which wore a gentle smile. Catra leaned down and kissed her, hoping that Adora understood Catra had no other way to express what she felt.

“Please,” Catra said, not caring for the moment if she sounded pathetic or needy, “just a little longer. Please.”

Hands strong and sure gripped Catra’s hips. Rather than answering, Adora flipped their positions and loomed above Catra, who couldn’t quite keep the grin off her face.

Light Hope was waiting patiently (or with the appearance of patience, at any rate) when the two emerged from the bedroom later that morning. “Adora, will you be leaving the Castle in order to cure your curse?”

“Actually,” Catra said, speaking up, “we could do it here if that would be easier. Entrapta would just need to bring her equipment down. I know that your friends probably would prefer to have you close by for a while.”

Adora winced at the mention of her friends, which Catra did not fail to notice. “Yeah, that’s… that’s probably a good idea. How long would it take to get everything down here?”

Catra shrugged. “Probably at least a day for transport and setup. If I contact her now, we could take care of everything by… I dunno, the day after next?”

There was tension in Adora’s posture that she failed to hide. “And then you’ll have to go back, I guess?”

Catra's shoulders slumped a little in realization. "Yeah, then I go back. You know that's how it has to be. Your friends don't know about me-" Adora's posture stiffened in panic, and Catra knew immediately. "Your friends *do* know about me, huh?" A stab of betrayal and anger shot white hot through her chest.

"Catra, no, listen, I…"

"You *what* , Adora? Put my people in danger?" Her hands were in fists, and she could feel herself trembling. "I never should have-"

"I didn't put your people in danger! I swore Glimmer to secrecy, and Bow won't talk if she doesn't." Adora said, defensively. When Catra didn't say anything in response, she added, "I also warned them to get out before I left."

Hearing her people weren't in danger of being arrested and interrogated calmed Catra a little, but then another question struck her. "How long have they known?"

"A day." Adora said. "I wanted to tell you last night, but-"

"But you were afraid of how I'd react." Catra said, sighing. "That and I guess the news I found our clones pushed that particular bit of news to the back of your mind." The fire of her anger guttered and went out, replaced by a dull aching hurt that was even worse. "At least my people are safe."

Adora could see Catra shift from angry to wounded, and felt this new thing, this delicate, fragile relationship between them crack and threaten to shatter. "I'm sorry," she said, not knowing what else to say. "I just… I couldn't keep lying to my friends. They mean too much to me."

More than me? Catra almost said, before she quashed that train of thought. Adora was honest, and loyal to a fault - it was part of why Catra loved her. Deep down, she knew that asking Adora to lie in the first place hadn't been fair. This wound would heal; was already healing, Catra knew. "I…" Catra said, then paused. She looked at Adora, saw the fear in her eyes that she'd irreparably

damaged their relationship, saw now the all-too-familiar signs of Adora tormenting herself that she should've noticed earlier. "I forgive you, Adora. I shouldn't have made you choose between me and the others in the first place. That's… that's not how I want to be with you."

"Well," Adora said, a little wryly, "If it's any consolation, I think I chose you. Glimmer thinks I'm a traitor, and I think Bow was coming around to the idea."

The comment was meant as a joke, Catra knew, but she felt herself tense all the same. Adora had to stay with the Rebellion - if she didn't, it could spell disaster. *You fucked it up,* a voice said in the back of Catra's head, maddeningly familiar. *You've ruined Adora's life, just like I always knew you would. She's chosen* you *, and now Etheria will fall to the Horde. Such a waste of her potential.*

"I'm a fool." Catra said, quietly. "I should have stayed away." She backed away. "I've ruined everything."

"No." Adora said, forcefully. "No you haven't. I would not - *will not* - let you beat yourself up over this. Bow and Glimmer will come around, eventually."

"And if they don't?"

"They *will* ." Adora said, as if she were speaking a law into being. "They're my *friends* , Catra, and they understand what you mean to me."

"What about the rest of the Rebellion?" Catra asked, somehow unable to let this go. "What happens when *they* find out?"

"The Rebellion needs She-Ra." Adora said, simply. "You've said so yourself. You'll see - once I sit down and talk through everything with Bow and Glimmer, everything will be fine."

Adora's confidence was infectious. Catra smiled, and shook her head. "Gods, I'm a fucking mess." In a quieter tone, she added, "I

don’t know why you put up with me.”

Arms wrapped hesitantly around Catra’s waist and Adora pulled her into a hug. “Oh, I think you know well enough.” Her voice dropped to a whisper, and Catra could hear the smile in her voice as she said, “It’s because I love you, idiot.”

“Well your idiot needs to go check in with her people so you can get rid of your curse.” Catra said, leaning back into the embrace in spite of herself. “So as much as I’d like to stay here and annoy your hologram by distracting you from whatever training they’ve got planned, I need to duck back into our bedroom.”

“‘Our bedroom.’” Adora said, smiling. “I don’t think I’ll get tired of hearing you say that.”

Catra laughed as she gently detached herself from Adora’s grasp. “Okay, okay, you don’t need to lay it on that thick, Princess, I already forgave you.”

Heading to the room, Catra realized that what she’d said was entirely true. She *had* already forgiven Adora - forgiven her so quickly that it almost seemed impossible. Adora had made a decision to bring her friends into things, and to trust they’d understand. Catra trusted Adora’s judgment, trusted that Adora wouldn’t tell too much.

“Commander!” Scorpia’s voice crackled over the radio. “We just got word from our Brightmoon assets - Adora told them their cover was blown and they needed to get out.”

“Yeah, we uh, just talked about that.” Catra said, deciding it was best to just rip the bandage off as quickly as possible. “She couldn’t keep lying to her friends, so she came clean about our involvement. It only exposed the ones we inserted with her - the others should still have their cover intact.”

“Wait, the Rebellion knows about us?” Scorpia’s voice carried a tone of definite disapproval. “That’s going to put a real damper on our operation.”

“Calm down,” Catra said, “she only told her two friends, and they both promised not to tell anyone yet. They had a fight about it, so it’s possible they went to the Queen, but we don’t know for certain. Nobody’s come knocking at the door to arrest her though, which is a good sign.”

“You think the Queen would have Adora arrested?”

“I think the Queen would realize how the hero of the Rebellion shacking up with the former Commander of the Horde would look to the public and take steps to prevent it from happening.” Catra said. “At the very least there’s no way she’d risk She-Ra falling into the hands of the enemy.”

“Hmm,” Scorpia sounded thoughtful, “I suppose you’re right. Still, I’ll have everyone keep a close eye on things there, just to be sure.”

“Good idea.” Catra said.

“I can’t help but notice,” Scorpia said, not without a hint of hesitation in her voice, “but you haven’t said anything like ‘send an extraction team to get me out of here.’ I take it you’re okay with Adora spilling this to her friends?”

“Well, I’m not *okay* with it,” Catra replied with a sigh, “but trust her judgment. If she thinks Glimmer and Bow will keep the secret for her, then I just have to trust that she’s right.”

“You really *do* love that girl, huh?” Scorpia said, half-teasing, half-fond. “Alright, if you trust her, then we’ll trust you.”

“Speaking of trusting me,” Catra said, “Can you get Entrapta and her equipment down here to administer the cure?”

“As long as you can guarantee her safety, Commander. Entrapta’s one of our most valuable assets.” Scorpia replied cheerfully.

“And more than that to you, I know.” Catra replied. “As long as she doesn’t accidentally turn the castle into a killing machine,

she'll be perfectly safe. Both Adora and I will see to that."

"Commander, just so we're clear," Scorpia's voice carried an undercurrent of steel to it that surprised Catra, "I'm trusting your judgment on this, but I need to know you're not letting your feelings for Adora get in the way of our mission. Promise me you won't put us in danger for her."

"Don't worry," Catra said, as reassuringly as she could manage, "the only person getting put in danger for her will be me."

There was a chuckle as Scorpia responded. "I'd prefer it were nobody, but it's not like I'd be able to make the same promise about Entrapta."

Catra grinned, even though Scorpia couldn't see it. "I try not to make promises I can't keep. I'll let you know how everything shakes out once Entrapta gets here."

"You planning on staying there for a while after everything's done, take some time to talk over what you plan to do with your uh… kids?"

Catra felt her fur bristle at the concept of the clones being her children. "Nah, there's too much else going on. We talked a little about it last night, and we'll talk more about it today, unless something else comes up."

Scorpia's voice had a note of concern in it. "I know I was just lecturing you about not letting your feelings get in the way, Commander, but you know you can take a little time for yourself, right?"

"I know," Catra said, "but it's critical Adora doesn't spend too much time out here. She's got to go smooth things over with her friends, and the longer she stays here the more time they've got to get the wrong idea." For the second time that day, she admitted, "I don't want her to have to choose between them and me."

If this surprised Scorpia, she didn't say it. Instead, she said, "I'll make sure to have something for you to do when you get back, then. We've had a few more job offers come in that you might find interesting."

"As long as I don't end up finding any more secret clones, that sounds almost pleasant." Catra grinned. "I'll contact you when Entrapta arrives. Catra out."

With her check-in complete, Catra had time to herself. Adora, she gathered, would be training with Light Hope - combat scenarios designed for She-Ra, but Adora insisted on doing it anyway. Catra thought it was probably the right idea - and assumed (correctly) that Adora needed to prove to herself that she didn't need She-Ra to be an effective soldier. Catra thought that Adora was the only reason She-Ra had been any sort of effective to begin with, honestly, but she also understood all too well the thought process that would lead Adora to feel like she needed to prove herself.

While Adora trained, Catra decided she would take advantage of the distracted Light Hope and do a little poking around the castle. She'd been curious for years, ever since her first time visiting in fact, and now she had the chance to roam around without being harassed by murderous robots. Adora had mentioned something that looked like a command room the day before, and Catra figured that was a good place to start. She hadn't the faintest idea *where* she'd find it, but growing up in the Fright Zone had taught her the importance of cultivating a good sense of direction.

The problem was, she soon discovered, that the castle hallways were all very similar to one another. It almost felt like the entire place had been built out of a kit, Catra thought; like there was a template being followed. She'd come prepared for this, however, and withdrew a pencil that she used to leave small markings on the wall as she went. After making the first mark, she sat and watched it patiently for a few minutes. When it showed no sign of disappearing, she nodded in satisfaction and moved on, marking as she went.

The hallway sloped downward, which Catra considered a good sign - Adora had said they'd been deep in the bowels of the castle when she'd made her own attempt to power through the curse the day before. Catra sniffed the air experimentally. There was a whiff of Adora's scent down here, which meant she was on the right track. Catra's pupil was wide in the darkness, and she was surprised that Adora hadn't mentioned the signs of battle in the hallway. There were marks on the wall which looked to have been caused by a bladed weapon, or claws, accompanied by faded scorch marks that indicated some kind of energy weapon. There had been a battle here - which, Catra supposed, tracked with the history of the First Ones as far as she knew it. Something - The Horde, Catra assumed - had overwhelmed the First Ones once the last She-Ra had betrayed them or gone mad or *whatever* it was that had happened. The only thing that bothered her was that the claw and blade marks didn't track with Horde tactics. Energy weapons did, so she supposed it was possible the blades and claws were from the defenders and not the attackers.

That the marred walls seemed to be leading her in the direction of the command room, of course, suggested a defensive action had been fought. Catra was increasingly curious to see the state of the command center now, and increased her pace. When she reached her destination, she could see fresh scorch marks near the console. Adora had, it seemed, been throwing off an enormous amount of power, and it hadn't been enough to break the curse. Something about that unsettled her more than anything else. Shadow Weaver had developed an anti-Adora weapon. That more than anything else convinced her of one thing: something had shifted Shadow Weaver's priorities. Weaver's obsession with using Adora's powers to her own ends had been a constant - now, however, she seemed to have found some other source of power to chase. One which Adora's presence would undermine.

The rest of the room had not been spared either - nothing else appeared *scorched* , but some force had blown over the few remaining chairs and scattered documents around the room. Catra was disappointed to see that power had not been restored - she'd wanted the chance to poke around the center console's controls -

but the map was interesting in and of itself. It told her that whatever had destroyed the First Ones' presence on Etheria had likely been responsible for the creation of the Crimson Wastes. That alone was something interesting enough, but something else caught her eye as she peered at the map. A small symbol was centered in the vast forest where the Crimson Wastes now stood. Something about it seemed familiar, but Catra couldn't place it. She copied the symbol down as best as she could, figuring that Entrapta might know something about it - or maybe it was a bit of First Ones writing that Adora could translate.

Catra wandered back up to her room and was only slightly surprised to see Adora laying on the bed looking somewhat lost. "Hey, Adora. Done training already?"

"I can only destroy so many spider bots before it gets old." Adora said with a groan. "And it doesn't help matters that, you know, I have *limits* now."

That was when Catra noticed the bruises flowering on Adora's arms, and the signs of fresh blood on her clothes. Concern crossed her features and she stepped closer to inspect them a little more closely. "Some of those look pretty bad, Adora. Let me grab my kit."

For a moment, Adora looked like she would protest, but after taking another look at the worry on Catra's face, she relented. "Alright, if you want."

There was an immense amount of care in the way that Catra gently cleaned the various cuts training had gifted Adora. A hiss escaped Adora as Catra poured disinfectant on one particularly deep cut, and Catra looked up with an expression that was both worried and teasing. "You okay there, Princess?"

"It stings!" Adora said, a little annoyed. "I seem to recall a certain *someone* never letting me properly disinfect her cuts when we were younger for just that reason."

“No, it’s because I could clean my wounds just fine with my tongue!” Catra protested. “It’s part of the whole magicat thing.”

“Ah,” Adora said, a wicked smile crossing her face, “so you were just *disinfecting* me the other night, huh?”

Catra blushed a deep crimson under her fur. “I can’t fucking believe you.”

Adora laughed, and pulled Catra up to kiss her. “Thank you for your concern. And for… for not leaving, earlier.”

“I could never.” Catra said, because it was true. Then, sensing an opportunity for revenge, she added, “Besides, we have to set a good example for our kids.”

That caught Adora off guard, and she pulled back to look at Catra, shocked. “Our *kids* ?”

Catra shrugged. “What else do you want me to call ‘em, Adora? They’re us but tiny, and from what I’ve seen Shadow Weaver already did a number on them.”

“What do you mean?”

“I mean…” Catra sighed, “you know how you and I were raised? As a pair? She did the same thing with them.” There was anger in her voice as she continued. “I can see it - the way that Mara considers C’yra her commander, the way that C’yra feels responsible for everything Mara does… it’s a mirror of us. They’re heading for the same thing that ripped us apart, I think.” She ran her metal hand through her hair. “I want to stop it. Stop *them* , I mean. Get them away from all this, but I don’t see how.”

Adora looked at Catra for a long moment. “You’re really worried about this, huh?”

“How close did we come to destroying the world when we fought, Adora?” Catra asked, with fire in her eye. “How much destruction did *I cause* because I didn’t know any other way to be? Do you

know how close I came to complete self-destruction with you gone? *Gods* , Adora, the number of near-misses Scorpia managed to stop," she said, a grim laugh escaping her, "if I can spare anyone what I put myself through…"

Adora was looking at Catra with shock in her eyes. "I never knew," she said, softly, "I'm so sorry, I never-"

"It was a long time ago." Catra said, shortly. "And we've had other things on our minds since we met back up." At Adora's unchanged expression, Catra reached out and gave her shoulder a reassuring squeeze. "Hey, I know what you're thinking but it wasn't your fault, got it? I did those things, and I've spent a long time coming to grips with that."

"I know," Adora said, though not without a struggle, "I just wish… I wish it could've been different. I wish we could've gotten here without so much…"

"Pain?" Catra said, raising an eyebrow. "Yeah. Me too. But we're here now, and we can move forward from there."

"When can I see them?" Adora asked.

"We'll figure something out." Catra said. "You probably need to smooth things over with your friends first."

Adora groaned, flopping back on the bed dramatically. "Gods, that's a conversation I don't want to have. I don't even know how to begin with them."

Catra flopped next to her. "Just be honest with them,' she said with a grin, "tell them 'I've fallen in love with my ex-best friend, and we're going to stop the war and go raise our clones in lesbian bliss somewhere.'"

Adora rolled her eyes and snorted. "That a marriage proposal, Commander?"

"Oh, I don't know." Catra said, airily, "is that a yes?"

“Could be.” Adora said, with an equal casualness. “I suppose we’re going to have to revisit the idea once this is all over. But until then,” she said, rolling over and looming above Catra with purpose, “maybe we’ll just focus on making up for lost time.”

Catra grinned wide. “You sure you have time for this? Light Hope doesn’t have some other training for you planned?”

“I already ran through the combat trials,” Adora said, “and I can’t do the spellwork at the moment. Besides, I only get you for another day, right?”

You’ve got me for the rest of your life , Catra thought, looking up, but she only nodded. “We knew this is how it had to be for now.”

“Then please,” Adora said, an edge of pleading to her voice, “let me show you how I feel.”

Catra reached up to frame Adora’s face. “Okay,” she said, “show me.”

Chapter End Notes

> *P.O.S. at the beginning of Let it Rattle voice* Sorry this took so long.
>
> Took a while to get this one out - mostly because I felt the need to mess around a little and add another chapter to Fang and Claw. Some other ideas have taken up some time too, though I regret to inform you they aren't She-Ra related and thus are completely uninteresting (they're also not in a finished state so).
>
> Anyway, I hope this was worth the rate. Next chapter: The actual return of She-Ra, a check-in with our favorite clones, and the long-awaited return of Entrapta in full-on researcher mode (the most adorable version of Entrapta, as we all know). Thanks for reading! Thanks for kudos!

Thanks for commenting and indulging me and my almost pathological need to reply to basically every comment at least once! See you next time (which will hopefully not be quite so long, but who can say?)!

Recovery, of a Sort

Chapter Summary

> Entrapta's cure is tested. Catra finds stowaways and gives advice. Adora makes another promise and finds more questions.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Entrapta bounded off the skiff with an almost infectious excitement. “Commander! I’ve brought everything we need!” She grinned widely. “The equipment just needs the sword to power it, and we’ll be in business!”

“How much equipment is there?” Catra asked, still feeling a little sleepy and disinclined to spend too much time hauling machinery into the Crystal Castle.

“Oh, not much.” Entrapta reassured her commander. “Three crates! You can probably lift one of them on your own, too.”

Catra raised an eyebrow. “That’s all?”

“Oh, well that’s all the *crates* .” nodded Entrapta. “There’s also four longboxes, which probably take two people to move - at least, they took two people at the base to move - oh, and a case!” she added, holding up the case in question triumphantly. “But I’ve already got that so you don’t need to worry.”

“Well that’s nice, at least.” Catra said, deadpan. “I’ll go get Adora to help. She might as well earn her cure.”

Entrapta looked genuinely surprised for a moment. “I thought she’d done that with you last night, Commander.” The snort of laughter that she couldn’t quite suppress was the only sign that she wasn’t entirely serious.

Catra's voice was several octaves higher. "I can't imagine what you're talking about, Entrapta."

"Commander," said Entrapta patiently, "you're wearing her shirt. I think you know precisely what I'm talking about."

"She's got a point, you know." Adora said, walking out of the Castle entrance. "I don't think any of your men are operating under the illusion you and I are not involved."

Catra groaned. "Can I at least *pretend* to have some kind of private life?"

"It's totally private. Only I know you're wearing Adora's shirt. Oh, and Scorpia will know, because I promised her I would tell her how you two were doing."

Adora laughed, and Catra shot a glare her way. "Hey, get ready Princess. Once you make good with your friends they're going to do the same thing to you. Maybe I should make sure to give you some marks you have to explain to them when you get back, hmm?"

Adora's breath caught for a moment, then she leaned forward, voice low and sultry. "You making a promise for later, kitten?"

Catra felt her fur stand on end and the breath leave her body. She was still adjusting to an Adora that was so… *forward* . Scrambling to recover, she matched Adora's look with one of her own, "That can be arranged."

Adora's smile took on a decidedly hungry look. "I'm looking forward to it."

Entrapta clapped her hands loudly, reminding the two that she was still there. "Hey! Sex later! Equipment unloading now!"

That actually managed to fluster Adora, much to Catra's delight. She grinned widely. "Sure thing, 'trapta."

As soon as she set foot on the skiff, Catra knew something was up. Adora picked up on Catra's tension immediately, and made a few quick hand signals, an old sign language they'd developed as cadets. Adora forced herself to seem casual as she approached the first of the crates. She spoke loudly, carelessly. "So it's just these three crates?"

"And those longboxes." Catra said, circling around the other side. "Entrapta says we'll have to do those together." Her ear twitched and she grinned. "Go ahead and grab one of the crates, Adora. I'm sure our guests will be willing to help carry one as well, won't you?"

There was a muffled curse from inside one of the longboxes. Catra knocked on the lid. "Your cover's blown, kids. Come on out."

The lid creaked open and Mara's blue eyes glared up at her. Catra heard a small gasp from Adora at the sight and instinctively reached over to put a hand on her shoulder. C'yra's expression was one of disappointment, and her posture seemed to be bracing her against an expected blow. Catra noticed, felt her heart break a little, and gave as reassuring of a grin as she could.

"I see that you decided to take advantage of Entrapta's somewhat limited attention span, huh? Not a bad strategy - but you didn't put enough thought into an exit. You didn't know where these were headed, did you?"

"We *did* , in fact." Mara butted in, aggressively. "The Whispering Woods are a good place to disappear."

"The 'disappearing' part usually refers to being consumed by hostile wildlife." Catra said, dryly.

Mara looked like she was about to respond, but C'yra cut in. "You're… *her* ." she said, staring at Adora.

Adora, who had been staring at the two in something like shock, seemed to shake out of the daze she was in. "Huh?"

"You're *her* ." C'yra repeated. "The Great Betrayer. She-Ra. Our whole… *existence* was built around your betrayal. Mara…" her voice was full of barely concealed rage, "Mara went through *hell* because *you left* ."

Adora rocked backwards like she'd been slapped, her eyes wide with horror. "I didn't know-" she started to say, but C'yra was not interested in listening.

"So many lessons about the *Great Betrayer* ," she spat, "so many reminders that I was responsible for keeping Mara in line, that Mara couldn't be *trusted* , that she should be a blunt tool and nothing more." Her hands were clenched into fists, and she was shaking. "I swore to Mara… *swore* that if I found you I'd kill you. That I'd make you pay for what you did."

"And?" Catra said, stepping in front of Adora protectively, "What do you think now?"

Mara placed a hand on C'yra's shoulder. "It wasn't her fault, Commander. If what… if what the Commander says is true, and *she* didn't know, how could Ad-the Great Betrayer know?"

Adora seemed surprised to hear Mara come to her defense. She looked at the girl with gratitude in her eyes, but didn't speak. C'yra's body language had shifted as soon as Mara touched her, some of the tension had vanished almost immediately but it was clear she was still angry.

"I think…" said C'yra, slowly, with a visible effort to control her voice, "I think that Mara's right, and you didn't know. That doesn't change what happened to us."

Adora dropped to a knee in front of the two. "It doesn't, and I can't undo what happened to you." she said, voice steady and the look in her eye Catra recognized as being the prelude to making some kind of ridiculous, self-sacrificing offer. "If you still want to kill me," she said, "I won't fight you. But I'd ask you to wait until

I’ve had a chance to destroy the Horde,” her voice grew dangerous, “and rip Shadow Weaver’s heart from her chest.”

There was an anger Catra had never heard before in Adora’s voice. She looked over in surprise and saw Adora’s face had hardened, her jaw was clenched and she was close, it seemed, to grinding her teeth. Catra had always known Adora to be a fierce fighter, but never had seen her as capable of the violence that her posture now promised. It was almost frightening to behold - and from the look in Mara and C’yra’s faces, Catra was not the only one to think so.

“Well?” Adora asked, not realizing (or perhaps not caring in the moment) the effect she was having on the three. “Do we have a deal, C’yra?”

To her credit, C’yra mastered herself quickly upon being addressed. “We have a deal. When Shadow Weaver’s dead, however…”

“I won’t fight you.” Adora said, the anger draining out of her posture. There was a wry look as she added, “Although I hope I manage to earn mercy before this is all over.”

There was something imperious in C’yra’s manner as she responded. “Perhaps you will.”

“Glad that’s settled.” Catra said, not entirely pleased with this turn of events, but willing (for the moment) to trust Adora’s judgment. “Now help us unload this crap. The two of you ought to be able to shift one of those crates, at least.”

Mara was only too willing to help, and grabbed C’yra’s hand, leading her away from the two older women. Catra watched the two long enough to see they were actually going to move the crate and not bolt for the woods, then turned her attention back to Adora. “You okay? That uh, wasn’t exactly how I hoped this first meeting would go.”

Adora took a deep breath and seemed to master herself, finally. The cold fury that had gripped her dissipated, and her body relaxed. “I’m not sure how I expected it to go.” she said, after a moment. “I guess it’s not a surprise that they can’t help but hate me.”

“They’ll come around.” Catra said. “At least they didn’t try to kill you immediately like they did to me.”

“I’m pretty sure that’s only because you were standing there and C’yra wasn’t sure she could take the both of us at once.” Adora said, sighing and running a hand through her hair. “How could they do that to them? They’re *kids* , Catra.”

“So were we.” Catra reminded her. “They’ve got a chance to grow up outside of all this.”

Adora watched the two as Entrapta, showing no signs of surprise, waved them and the crate over in her direction. “I’m not sure they want to.”

“I’m not sure that I care to give them the choice.” Catra said, shortly. “If they still want to fight when they’re older, I won’t stop them, but now? No. The world has enough child soldiers without me adding two more to the mix.”

“So what’s the plan to keep them from running off to do it on their own?”

Catra smiled winningly. “I said I wouldn’t let them fight, but I didn’t say anything about not training them. Along with a bunch of other educational classes - more than you and I got from the Horde. I’ve got a couple soldiers from Brightmoon who used to teach, so I’ve been thinking I might see if they’ll establish some kind of school on site. A lot of our people never got much of an education to begin with, you know?”

Adora watched Catra come alive as she talked about her plans for her organization. There was an undeniable drive to do things better, to make sure her people were well taken care of. Except

she hadn’t referred to them as her people, she’d referred to them as, “ *Our* people, huh?” Adora said, with a fond smile on her face.

Judging by Catra’s reaction, she hadn’t realized what she’d said. She recovered quickly, though, and shrugged. “I mean, you’re part of this… thing I’m building. You know that, right?”

“Yeah, it’s just…” Adora fumbled for the right words. “Hearing it makes it *real* , somehow. You know?”

Catra would have responded, but she spotted C’yra and Mara headed back to the skiff. “Nice work.” she called to them, startling Mara a little. “Can you grab another one?”

C’yra glared at Adora, but at a nudge from Mara she nodded and gave a half-hearted salute. “Aye, Commander.”

As the two headed back to the skiff, Catra noticed that Mara was speaking insistently to C’yra, whose ears drooped in an all-too familiar motion. She filed it away, figuring she could talk to one or both of them about it later. The sight of Adora seemed to have deeply disturbed C’yra, though if they’d really paid the price for Adora’s desertion she could understand the anger. It was good that Mara, at least, seemed slightly ahead of the curve on that score - Catra doubted C’yra would listen to *her* , but she seemed to listen to Mara.

Entrapta had already started assembling the apparatus by the time the last of the crates were unloaded. Adora watched her closely as she worked, lending a hand when requested. Catra watched the procedure, feeling less and less enthused about the prospect of Adora going back to being She-Ra by the minute. She knew it was irrational, but She-Ra returning made her worry that Adora would disappear, drawn back to her Princess friends. Even though that was - Catra knew - completely not true, it didn’t change the actual fact that as soon as Adora was cured, Catra needed to get back to her people, and Adora needed to get back to the Rebellion - and who knew when they’d manage to meet again?

She was so lost in thought that she didn't hear C'yra approach. "Um, Commander?"

Catra managed not to react with any visible surprise. "I'm not your commander, kid. You can just call me Catra."

C'yra frowned a little at that, but acquiesced. "Catra, then. I have a question."

"Go ahead." Catra said. "What do you want to know?"

"Well…" C'yra seemed to hesitate for a moment. She glanced over at where Mara was somewhat delightedly peppering Entrapta with questions about her process that the princess seemed only too happy to answer at intense length, though somewhat impressively she never stopped working while doing so. The sight of her friend seemed to give her the push she needed to go on. "How did you stop hating her? The Great… that is, Adora, I mean."

Catra had expected a lot of things, but this particular question wasn't one she felt quite ready for. She ran her metal hand over her face, closed her eye, and sighed. "I'd be lying if I said it was easy, kiddo. I hated her for *years* , or thought I did. Her leaving was the breaking of a promise we'd made - and I couldn't understand how she could do it. How she could leave *me* ."

The ghost of an old anger flickered briefly in her chest, but it had no hold over her the way it used to and went out as quickly as it had appeared. "But I had it all wrong - if she'd stayed… things would've gotten worse."

"What do you mean?" C'yra asked, brow wrinkled in confusion. "Aren't you two- I mean, the soldiers we heard talk about you always said-"

"We were inseparable?" Catra said, with a bitter grin. "Or maybe you heard the ones who said we loved each other, hmm?" C'yra blushed and looked away, which made Catra chuckle. "It's not entirely untrue. But Shadow Weaver… she knew we were close,

and she used that to control us. It wasn't until Adora left that I realized how we'd been played off of one another."

"But you said you still hated her."

"Yeah, I did." Catra admitted. "But I also never stopped caring about her. Not once. And eventually, I understood why she left. Why she *had* to leave."

"Why'd she have to leave?"

Catra sighed. "Because she saw what the Horde was doing. And once she saw that, she knew she couldn't support it anymore. Not even if it meant losing me."

C'yra digested this information. "Did you know what the Horde was doing too?"

Catra knew where this line of inquiry was headed. "Yeah."

"Then… why'd you stay?"

"Because," Catra said, slowly, "I'm not the hero Adora is. I thought as long as I had *her* , it didn't matter. Then she left, and I was so full of hate that I refused to follow her. I wanted to hurt her the way she'd hurt me. By the time I realized my mistake, I was convinced it was too late, and resolved to make the best of it. Maybe change the Horde from the inside and at least keep people on our side safe."

"And that's when you stopped hating her?"

"Yeah." Catra said. "It was killing me to hate her. It was killing other people, too - my people, who were getting thrown into fights just so I could selfishly have my revenge, which I'm not sure I even really *wanted* ." She couldn't help a self-deprecating chuckle. "A friend of mine helped me realize how destructive I was being, and after that… I understood some things are bigger than two people. Sometimes, you have to choose between the mission

and your friends, and Adora chose the mission. I did too, eventually. After that, I just… stopped hating her."

"That doesn't help me at *all* ." C'yra groaned, sounding frustrated. "I *know* she's not the one who hurt Mara, not really, but…"

Catra reached out slowly - not quite sure how C'yra would react - and put an arm around her shoulder. C'yra stiffened, but then something in her snapped and she seemed to collapse against Catra. "I know." Catra whispered, soothingly. She stroked the girl's back gently in a half-remembered motion. "It's hard. You were told it was her fault, and you can't just… *forget* it. Give it time. You don't have to make friends with her, but you have to start the same way I did - You have to forgive Adora for leaving."

C'yra's voice was muffled. "I don't know if I *can* ."

"Take your time." Catra said, and glanced over to where Adora and Entrapta were finishing up while Mara continued to ask questions - some of which Adora seemed to be answering. "Your friend seems to trust her, at any rate."

"She's too trusting." C'yra said, looking over and unable to completely disguise the fondness in her eyes. "Even though she's the one who realized what the Horde was first and encouraged me to flee, she still trusted all the guards to help us out and not tell Shadow Weaver."

" *Did* they help?"

"I fed them false information." C'yra said, with a hint of pride in her voice. "So when we escaped, all the guards were in the wrong place."

Catra made a noise of approval. "Smart thinking. But it doesn't mean Mara's wrong to trust Adora, you know."

"I know." C'yra said, sighing. "I just wish she wasn't so *quick* to trust."

“Honestly, I think it’s genetic.” Catra said, glancing over at Adora, who was watching the two of them now with undisguised interest. She gave C’yra one more reassuring squeeze and stood up. “Looks like they’re finished setting up. You wanna go see if Entrapta’s research pays off?”

C’yra looked like maybe she wanted to say something else, but she’d also noticed Adora’s look and had quickly recomposed herself back into an outward appearance of imperiousness. “Sure, why not?” When she turned back to Catra, however, there was still a flash of vulnerability on her face. “Hey, Comman-er, Catra?”

“Yeah kid?”

“Thanks. Um. For telling me all this.”

Catra felt a surge of affection and pity for this young kid in front of her, brought up in a world that she never should’ve had to deal with. Her throat felt unexpectedly tight, and she felt like she might start crying. “Any time, C’yra. Just… give it time, okay? And don’t be afraid to come to me about anything else - this is… well, it’s a strange situation we’re in.”

C’yra gave her a quick nod and dashed off in Mara’s direction. Catra resisted the urge to follow suit and walked casually over. The apparatus looked, Catra thought, uncomfortably like the same sort of torture equipment she’d found Adora in. She looked over at Adora to try to gauge her feelings on things, and was unsurprised to see that she was very clearly nervous.

“Hey,” she said, in a low, hopefully reassuring voice, “it’ll work. Entrapta knows her stuff.”

Adora worried at her lower lip. “Yeah, I know. I’m just… I feel like I’m missing something important. Like there’s some piece of this I’m not seeing.”

Catra knew Adora well enough to know that her instincts were usually pretty good. “Okay…” she said, rubbing her chin, “we can

call this off. You can see if Light Hope's got any further information, or something?"

The idea was tempting, but Adora knew the Rebellion couldn't afford to be without She-Ra for much longer - if the Horde realized she'd lost her powers, they would move, and move hard. "No, let's do this now. I can do some more research after I've got She-Ra back."

Catra made a mental note to see if any of her personnel were historians to help and nodded. "Okay. Ready, 'trapta?"

Entrapta's hands were clasped in front of her and she was nearly vibrating with excitement. "You betcha, Commander! Oh, we're going to get such interesting *data* from all this! Let me just…" she maneuvered Adora into place and strapped some leads to her head. "Okay, this goes *here,* this goes *there* , and - wait, no, that goes *here* , sorry. Commander, can you grab the sword?"

Catra hadn't realized that Adora had even brought the sword out, but found it leaning against the frame of the apparatus and held it out to Entrapta.

"Oh no, my hands are full - there's a slot for it over there," Entrapta's hair pointed, "just stick it in and turn it. You know, like a key."

Catra shrugged and did as she was instructed. A low electric hum started building, and Adora shifted a little nervously. "It's uh, it's supposed to be doing that, right?" she asked with an edge to her voice.

"Of course it is! The humming means it's working!" Entrapta said, then stopped and made a brief adjustment to some of the wiring and the humming changed in tone. "Correction! *That* means it's working."

Catra shot Entrapta a warning look. "You're *sure* ?"

"As sure as I can be, Commander! There's always the chance something goes wrong and this thing explodes and we all die horribly!" Entrapta's eyes grew wider and wider as she theorized. "The reasons for it would be *fascinating* , it would mean that everything we think we know about First Ones technology is wrong!" She noticed the horrified looks on Catra and Adora's faces and coughed, looking a little embarrassed. "But the odds are very, *very* low, so it'll be fine."

"Adora?" Catra looked over at her. "You ready?"

Adora swallowed nervously, and nodded. "Hit it."

Entrapta grinned excitedly and flipped a switch. The humming got louder and the sword started glowing. A blue energy began dancing over Adora's skin, and she tensed visibly as the current ran through her. Instinctively, Catra positioned herself between C'yra, Mara, and the machine. Adora's eyes were screwed shut, and then they suddenly flew open. Light poured out of her mouth in a howling scream, and Catra rushed forward to hit the shutdown button, only for Entrapta to hold her back. "No Commander! That means it's working! Trust me!"

"She's in pain!" Catra shouted, pushing forward.

Entrapta's hair wrapped around Catra, holding her firm. "If you stop this, it'll have been for nothing!"

That got through to Catra, and she stopped struggling, but there were tears running down her face as she watched Adora convulse.

Adora was barely holding on to consciousness as energy flooded her body. She was vaguely aware of Catra's shouting, but she couldn't speak. The sound ripping out of her throat wasn't her voice, it was something else - something that was being burned out of her. When she finally lost consciousness, it was a relief.

She was back in the cave with a caged She-Ra, except this time She-Ra seemed a little more lucid. She-Ra glared at Adora as she

approached.

“What business do you have here, *usurper?* ” the Princess snarled.

Adora was confused. “What do you mean, usurper?”

“Release me!” She-Ra demanded. “You had no right!”

“How do I do that?” Adora asked. “What… what happened? I want to help you!”

“Help me?” She-Ra’s eyes seemed to clear, and she looked at Adora in recognition. “Adora?”

“Yes, it’s me.” Adora said, feeling like she was talking to herself. “How do I get you out of here?”

“You must destroy the lock.” She-Ra said, gripping the bars and pleading. “You cannot allow them to make me a weapon. You *cannot* .”

“Who?” Adora asked. There was a roaring in her ears and her heart was beating fast, and she felt like she was losing consciousness again. “Who’s trying to make you a weapon?”

“The Et*******” She-Ra’s voice became garbled, as if something was blocking her. “Please! I cannot-”

“-dora! Wake up!” Catra’s voice broke in and Adora’s eyes flew open. She sat up, gasping for air. She was back in their bedroom, head swimming. Catra looked over her shoulder. “Entrapta! Something’s wrong!”

“No, it’s-” Adora took a deep breath. “I had another vision. The cave.”

Catra looked confused. “What are you talking about?”

“Before you got here, when Light Hope and I tried to power through the curse,” Adora explained, the words coming slow. “I

had… I had this *vision* . She-Ra's imprisoned. Something's… limiting her, and Razz said… She said Mara's friend from Halfmoon could help. When I lost consciousness this time, I was back in the cave where She-Ra's caged. She was… she *begged* me to free her, but I don't know how. I don't even know what her being imprisoned means."

"Halfmoon?" Catra said, confused. "What's Halfmoon?"

"An old kingdom. It was… I don't know, it was on the maps in the command center, but it's located where the Crimson Waste is now."

Catra frowned, and dug out the symbol she'd copied from the map the day before. "This symbol," she said, slowly, "is this symbol Halfmoon?"

Adora looked at the symbol and nodded. "Yeah. Why do you have that?"

"I went exploring yesterday." Catra explained. "Decided to explore that command center you talked about, and something about this symbol was… *familiar* . I don't know why."

Adora digested this information. Once again she got the feeling that she was missing something important, that there was a piece she was missing, but she couldn't quite grasp it. Her concentration was broken by a shout from outside.

"Adora!" Entrapta bounded into the room. "I think the experiment was a success! But you'll need to transform to be sure. Can you transform?"

Adora stood up and took a deep breath. "Yeah, I can try. Where's the sword?"

Entrapta produced the sword from where her hair had been holding on to it. "Right here!"

Adora grabbed the sword, lifted it, and said the words. There was the usual flash, and this time, She-Ra stood before Entrapta and Catra. After a few tense seconds, She-Ra smiled. "It worked! I'm… I'm back to normal!"

"Great!" Entrapta said, clapping her hands together with glee. "That means I was right about the sword!"

"What do you mean?" She-Ra asked, cocking her head curiously.

"It's like a control system." Entrapta explained excitedly. "The She-Ra powers are channeled through the sword - it's how I was able to remove the curse. I used it to inject code that countered the curse's effects."

She-Ra frowned at the explanation, her brow furrowing as Razz's words echoed in her mind. *The sword is the key and the lock* . She closed her eyes, trying to will herself back to the cave without success.

"Uh, Adora?" Catra asked, sounding a little worried. "You okay?"

She-Ra shifted back into Adora's form. "Yeah, I'm… I'm fine. Just thinking about something Razz said about the sword." She grinned. "Nice to be able to transform and not collapse, again. Thanks for your help, Entrapta."

"Oh no, the pleasure was all mine! I got so much fascinating data from this! It'll take me *months* to sift through it all! It's going to be so exciting!"

"But for now," Catra said, cutting in, "let's get something to eat and then get some rest. We'll have to head out in the morning." Her ear twitched, and she snorted. "Can I trust you two to not run off into the woods and get in trouble if you stay here with us for a night?"

There was another curse, and a whispered "How does she *do* that?" from Mara as C'yra stuck her head in the doorway.

“Um, yeah. We’ll stay here. That is, I’ve decided… that we want to stay. For now.”

“Glad to hear it.” Catra said. “There’s… well, there’s a lot of stuff we’ll have to go over when we get back to the base, but for now, consider yourselves at liberty to explore the area - *provided you take a radio* and contact us if you get into any trouble, got it?”

C’yra saluted smartly. “Of course, Comman-er, Catra.”

“Entrapta, you feel like talking to an ancient First Ones AI?” Catra asked, glancing over at Adora. “I’m pretty sure you might be able to find some interesting things out.”

“I’ll tell Light Hope to give you access to any information you want to see.” Adora said. “It’s the least I can do for your help.”

Entrapta looked like she might die of happiness on the spot. “Oh,” she said, “that’s the nicest thing anyone’s ever done for me.”

Catra drew close to Adora and whispered in her ear. “As for you, I believe I owe you some *bruises* , don’t I?” Adora shivered, and Catra laughed.

It was no surprise to Entrapta, later that night, that Catra asked her to sleep on the skiff with Mara and C’yra.

Chapter End Notes

> And that's all she wrote for this edition of "Adora and Catra are kind of adorable together." Back to soldiering and sneaking about and I guess Adora has to have an actual long talk with Glimmer and Bow, doesn't she?
>
> What *were* Mara and Adora talking about, I wonder?
>
> Thanks as always for your patience between updates, and the kudos, comments, and telling your friends and enemies about this stuff so they can read it too. See you next time, whenever that is!

Homecoming, of a Sort

Chapter Summary

> Adora returns to Brightmoon and faces the music. Glimmer makes a decision. Bow frets.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora stood before the door to Glimmer's bedroom and took a deep breath. When she'd arrived back at the castle, nobody had been there to greet her - which wasn't surprising, as Adora hadn't sent word that she'd be returning. She'd wanted her return to be relatively quiet, as it seemed like risking a shouting match in the open would probably raise questions among the castle guard that Adora really didn't want asked (or answered) just yet. She knocked softly on the door, and heard the sound of someone on the other side of the door approach. When the door opened, Adora was only slightly surprised to see Bow's face. His expression slid from surprised to happy to guarded within a few seconds.

"Hi." Adora said, quietly. "Can I come in?"

Bow looked back over his shoulder at, Adora presumed, Glimmer, then stepped back and opened the door to let her pass. Adora stepped in and looked over where Glimmer was in the process of fixing her hair. Glimmer looked over at Adora, frowned, said nothing. Adora waved, a little weakly.

"I'm back." she said, feeling a little stupid.

"I can see that." Glimmer replied, coolly. "Was Light Hope any help?"

"Sort of." Adora said. "I was able to get my powers back, but it was because Entrapta flew down with some equipment that solved the problem." she paused, giving Glimmer a chance to

respond, but when her friend continued to just look at her she continued. “Also, I met my clone.”

That got a response. Bow squeaked out a “clone?” while Glimmer somehow managed to maintain slightly more composure. “I assume,” Glimmer said, “this came as a surprise to you too?”

“Not quite.” Adora said. “Entrapta had found evidence of a cloning project the Horde was running, but to our knowledge they were still being held somewhere.” she shrugged. “As it turns out, they’d decided to escape at some point after Catra was declared dead by the Horde. Catra ran into them attacking a Horde outpost.”

Glimmer’s eyebrows nearly shot off her head. “She did *what* ?”

Adora rubbed the back of her head in a nervous gesture. “Yeah, she and um… Catra’s clone mounted an assault. Then they tried to kill Catra.”

“I like them already.” Glimmer muttered, earning a glare from Bow.

Almost without meaning to, Adora laughed. “Yeah, Catra was weirdly proud of ‘em too. I was the only one who was kind of shocked by the idea.”

“So… where are they?” Glimmer asked, looking around as if the two clones were going to walk through the door any moment.

“Er,” Adora knew this was not going to go over well, “they’re with Catra. They don’t really trust the Rebellion.”

“They tried to *kill* Catra!”

“Yes, but then she saved their lives. So they decided to trust her.” Adora shrugged. “Plus, Catra knows how bad Shadow Weaver can get more than anyone.” there was a look in Adora’s eyes that gave Glimmer pause, and Adora added. “Especially me.”

“What do you mean?” Glimmer asked. “That is… you mentioned that Shadow Weaver treated you differently than the others before, but...”

“I got a different kind of abuse.” Adora supplied, shrugging. “She made sure that I knew I was responsible for anything bad that happened to Catra - that I had to control her in order to keep her. That I was *better* than everyone else, and more was expected of me, and because of that my failures were worse than Catra’s failures. It was an enormous amount of pressure to… to perform, to be the best. I had to do it, because if I didn’t Catra would suffer the consequences, but what I didn’t know was that Catra was suffering the consequences regardless.”

In the years Glimmer had known Adora, the subject of her time in the Horde had always been something they’d never gone into particularly deeply. Adora had always kept that part of her history private - and Glimmer, while curious, had always been willing to respect that desire. After all, when Adora’s knowledge of the way the Horde worked was required, she’d always been forthcoming about what she knew, so what did it matter if Adora kept her childhood private? Now that Adora was apparently willing to talk, Glimmer couldn’t resist the urge to pry a little more.

“But why? What was the point?”

“If I knew that, maybe I could’ve ended the war sooner.” Adora sighed. “I think… I think it was meant to make sure that we couldn’t ever quite relate to one another. I could write off Shadow Weaver’s punishments as not being too bad, because I never realized how bad it actually was until it was too late, and she had me so convinced Catra’s behavior was my responsibility I only ever tried to get Catra to behave herself rather than going after Weaver.”

“So Catra’s got a better idea of what the kids have been through, you think?”

“Yeah. And they’re more likely to trust an ex-Commander of the Horde than the Great Betrayer.” Adora said, making a face. “In fact, C’yra kind of blames me for what happened to them.”

“C’yra?”

“The uh, magicat kid.” Adora said. “The uh, human kid is named Mara, which is… I don’t know. It was the name of the She-Ra before me, and it makes me think that Shadow Weaver knew who I was before she found me.”

Glimmer looked thoughtful. “I wonder who C’yra was, then.”

Adora was caught off guard by the question, both because she hadn’t thought about it at all and because Glimmer seemed to be taking an interest in something involving Catra. “Huh?”

Bow piped up, excited at the thought of a new mystery to solve. “Well, you know, if your clone was named after the last She-Ra, then who was C’yra? I wonder if there’s some record of her - maybe it would give some insight into whatever Weaver’s planning!”

Adora thought about this for a moment. She knew this was not actually a worthwhile line of inquiry - whatever plans Shadow Weaver’d had for the clones had ended with their escape - but she was also pretty sure that Bow knew it too. What it would mean, however, was that the group would have something to focus on apart from the question of Adora’s loyalties, and maybe she could get Glimmer to understand Catra a little more.

“Maybe it could,” she said, slowly, then turned to Glimmer. “It might be a dead end though - can we spare the time to investigate?”

Glimmer frowned. “I think we can use any edge we can get. Horde operations are still fairly quiet, and we’re still waiting to hear back from our intel teams about that weapon you found, so we can spare some time.”

“I’ll contact my dads! They’re good with history stuff.”

“See if they have anything on uh, Halfmoon too.” Adora said, suddenly.

“Huh?”

“It’s… I think it used to be a kingdom out by the Crimson Wastes.” explained Adora. “I had a um, I guess a vision? Halfmoon came up.”

“I know about Halfmoon.” Glimmer said, cutting Bow off before he could respond. “It was the old Kingdom of the Magicats. Mom told me about them - they used to be allies with us, but the kingdom was destroyed in some disaster. It was before my mom was even born. My grandma never talked about it.”

Adora had a feeling that it was more likely Angella didn’t want to tell Glimmer whatever had caused the destruction of an entire kingdom, but she kept that to herself. “Do you think that this… C’yra might have been some figure from Halfmoon’s history, then?”

Glimmer shrugged. “I could ask my mom, I guess…” she said reluctantly.

Bow cut in. “Better not to bother her. After all, if this does turn out to be a dead end, we don’t want to have wasted her time, right?”

“Good point.” Glimmer agreed, maybe a little too quickly. “We can handle this one on our own - if it turns out to be nothing, then mom doesn’t even have to know what we were doing.”

Adora could’ve let the matter rest there, but for some reason she had to push - just a little. Just to know what Angella knew. “Are you comfortable keeping that secret from the Queen?”

Glimmer gave Adora a very significant look. “It’s not the biggest secret I’ll be keeping from her.”

“Thank you.” Adora said, not bothering to keep the relief out of her voice. “I.. I know I’m asking a lot.”

“You are.” Glimmer said lightly. “But you’re my friend, and I trust you.”

Adora couldn’t find the words to express her gratitude, so instead she settled for a hug. Glimmer returned it carefully, like she was afraid Adora would change her mind.

After a moment - perhaps motivated by the same inability to leave things unsaid that Adora had, Glimmer added. “We *will* have to make a decision about her, sooner or later. Even if it’s not until the war’s over.”

Adora thought about what Catra had said. That her organization wasn’t meant to exist with the Alliance or Horde, that Adora had a place there, if she wanted it. “I know.” she said, and even as she said it Adora knew deep down she might end up losing Glimmer and Bow. “We’ll figure it out.”

That seemed to reassure Glimmer somewhat, and she stepped back from the hug and wiped her eyes. “Okay.” she said, and sniffed. “I’ll let my mom know we’re chasing down a possible lead, and we’ll move on from there. Oh! My mother! You should probably let her know we’ve got She-Ra back!”

Adora blinked in surprise. “Oh right. You know, I was so worried about getting back and trying to make things right I never even thought to see her.”

“Well come on, we’ll go see her together.” Glimmer said, looking at least a little pleased at Adora’s admission.

“I’ll send a message to my dads.” Bow said. “No need for all three of us to bother her, right?” He gave Adora a peculiar look, and then left.

As soon as he left the room, Glimmer seemed to relax even more. “Thank goodness.”

Adora was puzzled. “What do you mean? Are you and Bow fighting?”

“No, it’s just... “ Glimmer sighed. “We fought, yes. About you, or more accurately about you and Catra. He was… well. He made some good points, but also said he’d support whatever I decided to do in the end.”

Adora was confused. “So why the look when he left?”

Glimmer laughed. “I’m pretty he’s not entirely convinced I won’t teleport you to a holding cell as soon as his back is turned just so I don’t have to see the look of disapproval on his face.”

At the look of shock on Adora’s face, she hastened to add, “Which I’m not going to do! I was serious when I said I trust you, Adora.”

“Well that’s a relief.” Adora said, and briefly considered making a joke about not wanting to have to fight her as She-Ra before deciding they were probably not quite at that point yet. “Better go see your mom before Bow gets too worried, huh?”

Glimmer laughed and grabbed Adora’s hand. “Yeah, let’s go. You can tell him I told you all this later, by the way - I’m sure he’ll want to know if I brought it up or not.”

Adora caught a hint of annoyance in Glimmer’s voice and frowned. “I’m sorry, Glim. The last thing I wanted to do is have you and Bow fighting because of something I did.”

“Oh no, Adora, trust me - Bow and I have fought before, and we’ll fight again. We don’t always see eye to eye, you know?” Glimmer shrugged, and a hint of fondness crossed her face. “He keeps me honest.”

“Yeah, I can understand that.” Adora said, a knowing smile on her face. “I’m the same way with Catra.”

Glimmer snorted and muttered something like a denial, but there was a faint blush on her cheeks that caused Adora’s laughter to

echo in the room as she teleported the two of them to the throne room.

Chapter End Notes

Ugh, I know, it's been forever and here I come bearing a *short chapter*, no less. Unfortunately for us all, it just felt like a good place to end things! Sorry about that. March is generally a tough month for me, and now I've got fretting over a fuckin' pandemic to add to things (oh, and working from home, which is one of those things that sounds *real cool* until you start going stir-crazy and realize that in spite of your insular ways you kind of liked the very limited social contact being around other people provided.

Plus *Doom Eternal* came out on Friday and, well, I've been busy ripping and tearing (and had the somewhat odd realization that some plot points I'd had in a different fanfic are... skating along the edge of the ridiculous shit that game gets up to narratively and I can't decide if I'm proud or embarrassed or a combination of both). So yeah, long story short, things are exceedingly odd, and we're under a soft sort of lockdown over here, and focusing up on writing has been hard.

BUT! Getting back to this was important to me, both because I love this world I've taken over with my particular brand of nonsense and also because I know y'all like reading this thing, and maybe it'll help take the edge off what is a very strange, very stressful time for basically everyone alive. So thank you for reading, and wash your fucking hands, and stay safe and I hope we all come out the other end alive. I've got more of this to tell so I certainly cannot go dying of some fucking virus any time soon, and without you to read it what's the bloody point, honestly? Until next time, dear readers, take it uh... take it fuckin' easy?

Christ, that's a bad sign-off. We'll be back with another chapter sooner rather than later, I think.

The Crimson Wastes

Chapter Summary

> Adora and Bow have a heart to heart. Glimmer forms an important opinion re: the Crimson Wastes.
>
> The Forge is re-lit.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"You guys, I'm so excited about this! I feel like it's been ages since we were off on a *quest!* " Bow's voice echoed through the Whispering Woods as the trio made their way down the path. Glimmer and Adora exchanged a look and laughed.

"We were just out on a mission like, three weeks ago!" Glimmer said.

"Yeah, but that was a *mission* ." Bow argued. "This is a *quest* . It's different! Quests are more important!"

Glimmer rolled her eyes. "This isn't a quest anyway. It's just… fancy reconnaissance."

"What makes it fancy?" Adora asked.

Glimmer placed a hand on her chest and tossed her hair in the nonexistent wind. "Because *I'm* here, and I make *everything* fancy." At the sight of her companions' nonplussed expressions, she laughed. "Plus, since this deals with She-Ra stuff, potentially, that makes it fancy."

"I see." Bow said, nodding seriously. "She-Ra stuff is fancy. Got it."

" *Princess* stuff is fancy." Glimmer corrected him.

It was a reminder of where Adora's - or She-Ra's, at any rate - loyalties lay. Adora honestly couldn't decide if Glimmer had said it on purpose or not, but given they'd just been talking about trusting each other the day before, she wrote it off as overthinking things.

"What about Bow stuff?" Bow asked, sounding wounded. "Aren't *I* fancy too?"

"The *fanciest* ." Glimmer assured him, laughing.

The rest of the day's travel was uneventful. The Crimson Wastes were still at least a few days' journey off - they'd decided not to travel by vehicle to keep the mission as low-profile as possible - and more obviously to give them more time to get used to being around one another. Whether or not Queen Angella had considered the possibility her daughter's request had been borne out of a desire to get some time alone to make peace with her friends, both of whom she'd fought with recently, hadn't been much of a concern. Adora suspected Angella knew they'd been fighting, but she was fairly confident the exact cause remained unknown. She didn't know - couldn't tell - if she was just being paranoid. Couldn't quite place why she didn't trust Angella anymore, or when exactly that had started, but if anything finding Catra alive had only increased the feeling of distrust.

"-further to go, I think!" Bow's cheery tone broke into Adora's thoughts and brought her back to reality.

"You do realize that once we get to the wastes, we still don't really know what we're looking for, right?" Glimmer replied, a note of teasing in her voice.

Bow shrugged, unconcerned. "Well yeah, that's why I left that communicator with my dads. They'll probably dig something up, and we've got that map your mom gave you to boot! We know where to start looking, at any rate."

"He's right, you know." Adora said, smiling. "We've got a *destination* , at least. The location of the palace will probably have something we can look into."

"And," Bow added, "there might even be First Ones tech we can find! This scanner will pick it up, and we can see where it leads us."

"Improvise, huh?" Glimmer grinned. "Just like the old days."

"Yeah, like old times." Adora smiled back, and felt a rush of nostalgia. It was nice to be back out with her friends, even if so much had changed. Even if she couldn't really trust them as much as she wanted to.

By the time they reached the Crimson Wastes, things almost felt like they would be okay - although troublingly, Bow's fathers still hadn't been able to find anything to indicate what had happened to Halfmoon. The only lead they had was the map, and Adora still wasn't entirely certain Angella didn't have some other motive for sending them there.

When she'd brought the concern up to Glimmer, Adora had been surprised by her response.

"My mom's usually working some kind of angle, honestly." Glimmer had said. "There's a good chance that she thinks the trip will do us good - or there's something going on at the palace she wants to keep secret from us for now."

"That doesn't concern you?" Adora had asked. "That she might be keeping something secret from you?"

Glimmer had shrugged. "I'd be lying if I said I'm not annoyed that she's still treating me like a kid, but… I trust that she's got the best interests of the Rebellion in mind. If she's keeping a secret from me, it's because she's being overprotective."

Or she knows you wouldn't approve of whatever she's doing , Adora had thought. She knew that would just lead to a fight that

she didn't want to have just now - it would be difficult, if not impossible, to convince Glimmer her trust was misplaced without having Glimmer think that maybe her trust in Adora was *also* misplaced. Adora needed that trust - needed to know that Glimmer trusted Adora was there to help, wanted to fight the Horde as much as she did - and more importantly Adora knew they had no chance of staying friends if they didn't or couldn't trust each other. So instead, Adora had merely hummed and said, "Well, you know her better than I do." and let the matter drop.

They made camp at the edge of the Crimson Wastes and all tried not to think about how the Crimson Wastes were generally considered a lawless deathtrap. It was something that could wait until the morning. Adora sat outside her tent into the late night, staring up at the moons and thinking about Catra, and the clones. It had only been a few days since they'd parted, but Adora missed her terribly. She wished that Catra could be making the trip to the Wastes with them. She was certain if the others just had a chance to meet Catra - to hear her speak about what she wanted to do with her soldiers, about fighting Hordak - and they'd understand why Adora trusted her. She was so lost in thought she didn't hear Bow sit down next to her.

"Missing Catra, huh?"

Adora looked sideways at him and saw an understanding smile on his face. "Was it that obvious?"

"You've got this dopey look on your face." Bow said, and then hastened to add, "Not like, in a *bad* way, it's just…"

"Well, that's fair enough. It's… hard not having her around. I missed her before, when I thought she still hated me." Adora laughed, shaking her head. "Now that I know she doesn't… I guess I miss her *more* ."

"That makes sense." Bow said, shrugging. "I mean, if you thought it was all over, you could kind of get over it." A wry grin crossed his face, and his voice softened, like he was telling some kind of

secret. "Now you've got this… this new thing, and it's terrifying because it feels like you have more to lose."

Adora gave him a long look. "Pretty perceptive there, Bow. You sound like you're speaking from experience."

"It's true." Bow said, giving Adora a serious look. "I've been dating Hordak."

Adora's expression went through several different permutations before settling on a mixture of disbelief and annoyance. "Oh come *on,* be serious."

There was a moment of silence before Bow's composure shattered and he started laughing. "Had you going for a minute, didn't I?"

"Not even a little." Adora snorted. "I was just a little caught off guard is all. I thought for sure you were going to tell me you and Glimmer-"

Bow's response of " *Now* who's being ridiculous?" came just a little too quickly to be entirely sincere.

Adora laughed. "Well, at any rate - you should get some sleep. I'll take the first watch tonight."

Bow nodded and stood, stretching his back out. "Sounds like a good idea. Wake me for second watch - don't tell her, but I think Glimmer's been worn out by all this traveling more than she wants to admit. Best to let her sleep a little longer."

"Will do." Adora said. "Sleep well."

The Crimson Wastes lived up to their name. The terrain was blasted to hell, rocky and only occasionally dotted with thorny brush and the odd cactus. That would have been fine - boring, but fine - if not for the fact that the thorny brush also had aggressive vines that kept trying to wrap them up and drag them off to who knows where. After the fourth time it happened, Adora kept the Sword of Protection out, and Bow carried his knives with him.

They were all covered in cuts and scratches, and going was slow - if it wasn't crawling over rocks, it was fighting against shifting red sands that slowed progress to a crawl.

"We should've brought Swift Wind." Glimmer said. "Swift Wind and like, another two horses."

"I think Swift Wind would've probably vetoed using any other horses." Adora pointed out, a little loathe to admit that she'd thought the same thing. "Besides, I don't know that horses would handle the terrain any better than us."

"Uh, guys?" Bow said, pointing ahead. "What are those?"

Glimmer shielded her eyes and peered at the two massive, lizardlike creatures which were moving in their direction at a disturbingly high speed. "No idea, but maybe we shouldn't stick around and find out."

Adora took a few steps back and checked their surroundings, looking for any kind of shelter. "Yeah that's… that's probably a good idea. Anyone see a good hiding spot?"

"Just those cliffs off in the distance." Glimmer said, frowning. "I should be able to get us most of the way there, but then we'll have to run for it."

"Great." Adora said. "Can you port us all at once?"

"No sweat." Glimmer said, in a tone of voice that implied there would probably be *some* sweat but she wasn't about to admit it. "Hang on tight."

The three vanished in a flash of sparks and reappeared roughly half a kilometer from the cliffs, which had - fortunately - put them even further away from whatever the giant lizards had been. They took off at a run, not really having any destination in mind beyond the cliffs themselves.

“There!” Bow pointed. “That narrow opening might be a cave! We can hide out there, maybe see if they keep going.”

“And hope there’s nothing trying to kill us in there.” Glimmer added.

Adora had been feeling a thrill of adrenaline the whole time, and grinned. “Hey, if there’s something in there, we’ll improvise.”

“Or run away from *two* groups of things that want to kill us!” Bow said. “Still seems better than waiting for those lizards to figure out we’re over here now.”

Glimmer sighed. “Potentially dangerous crack it is, then! Let’s go!”

The opening was wider than it first appeared, but still seemed too narrow for the beasts to get through, so the three ducked inside. Glimmer lit up the end of her staff, illuminating what almost looked like a small, rough-hewn antechamber. Adora immediately began exploring the area and found another, narrower passage at the back of the room.

Bow leaned against the wall, catching his breath. “Hey, you know what? I think I hate the Crimson Wastes.” Noticing Adora’s peering down the new passage, he called back. “You find something?”

“This looks like could be part of a bigger structure.” Adora said, calling back over her shoulder. “We uh, we might want to check it out.”

“You don’t think we’re in something’s home, do you?” Glimmer asked, clearly concerned.

“Only one way to find out!” Bow said, moving to the back of the chamber to join Adora. “Come on, Glimmer!”

The passage wound on a downward slope, and the air took on a cool, earthy smell. After a few minutes of marching, the passage widened to allow Glimmer to walk side-by-side with Bow. The light from her staff cast Adora’s shadow in front of her, which Adora

knew would most likely alert anyone she was coming, but it was not as if she could see in the dark.

"How far do you think this goes?" Bow whispered.

"I don't know." Adora said, frowning. "You think we should go back?"

"We know what's behind us." Glimmer said. "And honestly, it's nice to be out of the sun. Might as well keep going. If this doesn't open up into a place suitable for a camp soon, we can always turn back."

They continued on. The sound of dripping water echoed around them, and Adora quickened her pace. She began to feel like she was being drawn forward - there was something calling her and she had to find it. Something important. The passage opened up into a gigantic chamber next to a vast underground lake. The light from Glimmer's staff was caught and reflected by numerous crystals in the rock face, creating a dazzling effect. The three stood in silence for a moment, briefly awed by the scene.

"Well," Glimmer finally said, "that's certainly something I've never seen before."

Adora felt an odd sort of familiarity. She shook her head, stopped walking, tried to clear her mind. There was something here, something she needed to see. Glimmer looked over at Adora, worry crossing her features.

"Adora? You okay?"

"Huh? Yeah, I'm… I'm fine." Adora said, then in a softer tone muttered, "Have I been here before?"

Release me.

"What?"

Only you can release me, Eternian.

“Eternian?”

You hold the key and lock. You hold the power. Release me! Etheria is in danger!

“I know, the Horde is-”

There are greater threats than the Horde, child. Now, quickly! The sword! You must-

“Yes.” Adora drew the Sword of Protection and drove it into the rocky floor. The cavern shook and the lake surface began roiling as something began to raise from the depths. A blue glow shot through the cavern floor, and Adora heard Bow and Glimmer yelling as if from a great distance.

A platform emerged from the lake. On the platform was a forge with a heavily runed anvil, and Adora had a sudden vision of a massive forgemaster, broad shouldered and wearing the mark of the First Ones on his clothing hammered what Adora recognized instantly as the Sword of Protection. A voice was speaking to someone, as if giving a tour.

“Based on our research, the goddess is part of the planet’s own natural magical force. No runestone is required for her to manifest, although we predict the sword will provide complete control over her manifestation.”

“Do you believe, cousin, that she will agree to such an arrangement?”

“Why do you not believe she will turn down this great gift of friendship we offer? You worry over nothing. She will accept the gift, and aid us in coming one step closer to completion of the Heart.”

A stone caught Adora’s foot, and she stumbled forward. Her hand shot out and caught the anvil to steady herself. There was a flash of brilliant golden light, and Adora went flying backwards,

impacting off the ground with a painful grunt. She sat up dazedly as Glimmer and Bow sprinted toward her.

“Adora! Are you okay? What the hell was that?”

Adora looked around in confusion. “I… I don’t know. This place - I think this is where they made the Sword of Protection.”

Bow’s voice could still, on occasion, crack when he was particularly surprised or taken aback. It did so now. “What? Who made the sword?”

Standing a little shakily, Adora began to slowly piece through everything she’d seen. “The First Ones, I think. They created the Sword to give its wielder more control over She-Ra’s powers, but… it seems like it isn’t actually needed in order for the transformation.”

“That doesn’t make any sense.” Glimmer broke in, sounding equally confused. “No Princess is able to transform without a runestone, and the sword contains your runestone. If you didn’t have a runestone, you shouldn’t be able to transform.”

Adora wasn’t entirely sure herself. Something had felt off about the entire conversation. The First Ones hadn’t told She-Ra something. The way they’d said ‘control’ had sent a chill down her spine, even though on some level it made perfect sense to give someone more control over their powers, make it easier to help those who needed help. Something deep down made her doubt the First Ones had been so generous in their intentions.

“They said she didn’t need a runestone.” Adora replied, still sounding a little dazed. “She was… she begged me to free her. The Sword… I need to…”

Bow shot Glimmer a look. “Hey, you sure you didn’t hit your head? You look a little dazed. Why don’t we make camp and you let your pal Bow take a look at you to make sure everything’s okay, Sound good?”

“Okay, yeah.” Adora nodded, and allowed Bow to support her as they moved away from the lake’s edge. Glimmer moved to retrieve the sword, but Adora’s shout stopped her. “No! Leave it there! It’s powering this place, I think.” Also, some part of her wanted to leave it there forever - some instinct was deeply on edge and wanted to run from this place, but she knew she needed to be here, *needed* to understand. There was a low level buzz in the back of her mind and she felt like she was *this* close to understanding everything. The buzz faded as they moved away from the forge, giving Adora more time to think. She leaned against a wall and slid down into a sitting position.

Glimmer crouched next to Adora, looking deeply concerned. “Are you sure you’re okay? You were in some kind of trance, and then that thing sent you flying.”

“I’m not sure. Something about this place seems like it’s…” Adora searched for the right word and came up empty. “I don’t know. There’s something here I need to understand, but I don’t know *what* .”

“This can’t be a First Ones structure.” Bow said, sounding puzzled. “The scanner’s not picking anything up.”

Glimmer hummed. “You think if we sent a picture of this to your dads they might recognize it? What if this is related to Halfmoon somehow?”

“Did Halfmoon have this kind of technology?” Bow wondered out loud.

Your friend from Halfmoon can help , Adora thought. She opened her mouth to reply, but another voice cut her off.

“Once, we had much more than this.” A variety of feline forms suddenly stepped out of the shadows and a semi-circle of spears pointed in the trio’s direction. A broad shouldered magicat with bright golden eyes stepped forward into the semicircle. “Now we

protect its secrets. Secrets which you will find dearly bought, I fear."

"Hey, Adora?" Glimmer said. "I *really* fucking hate the Crimson Wastes."

Chapter End Notes

Man, *quarantine*, huh? Turns out it has severely crippled my writing process, mostly because I used to do all my plotting in the gym, and the gym is closed. So that's why the long silence (well, that and an off-hand comment made while watching someone play a Nancy Drew game led to, well, it's under my published works if you're curious). Turns out when you sit on the couch all day working, you don't enjoy sitting on the couch writing as much! I also super-fucked up my knee so I couldn't even get out and run for like two and a half weeks or something (time is hard to keep track of these days), and if you don't believe that exercise is good for the brain, well, I finally got out for a run again and the rest of this chapter fell into place. Take care of yourselves is what I'm saying.

Also, thanks for your patience as I run down various rabbit holes chasing ideas unrelated to this, thanks for commenting, thanks for the kudos, thanks for making this thing reach over 20k hits which is *fucking bananas*, and thanks most of all for telling your friends about this absolute nonsense. Next chapter we'll see how Catra and the kids are doing, hmm?

As for what exactly our heroes have stumbled into, and who this fellow is, well... you can either wait and find out, or you can read the next sentence which will, depending on what Metal Gear Solid games you know the plot of, make things a little more clear.

Big Boss, after all, did end up helping Sandanistas, didn't he?

EDIT: Oh god we are dangerously close to 100k words. How the hell did I get here?

Breaks and Repairs

Chapter Summary

> C'yra and Mara start training. Catra makes a judgment call and remembers some things. Scorpia helps out as best as she can.

Chapter Notes

> Just a heads up, there's some references to self harm in this one so tread with caution, should caution be required for you.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“Hey Commander, you got a minute?”

Catra looked up from a report detailing the Horde’s latest expected troop movements and was surprised to see Aethina standing at the door with a somewhat nervous expression. “Of course, soldier. What can I do for you?”

“It’s about your uh…” Aethina fumbled around for the right wording, before settling on “that is, the uh... children.”

“Soldier,” Catra said, in a tone that was half warning, half reassurance, “if something’s happened to them I need you to let me know now.”

“Oh no, no, they’re uh… they’re fine! It’s just that…”

Catra could feel her patience beginning to evaporate. “Spit it out, Aethina.”

“Well, we were wondering if you could maybe talk to them about going a little easier on the other trainees in combat training.”

Catra snorted. “Giving some of the recruits trouble?” she shook her head and chuckled. “It’ll motivate the others to try harder.”

“Commander, they’ve broken three recruits’ arms.” Aethina said, a little stung by Catra’s apparent amusement.

That brought Catra up short. “Each?”

“No, just between the two of them.”

“Let me guess,” Catra said, sighing, “Mara’s the one who broke *two* , and at least one of them got a hit in on C’yra.”

“How did you-?”

“She had my upbringing.” Catra cut Aethina off, a little more curtly than she intended. She sighed again and composed herself. “Send them both here, I’ll speak with them.”

“Oh good! I uh, they’re already here.”

Catra laughed. She couldn’t help it. “Okay then, send them in, soldier. Dismissed.”

Aethina saluted and left with the air of someone who had just been told they would not have to stand in front of a gun after all. A few seconds later the door to Catra’s office opened again and a guilty looking C’yra entered, followed by a defiant Mara. Catra felt a wave of familiarity. How many times had it been her with the defiant look? A defiance which only ever invited pain, but for Catra it had been necessary - a way to struggle against the system in which she’d found herself, stuck under an authority figure who reminded her, constantly, that she was nothing and would only ever be nothing. She took a deep breath and banished the thought from her mind.

C’yra seemed to take this as a sign that a lecture was forthcoming, and spoke up quickly. “It’s my fault, Commander. I provoked the attack and Mara was just-”

Mara cut her off. “They were ganging up on her, I had to-”

Catra held her hand up, forestalling further comment. “You aren’t in trouble.”

That brought them both up short. C’yra seemed to relax, and sent a relieved look in Mara’s direction. Mara seemed confused, and then immediately suspicious that there was another shoe about to drop. Or, if Catra’s experiences were any indication, another shoe waiting to kick her in the ribs. C’yra noticed it immediately, of course, and tension returned to her posture even as she put a reassuring hand on Mara’s shoulder and squeezed.

“Okay.” Catra said. “Now that we’ve established nobody’s in trouble, I need you to tell me exactly what happened. Mara?”

Mara seemed surprised to be asked. C’yra, apparently, was the designated spokesman for the duo - which was precisely why Catra didn’t want to ask her. Mara, Catra thought, needed to be able to stand on her own. Needed to know that she was not just C’yra’s lackey. She watched C’yra closely to see whether or not the girl would encourage her friend or jump in.

“It…” Mara started, and then, in a move that made Catra inwardly relieved, C’yra gave Mara’s shoulder another reassuring squeeze. “We were in a group combat training. Two teams of four. Command- that is, C’yra, was on my team and we elected to keep the opposition’s attention while our other two teammates waited for an opening. It was… not the best plan. C’yra and I were overwhelmed, and,” she swallowed, mastered herself, continued, “it was like our training used to be, suddenly. C’yra took the first one down, but that brought the other three down on her and I… reacted accordingly.”

“Your old training?” Catra asked, fingers unconsciously tightening their grip on the pen she’d been using. “You were regularly placed in unequal engagements?”

“The enemy will prioritize extermination of the Commander.” Mara said, like she was reciting something from memory. “To overcome the blood of the Betrayer in me, I must protect the Commander at

all costs, including the loss of my own life. Failure to defend the Commander results in…" her voice became even quieter. "Severe punishment."

Distress was etched across C'yra's features. "You never said-"

"You weren't supposed to *know* ." Mara said, whirling around, agitated. "You already worry about me too much and I knew-"

Catra felt her heart breaking, and a fresh jolt of rage shot through her that she tamped down. Anger would not help this situation. There would be time, later, to unleash her fury about what had been done to the two children in front of her. For now, she stood and walked around her desk. Crouching down in front of the two, she very slowly, very carefully placed a hand on each of their shoulders. "I promise, you're not in trouble. If anything I owe you both an apology for not realizing what this might have done to you sooner."

C'yra immediately protested. "Commander, no, we're perfectly capable, you don't have to-"

"Yes, I do. You both have been through more than most soldiers, and I didn't take that into consideration. I'll talk with the trainers, let them know you're going to take a few days off - yes," she said, cutting off the protest that C'yra was getting ready to mount, "I know, I said you aren't in trouble but I'm pulling you out of physical training. That's because I think I'll train you myself for a few days. You can break my arm instead of some recruit's."

"It was an accident!" C'yra protested again.

"That was a joke, kid." Catra said. "Now, the only thing I *do* want you to do is visit those recruits in the med bay, see how they're doing." She paused, thought how ridiculous what she'd just said sounded, and pressed on. "It lets them know there's nothing, you know, personal about what happened."

"We already apologized!" Mara protested.

“I’m sure you did,” Catra replied, “but checking in on them reinforces that you’re really sorry. Sometimes... “ she rubbed her chin, looking for the right words. “Sometimes you need to apologize more than once. Some things require a little more. Breaking bones falls under that category, even if it was an accident.” She thought, suddenly, of the numerous villages she’d helped the Horde raze to the ground. Would anyone ever forgive her? Would it ever be possible that the Alliance would leave her in peace, if they knew where she was? Could she ever make up for all she’d done? *Best not to go there* , she thought. *You’ll make amends by ending this war.*

C’yra nodded in understanding, but Mara still seemed a little annoyed. “Yes, Commander.” C’yra said. “We’ll go check in on them.”

“Good.” Catra said, standing up. “Can you give me and Mara a moment alone, C’yra? There’s one more thing we need to discuss in private.”

Mara stiffened further, and there was a flash of fear in her eyes. C’yra took an aggressive step forward, and Catra saw a familiar look of protectiveness in the girl’s eyes. “If you hurt her, I’ll kill you.”

“You have my word.” Catra said, solemnly. “I will never harm you or Mara. Ever.”

With one last worried look at Mara, C’yra left. Mara took an immediately defensive posture as soon as the door closed, and was so clearly bracing herself for a blow that Catra felt the need to back up immediately. “Hey, I said I wasn’t going to hurt you, and I meant it.”

“That’s what they always told C’yra to get her to leave.” Mara said.

“And you never told her they broke their word every time.” Catra said, quietly. A cold feeling in her gut grew as her own memories filled in the details. “Because you deserved it, right? And she

never should have bothered with you in the first place, because you weren't worth it, so why tell her?"

Mara nodded, still bracing for a blow that was never going to come.

"Mara, look at me." Catra said, crouching down again. When Mara met her eyes, Catra continued, keeping her voice soft. "I know you might not believe me, but the ones who told you how worthless you were? They were so, so wrong. You are worth more than you know."

"But it's *true* ." Mara said, sounding broken. "I… I lost control and hurt those people, because I'm just a waste of potential, and I always will be."

"Given everything that you've been through, your reaction made complete sense." Catra said, firmly. "And trust me, if you were a waste of potential, you wouldn't feel bad about what you'd done. You wouldn't want to be *better* . But you do, and you can be. I'll help you, if you want."

"Why?" Mara asked. "Why help me?"

"Because," Catra said patiently, "you need help, and you deserve help, and you are *worth helping* ."

"I'm not-"

"You *are* ." Catra said, firmly. "If you don't believe me, believe C'yra. She thinks you're worth a whole hell of a lot."

"That's just because she's my Commander." Mara said, frowning like Adora did whenever she was being stubborn about something.

"No," Catra said, with a smile, "she's your *friend* . I saw the look on her face when I sent her out. I'd bet you anything that she's on the other side of that office door ready to break it down the second you call for her. You know she's your friend, you just… you just have trouble believing it could be true because it doesn't

square with what Shadow Weaver told you - and you can't help but believe Shadow Weaver still, a little, because she raised you, and after all you *did* break those recruits' arms."

"How can you know that for sure?" Mara said, staring at Catra now with something like surprise. "How do you know what Shadow Weaver told me?"

"Because that's what Shadow Weaver told *me* my whole life." Catra said. "It's hard to shake. I can't promise, in fact, that you'll ever shake it completely. But - you're not alone, Mara. When you start doubting yourself - when you can hear Shadow Weaver's voice telling you how worthless you are - you can come to me, or you can talk to Scorpia about it, or, if you like, I can find someone else for you to talk to. But don't be afraid to ask us for help, alright? I know how hard it can be."

Unexpectedly, Mara surged forward and hugged Catra fiercely. "I'm sorry." she sobbed. "I'm sorry that I… that I caused so much trouble, and that you have to-"

Catra stroked her hair soothingly and hushed her. "It's okay, Mara. I'm here. C'yra's here. We'll all help you, okay? You're not alone."

That seemed to make Mara cry even harder, and Catra held her quietly through it as Mara let herself finally let go of everything she'd been holding in for who knew how long. She was just a kid, Catra thought. Just a terrified, traumatized kid who had somehow managed to survive hell with the help of her friend, and now she was realizing she was safe.

Catra crouched there, soothing Mara, for who knew how long. Eventually, Mara seemed to recover a bit. "There's one more thing I want to offer you, Mara." Catra said. "You mentioned you lost control and hurt those recruits. I can help you with control, if you want. I don't know if it'll work for you like it's worked for me, but it might help prevent a repeat of today."

"I… I'd like that." Mara said, after a pause. "Could you do the same for C'yra? She… she froze up. That's how they got her. It was like she thought she was back in the Fright Zone."

Catra nodded. Of course both of them would have flashbacks. They probably had the same kinds of nightmares she did. "I can work with her too. One thing though - they would be separate sessions. I know you two are close, but you need to be able to do this on your own. Deal?"

Mara nodded. "Deal."

"Okay." Catra said, giving Mara a squeeze and touseling her hair a little. "Go check up on those recruits. You can tell C'yra everything we talked about here, if you want - but I won't say a word to anyone unless you ask me to, alright?"

Mara nodded again. "Okay."

Catra opened the door and, just as she'd predicted, C'yra was indeed standing directly in front of the door waiting for them. Mara's eyes widened a little in surprise and then she smiled. "It's okay, C'yra. Thanks for waiting."

C'yra noticed the red eyes and tear stains immediately. "Are you okay?"

"Yeah, I'm fine." Mara replied, still smiling. There was a shift in her posture, like she was more relaxed than she'd been all day. "I'll tell you all about it later - but we should go to the infirmary like Catra said first."

Catra smiled. "I'll see you both tomorrow morning. Meet me here when you'd usually go to the training grounds, got it?"

"Yes ma'am." C'yra said, snapping off a salute.

Mara rolled her eyes. "She's not our *Commander* , C'yra. She said you can call her Catra."

The two children made their way down the hallway, and Catra watched them until they rounded the corner in the direction of the infirmary. Then, she went back into her office and closed the door. After a moment's thought, she grabbed the radio and called Scorpia.

"Hey Commander! What can I do for you?"

"You got a minute to talk, Scorp? It's uh, about our guests."

"Be right there, Commander."

"Great." Catra replied, and began doing her best to compose herself. The whole interaction had set loose feelings and memories she'd dealt with already, kept locked away for her own sanity's sake. Memories of the beatings, the constant excuses she'd given to Adora because if Adora knew, she'd try to stop it and cause more trouble and Catra wasn't worth it, wasn't worth the trouble. Even as she insisted to herself she wasn't worth it she resented Adora for doing nothing, resented her for being so blind, for being the *favorite* , until the poisonous hatred beaten into her bones nearly choked her to death.

It had been Scorpia who had chanced upon her one night. A night where Catra had been so overwhelmed by everything she'd done something drastic. She'd attempted escape. Scorpia had acted swiftly - had both kept Catra alive and provided a cover story. The Commander had been attacked by a Rebellion Assassin, the story went, and had fought them off. The Fright Zone had gone on high alert, had unfortunately never captured the assassin in question. It was flimsy at best, but shortly after the incident the Commander of the Horde had begun implementing changes to the way the Horde military force operated, and everyone seemed to consider this assassin's attack as the beginning of the rise of the Commander's legend. It was, Catra thought, purely a happy accident that the tank explosion had scarred her so badly as to obscure the scars of that night - thus far, Adora did not know the particulars, because there was no way to see them clearly anymore, and she'd respected Catra's reluctance to talk about just

how dark things had gotten in those first few years after Adora's defection.

That might have sent Catra's thoughts down a different direction that was equally unpleasant - the one where she became convinced she didn't deserve Adora and thought about how she would inevitably fuck up everything - but Scorpia chose that moment to arrive. She took one look at Catra and asked, "What happened?"

"They broke three recruits' arms."

"Each?"

"No, C'yra broke one, Mara broke two." Catra sighed. "I'm not completely sure, but I think they had a uh, like a flashback. Mara in particular. She uh… had a similar training program to mine. Or the exact same one. I can't say for sure."

Scorpia's eyes widened as she realized what Catra meant. "They were doing group combat today. That's what triggered it, right?"

Catra nodded. "I'm going to train them myself for a few days. Teach them how to manage those attacks. At least get them pointed in the right direction until we can find someone on staff with a little more experience treating this kind of thing."

"I'll ask Rogelio if he knows anyone." Scorpia replied, and hesitated before she continued. "What about you, Commander? You look a little shaken. Er, if you don't mind me saying so."

"No, you're right." Catra sighed. "I talked with Mara in private. She's been keeping the extent of what she went through from C'yra - like I did with Adora. Same reason, too. She didn't - doesn't - believe that she's worth C'yra's care. I see so much of myself in her, Scorpia. She didn't deserve it."

There was concern in Scorpia's voice. "You know you didn't either, right Commander?"

Catra exhaled slowly. “Yeah, I know. Whether or not I *believe* it… that depends on the day, I guess.”

Scorpia snorted and walked around the desk to put her claws on Catra’s shoulders. “Commander, not to put too fine a point on it, but not only have you built a formidable mercenary company that is *still growing* , but you also happen to have caught the eye of She-Ra, who has - if what Entrapta tells me is true - been *quite* vocally affectionate with you. That’s not nothing.”

Catra grinned and pulled Scorpia into a hug. “No, I suppose it isn’t. Thanks, Scorpia. I… well, you know.”

“Yeah, Commander. I know.” Scorpia patted Catra’s back.

A thought suddenly struck Catra, and she pulled back. “Er, when Entrapta said ‘vocally affectionate,’ did she uh…”

Scorpia laughed. “You don’t *really* want me to answer that, do you Commander?”

Chapter End Notes

> Looks like I had one more chapter left in me before Season 5 comes along to wreck my shit (don't worry, She-Ra ending won't end my interest in finishing this story. Shit, I still write *Daria* fanfic and that ain't been on air for over a decade).
>
> I apologize for how heavy things get in this one. Catra's still a work in progress (aren't we all), and the kids, well, they need a chance to heal. They'll get there eventually. Also we'll get chapters where they aren't reliving some hellish thing that happened to them. Promise.
>
> Thanks for reading, commenting, and doubtless telling everyone you know how rad this fic is. See you guys on the other side of season five - when we'll get back to the Crimson Wastes!

A Queen without a Kingdom

Chapter Summary

Glimmer practices more diplomacy. Adora learns the truth and makes a decision. The Lost Army of Halfmoon appears.

She-Ra is unleashed.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Bow's voice echoed a little too loudly in the cave. "Should we just run? We should run."

"That," the lead magicat said, "would be an exceedingly bad idea. Even though you, Princess Glimmer, do possess the power of teleportation - if the reports are true."

"They are." Glimmer said, her chin held high. "If you know who I am, then you know that holding me captive would be regarded as an attack on the Alliance."

"If we were worried about what the Alliance thought of us, you would have known we existed." the lead replied, a smile on his face carrying a slight threat. "You, however, have not ever bothered with the matters of the Crimson Wastes, and that's been fine with us."

"They're *wastes* ." Glimmer replied, as if it was obvious. "The Horde doesn't come here, so… we didn't either."

"Tell me Princess," and there was *definitely* amusement in the magicat's voice now, "do they teach you the history of the wastes in Brightmoon?"

Bow piped up. "The Crimson Wastes were once the magicat kingdom of Halfmoon, which was destroyed in an unknown

cataclysm a thousand years ago, if not more. In the aftermath, it is generally accepted that magicat society collapsed and the refugees were folded into the various other kingdoms on Etheria." At the surprised looks on Glimmer and Adora's faces, he seemed nonplussed. "What? You've met my dads."

"Impressive!" The lead magicat said, applauding. "Doubtless accurate, as far as anyone's aware - although there is more to the story than your histories say, of course." He gave Adora a significant look before continuing. "The cause of the cataclysm, for example."

"She-Ra." Adora said, her eyes wide. "It was… it was She-Ra. She caused it, didn't she?"

The magicat snorted. "Don't be ridiculous, child. You name a player in a larger tragedy, but the author of it…" he trailed off and sniffed the air.

"Who?" Adora asked, almost pleading. "Who caused it?"

The response came quick and curt. "Such topics are not for here - and they are not for strangers, even those carrying ancient artifacts and Princesses of rebellions. You must first be judged. Come!"

He strode off, and the other magicats accompanying him formed a path of spears to corral the three intruders. Glimmer looked sideways at Adora and Bow and raised an eyebrow significantly. Adora shook her head slightly, and Glimmer nodded in response. They fell into step behind the leader.

"Um, excuse me, uh…" Adora started to say, but was cut off.

"Fel'cath." the magicat said. "I am called Fel'cath."

"Fel'cath." Adora said, nodding. "What of m-the sword?"

"The Sword," Fel'cath said, and there was something in his tone like shame, or disgust, "will remain here under guard. Do not

worry - we will not touch it."

It was surprisingly easy for Adora to agree to this arrangement. "Lead on." Glimmer looked nervous, but Adora put a hand on her shoulder and spoke low. "Don't worry, I don't think they mean us harm. I think… I think this is what Razz was trying to tell me to find."

"Alright, I trust you." Glimmer whispered back. "But I've got enough juice left for a couple longer jumps if it comes to it."

"Let's hope it doesn't." Fel'cath said, a smile evident in his voice.

"Right. Big ears." Glimmer grumbled. "Of course."

"One of our many useful qualities." Fel'cath called back. He was *definitely* amused now. "Come along, young ones."

The passage Fel'cath led them to was narrow enough that they were forced to walk single file. A part of Adora's brain suggested it was foolish for Fel'cath to have his back to what were in theory prisoners who had not been restrained in any way - but that was either because he didn't consider them a threat (which was a mistake) or he trusted them (which was *also* a mistake, except that Adora was burning with curiosity to know more about the magicats and Halfmoon, and would have stopped Bow or Glimmer if they'd tried anything (had Fel'cath guessed that? Had Adora been so nakedly obvious in her desire to *know?* Did he know who she was? He must have known. Mustn't he?)).

They walked for what felt like an hour, although Adora couldn't be sure. Her brain was whirling with questions, and the dim light of the tunnel gave everything an almost dreamlike effect. Eventually the passage terminated into an enormous and ornate door. Fel'cath rapped out a complex pattern on the door and it swung open, revealing an immense underground hall. The hall was full of crates of what Adora assumed were supplies, and she felt her blood run cold as she noticed the familiar sign of the Horde

stamped on some of them. Fel'cath noticed her discomfort immediately.

"Fear not, young one. We do not deal with the Horde, but… their supplies do fall into our hands now and again."

Glimmer frowned. "As do supplies from the Alliance, I see."

Fel'cath shrugged, as if to say *well, yes.* "Perhaps we shall give you a tour later, depending on your fate."

Bow swallowed nervously. "I don't like the way that sounds at all."

Adora held her head high, a feeling of defiance building in her chest. "Don't worry Bow." she said, not caring who else could hear her. "If we have to fight our way out of here we will."

Something that looked like a command tent stood at the back of the hall. The setup resembled the forward operating camp of an army on the move more than a kingdom, Adora thought. Fel'cath strode into the tent and motioned for the group to follow. Another magicat - female, broad shouldered and with piercing blue eyes looked over the group as they entered. She wore no obvious adornment, but Adora knew instinctively this was who would judge them. Her voice was deep and carried an unmistakable power that reminded Adora deeply and uncomfortably of Shadow Weaver, if Shadow Weaver were a musclebound magicat wearing combat fatigues instead of a horrifyingly withered, abusive sorceress.

"Fel'cath. I see you've brought guests."

"Commander Dha'ra. We found these three in the Forge. They appear to have activated it."

Dha'ra looked over them with interest. "Activated the Forge, did they? So the sword is *here* , is it?"

"We left it in the Forge, Commander. It seems to be powering the area."

“And, of course,” Dha’ra said, glancing over the three prisoners, “you thought it best to separate She-Ra from the weapon. A prudent decision. It is… difficult to know who to trust these days, even protectresses of legend.”

“ *Protectresses of legend* ,” Fel’cath said, with a grim expression on his face, “can be misled.”

“We are enemies of the Horde and representatives of the Princess Alliance and greater Etherian Rebellion.” Glimmer said, drawing herself up imperiously. “Those who stand against the Horde would do well not to hinder us.”

“Ah yes, the Princess Alliance.” Dhar’ra’s expression was a blend of annoyance and amusement. “It is a shame your Alliance has never seen fit to seek or offer aid to those in the Crimson Wastes, we may have given even the slightest of shits about who you are.”

Adora decided she liked Dhar’ra in that moment. Glimmer, to her credit, was not taken aback by the response. “The Crimson Waste has long been considered a lawless wasteland, and the only reports that reached us were of bandits attacking our convoys.” she replied coolly. “Clearly the full scope of the situation here was never given to us.”

“Or you did not care to listen.” Dhar’ra replied, a little acidly.

Glimmer nodded in agreement. “Or we did not care to listen. It is increasingly clear to me that much I thought was true is not.” *That* caught Adora off guard, and she turned to consider her friend more closely. Glimmer knew something - or suspected something, at any rate. “For example,” Glimmer continued, “the royal line of Halfmoon was thought to be severed. Clearly, that was untrue, your majesty.”

“Queens,” Dhar’ra said with a laugh, “require kingdoms, and no magicat has had a kingdom since the days of Queen C’yra. But we are once again getting ahead of ourselves, are we not? You tread where it is forbidden to tread, princess. How did you come here,

and why? Speak quickly and truthfully, lest our judgment become harsh."

"We came at the request of my friend here," Glimmer said, gesturing in Adora's direction, "who sought to better understand the region's history. I suspect.." she looked over at Adora briefly, "there is some connection between She-Ra and Halfmoon. Unfortunately, my kingdom's records are damaged and incomplete."

"Ah yes," Dhar'ra said dryly, "my own kingdom's records have also suffered some *damage* . Fortunately for you, the stories of She-Ra and Halfmoon survived. It does not surprise me that Brightmoon did not see fit to preserve them."

There's old anger there, and bitterness, and Adora could hear and see it clear as day. "Then please," she said, breaking into the conversation, "help us to bring these stories to light. Help us rebuild what once existed between the two kingdoms."

Dhar'ra turned her gaze on Adora, so piercing as to see right through her. "Seeking to heal the wrongs of the past, young one?" She hummed thoughtfully to herself, and then her face hardened again. "You say your kingdom's knowledge was lost. How, then, did you find and activate the Forge?"

"As difficult as it may be to believe, your majesty-"

"I am not a queen, princess - just a commander."

Commander of what? Adora thought, but kept quiet.

"Commander, then. We discovered the Forge by chance. We were fleeing pursuit from two massive beasts, and sought shelter in a cave along the cliffside. Adora discovered a narrow passage that led us to the Forge."

Adora spoke up again. "Activating the Forge was my doing, Commander. Forgive me, I was… drawn there, I think. Someone

told me to activate the Forge and I… I just *knew* how to do it. They called me… Eternian."

"What else did this voice say?" Dhar'ra asked, leaning forward. Her expression grew hard.

Adora felt compelled to answer. "It.. it begged me to free it. Said there were greater threats than the Horde. Said I had the key and the lock, and I could release them."

"So…" Dhar'ra said, seemingly to herself, "something's given her back some semblance of control. Curious. Most curious indeed."

"You know something then?" Adora felt another lurch in her gut, and was once again unable to keep the nakedly pleading tone out of her voice. She was so close to an answer, the long dormant desire to know her history roaring back with a vengeance so strong it nearly brought her to her knees. "Please, I have to know! Why am I having these visions? What's a bigger threat than the Horde?" she felt a sob escape her. "Who *am* I?"

A soft hand on her shoulder brought her back to reality. Dhar'ra was looking at her with a pitying expression. "I cannot answer all these questions, young one." Adora's shoulders slumped, and Dhar'ra smiled. "But I can answer some of them. In return, perhaps you will be able to help us."

"Agreed." Glimmer said. "I would consider it an honor to begin repairing the relationship that once existed between our kingdoms."

"You may reconsider that offer," Dhar'ra said, and there was another flash of some long-simmering resentment, "when you learn the exact nature of what our 'relationship' once was, Princess Glimmer. Nevertheless, I accept your offer in the spirit with which it was given. The Lost Army of Halfmoon welcomes you to our encampment."

Encampment was the right word for it, as it turned out. There were several shelters erected to provide a place for the magicats

to sleep, and there were a number of other tents which Adora identified as being an infirmary, a mess tent, and a few other tents with purposes she couldn't immediately see. Dhar'ra led them to one such tent and ushered them inside. She spoke quietly to a soldier standing guard, who saluted and headed off in the direction of the mess. When they'd filed in and had a seat, Dhar'ra began speaking almost immediately.

"I apologize for not being able to go into much detail - time is not a luxury I think we have, at the moment, and there are others with greater knowledge of the history of Halfmoon than I. Fortunately, however, the story of She-Ra and the Magicats is one which every child knows."

"Were they allies?" Adora asked, curious.

"Allies, then enemies, then allies once more." Dhar'ra replied. "She-Ra is - as you've no doubt been made aware - the Protector of Etheria. A goddess, with the power to heal and defend the planet. For thousands of years, she served as peacekeeper among the nations of Etheria, aided by the princesses of the kingdoms. Then, the First Ones arrived. Or more accurately, the *Eternians* arrived. The First Ones nonsense came later."

"Eternian?" Adora said. "The voice… it called me Eternian."

"That," said Dhar'ra, "is because you *are* an Eternian. You would not be able to wield the Sword of Protection otherwise."

"What do you mean 'arrived?'" Glimmer asked. "From where?"

"From the stars." Dhar'ra said, shrugging. "There were, apparently, once more than moons and the sun in the sky. There were other worlds, each with their own sun, across vast distances we can't conceive. These distant suns were called stars, and it was from one such star, in great ships of metal built to voyage between worlds, that the Eternians came."

"I'm… I'm from *another world?* " Adora felt like she might be sick. "How did I… How did I get here?"

“Does it matter?” Dhar’ra asked. “You are here now, and if your present company is any indication, you have become quite involved in the matters of Etheria. And before you ask how I could *possibly* know for certain you are an Eternian, well, I shall ask you a simple question: Are you She-Ra?”

“Yes.”

“Then you are Eternian. Only an Eternian could become She-Ra and wield the Sword of Protection. That is when the magicats and She-Ra became enemies. We agreed to aid the Eternians in developing a weapon fit for She-Ra. They claimed it would help her. What it did was control her, and bind the power of an Etherian princess to Eternian blood.” Dhar’ra shook her head in sorrow. “It is my people’s great shame to have contributed to such an injustice.”

“Why did the Eternians want control of She-Ra?” Glimmer asked.

“They feared something. Some threat that She-Ra had driven from Etheria in the distant past had driven Eternia from their home. They came seeking aid, but when they realized the nature of Etheria itself, they decided to control the planet and use its powers to eliminate their enemy.”

“And to do that,” Bow spoke up for the first time, “they needed control of She-Ra?”

“No one chosen by She-Ra would have allowed the use of such a weapon.” Dhar’ra replied, and then smiled. “Not even the chosen Eternian, when the time came - although they thought to build a failsafe. Before that, however, came the insurgency.”

Her eyes seemed to glow as she continued. “When the people of Halfmoon realized what the Eternians sought to accomplish - what we’d *helped* them accomplish, we sought to stop it. We couldn’t do it openly, because the First Ones had outmaneuvered us politically, Our kingdom was powerful, but we would not have been able to withstand the power of the rest of Etheria. So we

turned to espionage. Small teams, no more than four strong, performed acts of sabotage on Eternian facilities. We hindered their Heart of Etheria project whenever and wherever we could. Unfortunately, it wasn't enough - and She-Ra was constantly on our trail. If not for her interference, who knows what might have happened?"

"Eventually, we decided that we had to convince She-Ra she was being misled. Queen C'yra led a mission which was intended to draw her out. When She-Ra appeared, the Queen convinced her to listen."

"How'd she do that?" Adora asked, curious.

"Fought her to a standstill." Dhar'ra said. "The greatest battle anyone had ever seen. The two were great friends after that. As soon as She-Ra saw what the Eternians - what her people - were planning, she sought to stop it. Alas! It was too late. The Eternians played their final trump card and took away She-Ra's will. She fired the Heart, but not before sealing Etheria off."

Bow broke in again, unable to contain his curiosity. "But what is it? What does it do?"

"The planet itself becomes a weapon." Dhar'ra explained. "It uses the connection princesses have with their runestones to focus the magical lifeforce of the planet and detonate it in a massive wave. The wave rushes through space, destroying everything in its path. She-Ra - Mara - managed to pull Etheria into a pocket dimension. When the Heart fired, it fired into nothingness. Unfortunately, Mara had to be airborne to open the portal. The blast knocked her ship out of the sky, and she crashed into the forest of Halfmoon."

"And when her ship crashed, it formed the Crimson Wastes." Adora finished. "Gods, I… I'm so sorry."

"We knew the risk of our rebellion." Dhar'ra said, proudly. "The majority of the kingdom's inhabitants fled the wreck of Halfmoon, became nomads, scattered to the four winds. The Queen's family

and her guard remained. We went underground, swearing to protect the Forge and the Heart. Thus we've done for generations. Now the Horde has started showing up more frequently, and we've been fighting them. When the Alliance has deigned to enter our territory, we've done our best to make them unwelcome as well. You three are the first to see these caverns in a very long time - and if not for the fact that you brought the Sword with you and activated the Forge, you would remain our prisoner. However…" her attention turned to Adora now. "You wished to know the answer to many questions. The voice you've been hearing is She-Ra. To free her, you must destroy the Sword. I do not know how you came to be here, but I can tell you this: around the time Hordak appeared on Etheria, we detected an energy spike centered around the Crystal Castle."

Adora's hands were in fists. "Light Hope." she said, and there was venom in her voice. "Light Hope brought me here."

Dhar'ra shrugged. "It's possible."

"Wait, did you say *destroy the Sword?* " Glimmer broke in suddenly. "But the Sword is the source of She-Ra's power! It's how Adora *becomes She-Ra!* "

"Were you not listening?" Dhar'ra replied, patiently. "She-Ra is not the sword. The sword just made her easier to control. I cannot promise you will be able to control her as you once did, but… her strength will remain yours. I will also say this: should you destroy the Sword, it will not end the threat the Heart poses. She-Ra's power could still be used to fire the Heart, in theory."

"But I would have to choose to do so, right?" Adora asked. "I'd be in control?"

"The mechanisms of the Eternians would not be able to force activation of the Heart, but She-Ra was not meant to be *controlled* , child. She will lend her aid, work with you, fight for you - but you cannot force her. It is a *partnership* . If She-Ra has

chosen you as her avatar - and she has, Sword or no - then you will be able to call on her when necessary."

"It's too big a risk!" Glimmer said, casting a worried look at Adora. "If she can't learn how to call on She-Ra, we might-"

"I'll do it." Adora said, standing up decisively. "I won't keep She-Ra imprisoned. Not even.." she locked eyes with Glimmer, begging her to understand, "not even if it means losing her."

"I hate it," Glimmer sighed, "but you're right. Imprisoning She-Ra is something the Horde would do. We're not the Horde. We'll figure it out."

"Improvise, right?" Bow said, grinning. "We're great at that!"

"Very well." Dhar'ra said, rising. "We shall destroy the Sword of Protection."

"I have one more question." Adora said. "My… my friend was kidnapped by the Horde at a young age. She's a Magicat like you. Her name's Catra. Is she… that is, was her family here?"

"We have been hidden from the Horde for many years." Dhar'ra said. "And have never lost a child to a Horde raid. I cannot help you. I'm sorry."

"No, it's just…" Adora sighed. "I know it bothers her. We both used to wonder who our parents were. Now… well, I guess I just hoped at least *one* of us might be able to find our family."

Dhar'ra gave Adora a sympathetic look. "I can ask my agents to make inquiries. The magicat people scattered across Etheria in the wake of Halfmoon's fall, but a few of the wandering families maintain ties. One may know something."

"I would… I would be in your debt, Commander." Adora said, bowing low.

“You’re going to free She-Ra and right a wrong my people helped perpetrate centuries ago.” Dhar’ra replied. “I think it’s the least we can do.”

A few hours later, the Forge echoed with Adora’s scream.

Chapter End Notes

I was positive I wasn't going to finish the next chapter any time soon, but... this just came tumbling out. I couldn't help it, I had the chance to go deep on lore that is completely invalid now and I took it.

At the time of this writing I'm four episodes into season five and I have shed tears at *least* once an episode (episode three basically had me dead the entire running time). Plus, tumblr helpfully thought I'd be interested in a post that was a big spoiler - *the* big spoiler, and if you know, you know, so I know where season five is going (how it will get there, and *when* it will get there, is still a mystery that I will savor and enjoy - spoilers don't really bother me that much if I'm honest) and when I saw it I got immensely excited. I'll say no more on it, just know that it's possible output will increase with this immense injection of pure delight that is She-Ra season five.

Thanks everyone for reading, I'm sorry that this will not be as good as actual She-Ra, but hey, we're over 100k words now. This is the longest thing I've ever written! I don't... I don't know how I feel about that, to be honest. Thanks for sticking with this, everyone! I doubt very much I would have kept going if not for y'all leaving kudos and comments. That or I would've ended it with a cumbersome flash forward like 40,000 words ago.

NEXT TIME: I believe I promised y'all a giant robot when this all started, didn't I?

Unwelcome Complications

Chapter Summary

> Entrapta finds a new object of affection. Catra flies solo. Shadow Weaver sends her regards.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Scorpia's voice crackled over Catra's earpiece. "Uh, Commander? About this current mission - I thought I'd give you a little more of the background."

"What's the complication?"

"No complication!" Scorpia said in a tone of voice that meant there was definitely a complication. "Our client is a weapons research center. Apparently they've been working on some new shoulder-mounted anti-tank system. Apparently you can guide the projectiles? I asked Entrapta about it and she got really excited. Like, *really* excited. Like, the sort of excited that ends with me and her-"

"I get it!" Catra cut her off. "What's the complication."

"Oh right, sorry! A small Rebellion force took it on a mission that went sideways on them. Last transmission from them indicated they'd retreated to a cave system and hidden the weapon, but with no further transmissions after that the assumption is the force was wiped out shortly thereafter. The thing is, our client had distributed this system without authorization."

"Meaning they need someone to get it back quietly." Catra finished. "This was all in the briefing. What's the complication?"

“You read the briefing? I’m shocked!”

“Scorpia…”

“Okay, okay, just trying to give you the complete picture is all.” Scorpia said, and Catra could hear her rubbing her claws together nervously. “So the thing is we just got word from the intel team. The Horde’s increased activity in the area - specifically near the cave system.”

Catra hummed. “They know it’s there.”

“Or suspect it’s there, anyway. Details are hazier than I’d like on this one, Commander. Be careful.”

“Thanks for the heads-up, Scorp. I’m almost there - going dark for now. I’ll contact you when I’m on my way out.”

Catra had elected to fly herself this time - she’d told Scorpia it was due to the sensitivity of the mission, but it was more because she wasn’t quite ready to risk another pilot. She put the skiff down several kilometers from her destination and continued on foot. It felt good to be doing field work again - and not just because it kept her mind off of Adora, who had dropped out of contact (*she told you where she was going, she’s not leaving you*) and would probably not be back for another week at least. Catra had been mostly concerned with training Mara and C’yra and had been unwilling to leave until she knew for certain the two were in good hands. Scorpia had promised to look after them, and Rogelio had found a therapist who had, before joining the Rebellion, specialized in dealing with children to talk to the two about their upbringing.

What had caught Catra off guard was the disappointment the two had both expressed when Catra explained that she had work to do and would need to miss two days of their regular morning training. When Catra had suggested finding a replacement, the two had outright rejected the idea.

"I think they just like spending time with you, Commander." Scorpia had said with a look on her face suggesting she found the whole thing *incredibly* cute.

Catra thought it was more likely they were just nervous about training with other people again, and said so, but Scorpia had just given her a knowing look and a "Whatever you say, Commander."

I can't let them rely on me. Catra thought to herself as she made her way to the caves. *This business might end with me dead and they'll need to stand on their own. I should tell Scorpia to make sure there's a way to get them to Adora if something happens to me.* Not for the first time, Catra found herself wondering if she'd made a mistake. *Maybe it would have been better if Adora didn't know I was still alive. She'd already mourned me. Now if something happens, she'll have to do it again. She shouldn't have to…*

Don't be ridiculous, Adora's voice echoed in her mind, *if you think she'd give up everything we have now to save herself the pain of losing you again, you're dumber than I thought.* You *certainly wouldn't.*

But I can't hurt her again , Catra argued with herself.

So don't get killed! Easy!

That seemed to settle the argument. Catra moved forward carefully, taking a path parallel to the larger track. She'd memorized a map of the area and Scorpia had marked the most likely spots for Horde patrol routes based on their intel. Of course, that was before Scorpia had said there would be increased activity, but Catra figured that as long as she was careful it wouldn't be too big of an issue.

If I'm lucky. Catra thought. *I think I might have used all my luck up when I got Adora back.*

The sound of movement nearby drove any further musings on her luck out of her mind. She dropped to the ground soundlessly,

taking deep, controlled breaths. Catra focused on the sounds, picking them apart into separate entities. A two man patrol, one of whom had a slight hesitation to their step which indicated an untreated injury. As they drew closer, she could hear their breathing - heavier than normal, meaning they were probably tired. *Shadow Weaver's running them into the ground* , Catra thought. *Overworking them.* She felt a surge of anger at what was happening to her old soldiers and resolved to leave them alive. She eased Entrapta's tranquilizer pistol out of its holster slowly. The sound of the patrol passed by her, and Catra rose up soundlessly and padded after them. There was a hiss and a clack from the gun as a puff of gas propelled the tranquilizer dart deep into the first soldier's neck, followed swiftly by a second. The two soldiers crumpled to the ground, and Catra dragged them off the patrol path. She stole the communicator off one of the soldiers and continued forward.

"HP-43 here, reporting in. No sign of hostiles. ST-9 can proceed to the caverns."

"CP-8, acknowledged. Interrogation of the remaining hostile indicates the weapon system is in a small chamber in the southeast."

"ST-9, acknowledged. Any further information?"

"Unfortunately not. Subject expired under the strain. Get it done. CP out."

Catra swore under her breath and increased her pace. *Get to the caverns ahead of the search team, grab the weapon, get out. Easy* .

There were another three guards standing at the entrance to the cave. Catra dropped the first two without a sound, but the third gave a panicked shout that echoed in the entryway. Cursing under her breath, Catra moved into the caverns knowing full well any soldiers would be on alert.

“ST-9, heard sounds of a scuffle outside. Someone check it out.”

“CP-8, acknowledged. Any patrol in the area, head for the caverns.”

So much for easy .

The search team was a team of four. Catra considered her options carefully. There wasn’t a lot of time - additional patrols would arrive soon, and she still hadn’t found the weapon system. She reached for her belt and withdrew a small stun grenade. She rolled the grenade on the ground into the chamber, squeezed her good eye shut, and plugged her ears. At the sound of the detonation, she dashed forward and had the team on the ground in a matter of seconds. Adrenaline sang in her blood and she grinned in spite of the danger. It was good to be in the field again. Things were simpler, and every job she took would get her one step closer to bringing Hordak down for good.

As it turned out the search team had already found the weapon. A large metal case sat in the center of the room. Catra popped it open and her eye widened in delight. A number of projectiles - rockets, she assumed - were arranged next to what was clearly a shoulder-mounted launcher. The rockets had strange, bulbous noses and (perhaps purely for aesthetic purposes) were inscribed with what looked like First Ones runes. She keyed her radio.

“Commander here. Found the target. Are you sure we have to take this back? It’s beautiful.”

Entrapta’s voice broke over the line. “ *Really?* Can you show me? Show me! Use your tablet!”

“I don’t know that I’ve got time for a photo shoot.” Catra responded, grinning a little at her excitement.

“No, come on Commander, don’t get her all-” Scorpia’s voice broke off. “Aw no ‘trapta, don’t give me that look. The contract’s to return the weapon.”

Catra closed the case back up and was relieved to find it had a shoulder strap. She slung it over her back and found it was surprisingly light and easy to carry. *Well now, that's a stroke of luck.* Throwing caution (mostly) to the wind, Catra sprinted for the cave exit. It didn't take her very long to make her way out past the unconscious guards, and she felt a surge of satisfaction. She'd made it out before reinforcements could arrive.

The smell hit her before she noticed the red fog rolling in. It smelled *wrong* , like rotten meat. She was exposed - out in the open with no good cover, nowhere to hide. Adora's description of the strange soldiers who'd attacked them in the woods came back: fast, able to sink into shadows, stronger than normal, and expert combat form. *Adora said there were four of them, but she killed one. Hopefully Shadow Weaver hasn't trained up another.*

Catra breathed deeply, focused on sound. *You've fought Shadow Weaver before and come out on top. You can fight her creations. You can do this.*

When the three soldiers appeared, Catra had to suppress a shudder. They moved in almost total silence, footfalls light. Catra didn't wait for them to get into position - she flung another stun grenade in their direction and took off running, not sure she could outrun them but hoping to at least give herself some time to think. There was a ripping sound and the ground itself surged upward under Catra's feet, sending her in the air. Catra flailed, righted herself, and somehow managed to roll into a landing that jarred her teeth together. Coming up into a fighting stance, she saw two step out from the shadows in front of her, while the sound of boots behind her let her know the third had effectively surrounded her.

They paused, studying Catra closely. Then, unexpectedly, instead of attacking they straightened up, stood at attention. There was a sudden rumble to Catra's left, accompanied by the sound of groaning metal. She looked over… and up, and up. Entrapta's two-legged mech towered over her. It had seen a few modifications - the entire structure coursed with a crackling red energy, a massive

cannon was mounted to its shoulder, and the arms, such as they were, seemed to actually be two of what Entrapta had referred to as autocannons - meant to function much like the simple projectile rifles she'd developed, but whirling at high speed. There was a crackling noise as an external speaker activated.

"So, the rumors are true, are they?" Catra's fur stood on end, her ears went back, and she snarled involuntarily at the sound of Shadow Weaver's voice. "You somehow managed to not only evade our hunter killer teams, but didn't crawl off and die. I'm almost impressed. If you'd put this much effort into your training as a cadet, perhaps you wouldn't have been such a waste of time."

Catra's response was to shrug the case off her shoulder and pop it open in a single, fluid motion.

"Determined to go down fighting, are you?" Shadow Weaver mocked. "Well, that's almost admirable. I'll give you a chance, then. Perhaps you'll provide my pilot some much-needed training."

While Shadow Weaver talked, Catra loaded one of the rockets. She brought the launcher up to her shoulder and, uncertain as to how precisely to use it, she flipped some switches and hoped for the best. There was a low tone and a small heads up display sprang to life in front of her good eye, displaying targeting data.

Catra's mind was racing. *What did Entrapta say the weak spot on this thing was again? The hip joints? Can this thing target the hip joint? Is one rocket going to be enough? You don't have time for another shot, and these three assholes aren't going to just stand back and let you go if it does. You've got to take them down as soon as you fire. Calm. You can do this. Don't get killed, remember?*

"I want you to know, Catra, that it will be a shame to see you die. I always did think you were a waste of potential, and now… I see I was right. Ah, well. When I find the spare and bring her back, I'll do better next time."

Several things happened at once. The autocannon whirred to life as Catra fired. The two enhanced soldiers in front of her reacted to the autocannon's noise by dashing to the side. The third put itself squarely between the mech and Catra, doubtless assuming it could use her as a shield. Catra roared with rage and bounded forward, dropping to all fours and hoping she could move faster than the autocannons could adjust their aim, making for between the two legs. She very nearly beat the rocket there, but the explosion and shriek of tearing metal heralded her success. The mech staggered backwards and began an attempt to turn to bring Catra back into its sights. Her back burned with something - heat from the explosion, she thought - and her ears were ringing, but she pressed the attack.

Catra jumped on one of the legs and began climbing, claws digging into the metal surface for purchase. She spotted several hydraulic lines and shredded them. The mech's legs whined in protest. Suddenly an all-too familiar jolt went through Catra's body as a countermeasure electrified the mech's surface. Her vision went white and Catra was flung backwards, landing roughly on the ground. She rolled up to her feet, spotted the case and the launcher where she'd dropped them, and darted forward. The mech was struggling to turn - the damage from the rocket and Catra's claws slowing it down. Catra slammed the case shut and swung it on a hunch. There was a crack as it connected with the head of one of Shadow Weaver's soldiers who had just teleported, seeing a chance to take Catra down. The blow knocked the respirator out of his mouth, and there was an awful shrieking noise as he clawed at his throat before dropping to the ground.

Catra wasn't sure where the other two were, but the mech chose that moment to quite spectacularly topple forward, kicking up an enormous cloud of dust. Seeing her chance, Catra sprinted into the cloud, dropping another stun grenade as she ran. The cloud dissipated quickly, but Catra hoped it had given her enough of a head start to get out of sight.

Don't get killed, she repeated to herself. *Get out of here. Get back to base.*

She ran until the reddish fog that had heralded the arrival of Weaver's troops was nowhere to be seen. Catra wasn't sure if that meant she was out of danger, but she couldn't smell the rot anymore and felt like it was a good sign. She took the long way to where she'd stashed the skiff, doubling back several times just to make sure she'd lost her pursuers. It wasn't until she'd reached the skiff and punched in the coordinates to the base that she realized the warm feeling on her back was her own blood. The pain of the injury finally arrived a few seconds later and she slumped forward in the pilot's chair, gritting her teeth.

"Scorpia? About that complication you mentioned?"

Worry was evident in Scorpia's voice when she responded. "Commander? You okay?"

"We'll see." Catra replied. There was a steady dripping sound now as her back bled freely, running down her leg. She was starting to feel dizzy, but whether that was blood loss or just exhaustion, she couldn't tell. "Tell Entrapta that Hordak got her mech working."

" *Shit* , Commander. What happened?"

"Later, Scorp." Catra said. "Can you do me a favor? I'm starting to feel like I might lose consciousness. If that happens, you'll need to have someone standing by to intercept the skiff and bring it down safely."

"You're not gonna pass out, Commander." Scorpia said. "Keep talking to me and we'll get you in safely."

"Sure." Catra said, taking a deep breath and wincing. "Sounds like a plan."

"The fight." Scorpia said. "What happened?"

"Used the launcher to take out one of the hip joints. Climbed up and severed some hydraulics and that disabled it."

"You had time to get that thing out of its case?"

“Shadow Weaver.” Catra said. “Shadow Weaver wanted to gloat. She knows I’m alive now.” Her heart rate picked up. “Scorp, she *knows* . She’s going to come for me. She’s going to…”

“If she comes for you, she’s signing her own death certificate.” Scorpia said, snorting. “You think I’d let her just waltz in? And she can’t find you at any rate. That far sight shit she used to do needed that gem of hers, and you turned that into dust.”

Catra wasn’t listening, her vision was starting to go black and her voice was growing faint. “You’ve got to tell Adora I’m sorry, Scorp. I tried not to die. I tried. I’m sorry. Gods, I love her.” Some final instinct got her to slide out of the pilot’s chair and on to the floor so she wouldn’t hit the controls. “Tell her that, Scorpia. You tell her I loved her. That’s… that’s an order.”

“Commander? Commander? Commander! Don’t you fucking dare - Commander!”

Chapter End Notes

Well, sorry y'all. I wanted to write some absolutely tooth rotting fluff because of the way Season Five wrapped up, but instead you get my most blatant Metal Gear references yet. Not just that, but *another cliffhanger to boot*, what the fuck is my problem? I think it's because season five filled my heart with such indescribable joy I had to even things out a little.

Don't worry though, at least next chapter will explain what Adora was screaming about at the end of last chapter! Also, because I know you're curious, the aforementioned fluff, where our two (rot13 spoilers because maybe you didn't know yet: PNABA UN UN SHPX LRF GURL SHPXVAT XVFFRQ FB UNEQ GURL FNIRQ GUR ZBGURESHPXVAT HAVIREFR) ladies get some time to themselves will arrive soon enough.

I've said it before, and I'll say it again: thanks for reading, thanks for commenting, thanks for your kudos, and uh, I still

cannot *believe* Noelle Stevenson qvq gur tbqqnza guvat. What a fucking ride.

Prison Break

Chapter Summary

> She-Ra breaks out. Adora finds her strength. Glimmer has a change of heart. Scorpia reaches out.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The scream echoed through the Forge, accompanied by blinding radiance. Bow and Glimmer covered their eyes, but Dhar'ra's were wide and she smiled and wore an expression of unfettered joy.

"You've done it, Adora! Ground yourself! Find your focus like we talked about!"

Adora's eyes were a brilliant, shining blue, and her skin was a searing white. Her hair floated above her head, wild and out of control. Fel'cath stood at the anvil of the Forge, hammer in hand. The shattered Sword of Protection lay on the anvil, sending out seeking blue tendrils that sought to wrap around Adora. The hammer came down on the shards with a boom, and the tendrils retreated.

Dhar'ra continued to shout. "You have to ground yourself! She-Ra's power has been unleashed, but it needs to focus! If it runs rampant I don't know you'll be able to reconnect to her!"

The hammer boomed again. There was another surge of light and a deafening roar. Adora opened her eyes and found herself standing in the same cave from her visions. The cage, which had formerly housed a captive goddess, was scattered in pieces across the floor. A tremor ran through the cave, and there was a thrill of energy through Adora's body - a sudden excitement, like something dormant had woken up. A light shone from a passage she hadn't noticed before, and she ran after it.

“She-Ra! Is that you?” Her voice echoed eerily, but she felt no fear. This, some instinct told her, was as much her domain as it was She-Ra’s.

“You have done it.” She-Ra’s voice echoed around Adora in reply. “You have freed me. Mara’s work is finally complete.”

“They told me,” Adora said, “the magicats. They told me what she did. That she had to die to save Etheria.”

“It is sometimes so.” She-Ra replied. “To wield my power is to throw yourself into danger, over and over again. It takes strength to do so. I wonder, Adora of Eternia, whether or not you have that strength.”

“I’ve trained.” Adora replied, feeling a wave of nervousness. “I’ve fought with your powers and without them, and come out victorious. I’ve sacrificed myself to save others. I have stood alone against enemies of Etheria and lived.”

“You stand alone?” She-Ra appeared then, too bright and beautiful. A look of gentle amusement was on her face. “Is it your ability to stand alone and crush your enemies that makes you strong?”

Adora was caught off guard. “I… it is what I have been taught.” she said, a note of confusion in her voice. “My responsibility as She-Ra is to protect Etheria. The world relies on me.” *I had to give you up once,* she heard herself saying to Catra, and swallowed. “I have to stand alone.”

She-Ra threw back her head and laughed. It was shocking - both because it was entirely inappropriate, in Adora’s opinion, and because the sound was full of such unrestrained delight that Adora couldn’t help but smile in spite of it.

“Oh my dear child,” She-Ra said, wiping a tear from her eye, “you must forgive me. If Mara had heard that speech, she would swear it came straight from Light Hope in one of her grumpier moods.” Composing herself, the goddess continued. “There is strength in

standing alone - and in crushing your enemies - but it is not a lasting strength. No, Adora of Eternia, I believe you already know, deep down, where your strength lies. I shall ask a different question, then. I know you are strong - strong enough to bear the burden of my power. What is the source of your strength? What will anchor me to you?"

All I could think about was how I wanted to see you again, and just go somewhere away from everything to figure our shit out and then just… live out my days with you in peace. Right now feels kinda like I imagined it could if we did.

"Well, guess we'll have to make sure we keep an eye out for a suitable spot."

"We're going to figure out a way to end this war, and I'm going to throw you over my shoulder and ride off into the fucking sunset, to a cabin somewhere in the middle of nowhere, and we're going to live in something like peace."

I.. I know I'm asking a lot.

"You are. But you're my friend, and I trust you."

"Now you've got this… this new thing, and it's terrifying because it feels like you have more to lose."

"My friends." Adora said, understanding dawning in her eyes. She thought of countless sleepovers with Bow and Glimmer, of their adventures across Etheria in service of the Rebellion. She thought of Catra, of sleeping curled up next to her and kissing her, rolling around in bed with her and waking up the next morning with the weight of another body draped shamelessly over her torso. "The ones I love. The ones who love me."

The arms of She-Ra wrapped around Adora, pulling her into a warm embrace. "Well answered, Adora of Eternia. You carry the light of She-Ra with you - pass it on to the others. Lend my strength to your friends, and they will find their own strength increased. You will alter the course of Etherian history, and in this

act, perhaps, face greater danger than any She-Ra has for generations. Now *awaken* , Adora. Awaken and fight for the honor of Mara's rebellion. Fight for the honor of Grayskull!"

In the cavern, Fel'cath had not ceased bringing the hammer down on the shards. Adora's screams had stopped, but she was still coursing with power, paralyzed to the rest of the world. Glimmer looked over to Bow with a panicked expression. "This isn't working! We have to snap her out of it somehow!"

Bow opened his mouth to respond just as there was an almighty crack. A wave of pressure shot out from Adora, knocking everyone back, and when they recovered She-Ra stood in the center of the cave. She was taller than Glimmer remembered, and wore a differently-shaped crown. It reminded her of something, but she couldn't place it. Her eyes were still piercing blue, but there was something else there now - something wild and untamed, something altogether *new* .

"Hey guys." She-Ra said, and it was still Adora's voice as always, but it almost sounded like she might start laughing at any moment for the sheer joy of being *free* . "Sorry that took a little longer."

Fel'cath stood sweating at the anvil and let his hammer drop from his hand with a clatter. "Queen C'yra's *tits* , I think my arm's about to fall off."

She-Ra strode over to the swearing magicat and laid a hand on his shoulder. Fel'cath looked up at her with a shocked expression as his shoulder began to glow. "Thank you, Fel'cath. The ancestors look down upon your deed with pride." she smiled, and added, "even if you do swear on the queen's tits."

Fel'cath bowed low. "Perhaps," he said, "I should take to swearing on She-Ra's tits. The queen never healed my shoulder."

She-Ra, Protectress of Etheria, Goddess of Unfathomable Power, doubled over and laughed until tears sprang to her eyes. "By all

means, I give my blessing to do so."

"Adora!" Glimmer shouted, teleporting to her with glee. "You did it! You freed She-Ra!"

Bow gave her a once-over. "Yeah, you look good!"

"He means you got *hotter* , Adora." Glimmer snickered. "He's just too polite to say it."

"Not you though, huh?" She-Ra's eyebrow raised and she grinned and sketched a bow. "My thanks, Princess of Brightmoon, for your honesty. I'm glad to know that centuries of imprisonment have not damaged my looks."

That brought Glimmer up short. "Wait… what do you mean, 'centuries of imprisonment?' You're still… you're *Adora* , right?"

Another laugh escaped She-Ra, bubbling up from what seemed to be an endless spring of joy. "Yes, Glimmer, I am still Adora. But I am also She-Ra. The Sword of Protection locked my voice away for so long - kept me from being able to communicate, to warn the Eternians of what they were causing, of what their fear would bring them…" a faraway look appeared on her face. "Did they not know? Did they fail to understand that Etheria is my home, but I would leave home to defend them if they asked? Alas for their folly! Much could have been avoided, if things had been different. Yet if things were different," she said, her smile returning, dazzling, heartbreakingly beautiful, "I would not have met Catra, nor would I have met you, or Bow. A trade I would not make for anything."

"She-Ra," Dhar'ra said, kneeling on the ground. "I must apologize, on behalf of the Kingdom of Halfmoon. If we'd known -"

She-Ra held out her hand and raised Dhar'ra up. "Ah, Commander Dhar'ra. In your face I see the spitting image of Queen C'yra, my old friend." she breathed deep, and a flash of immeasurable grief crossed her features before she smiled gently again and continued. "There is nothing to forgive. Even many Eternians did

not know what their leaders planned. It grieves me that such a civilization fell so low. It is through your help that I was freed, and you showed Mara the path forward to save the universe. Now, however, there is still work to do."

She-Ra raised her hand to the sky, and closed her eyes. A sword - longer and narrower than the Sword of Protection, materialized in her hand and shot a beam of multicolored light into the ceiling. The Forge hummed with power.

"Um, Glimmer?" Bow's voice broke in nervously. "You're uh… glowing."

"It's…" Glimmer's voice was a little breathless. "It's her. I think… I think this entire cavern's just been… infused with raw magic! It's like… Bow, it's like nothing I've ever-" she broke off, laughing. "I can feel the runestone in Brightmoon from *here* ."

"As it should be, Glimmer." She-Ra said with a smile. "Something…" she frowned. "Something is still wrong. A blockage. Hidden. We can deal with it later. For now, this will have to be enough. I am weary now - I have not stretched myself like this in an age."

There was another flash, and Adora reappeared, smiling broad and triumphant. "She's back! She's really… We're going to do it! We're going to beat the Horde!"

"The Lost Army of Halfmoon," Dhar'ra said, walking slowly up to Adora, "is at your disposal, She-Ra."

Adora , Adora thought, *my name's Adora* , but then she *remembered* , remembered *everything* , smiled and said, "We are proud to have you as allies." Turning to Bow and Glimmer, she grinned a little smugly and said, "So I got *hotter* , huh?"

"Ooooh yeah." Glimmer said, grinning. "Just do me a favor and make sure I'm in the room the first time you do it in front of Catra. I've never seen someone spontaneously combust before."

"You know there's even a rumor that I'm sleeping with She-Ra?"

"Now that *I might want to watch."*

"Oh my god are you *blushing* ? Bow! Bow, she's *blushing!* "

Bow grabbed Glimmer and dragged her back. "Sorry Adora, I think having her magic juiced up has her a little loopy."

"Hmm," Adora said, faux thoughtful, "yeah, that might be it. If only there were a way for you to help her burn off all that excess energy."

Both Bow and Glimmer suddenly found themselves victims of a spontaneous coughing fit. Adora cackled in a very Catra-like manner and grinned. "Come on guys, we should get back to Brightmoon. There's a lot to cover," Her hands tightened into fists. "And I need to have a long, *long* talk with Light Hope."

"I'm sure… I'm sure she had her reasons for bringing you here, right?" Glimmer said, a little tremor in her voice. Even after hearing what the First Ones - the Eternians, that is - had done, she couldn't quite bring herself to see them as a threat rather than an old ally.

"Maybe so," Adora said, thoughtfully, "but I doubt it. I think I was brought here to be a weapon."

"To fight the Horde, right?"

Adora shook her head. "I'm not sure anymore. This… this weapon that Mara tried to stop. I think it still exists. The blockage I mentioned earlier… I don't know. It might be related to it." she turned to Dhar'ra, who had watched their exchange with amusement. "What do you know about the Heart of Etheria?"

Dhar'ra shook her head in apology. "Only what I told you. It was - is - a weapon of terrible power. The location, how it works, whether or not it can be stopped - all that knowledge went up with the destruction of the capital city."

“There’s got to be *something* about it somewhere.” Adora muttered. “Light Hope knows. I’m sure she does. I just have to get her to *tell* me. I’m not sure how that’ll go when she realizes I’ve shattered the sword.”

“My advice is to hit her until she starts talking.” Fel’cath said, shrugging. “If you wish, we can provide you with weapons forged to combat the Eternians and their technology. She-Ra’s power restored the Forge, after all.”

Bow’s eyes lit up. “Could you make me a new bow? Or special arrows?”

“Yeah, I just said we could provide you with-”

“This is the best day of my life!” Bow said, looking like he might burst into tears at any moment. “I’ve got so many arrow designs to show you!”

While Bow began chatting excitedly to Fel’cath, Glimmer’s expression began to slip from her previous elation into something far less happy. Adora looked over at her questioningly. “You okay, Glim'?”

“Yeah, just… this is a lot to take in, you know? She-Ra was *imprisoned?* You broke her out and there was this whole… *thing* when you were transformed where you were you but also not you?”

“It’s… hard to explain.” Adora said, scratching the back of her head. “It’s like… it’s like I’m me, except also I’m her at the same time. I have her memories, her… her *knowledge* , I know how to use her powers better than I ever did before. But we’re still separate - I can talk to her, and she can talk to me when we’re together.”

“And now? Do you know what she knows now?”

“Not really.” Adora frowned. “It fades. Like… I remember some things, but the immediacy of the feelings isn’t there. When I look

at the Commander over there, I don’t see Queen C’yra’s face in her features, but She-Ra does.”

“You think the Queen’s role in the rebellion against the First Ones is why Shadow Weaver named that clone C’yra?” Glimmer asked, curious.

“Probably. I think she just wanted to give them names that she could throw at them as examples of powerful people to live up to. Speaking of which...with your powers juiced, you think you could teleport us out of the Crimson Wastes entirely? I think we’ve spent too much time here and I need to get in touch with-”

“Catra.” Glimmer nodded in understanding. “Look, I know that… I know that I’ve said I don’t trust her - and that eventually we’ll have to deal with what she’s doing but…” she gestured around the cavern. “Everything we’ve learned about the First Ones and what they did… We were wrong about *everything* , Adora. Maybe I’m wrong about her too.”

Adora looked at Glimmer in surprise. “What, really?”

“She had to know.” Glimmer said, looking at Adora. “My mother. She had to know, or at least suspect that something wasn't right. I mean, She-Ra was already gone by the time she was born, but…”

“But someone turned the Eternians into the First Ones.” Adora said. “Someone made sure the last She-Ra’s story was told as a descent into madness and not a rebellion.”

“Exactly. I hope it wasn’t her, but… I’m worried the Rebellion’s compromised by something.” Glimmer said, “We’ll need allies. An army, if that happens. One we can trust.”

“You’re talking about-” Adora realized her voice had raised up, and quickly quieted back down. “You’re talking about *fighting your mom?* ”

"What? No! I want to avoid that if we can! But… listen, Adora, if there was some kind of… agreement to bury the truth of the First Ones, and my mother *doesn't* know about it? That's something very old, and very powerful. I don't doubt they could have influence in the Rebellion."

"Okay." Adora said. "I'll talk to Catra about it. I need to let her know about all this She-Ra stuff anyway."

"I was being serious when I said I want to be there the first time she sees your new form." Glimmer said, shoving her worries to the side in favor of teasing. "Although maybe I'd end up traumatized by what would happen afterwards."

"I'm… not so sure I want to bring She-Ra along with me for that." Adora admitted. "That feels like… like something I might want to keep for myself."

"That might be the right idea." Glimmer said. "You deserve something for yourself."

Adora found herself looking at Glimmer again in a new light. There was something different in her eyes now - like the weight of learning the real history of Etheria had changed her, somehow. "So do you, you know." Adora nodded in Bow's direction. "If you want it."

"Gods, Adora, I'm trying to be serious."

"So am I!" Adora said, grabbing her friend's hands. "Glimmer, I know that we've been fighting a war for our whole lives, but… this feels different, now. She-Ra talked to me about some bigger threat, something dangerous. We'll beat the Horde, but I don't think that's going to end the war. You should take a chance while you can. Before it's too late! Believe me," she said with a wry grin, "I got a taste of what that's like. I don't recommend it. Just think about it, okay?"

Glimmer looked over at Bow again, and the fond smile on her face was impossible to miss. "Alright, fine, I'll… *consider* the possibility

that you're right. Hey Bow!"

"What's up Glimmer?"

"You wanna see how far I can teleport now?"

"Are we going to end up in the middle of a tree or a mountain or something?"

"One way to find out!" Glimmer grabbed Adora's hand, teleported the short distance to Bow, grabbed his hand, shouted "We'll be back, Commander Dhar'ra! Thanks for everything!" and closed her eyes. With a flash, the three disappeared.

"Too high!" Bow squeaked as the three reappeared over Brightmoon. "We're too high!"

"Whoops! Hang on!"

There was another flash and the three popped back into existence a few feet above the ground, landing in a heap. Glimmer giggled with delight. "Hahaha! Did you see that? All the way to Brightmoon!"

"Gotta admit," Adora said, standing and dusting herself off, "I'm impressed."

"It's the runestone." Glimmer said. "It's like a beacon now. I just… focused on it and here we are."

"Huh!" Bow said. "Well, as long as you adjust the height, I think that'll be pretty useful." He looked over in surprise at Adora, who had already started heading for her room. "Hey, where you going?"

"I need a shower." Adora said, calling back over her shoulder. "Glimmer, do you want me with you when we brief your mom?"

"Nah, go ahead and call your girlfriend." Glimmer said, waving her off. "If she wants a demonstration of the new She-Ra look, I'll

come get you.”

Adora blushed. “She’s not my- well, she *is* my… you know what, nevermind, thanks I’ll find you later!” This last was delivered as she broke into a jog, eager to hear from Catra again.

The comm pad she’d stashed in a desk drawer blinked at her urgently. Chuckling to herself, Adora pulled up Catra and connected the call. “Couldn’t bear to be away from me, huh?”

“Adora?”

“Scorpia?”

“Adora, thank gods! Look, we need your help. Something’s… something’s happened to Catra.”

Adora’s blood ran cold. “What? What’s happened?”

“I’m not.. We’re not sure. She’s…” Sorpia’s voice trembled and Adora felt the bottom fall out of her world. “she’s dying, Adora. Catra’s dying.”

Chapter End Notes

Wait didn't I just update this fucking thing yesterday?

Gee it is almost like Season Five got me fuckin' *possessed* or something. Well, that and they cut my hours at work again (don't worry, I'll survive, they have a social safety net here in Germany), so I've had a lot of time.

This chapter - along with the last chapter - have been on my mind for a very long time - somewhere between season three and four I decided I wanted to slot the First Ones into a more villainous role (because that's where they seemed like they might be headed), and putting them into the role of the Patriots felt like a good fit to me. Also I'm very obviously taking some liberties with the nature of She-Ra here and how she functions, and I just can't help taking some stuff from

season five (like that new She-Ra outfit) and adapting it for my purposes (making She-Ra's connection to magic as an elemental force more explicit also came out of season five, and while Horde Prime isn't going to show up in *this* story, well, his presence is still there).

I never thought I'd say this, but... apart from one or two more big scenes, we're coming closer to the end of this story. Let's say a conservative estimate of around 75% complete, as it stands. Everything ends, even ridiculous MGS/She-Ra crossovers.

Thanks so much for coming along on this ridiculous fucking journey with me. Your comments and kudos are always appreciated - do me a favor and recommend this thing to your friends, huh? Or keep it secret and it will just be us cool kids. I guess either way works.

Next time: Deathbeds! The clone kids! She-Ra! Spontaneous feline combustion, if Glimmer's prediction is anything to go by?

Rescue and Relief

Chapter Summary

> Scorpia distracts Entrapta. Glimmer makes a new plan. Adora delivers aid, news, and a job offer. Catra interferes with communication.

Chapter Notes

> Is there a content warning for "two people being ridiculous and also naked?"

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Things happened quickly after that. Adora came barreling out of her room and made straight for Glimmer's chambers, where she found the Princess in the process of cleaning up before heading to meet her mother. Glimmer had taken one look at Adora's face and known immediately what was happening.

"Catra?"

Adora nodded, panic in her eyes. "She got hurt on a mission. Scorpia says she's-" her voice failed her for a moment. "I have to go to her." she finally said. "I can't lose her again. I *won't* lose her!"

Glimmer gave Adora a long hug. "She's going to be okay, Adora. She-Ra can save her - *you* can save her." she stepped back. "I'll handle things with my mom. Tell her you're off testing your new powers or something."

"Thanks." Adora said, breathing in. "I'm sorry I've got to leave you guys again."

"I mean," Glimmer said, pulling back and shrugging, "we'll need someone to liaise with her company anyway…"

“What are you saying?”

“I’m saying go get her, Adora.” Glimmer said, with a grin. “Get her and tell her we’ve got a job for her. And when you’re sure she’s okay, contact me on the comm pad and we’ll discuss your new duties.”

Adora didn’t know what to say. She hugged Glimmer again. “I owe you.”

Glimmer smirked. “And don’t forget it! Now hurry!”

Swift Wind’s hooves had barely touched the ground when Adora jumped off and began striding toward the infirmary with a look on her face that made it abundantly clear she would brook no interference with her purpose. A few of Catra’s soldiers approached her with a look on their faces that said they were considering asking her business, but as soon as she turned her eyes on them they found they had other important matters to attend to that did not involve potentially being thrown through a wall - which was precisely what Adora looked like she was ready to do to anyone who stopped her. Her approach must have been spotted at some point, however, because Scorpia appeared walking in her direction.

“Adora! She’s this way.”

Adora’s voice was tight. “What happened?”

“She encountered those soldiers you fought. And uh, something bigger than that.” Scorpia’s voice was tight with anxiety. “Entrapta’s mech design - Shadow Weaver’s got it working somehow.”

Adora paused for a second, blinking in surprise. “She fought a giant mech?”

“Brought it down, too.” Scorpia said, shaking her head in admiration. “But then… something happened. She collapsed before she got back here. Entrapta treated her - there were

several deep bullet grazes on her back - but her condition's gotten worse instead of better."

"Show me."

Catra lay unconscious on her bed, soaked with sweat. Her torso was wrapped in bandages, but there were angry red veins standing out on her skin. They seemed to originate from her hands, and had spread up her arms, diving down her shoulders, headed for her heart. Her breathing was shallow - far too shallow for Adora's liking. Entrapta hovered nearby, looking helpless.

"Adora! I'm sorry! I tried everything but I can't figure out what's wrong!" she wailed. "There's some kind of infection spreading and I can't figure out how to treat it."

Adora focused on the red lines crawling on Catra's skin and breathed deeply. She traced a hand along them, feeling the way they stood out from her fur, feeling the corruption that thrummed in them. Panic welled in her chest - instinctively, she knew that they were choking the life out of Catra, that if they reached her heart she would lose Catra and be unable to bring her back. *No,* Adora thought, *I won't let that happen. I won't lose you again, Catra. I'm going to fix this, somehow. How do I fix this?*

Lend my strength to your friends , She-Ra's voice echoed in her mind, and something clicked into place.

"Don't worry, Entrapta." Adora said, suddenly serene. "She's going to be okay." She crouched down next to the bed and took Catra's hands in her own. Raising them to her mouth, she kissed them softly and spoke.

"Hey Catra, it's time to get up." Her eyes closed as she concentrated, and when they opened again they were glowing bright blue. Catra's body shifted, and she let out a whimper. Adora's grip tightened, the glow in her eyes increased and light began to run down her arms and into Catra's hands. Adora's hair

began to dance in the air behind her and Entrapta pulled out her voice recorder and began excitedly narrating the events.

"Subject Adora has begun channeling some kind of ambient magic into the Commander. Magical prowess not previously observed. Newly acquired ability, perhaps?"

"Come on, Catra," Adora said teasingly, a slight echo in her voice. "I came all the way out here to see you. The least you can do is say hello."

In response the red veins brightened, and Catra's body went rigid. She made a choking sound as the veins spread closer to her heart, and with a final gasp she shuddered and went deathly still. Adora's eyes blazed with power and she grit her teeth. A shimmer appeared around the two, like heated air in the desert, and when Adora spoke again, it was a single word, and it rang like a hammer on an anvil. "No."

The glow grew stronger. Scorpia gasped as the red veins began to retreat. Adora smiled, then, and leaned down close to whisper something inaudible into Catra's ear. There was an explosion of multicolored light, causing Entrapta and Scorpia to both shield their eyes. When they opened them again, Adora was smiling down at Catra with tears in her eyes. For an awful moment, nothing moved.

Then Catra took a deep, shuddering breath, and time seemed to restart. Her eye fluttered open, and she looked up into Adora's eyes in confusion. "Adora? What are you doing here?" She closed her eye again and rubbed her head. "No, wait, I remember. Shadow Weaver. She was… she taunted me. Tortured me. How did I escape?"

"It was a dream." Adora said, gathering Catra into her arms. She ran her fingers through Catra's hair, soothing, grounding them both. "Just a dream. I'm here now. You're here now. It's okay."

“I’m so sorry,” Catra said, closing her eyes and burying her face in the crook of Adora’s shoulder. “I’ve hurt you so much, and now I’ve hurt you again.”

“Hurt me?” Adora asked, looking confused.

Catra spoke slowly. “Shadow Weaver showed me... you were mourning my death…” she shook her head again. “No, no wait, that wasn’t real, was it?” Her arms tightened around Adora. “Is this real?”

“It’s real.” Adora reassured her. She dropped her voice to a whisper. “I doubt Scorpia and Entrapta would be here if this was a dream.”

Catra pulled back and seemed to fully take in her surroundings for the first time. “Hey Scorpia. ‘trapta. You didn’t get too worried about me, I hope.”

“Commander, with respect I’m sending a pilot along with you from here on out. Do you have any idea how much trouble a midair rescue is?” Scorpia tried to take a scolding tone, but as she’d lunged forward and wrapped both Catra and Adora into a bone-crushing hug it lacked some of its effectiveness.

“Adora, did something happen to your powers?” Entrapta asked, butting into the conversation before Catra could respond. “I’ve never *seen* that kind of magic before!”

“Oh uh, yeah.” Adora said, turning to face Entrapta but refusing to let Catra go. “We went to the Crimson Wastes and uh, found the kingdom of Halfmoon. Or what’s left of it.”

Catra went very still in Adora’s arms, then. “You… you *found* them? Did you…” *did you find my parents* , she didn’t ask. “Did you figure out who C’yra is?”

“Later.” Adora said, quietly. “I think you need to rest. You were… you were pretty close to gone.”

“Ooh! Were you able to sense her vital signs? That’s amazing!”

“Well!” Scorpia said, maybe a little too loudly. “We’ll leave you to get some rest, Commander.”

“B-but I have so many questions!” Entrapta protested.

“Yes,” Scorpia said, “but I… need your help! With that weapons system the Commander brought back! To analyze it before we return it!”

“Really? I get to-”

Scorpia nodded in a way that managed to convey enthusiasm and having just made an enormous mistake simultaneously. “Yep! It was so useful to the Commander, I think we should have one of our own, don’t you?”

Entrapta looped one hair tendril around Scorpia and began dragging her bodily out the door. “Okay bye Adora come talk to me later I want to talk about that thing your hair did!”

Adora was a little confused, especially by the blush that seemed to be rising on Scorpia’s face. “O..okay?”

Then the door swung shut behind them and it was just her and Catra again.

“So.” Catra said, swallowing. “What exactly -”

She was cut off as Adora kissed her with a fierce desperation. The surprised yelp turned into a rumbling purr as Catra’s tail whipped around to curl lazily around Adora’s waist. She pulled Adora into the bed with her, and her purring intensified.

“I missed you.” Adora said, finally. “Sorry I took so long.”

“You came for me.” Catra said, wonder in her voice. “Didn’t you?”

Adora laughed, tears in her eyes. “Of course I did. As soon as I heard from Scorpia I jumped on Swift Wind and took off.”

“No,” Catra shook her head, “I mean… in my dream. I saw you. You were like a beacon. You said you’d come out here to say hello, and then you said…” she swallowed, “you said you were going to stay.”

“Yeah.” Adora said, eyes still shining. “Yeah, I said that. I meant it.”

“But the Rebellion… your friends.” Catra’s voice shook. “I said you wouldn’t have to choose.”

Adora smiled then, excitement in her voice. “Glimmer wants to hire you. I’m going to pitch myself as the official liaison between your organization and mine.”

“Sparkles wants to *what?*” Catra yelped, her previous worry forgotten.

“We’re uh… we’re putting you on retainer. Not the Rebellion, or the Princess Alliance, but um… us. Like, me, Glimmer, and Bow.” Adora shrugged, as if she hadn’t just said something ridiculous. “We’re still working out the details.”

“What the hell happened?”

“Long story short,” Adora said, counting events off on her fingers, “I destroyed the Sword of Protection, the First Ones turned this planet into a massive weapon of destruction, and um, I’m a First One. Well, Eternian. They’re actually called Eternians.”

“The fuck is an Eternian?”

“Someone from Eternia. It’s another world.” Adora said, shrugging again. “There’s other worlds. We’re um.” she sighed and pulled a face. “Look, I can explain everything but…”

“Wait,” Catra said, still catching up, “you destroyed the Sword? What about She-Ra?”

Instead of answering, Adora held her hand out in front of her and summoned a sword - She-Ra’s *real* sword. “She-Ra’s me. She wasn’t in the sword, or bound to my genetic code, or… any of that. She’s magic itself. And I’m… I’m her.”

“I don’t get it.”

Adora grinned. “I’ll show you. For the honor of Grayskull!”

Catra yelped as Adora’s form grew taller, broader, and - though she didn’t think it was actually possible, *more beautiful.* It was almost difficult to look at her, blindingly radiant, magic thrumming under her skin. She-Ra laughed at Catra’s expression.

“You know, Glimmer claimed you’d spontaneously combust the first time you saw this happen.”

Catra’s mouth was dry. She’d seen She-Ra as her enemy, as something that had stolen Adora away. Yet here was She-Ra looking at her with an expression of amusement that was completely Adora’s, eyes that glowed blue but were Adora’s eyes, Adora’s voice.

“You’re…” Catra swallowed. “You’re *beautiful* . How did you get more beautiful?”

The question was delivered with such bluntness - with such a dazed, almost reverent tone, that She-Ra flushed a deep crimson. “Well. Um. I’m free now. The Sword of Protection was blocking my ability to manifest completely. This is how I’m meant to be.”

It was Catra’s turn to laugh. “Are you *flustered* , Adora? Did I fluster the mighty She-Ra?”

She-Ra smirked, then, and suddenly loomed over Catra with intent in her eyes that was very obvious. “She-Ra doesn’t get flustered.” she said, leaning down so her breath was hot in Catra’s ear. Catra

squirmed, not uncomfortably. “She-Ra *flusters* .” This statement was punctuated with a kiss right at the junction of Catra’s neck and shoulder, causing her to yelp and extend her claws slightly, gripping She-Ra’s shoulder.

There was another bright flash of light and Adora shuddered in Catra’s embrace. “C-Catra!”

“Did you just-”

“No! I just…” Adora spluttered, finding even darker shades of red to turn, “it’s hard to maintain the form when you’re uh… you know.”

Catra’s eye widened with glee. “Did I get the mighty She-Ra so wound up she *turned back into you?* ”

Adora pulled back and muttered something low under her breath about how *it’s not* her *fault you’ve got claws* , crossing her arms and looking a little grumpy. Catra started laughing, suddenly overwhelmed by a feeling of joy at the thought that Adora was hers, Adora had saved her life, Adora was going to *stay* , Adora was… was *Adora* , and nothing Catra could ever have imagined would ever match that feeling.

“Adora,” she finally managed, “you’re… *such* an idiot.”

“ *Your* idiot.” Adora corrected, dipping in for another kiss. “Now, about being all wound up...”

Catra very quickly lost track of time. The sun shining low through the windows caught her eye as she lay sprawled atop Adora, feeling the blonde stroke the fur along her spine lazily with one hand, while the other rested over her heart - reassurance for her that Catra was *there* and *alive,* that she’d been able to bring her back from the brink. Adora had told the whole story of finding the Forge, of Mara’s Rebellion - the history of Queen C’yra’s last stand and the diaspora of the magicats.

“So…” Catra spoke, hesitantly, “so my parents might still be out there somewhere?”

Adora’s petting stopped for a moment as she hesitated for a moment, then restarted. “I don’t know. You know how Horde raids can be, Catra.” There was another pause. “Do you… do you *remember* them at all?”

“A little.” Catra said, quietly. “Never more than a flash - a smile, or the way my father looked at my mother. They had eyes like mine.” Her hand unconsciously came up and stroked her eyepatch. “I think…” her voice trailed off as she tried to remember. “I think my mother’s name was C’yra. When I heard the name, it sounded so *familiar* to me, but I don’t know for sure. Maybe I’d just heard it in passing. Or maybe I just *wanted* to have heard it in passing. I don’t know.”

“Well,” Adora said, “Commander Dhar’ra promised she’d have her people reach out to some of the larger settlements. Maybe they’ll find something.”

“Thank you.” Catra said, pressing a kiss to Adora’s collarbone and maybe enjoying the way it made her shiver. “For asking them, I mean. It means a lot. I’d… I’d kinda like to meet them, if they’re still alive.”

Adora’s comm pad chirped, and she unthinkingly reached over to connect the call. Glimmer’s voice came out of the speaker. “Hey! Swift Wind just arrived back at the castle but he muttered something about you not even saying goodbye and I think he’s sulking. Everything okay?”

“I don’t know, Sparkles,” Catra drawled, scooping the pad out of Adora’s hands, “you tell me.”

“Catra!” Glimmer sounded surprisingly pleased. “I guess that means it went well, then!”

“ *Very* well.” purred Catra, enjoying the increasingly scandalized expression on Adora’s face. “I was just thanking her.”

There was a long silence on the other end of the line. “Adora,” Glimmer said, slowly, “did you answer a call while you were fooling around with your-”

“Hahaha, of course not what a silly idea, why would you even *think* that!” Adora said, grabbing the pad back. “I mean it’s just… who would ever *think* about doing that, just… wow, that’s *crazy* , it’s- Catra!”

She broke off as Catra very innocently cupped one of her breasts and gave it a squeeze. Catra purred. “Hmm? What is it, Adora?”

Glimmer’s voice was faint, like she was talking to someone else. “Oh my god Bow I think they’re about to start fucking on the call.”

“No we aren’t!” Adora shouted, shoving Catra off the bed as she roared with laughter. “Because that would be super insane and we haven’t even - we’ve got our clothes on and everything!”

Glimmer did not sound convinced. “Of course you do. Have you had a chance to tell Catra about our job offer, or have you been too busy definitely not fucking to do that?”

“She’s told me you want my company on retainer,” Catra replied from where she was in the process of climbing back into bed, “but nothing else beyond her new position as our official liaison.”

“Honestly, that’s all there is to know at this point.” Bow’s voice broke in. “But when we talked to the Queen, she let us know the Council’s been planning a major push soon. As soon as word gets out about a powered-up She-Ra there’s sure to be people taking it as a sign.”

“You know, I hadn’t considered it, but this might be our best shot.” Catra said. “That dumbass mech is out of commission for a little while, at least, so there’s one problem solved.”

“Yeah, but…” Adora bit her lip. “Those soldiers. The cannon they were planning on mounting to the mech - they’re still unknowns.”

“So we’ll improvise.” Glimmer said. “Either way, I figure my mom will want to have something going before month’s end. Is that enough time for you to get information out of Light Hope?”

“I was going to head there tomorrow before Scorpia called.” Adora said. “Give me a few days and I’ll bring Catra along.” she grinned, but there was something else under the expression. “It can be her first mission for us.”

“What about payment?” Catra asked. “We don’t work for free.”

Adora ran a finger up one of Catra’s legs. “I’ll think of some way to pay you back.”

“Gross.” Glimmer said. “Catra, I’ll redirect some supplies to a location of your choosing. Just tell me what your people need.”

Catra looked over at Adora curiously. “I’ll give you a complete list once I get a better idea of what’s involved in this… getting information out of Light Hope thing.”

Tension wound its way into Adora’s frame. “I’ll fill her in, Glimmer. We’ll contact you tomorrow, got it?”

“Just make sure you actually sleep at some point.” Glimmer said, and Catra could hear the smirk in her voice as she disconnected the call.

“Well,” Catra said, smiling in a way that made Adora’s stomach do a flip, “good thing that wasn’t a video call. Now, where were we?”

“Wait, Catra.” Adora said, demonstrating a remarkable level of self-control. “About Light Hope…”

“What about her?” Catra replied, doing her level best to control her disappointment.

“I think she’s the reason I’m here. I think… I think she brought me here to fire the Heart. It’s not going to be… it’s not going to

be a *polite conversation* once she realizes I've destroyed the Sword." Adora sighed. *I was only ever meant to be a weapon* .

"She brought you here?" Catra repeated, incredulously. "Should I send her a thank you card? Er, sorry, I know that…"

Adora laughed, her dour train of thought derailed. "No, you make a good point. It doesn't matter why I came here - I found you, after all."

Catra grinned, looking immensely pleased with herself. "And don't you forget it, princess. Now, if that concludes the mission briefing…" she said, looming over Adora with salacious intent.

"And it does." Adora said, a growing smile on her face.

"Then…" Catra paused, frowned. "Shit, I had something for this. Something about… briefs?"

"I may swoon at any moment." Adora snickered.

Catra huffed, a little annoyed. "Look, just shut up and kiss me, alright?"

Adora laughed aloud, and shortly after that, did as she was asked.

Chapter End Notes

> Okay so remember how I said the clones would be in this chapter? That was before I got carried away just having these two idiots be absolutely dumb in love with one another. Blame season five for this foray into overindulgent fluffiness, with a side helping of Glimmer being mortified. I swear I kept trying to make them angsty but then they would just start flirting ineptly at one another, it's not me I swear it's not me.
>
> Don't worry, the kids are gonna show up next chapter for sure. I'm not sure what else we'll see, because any time I write the clones there's a nonzero chance things get

overindulgently kind and sweet, much like whenever I put Adora and Catra in the same room.

This might be the last of the quick updates - which isn't to say that they'll slow down a lot, just that I had a couple other ideas that I might fiddle around with first. I keep saying stuff like this to manage expectations so that when I drop off the face of the earth and we go back to a month between chapters you'll have been warned.

Also, hello new people! You thought I didn't notice you, but nothing escapes my empty, hollow sockets. Thanks for the kudos, comments, and (possible) recommendations to your friends. You're all delightful.

Burdens

Chapter Summary

> Catra admires the view. Adora is a distraction. Scorpia's sense of timing is great. C'yra asks a hard question.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra woke slowly, luxuriating in the way Adora's weight rested comfortably on her. The strain of the previous day's exertions had finally caught up with them both sometime after sundown, and while Catra had initially thought they'd eventually put clothes on and leave the room to eat, they had in fact both nodded off instead. Catra considered that if not for her stomach's traitorous decision to remind her how long it had been since she'd had nourishment that wasn't from an IV drip, she might still be asleep, and looked down where Adora had buried herself in the soft fur of Catra's chest with what she knew, deep down, was an immensely goofy-looking grin. She was even prepared to forgive the fact that Adora was currently drooling on her breasts.

She ran the fingers of her good hand through Adora's hair gently and purred in contentment. "Gods," she murmured, "I cannot believe how much I love you."

Adora, occupying the center of Catra's universe, the most beautiful woman on this planet or any other that apparently(?) existed, mumbled something incoherent and sneezed as some of Catra's fur tickled her nose. It was both extremely disgusting and unbearably cute at the same time. Catra considered the merits of allowing her to continue sleeping, and very well might have done so, except Adora (the only woman Catra would or could ever love, with a heart so strong that it had pulled Catra back from death's clutches, who had never given up on the hope the Catra would find her way to her in spite of a laundry list of ways Catra had

hurt her) chose that moment to attempt to nuzzle further into Catra's chest which both exacerbated the sneezing issue and *tickled* , so much so that Catra couldn't quite keep from laughing, loudly. The defender of Etheria went from zero to full combat readiness in two seconds, which would have been more impressive if she wasn't naked and if her legs had (apparently) not quite recovered from the previous night.

As it was, she gave an undignified (*adorable* , Catra thought) squeak and toppled back over, which resulted in her landing heavily on Catra's stomach. Somehow Catra managed to both make a noise of pain at the impact and laugh even harder.

"Easy there, Adora!" she said, wrapping her up in her arms before Adora could make a second attempt. "No emergency, you just uh… you just tickled me a little."

There was a moment where Adora got her bearings as the fog of sleep gradually cleared. She looked around the room first, then up at Catra, then smiled like she was determined to outshine the sun. "Catra!" she said, brightly, then looked down at her position, back up, and blushed, looking shy, as if she hadn't spent a good portion of the previous evening causing Catra to fly apart at the seams and yowl obscene words of encouragement and affection. "Hi."

I am going to die here. Catra thought. *Adora is out to kill me by making my heart explode.* "Hi yourself, Adora. You sleep well?"

In response, Adora flopped back down on Catra's stomach (a bit more gently this time). "Yes. You're a very soft pillow."

Catra wanted to feel annoyed at being reduced to a pillow, but Adora was rubbing lazy circles into her stomach fur and, well, it was difficult to do anything but purr. She let her head fall back and closed her eye, hand back to idly stroking Adora's hair. "We should get something to eat." she finally managed to say.

Adora pressed a kiss to Catra's stomach that caused her breath to catch. "Well, I am a *little* hungry."

“Gods, Adora.” Catra managed, as Adora planted another kiss - a little lower, this time. “Are you trying to make sure we never leave this room?”

Adora took a deep breath that Catra *felt* . “Mmm. Is it working?”

Catra groaned. “Maybe a little.”

Adora’s throaty chuckle sent sparks running haywire through Catra’s body. “Good. I have to keep my pillow happy, after all.”

Scorpia’s voice suddenly intruded, emanating from the small communicator Catra kept by the bed. “Commander, are you there? The kids were asking when you’d be able train them again.”

Adora gave Catra a questioning look from her position just above her waist. “You’re training our clones?”

Catra sighed, reached over to paw at the communicator, realized she’d reached with the wrong hand, and rolled over completely, dislodging Adora and causing her to yelp. She mouthed a “sorry” to Adora and picked up the comm.

“Hey Scorp. Tell them to meet me at the training grounds in two hours - it should be free then, yeah?”

“Yep. You might want to get ready quick though - they seem pretty eager to see you and C’yra’s definitely planning some kind of assault on your room if we don’t let them back there. Not, of course,” Scorpia said, and there was fondness in her voice, “that she would ever admit to worrying about you. Takes after *you* there, Commander.”

“Hey, I’m open about my feelings!” Catra sounded outraged. “I love Adora and I’m never going to leave her! I think you’re too good of a friend to me and I don’t deserve it! In fact I don’t think I deserve anything other than death a lot of the time but I’m working on it! I spent most of last night having sex with the woman I love and that was my morning plan too until you called! How’s *that* for fucking open, huh?”

Adora's shocked laughter echoed in the room, and Catra thought she could hear Scorpia's face growing red on the other end of the line. "Very… very open, Commander." There was a cough. "I'll just… I'll let you get dressed and tell the kids to uh, meet you. Yeah. That sounds like the plan I was going to do."

"See that you do, Scorpia. I'm giving up a morning in the arms of a gorgeous woman for this."

Adora couldn't tell if Scorpia was mortified, trying not to laugh, or a combination of the two. "Yep okay Commander see you later!" There was a chirp as the call disconnected.

Catra sat up and stretched, then shot a look down where Adora had claimed a position draped across her legs. "As much as it pains me to say it, Adora, I think I have to get up now."

"How disappointing." Adora said, stretching in a way that Catra definitely found interesting. *Seeing the kids* , Adora thought. *I wonder.* "Do you…" she started to say, and then hesitated. "Do you think they'd want to see me too?"

Catra's instinct was to say *of course they would* , but if she was being honest she didn't actually know. Certainly both had made some progress, and she'd talked with C'yra about letting her anger go, but… "I have no idea." she answered, and regretted it immediately as Adora's shoulders slumped. "Mara seemed to be getting along well enough with you at the Crystal Castle, and C'yra and I have.. talked about how she feels about you."

"How many other people did I hurt when I left?" Adora whispered, hugging herself as if to make herself smaller. "You, I knew I'd hurt. Who else caught hell for me leaving?"

Catra was there almost immediately, hands soft on her shoulders. "You can't blame yourself for that, Adora. You had to go. It would have killed you to stay."

"But-"

Catra's claws pricked lightly at Adora's skin, cutting her off. "I swear to all the gods Adora if you say it would be better if you'd died I will kill you myself. You don't need to take the weight of everyone's problems on, okay?" She kissed her gently, then whispered, "You aren't alone. You know that, right?"

"I know, it's just…" Adora sighed, shook her head. "Habit, I guess. I'm the mighty She-Ra, after all." Her voice sounded strained. "Defender of Etheria and great hope of the Rebellion."

Catra snorted and gave Adora a playful shove, trying to lighten the mood. "Yeah, well, the mighty She-Ra was drooling on my tits like five minutes ago so maybe cool it with the defender of the universe stuff, huh?"

"I don't *drool!* " Adora said, sounding scandalized.

"Adora, my fur's still damp. I don't want to call it an open and shut case, but… I don't see anyone else here."

"You could've… done it yourself! This is a frame job!" Adora stood, pointing accusingly in mock horror. "Betrayal!"

"A what now?"

"It's from these detective books Mermista likes."

"She's the… grumpy water one, right?"

"Yes, she's the - wait, we've been fighting how long and you never learned the names of the other princesses? You're not serious."

"No," Catra admitted, "I'm not serious at all."

"Brat." Adora said, swatting Catra. "Just for that, I'm taking the shower first."

"Ugh, fine, but only because I'm such a good host." Catra said, falling back on the bed a little dramatically.

Adora laughed and gave Catra a kiss before heading into the bathroom. Catra watched her go, tail swishing back and forth. She got up and grabbed some clothes for after her shower, ear twitching as she heard the telltale sounds of Adora singing something that sounded curiously like a sea shanty to herself. Catra's tail swished back and forth, and she took a deep breath. She managed to last another two minutes before she gave up and joined Adora in the shower.

Breakfast ended up shortened by necessity. Adora, dressed in a standard uniform (she happened to like the way it looked on her, and if Catra did too, well, that was just a bonus, wasn't it?) watched Catra closely as they ate, both because Catra was nice to look at and because somewhere in the back of her mind Adora knew she probably should've gotten more rest than they'd actually had the night before. Not that she *regretted* it, of course, but… Catra had been fairly close to dead.

The thought echoed uglily in her mind. To come so close to losing Catra again had been terrifying, and if not for the calming influence of She-Ra's powers, Adora wasn't sure what she could have done. It was entirely likely, Adora thought, that she would have refused to leave Catra's side even without Glimmer's unexpected offer - one which Adora still hadn't fully wrapped her head around. Something had shifted in Glimmer, some reignition of the rebellious streak she'd had when they'd first met. Adora wasn't sure what it actually *meant* for the Princess Alliance as a whole, and while a part of her worried that covering up what they were doing would end badly, a far greater part of her was so stunned by the idea of *not having to leave Catra's side* it silenced all worry. *You deserve something for yourself* , Glimmer had said. Well, Catra was something, and Adora did want her to herself. She could worry about the larger issues later, like maybe after she figured out how to talk to C'yra and Mara without… overthinking everything.

"She doesn't hate you." Mara said, a little apologetically. The statement hung in the air as Adora maneuvered equipment around to help Entrapta set up.

"Huh?"

"C'yra. She doesn't hate you." Mara repeated. "She just… gets real mad about everything, you know? What the Horde did."

"Well it is *my fault." Adora replied, sighing.*

Mara rolled her eyes. "Gods, you're just like her." she said, sounding annoyed.

"Huh?"

"C'yra blames herself for everything too." Mara said, simply. "It's dumb. You didn't know, and I'm pretty sure Shadow Weaver would've been bad regardless. The Horde didn't wait until you left to become bad, you know."

"It got worse, though, didn't it?" Adora asked, challengingly.

Mara was quiet, and Adora regretted asking, but then she seemed to recover and shrugged carelessly. "There wasn't much of a difference."

"I'm still responsible." Adora said, stubbornly, feeling a little foolish. "I'm still going to make sure they pay for this."

"With your magical She-Ra powers?" Mara asked, grinning.

"Well, yeah. Probably a little." Adora replied.

"How does… how does that work? They told me I was you - does that mean I'm going to turn into a giant lady with a sword some day?"

"I don't know." Adora admitted. "You're a... copy of me, I guess, and the Sword is supposedly keyed to me somehow, but I don't know for sure. It would probably choose you after I'm dead, though?"

"So after C'yra kills you, I'd be She-Ra?"

"I guess so." Adora said wryly. "Just try not to drive C'yra to the other side of whatever war's going on at the time when you get the sword, huh?"

Catra's voice interrupted her reveille. "Hey, you still in there Adora? You've been staring at those eggs for the last five minutes."

Adora blinked, coming back to herself. "Huh? Sorry, Catra. Just… thinking."

"It'll be fine, Adora. They'll come around." Catra said, as if reading her mind. "At any rate, *I'll* be happy to have you around. The training dummies aren't ideal for demonstrations."

"Plus you *loooove* me." Adora singsonged, grinning annoyingly.

Catra snorted, outwardly annoyed but inwardly glad to have distracted Adora. "Yeah well, don't go getting a big head about it. Now come on, we'd better get going."

Mara and C'yra dashed up to Catra as soon as she came in sight. "Comma-er, Catra!" Mara shouted, making no effort to hide the relief in her voice as she hugged her. "You're okay!"

C'yra stood off to the side and, with a little more control but a shaking in her voice that was unmistakable, merely said "It's good to see you up and about, Commander."

Catra smiled fondly at the two. "'Course I'm okay," she said, a little bravado in her tone. "You two have too much training left for me to leave you to your own devices. Plus," indicating Adora with a jerk of her head, "this one would never let me hear the end of it."

The two had been so excited to see Catra that they'd somehow missed Adora's presence. There was a flash of anger on C'yra's face that was quickly replaced something a little more neutral. "Adora. We'd heard you arrived yesterday but didn't see you. What brought you here?"

“She’s the reason I’m alive, C’yra.” Catra said, gently. “She came to heal me.”

C’yra stiffened a little in surprise, and her ears flattened against her head guiltily. “Thank you, Adora.” she said, bowing a little formally. “I… apologize for-”

“No please, don’t apologize.” Adora said, crouching down and speaking in a soft tone. “It’s not your fault. It never has been.”

“But I-”

Adora’s voice was firm. “You aren’t responsible for what you’ve been taught. You see that it’s wrong, and you change accordingly. Do you still think I’m a great betrayer? That the Horde is bringing civilization to Etheria?”

“No.”

“Then don’t apologize.” Adora repeated. Catra stared at her, curious. Her eyes flickered with a blue light, and Adora breathed deep before continuing. “It’s… hard. It’s hard to let go of old beliefs, old feelings. You can’t just *forget* everything you were taught about me - about the way the world supposedly was. But you can identify those lies for what they are, now. Eventually those feelings will fade.”

C’yra looked into Adora’s eyes like they might have some kind of secret, and for all Catra knew they did. “What did Shadow Weaver lie to *you* about, Adora?” There was no malice in the question, no anger - just curiosity.

“How the world worked. Who I was.” Adora said, voice steady. “What I was meant to do with my life. My place in the world. Who I should depend on. Who I could-” she paused again, and her eyes darted to Catra quickly. “Who I could love.”

Catra breathed in sharply and her hands balled into fists. She’d suspected it, of course - her whole life, *their* whole life, Shadow Weaver had told Catra how worthless she was, how *unworthy* of

Adora's attention she was. That Adora had been encouraged to discard Catra was not news. It was still, she found, not easy to hear. Catra nudged Mara and gave her a wordless nod to another part of the training grounds, sensing that Adora probably had more to say but it wasn't for her to hear - not yet. Mara looked torn, but something about the way C'yra's tail moved seemed to settle the question for her and she followed Catra.

"She told me that it was my fault whenever Mara got punished." C'yra said, almost inaudible. "Sometimes she'd make me watch, to make sure we both understood. If I screamed at her to stop, she would punish her even worse. It was my responsibility to watch - to be reminded that it was-"

"Your fault." Adora breathed out, heart breaking. "Yeah. I know. Everything depended on a flawless performance from you, right?" C'yra nodded, her body beginning to shake. Hesitantly, Adora reached out and placed a hand on the young magicat's shoulder. "It wasn't your fault, C'yra. None of it was your fault. I know that's difficult to believe - but you weren't the cause of what happened to Mara. You weren't the cause of what happened to *you* ."

C'yra had taken a hesitant step forward when Adora's hand landed on her shoulder, and now she stumbled even further forward, landing against Adora's body with a jolt. "But… if everything Shadow Weaver told me was a lie," she said, and it seemed like she was struggling to speak. Adora waited, saying nothing, keeping her hand steady on C'yra's shoulder. "What am I supposed to do? Who am I, if I'm not the Horde's savior? A perfect copy of the Commander, meant to take her place if… if something happened to her?"

Another lie , She-Ra's voice spoke up. *She's not a copy. Not like you think* .

Adora shook her head, shoved the thought aside. "C'yra, you have so much time to answer that question. But nobody can tell you what you're meant to be. You get to choose, and we'll make sure that you get the chance to. That's kind of our job."

“But what if I fail? What if I’m not *good enough* ?”

“If you fail?” Adora shrugged. “Then your friends will help you back up, and you can try again.”

C’yra looked dubious. “It *can’t* be that easy.”

“Easy?” Adora looked thoughtful. “No, I guess it isn’t always easy. But you don’t have to do it alone. You never did, no matter what she told you. Your friends aren’t a distraction. They’re your strength.”

C’yra’s tail snaked around Adora’s leg. “Do you… do you promise that I have a choice?”

Adora brought her head down to C’yra’s and rested her forehead against the young magicat’s. “I promise.”

Chapter End Notes

> Well, I didn't plan on having Adora and C'yra have a heart to heart but hey weird something had me think this conversation seemed relevant somehow. Probably nothing, huh? Probably talking about coming together to help each other, particularly in a fight against tyranny and abuse has no bearing on current events. I mean these themes were all present and going to get covered sooner or later, but sometimes the real world just kinda... gets in there when you don't mean it to, and if you're me you run with it.
>
> Look, the point is. The point is.
>
> Fuck the police. That's the point.
>
> Hopefully all the nonsense at the beginning involving Adora and Catra just being *absolutely ridiculous* together provided a break before the heavy stuff. Good thing we're not going to the Crystal Castle to talk to a deranged AI next chapter, huh? I'm sure that will be a very relaxing time.

Stay safe out there. Help how you can. Hang on tight. Much like the theme song says, now is the time to both be strong and brave. I love you guys, thanks for reading, we'll be back soon.

Acceptable Losses

Chapter Summary

> Light Hope spills the beans. Catra feels terrible about some things. Adora makes a slight miscalculation.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora sensed something was wrong as soon as the skiff set down. The front door to the Crystal Castle stood open, a flickering light emanating from the entryway. Catra sniffed the air experimentally and gave Adora a sideways look.

"You forget to lock up last time, Adora?" she asked, tone light.

"Oh sure," Adora said, snorting, "just left the front door to the building full of powerful ancient technology standing open, you know me."

"Yeah, that's what I thought." Catra said, and her hand dipped and came up holding a small pistol. "Guess I shouldn't have listened to you and brought a rifle with me after all, huh?"

Adora rolled her eyes. "Hey, I said you could if you wanted!"

"Yeah, but you only said that after you'd said you thought a rifle would be overkill."

"That's because it *would* be." Adora said, with perhaps a *slightly* teasing tone in her voice. "I mean come on, only a fool trusts their life to a *weapon* , remember?"

"I'm still not convinced they didn't just tell us that to cover up the fact that Shadow Weaver wasn't equipping the troops properly." Catra grumbled. "But you have a point. I think She-Ra can probably handle whatever this place would throw at us."

“Oh please, like you’d just sit back and watch.”

“I don’t know, have you *seen* the way your ass looks in that outfit?”

“Technically it’s *She-Ra’s* ass.”

“And you’re She-Ra, so it’s still your ass.”

The matter-of-fact way Catra delivered the comment made something in Adora’s heart shift, and she smiled. “Alright, well, you’ve got me there.” She peered into the doorway and then spun on her heel to give Catra the world’s cockiest grin. “So, ready to step into an obviously dangerous situation?”

“Wait, one second.” Catra bounded forward and kissed Adora, then stepped back with a grin of her own. “Okay, now we can go.”

Adora blushed. “You’re such a sap.”

“Don’t tell anyone,” Catra warned, “I’ve got a reputation to maintain.”

The source of the flickering light was - as Adora had suspected - the central console in the massive front hall. While she’d guessed the source, however, she had no idea what the cause could be. The console sparked, like something inside it had been damaged irreparably. Adora approached it cautiously, worried that it might explode or mistake her for an enemy and deploy spider bots.

“Light Hope?” she called out into the silence. “Are you there?”

Catra looked at Adora and shrugged. “Wasn’t there some kind of password or something to access this place?”

“Oh, right.” Adora said. “I just… haven’t had to use it in a while.” She cleared her throat and spoke in a clear voice. “Eternia.”

The flickering light stopped. There was a hum from somewhere deep within the facility. Deep purple lighting suffused the hall, and

Light Hope snapped into focus above the console.

“W-welcom-e, Sh-sh-he-Ra. Administrat-t-t-t-or access granted.”

Adora frowned. “Light Hope, give me a damage report.”

Light Hope flickered, alternating color between a deep purple and a softer pink for a moment before responding. “Critical damage to hear-r-r-r-r-t of E-e-e-e-e-theria control-l-l-l-l sys-sys-ystem. Sw-sw-sword of Prot-t-t-t-ection offline. L-l-l-ight Hope s-s-s-simulacrum fault. E-e-e-eternian imperial n-n-network offline. M-m-m-memory replica-ca-ca-cation offline. B-b-black garnet unaligned-d-d-d-d. D-de-fense system offline. Manual res-s-s-start requir-r-r-ed.”

“How do I restart the system?” Adora asked.

The hologram of Light Hope disappeared and was replaced with a three dimensional map of the Palace. Two blinking red dots displayed as Light Hope’s voice echoed through the hall.

“Power terminals must be ma-ma-manually switched over to e-e-e-emergency power.”

“Cause of damage?” Catra asked, surprised to hear herself ask the question.

“Q-q-q-uerier not recognized.”

“Light Hope, cause of damage?” Adora asked, smiling slightly at the way Catra rolled her eye and stuck her tongue out at the terminal.

“S-s-s-abotage by members of m-m-m-agicat separat-t-t-t-ist group Sq-q-q-uad Greysk-sk-sk-skull. D-d-d-imensional shif-f-f-f-t caused further d-d-d-damag-g-ge to r-r-r-unestone networ-r-r-r-rk. Bla-ack-ack garnet d-d-discon-n-n-ected.”

That’s interesting . Catra thought, and made a note to talk to Entrapta about it. She was about to nudge Adora when she

suddenly asked, “Play last transmission from this console. Administrator override.”

The map glitched and disappeared, replaced by what seemed to be a recording of Light Hope, but she was a pale pink instead of her usual dark purple. Light Hope’s voice shifted, sounding more alive, less artificial than before. “Emergency transmission, priority broadcast code 6-18-9-5-14-4-19-15-6-13-1-18-1. Mara, we are out of time. Eternian High Command has decided to use the Heart - I cannot stop them. The failsafe program is safe in Mystacor and is your best option, access code 6-18-13. Should you be unable to breach Mystacor, then you *must* activate the dimensional shift before firing preparations are complete. I am sorry Mara. You can no longer trust me. I have been compromised. They are going to reprogram me. I will delete my memory of making this message to keep it safe. I love you. Message ends.”

The image glitched, resolved, and the message repeated. Adora looked over at Catra, tears in her eyes. “They *killed* her. Them. They killed… they killed *both* of them. My… my people murdered them.”

“Hey, focus.” Catra said, placing a hand on Adora’s shoulder. “We can digest… all that stuff later. You need answers from the other Light Hope, right? We’ve got to get this place back online. Maybe you can find out more about this… Heart thing, find out if it was Light Hope who brought you here.” There was a pause as Catra considered her next question. “Um, why did you ask her to play the last transmission back, anyway?”

“I just… had a feeling I needed to.”

Catra raised an eyebrow. “A uh, She-Ra sort of feeling?”

“Yeah.” Adora nodded. “Since I broke the sword it’s like… it’s like sometimes I just *know* things. I knew there was something on the terminal I needed to hear, and the other day at the training grounds I…” she trailed off.

“You?” Catra nudged.

“I don’t think they’re clones.” Adora said. “Not precise copies. You’ve seen C’yra’s markings, they aren’t yours - and Mara’s eyes and hair aren’t quite the same as mine either. I think… I think they’ve been altered somehow. Or.. or She-Ra does, so I do. Does that make sense?”

“Not at all.” Catra said, then shrugged. “Then again, I don’t think I’ll ever understand any of this She-Ra stuff, so. If your… magical princess instincts say there’s something else going on with the kids, then I guess I’ll trust your instincts.” Her ears twitched at the sound of something moving outside the castle door and she shoved thoughts on the clones (not quite clones?) to the back of her mind. “Come on, we’d better get this place back online. I think the local fauna might see that open door as an invitation.”

Adora nodded and the two set off in the direction the map had indicated. The facility hallways were dark, but Adora had come prepared and produced a small flashlight to find her way. Catra followed behind, her ears perked up for the slightest sound of movement. She felt increasingly on edge - not just because they were in a facility that had clearly been compromised, but because they were bringing a system back online with no way of knowing how it would react to a She-Ra free of the Sword of Protection’s control. There would be a fight, Catra thought. That or the place would start showing them memories again, which was not something she was particularly eager to experience. *Why did I listen to Adora and leave the rifle? This pistol isn’t going to do anything.*

The lights in the hallway flickered suddenly, and the sound of fighting cut in and out. Adora looked like she was about to transform for a moment, but then she lowered her hand and relaxed. “It’s okay.” she said, looking back to Catra. “I think the surveillance system is playing back old footage. Not sure *why* , though.”

The sounds grew louder the further in they went. Catra, in spite of Adora's reassurance, unsheathed her claws and breathed a mental sigh of relief that she'd at least worn the more melee-focused hand for this trip. "Gee Adora, you always take me to such interesting places."

"What, you don't like my choice of date?" Adora laughed, and there was something in the tone of it that made Catra think Adora was grateful for the distraction. "You didn't mind this place *last* time we came here."

"Yeah well last time we weren't rebooting a potentially hostile… whatever the hell Light Hope is." Catra grumbled.

"What, you don't wanna make out a little in a haunted Eternian ruin?" Adora teased, the slightest hint of flirtation in her voice - just enough to make Catra consider the idea.

"I mean, let's not say anything we can't take back." Catra said, matching Adora's tone. "But then again Glimmer might get mad if I include 'making out with Adora' on the invoice."

Adora grinned and there was something on the edge of predatory in her expression. "What she doesn't know won't hurt her."

"Hey now," Catra said, smirking, "I'm an honest businesswoman. Can't be hiding things from my clients if I want to get repeat business."

"Says you." Adora smirked right back, then with an almost casual movement pinned Catra to the wall. "Still," she said, ghosting her lips over Catra's, "I guess if you wanna be *responsible* about it, we can-"

A particularly loud shout broke them apart. "Greyskull Squadron, we're nearly there! Maintain formation and we'll breach that command center in no time!"

Adora's head snapped around and her eyes were wide with shock. "Greyskull?" Without waiting for a response (or allowing Catra to

recover) she took off running down the hallway. When she rounded a corner, she saw it all play out in front of her. Mara, sword up, eyes bright and defiant, leading a group of other Eternians and Magicats in battle against innumerable security drones, backed up by uniformed guards. Catra arrived a second later, just in time to watch one magicat soldier's head snap back and drop without a sound. Mara didn't seem to notice and cleared a path, the sword shifting almost too fast to follow - now a spear, now a shield, now a whip - cutting through drones and soldiers alike.

Catra and Adora followed the battle as Greyskull Squadron forced its way step by step down the corridor. By the time they reached the end of the hallway, there were only four soldiers left - a magicat and three Eternians, plus Mara. Mara kicked through the door (*ah* , Catra thought, *that explains where it went*) and strode inside.

"Light Hope! I'm here!"

Light Hope flickered into existence. "Hello Mara. Your presence here is no longer required. The Council has decreed the Heart must be fired."

There was anger and something else in Mara's voice. "Light Hope, no. You can fight this. You don't have to-"

"The Council's decision is final. I am bound to follow the Council." Light Hope raised a hand, and any semblance of friendliness vanished from her face. "As are you."

Mara screamed as the Sword of Protection flared to life in her hand, light pouring out of her eyes and mouth. She staggered backwards, dropped to her knees and screamed again. Raising the sword above her head, she brought it down on the ground with terrifying force and staggered forward. The light went out. She looked at the remaining soldiers with her.

“I have to go. I can stop this, but… you need to stay here and confirm the dimensional jump coordinates.”

One of the Eternians spoke up. “What about the failsafe? Surely we can-”

“There’s no *time!* ” Mara shouted. “I know what I’m asking you to do. We can’t stop the Heart, but… but we can at least keep the rest of the galaxy safe and keep this from happening again.”

“Mara…” the magicat approached and took Mara’s hand in hers. Adora noticed, dimly, that she wore a golden headpiece and looked a lot like Dhar’ra. *My old friend,* She-Ra’s voice echoed in her mind. “Are you sure?”

“I am sorry, C’yra.” Mara said, and there were tears in her eyes. “There is no other way. I have to do this.”

C’yra closed her eyes and took a deep breath before pulling Mara into a fierce hug. “Then go, my old friend.” she whispered, fiercely. “We’ll make sure the confirmation goes through.”

One of the Eternians walked to the console and began entering commands rapidly. “Security systems are offline now, Mara.” he called over his shoulder. “You should have a straight shot out.”

Mara stepped back, nodded, and hesitated for a moment, sharing one last look with C’yra, who shook her head. “Get moving, hero.”

Mara strode from the room. C’yra’s attention turned back to the console and she began entering commands, tears in her eyes. The footage cut out. Adora and Catra looked at one another. “I can’t believe it.” Adora breathed out, finally. “She knew. She knew she wasn’t coming back.”

Catra swallowed, knowing that Adora would’ve made the same choice - knowing that she wouldn’t have been able to stand watching it happen. “Come on, Adora. The first of the power terminals is over here.”

Unlike the rest of the First Ones technology Catra had encountered in what had ultimately been a lengthy career of racing the Rebellion to get an edge, the power terminal seemed shockingly straightforward. It consisted of a very obviously important-looking breaker with two labels she couldn't read.

"Okay," Adora said, peering at the breaker, "I guess we just…" she reached out and threw the breaker switch to one side. There was a low hum and a soft red lighting slowly came up in the room. "Yeah. That seems to have… done something?"

"L-l-light Hop-p-p-pe s-s-s-simulacr-cr-cr-um online. Wel-wel-welcome, She-Ra and Companion. Aler-rt-rt-rt. Defense systems still offline. Recom-men-mended course of act-ct-ct-ction: complete power res-se-se-se-set."

"Isn't she useful." Catra muttered, already heading out of the room. "Come on, Adora."

"Hang on, let me just…" Adora turned in the direction of a console in the command room. "Light Hope, can you answer queries in your current state?"

"Yes, She-she-she-Ra."

Adora took a deep breath. "How did I arrive on this planet?"

"Subject brought via dimensio-sion-sion-sion-sional shift using st-st-st-ored pow-we-we-we-wer reservv-v-ves as a replacement for subject Mara, deceased. Sword of Protection user is requi-qui-qui-quired for successful deploy-ploy-ployment of Heart of Etheria weapons system."

"Where did you take me from?"

"Planetary data was n-n-n-n-not reco-cor-cor-cor-corded. Compatibility with Sword of Protection detected and retrieval ex-ex-ex-executed. All other matters deemed unneces-ss-ss-ss-ssary for power preservation con-con-concerns."

Catra placed a hand on Adora's shoulder and squeezed. "Adora…"

A bitter laugh echoed in the silence. "It wasn't fate. It wasn't even… it was just random chance. I was just the first thing she found." Adora's voice cracked. "I was ripped from my home and brought here just to be a weapon. It was never about restoring balance, or saving Etheria - I was brought here to destroy."

"So?" Catra asked, voice a little sharp. "Are you going to destroy the universe, Adora?"

Adora blinked in surprise. "What?"

"Are you going to fire the Heart and destroy the universe?" Catra repeated, patiently.

"Of course not-"

"Then who cares, Adora?" Catra exclaimed, throwing her arms out wide in exasperation. "You know what Shadow Weaver told *me* growing up? That I was a worthless monster. That I was an *unnecessary distraction* for you." her voice shook, and Adora looked like she wanted to say something, but Catra cut her off and continued. "She ground those lessons into my *bones* , Adora, and had me convinced for so long that's all I was ever going to be. But I wasn't. And you, I'm sorry to say, are a lot of things, but a weapon of mass destruction isn't one of them."

"But Catra, none of that was ever true." Adora replied. "Just Shadow Weaver trying to…" her voice trailed off.

Catra raised an eyebrow and looked at Adora. There was a glint of amusement in her eye. "Trying to *what* , Adora?"

Everything clicked into place. "Trying to control you."

"And why," Catra said, tail waving back and forth, patience in her tone, "do you think Light Hope told you so often that you're Etheria's last hope, and that it's your destiny to bring balance?"

Adora breathed out, feeling a sudden lightness. “To control me.”

“So…”

“So it doesn’t matter why she brought me here.” Adora’s eyes brightened. “I’ve made my own choices. I’m going to…” she paused, expression shifting into a look Catra recognized as Adora’s ‘I just made a decision and nothing is going to change my mind’ face, “I’m going to fix this. That blockage I felt as She-Ra, I think… I think if we can get to the Heart, I can do it. I can actually *heal the damage* this war did, Catra.”

“That’s my girl.” Catra said, standing on tiptoe to press a kiss to Adora’s lips. “Now come on, we’ll get this place back online and find out more about this-”

The room plunged into darkness, then came back online again. A soft static overlaid everything, indicating they were probably watching more security footage. Catra looked around and her heart sank. C’yra was slumped over the console, dead. The bodies of the other two rebel fighters were on the floor nearby, surrounded by the wreckage of drones and other Eternian soldiers. Two surviving soldiers stood amidst the ruin, breathing heavily.

“Shoot her again.” one said to the other. “Just to be sure.”

The other looked at his companion and rolled her eyes, but shouldered her rifle and fired. C’yra’s body jerked with the impact and slid off the console, leaving a bloody smear behind her. “Happy now?”

The man shook his head. “No. What the fuck even *happened* ? Light Hope? Can you give me a status report?”

“The dimensional shift has severely damaged the Heart of Etheria system. Ship impact detected in Kingdom of Halfmoon. Runestone network status: offline. She-Ra status: deceased.”

“Wait, *dimensional shift?* ” The man frowned. “Where *are* we?”

“Despandos. No other planetary bodies detected.”

“Shift us back, then.”

“Unable to comply. Insufficient power. Runestone network status: offline.”

“So what,” the woman said, looking horrified, “we’re *stuck* here?”

“In order to execute a successful dimensional shift, the runestone network must be brought back online.” Light Hope replied. “The Sword of Protection must also be found, and a new She-Ra chosen.”

“But all replacement candidates are off-world!” the man shouted. “This planet is a military outpost, not a colony!”

“A suitable candidate must be produced in order to restore balance to the runestone network.” Light Hope intoned. The two soldiers looked at one another uncomfortably.

“Uh, so we’re supposed to…?”

“I will locate a suitable candidate.” Light Hope said. “Forced production of a candidate is not required.”

“Oh thank the stars.” the man muttered. “Er, not that… uh…”

“No, no.” replied the woman. “It’s uh, it’s mutual.”

Clearly looking for a way out of the conversation, the man turned back to Light Hope. “What should we do while you’re locating a candidate?”

“Ensure the myth of She-Ra continues.” Light Hope intoned. “Do not allow the truth of the Heart to disrupt the support of our allies in Brightmoon. The remnants of the Rebellion must be discredited and extinguished. You will be the first ones to inform our allies of She-Ra’s tragic madness that led to this calamity. When another candidate is located, I will train them as She-Ra, and we will

restore the runestone network and fulfill the will of the Council. Our enemies *must not survive* ."

The two soldiers looked at one another, shrugged, and bowed. "It will be as you say, Light Hope."

The recording blinked out. Catra had been frozen, looking at the corpse of the Queen of the Magicats on the floor. When the recording disappeared, so did the Queen's body. "Well, I guess that explains 'the whole First Ones nonsense.'" Adora muttered.

Catra kept looking at where the Queen had fallen. Adora looked at her with a curious expression. "Catra? Are you okay?"

"She loved her." Catra said, quietly. "I think… I think she loved her."

Adora's brow wrinkled in confusion. "What do you mean? She had a family, didn't she? The line of succession was maintained, wasn't it?"

"Yeah, but…" she took a deep breath. "That look she gave Mara. I knew that look. It's the same look I used to give you. She was in love with Mara. Fuck, Adora, she loved her enough to *die* for her. You said Mara knew she was going to die when she left here. I think C'yra knew she was going to die when she stayed here." She shivered again. "Let's get out of here. I hate this fucking place."

"Yeah." Adora said, swallowing. "I think I'm starting to agree with you."

The two hurried through the corridors, hoping they wouldn't be privy to any further security footage as they went. It seemed the system (or perhaps, Adora thought, whatever remnant of the original Light Hope that remained) had shown them what it wanted to show, however, because they made it to the next breaker uninterrupted.

"So uh, what exactly happens once we throw this breaker?" Catra asked, suddenly feeling a little nervous.

"Well, it'll bring everything back online, which means that the place will be secure again - which I'm inclined to think is probably a good thing with the Horde still in operation. More importantly, I'll be able to access more information about the Heart."

"Okay." Catra nodded. "Let's do it."

Adora threw the switch. The lighting didn't change, but there was another hum and Light Hope's voice broke in again.

"Emergency power online. Defense systems online. Memory replication online. Light Hope simulacrum reboot complete. Runestone network offline. Eternian Imperial Network offline. Sword of Protection offline. Welcome, She-Ra. What is your query?"

"What is the Heart of Etheria?"

Light Hope's form flickered and was replaced by an image of an enormous cavern. A massive structure hung in the center, glowing faintly. "The Heart of Etheria is a mass-energy dispersal mechanism. Magical energy is syphoned from the surrounding environment and filtered through the runestone network. At the moment of use, the system draws on the energy of each runestone's associated princess to detonate the stored energy, sending a wave of force through space in a detonation pattern that would theoretically reach every planet within the mapped galaxy."

"Wouldn't that just kill everyone?" Catra asked, confused. Light Hope did not respond, so Adora repeated the question.

"Eternian citizens were given access to special bunkers." Light Hope replied. "Upon firing, the Heart would send a priority signal with instructions to shelter."

"And the non-citizens?" Adora asked. "The ones who *weren't* your enemy?"

“Acceptable losses.” Light Hope responded, tone unchanged. “The Council determined this to be a necessary sacrifice in light of the threat posed by the Horde.”

This time Adora beat Catra to the obvious question. “Who is the Horde?”

“Details unknown. Reports suggest they function as a hivemind with a central leader, known only as Prime. Last intelligence suggests nearly 75% of known galactic space is currently considered to be under Horde control. Eternian Imperial holdings have been reduced to only 20%. Battle projections suggest that no traces of the Eternian Empire remain outside this dimension.”

“What is the Failsafe?”

“Unknown.”

Adora groaned. “Can the magic stored in the Heart be released safely?”

“Unknown.”

“Ask her for complete schematics of the Heart.” suggested Catra. “Maybe Entrapta can figure something out.”

“Request complete schematics of the Heart of Etheria.” Adora said.

“Access denied. She-Ra is not authorized.”

“Administrator override.”

“Sword of Protection required for administrator override.”

Adora groaned in frustration and held out her hand. She-Ra’s sword appeared out of thin air in front of her. “There. Sword of Protection. Now override.”

“Alert.” Light Hope said, placidly, “She-Ra control system offline. She-Ra must now be considered a hostile entity. Deploying defense drones.”

“Ah.” Adora said. “Fuck.”

Chapter End Notes

See, I told you it would be a while before the next update and I was finally right. Plenty of reasons for it, most of them centering around having stuff to do on weekends a little more often. The good kind of stuff, don't worry. Later it might be for bad stuff - it's the summer and I fuckin' do not do well in the summer - but we'll make it through somehow.

But hey, that's not what you're here for. You're here for me to gush about this absolutely bitching piece of fanart from Jfmhill. Because GUYS LOOK AT IT. She's even pissed off about the thumb being twitchy! I love it! I am super into it! By all means draw me more fanart because I haven't stopped clapping my hands together like Augustus Gloop looking at the chocolate river since I saw it! That has made it surprisingly hard to type but I am doing my best. Fanart! For *this*! That's so fucking cool! It's so fucking cool! I made a joke like, way back at the beginning of this thing that if I got fanart I would spontaneously combust and while I have to admit I haven't (probably for the best, because then this thing really never would get finished) I am nonetheless so fucking delighted, you have no idea.

Oh, as for this chapter, well... there was a lot to cover, and I liked the idea of the compromised Light Hope being a little more forthcoming than repaired Light Hope. Plus now you know how this shit all went down! I liked the idea of C'yra being part of Squad Greyskull - I've got a whole *thing* about the name itself and why Mara chose it which, you know, probably will never be relevant but it's one of those things I had to have put together in my brain. Also, the Horde! Like, the actual Horde, not Hordak's little cosplay group. Once I

knew about Horde Prime, it became kind of obvious that the thing which drove the First Ones to be such rotten bastards was desperation (plus the First Ones didn't, in my view, understand magic as anything beyond a means to an end - something to be mined, rather than worked with - so they wouldn't be able to wield it effectively against Prime's forces).

It almost got a lot longer, but I do like ending on a swear word, so we'll catch up with those crazy kids and see how they get out of this pickle next time (it will involve swinging a sword around and shooting things, I'm sure). Plus we might see what other tricks Light Hope has up her sleeve.

The world outside continues to be a shitshow, but my god people are certainly taking the we must be brave part seriously, and that gives me hope. Stay safe out there, defund and abolish the police, remember to wash your hands, and hey, Happy Pride from this bi(g) old skeleton to you!

An Intruder Alert

Chapter Summary

Catra and Adora exit the Crystal Castle with new information. She-Ra demonstrates possessiveness.

A new business offer comes in.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"As far as plans go," Catra shouted, her claws shredding through the armor of another drone, "I think you've had better ones."

"Thanks, Catra!" Adora shouted, whirling the Sword of Protection around her head. "I've always valued your feedback! I'm just not sure now is the time!"

Catra snorted and ducked a swipe of a spider-like drone's bladed leg. "Fine, but we'll have a thorough performance review when this is all over."

"Don't you mean a *debriefing?* " Adora shouted, the sword shifting into a shield to block a particularly large blast.

Catra would have sent a more annoyed look in Adora's direction, but she was too busy riding another spider drone like an unruly horse to really drive home the point. "I cannot *believe* I'm in love with you!"

The hallway was choked with debris as Light Hope threw everything she could conjure at the two interlopers. The two had managed to make their way out of the second control room, but the entry hall was still what felt like an impossible distance away.

"Do you think she'll get sick of sending these things?" Adora asked, a slight note of concern bleeding through her otherwise

cavalier attitude.

“You’re the expert, you tell me!”

Adora had to admit that Catra had a point, but still. “I’m not an *expert* , she’s never tried to kill me before!”

“I’m going to assume ‘no,’ then.” Catra said, with a somewhat grim chuckle. “Well, at least I won’t die having never told you I love you.”

This proved too much for Adora to bear, and there was a sudden flash of blinding light as she turned into She-Ra. An enormous wave of energy tore through the hallway, leaving wreckage in its wake. She-Ra grabbed Catra by the collar and pulled her into a bruising kiss. “Nobody,” she said, her voice a low growl, “is going to take you away from me again.”

“Why Adora,” Catra replied, her voice a little higher than usual, verging on the edge of a laugh, “I didn’t know you were so *possessive* .”

She-Ra blinked, then laughed. “So I am. You have to understand something, Catra - I’ve spent centuries trapped in a hell of Eternian making. Being free again is… well.” she smiled in a way that made Catra’s stomach do a somersault. “I can do things I couldn’t before.”

“Like get possessive?”

She-Ra’s attention shifted and she looked over Catra’s shoulder. “Like level this whole fucking building if you send a single drone more, administrator program L1GT H0P3. The time for hurting those I love is over.”

“Leaving this facility standing is a tactical error.” Light Hope’s voice echoed in the hallway. “I *will* see my orders fulfilled with or without the She-Ra.”

“Don’t mistake my mercy for weakness.” She-Ra responded. “For what you once were to Mara, I’ll leave what’s left of you alive. Maybe dismantling the Heart will bring you some kind of peace.”

“Peace?” Light Hope’s voice was mocking. “You will bring only ruin, and sacrifice your only chance for victory. But I will grant you one last favor, for allowing me to survive to see the cost of your folly. I shall grant your Catra something she greatly desires.”

The lights went out, and when they came back on a moment later, the two were on a ship. It was a small sloop - a swift boat with a cabin in the back and little else apart from a cargo hold. Sea sprayed over the bow as it cut through the water, and Catra sniffed the salt air and felt a wave of familiarity.

Catra looked at Adora in confusion. “What the hell is this?”

Adora shrugged. “It looks like when the palace would play back memories, but… I don’t recognize this place at all.”

“Yeah, I don’t… I don’t think I do either?” Catra frowned. “You think it’s security footage again?”

Voices drifted out of the ship’s cabin. “-think we’ll make it in time?” asked an almost teasing voice.

“Darling,” a deeper voice replied, “this ship will outrun the wind itself just to see you smile.”

The comment earned its speaker a snorting laugh. “You’re such an idiot.”

“Ah, but I’m *your* idiot, am I not? Why, you even deigned to raise a *child* with me.”

“And she took what little intelligence was left to you, I see.”

“Well, perhaps. Although I must say her looks clearly come from you. *I* certainly could never be responsible for such beauty.”

“Flatterer.” Silence, followed by the unmistakable sound of purring.

Something lurched in Catra’s chest and she stumbled towards the cabin on unsteady feet. *It’s them it’s them I remember them I remember-*

“Catra?” Adora’s voice sounded distant. “What’s wrong?”

Catra ignored her and placed a trembling hand on the door, pushed it expecting resistance and instead phased right through. A tall magicat, broad shouldered, long limbed, with dark and wild hair, twinkling golden eyes, embraced a shorter feline form that was smaller, more lithe, blond fur striped with brown and unmistakably her father - he peered up at Catra’s mother with mismatched eyes and an expression of complete devotion.

“Careful now,” her father teased, “you might wake the little one with all that purring.”

Catra’s gaze shifted to what was unmistakably her, curled up on her parent’s bed, golden eye half-open in drowsy curiosity. She watched herself watch her parents as they kissed softly - once, twice, then her mother headed out the cabin door to check their course while her father, who had by now noticed Catra’s drowsy curiosity, plopped down on the bed and gave her a nudge.

“Awake, kitten?”

The young magicat shut her eye immediately. “Noooooo.”

“Ah,” her father said, nodding gravely, “well, if you’re asleep, then you must be dead to the world. Unable to even notice…” his hands extended out in a gesture of faux menace, “ *the approach of a dreadful beast!* ”

Catra shrieked with laughter as her father’s fingers sought her sides, tail whipping back and forth delightedly. “Daaaaaad, stooooop!”

“I can’t help it!” her father said in mock horror. “The beast! It’s *taken control of meeeeeeee!”*

“Finn!” her mother’s voice carried a note of forced casualness. “I need you here! I think we might have visitors soon.”

“Coming, my dear!” Finn replied, and winked at Catra. “Sorry kitten - you know the drill.”

“Duck in the box until company’s gone.” the young child said, and Catra found herself mouthing along unconsciously. “Three knocks means I can come out.”

“That’s my girl.” Finn grinned and kissed Catra on the forehead. The child climbed into a wooden chest and pulled the lid shut.

“Please,” Catra begged suddenly. “stop this. Don’t make me-”

The room went dark and quiet, broken only by indistinct conversation drifting in from outside. Catra could hear her mother’s voice grow tighter, more controlled, culminating in a shout. “I won’t let them touch her, Finn! Keep our daughter safe!”

There were sounds of battle, and Finn’s anguished cry. “C’yra! No!” followed by a crazed laugh. “Come on then you bastards! Let’s get it over with!”

Gunfire. A heavy tread. The muffled sound of someone giving orders. “Take all cargo and sink the ship.”

The lights came back up to the familiar surroundings of the Crystal Castle. Catra was crumpled on the floor, curled up and sobbing. Adora knelt beside her, uncertain of what to do. She hesitantly extended a hand and stroked Catra’s hair.

“Come on.” Adora said, and felt like a monster for saying it. “We have to go. I don’t know how long we can trust Light Hope to keep her word.”

Catra didn't move. *My parents. These were my parents. Finn and C'yra. C'yra used to sing me to sleep when I got grumpy. Finn used to climb the mast with me on his shoulders to show me the moons at night. The Horde killed them. They loved me, and they tried to protect me, and the Horde killed them, and I became a soldier for the Horde. I brought ruin to Etheria and I did it in the name of the army that murdered my parents. I did it* willingly.

She felt one of Adora's arms slide under her legs, the other around her back. "Catra? I'm going to pick you up and carry you out of here, okay? We have to go."

Adora stood, carrying Catra like she weighed nothing at all, and strode as quickly as her feet would carry her out of the Crystal Castle into the sunlight.

"Focus on my voice, Catra." Adora said. "I don't know what's… I don't know what you're feeling right now, but whatever else happens, I'm here and I'm not leaving."

Catra's voice was a whisper. "I fought for the people that killed my parents."

"You couldn't have known."

"Clearly I *did* know, on some level! I mean… that memory came from my brain, right?" Catra's voice broke.

"Yes," Adora said, "but you know Shadow Weaver's capabilities. Do you think she would have allowed you to remember what happened to them? Who you were? Total loyalty to the Horde means the Horde is the only thing you've ever known, remember?"

"If Shadow Weaver wiped my memory, then how did-"

Adora cocked her head to one side, as if listening to something. "She can't erase memories - only block them. Redirect your thoughts elsewhere, that sort of thing." she coughed and looked vaguely embarrassed. "Um, I think. She-Ra… thinks." Catra

opened her mouth again to say that wasn't very comforting, but Adora was one step ahead of her again. "I know it doesn't feel great to hear me say that you didn't have any control over this. Our lives have been a series of people taking control away from us, over and over again, but you're in control now, okay?"

Catra took a deep breath and clung to Adora. She hated the feeling. Hated that she felt like she'd been ripped apart and Adora was the only thing holding her together. Most of all, however, she hated that Shadow Weaver had apparently taken the memory of her parents from her. "Okay." she finally said, taking a deep breath. "Okay. I can… Let's get out of here."

Adora bit back the urge to make sure Catra was okay - she knew that what Catra really needed was time to process the news of her parents' fate, but she also knew that *now* was not the time. They needed to get back to headquarters so Adora could give Entrapta what little information she'd gotten from Light Hope - and hopefully manage to replicate at least the basic schematics of the Heart's design from memory. Then they'd need to contact Glimmer and get access to Mystacor's vaults to see if they could locate whatever the hell the failsafe was. Oh, and somewhere in there she'd need to find out how precisely Hordak (or more likely, Shadow Weaver) had altered Mara and C'yra. If there was some kind of kill switch or weakness, she needed to know it and get rid of it. Somehow.

Once the skiff was in the air and safely underway, Adora sat down in the copilot's seat next to Catra and put a hand on her shoulder reassuringly. Catra's flesh and blood hand came up and gripped Adora's tightly. They flew in silence all the way back to base. Catra never let go.

The next few hours were a whirlwind of activity. Scorpia was waiting for them as they hopped off the skiff.

"Commander! Adora! How'd it go?"

Adora opened her mouth to respond but was cut off by Catra. "Pretty well, all things considered. Turns out there's some kind of horrible weapon made out of the planet that Adora thinks she can stop. Oh, and we might have broken whatever control program used to run that horrible weapon. Or more accurately, Adora might have when she broke the sword."

Scorpia's eyes were wide. "Well uh. Well! That's a lot of… a lot. Yeah. Okay. So…"

"Arrange for a squad to go collect our payment." Catra said, pulling out a tracker pad and typing a set of coordinates into it before handing it over. "Courtesy of whatever faction of the Princess Alliance we've just allied ourselves with. Delivery's tomorrow. Oh, and send Entrapta by my office, would you? There's a few things we found out that I need her to look into." Scorpia nodded, and Catra smiled gratefully. "Thanks, Scorp. How are the kids?"

Adora couldn't help but grin affectionately at the phrase, and Scorpia looked equally delighted. "Oh they're doing great! Lonnie's teaching them about farming, which I think is just her way of giving them an excuse to run around outside, honestly."

"And the uh... counseling sessions?" Catra hesitated. "Did they go?"

"Yep! Mara asked if she could stop going though. Says she prefers talking to you about this stuff."

Catra digested the news quietly. "Done. If she doesn't feel comfortable talking, then it's doing just as much harm as good."

Adora hummed to herself and tried not to look too interested in the proceedings. It seemed obvious to her the connection shared between Mara and Catra lay in the role Shadow Weaver had pressured them to play - as the second fiddle to the more 'gifted' C'yra and Adora, respectively - and a selfish part of her wondered whether or not she could share a similar bond with C'yra. She

knew it was selfish - knew that C'yra's baggage included years of considering Adora the reason their lives were a living hell - but she couldn't help it.

Catra's voice cut across Adora's train of thought. "- sure Adora would be willing to help, right?"

"Huh?" Adora asked. "Sorry, I spaced out for a second."

"Lonnie's requesting help in the fields." Catra repeated, smiling at Adora with open affection. "There's some rubble that needs shifting to clear out another field. Moving heavy rocks out of the way seems like it's right up your alley."

"I knew it!" Adora said, sounding wounded. "You only ever wanted me for my muscles."

"Yep!" Catra said, cheerily. "So go out there and move some heavy things, Adora. Er, after you check in with Glimmer, anyway."

"Fine." Adora said, and then leaned deep into Catra's personal space with a grin and a tone of voice that made her fur stand on end. "Just be sure you can pay me for all my hard work later."

Catra took a half second to double-check that Scorpia was the only person in sight and pulled Adora in for a heated - but quick, totally quick - kiss. "That depends on how good a job you do." she said with a smirk. "But I'm sure you'll rise to the challenge."

Adora took a moment to regain her balance, and then smiled like she'd just discovered what happiness was. "Wow." she said, unable to stop blushing. "Okay. Well. I'm just going to. Yep."

Scorpia did an admirable job of maintaining her professionalism in the face of everything. "I'll send Entrapta over, Commander. Oh, and there's some requisition requests for you to look over while you wait. Kind of a lot of them, actually. We're growing pretty fast."

“Hmm.” Catra said. “I’ll address the new recruits tomorrow, give them their chance to fight.”

A flicker of concern crossed Scorpia’s face, but she smoothed it away and nodded. “I’ll make sure the training grounds are free, then.”

Adora had almost made back to Catra’s quarters when she ran into Entrapta exiting the infirmary. “Oh, hey Entrapta!” Adora said, waving. “Catra’s looking for you.”

Curiosity sparkled in Entrapta’s eyes. “Oh? What does she need?”

“We got a bunch of data about some First Ones structures.” Adora explained. “You’re the resident expert on technology, so…”

“I *am* an expert, aren’t I?” Entrapta preened a little. “Is Catra in her office?”

“Yeah,” Adora said, gesturing in the general direction of the office, “Scorpia was going to tell you to meet her there, but since I found you first, I guess she doesn’t have to!”

“A fortunate meeting!” Entrapta said, enthusiastically. “Do you know what the odds are of a meeting like this? I’m not sure myself, but I think they are *fairly* low. I’d need to double-check though. I bet I can write a program to check the math for me…”

“Uh...huh.” Adora said. “Well, I’ll see you later. I’ve got to check in with Glimmer.”

“Say hi for me!” Entrapta replied, snapping out of her muttering. “See you later, ‘dora!” She waved and headed in the direction of Catra’s office.

Catra’s office had become steadily more and more disorganized, and her desk was now half-buried under a mountain of after-action reports, supply requests, job offers, and intel reports. Catra’s shoulders slumped as she stared down the piles, and then with a sigh she set to working her way through the requisition

requests with the overwhelming feeling that she would much rather be visiting Mara and C'yra (or unwinding with Adora) than doing anything remotely like paperwork.

"Catra?" Entrapta's head poked in the doorway. "Are you free?"

Catra looked up sharply. "Didn't Scorpia send you here?"

"Oh," Entrapta looked back over her shoulder, "no, I had something to discuss with you. I must have missed her."

"Well it's just as well you're here." Catra said, leaning back a little. "I wanted to talk to you about the kids. There's some concerns I've got about their health and I need you to check them over - quietly, understand?"

Entrapta saluted enthusiastically. "Of course Catra! You can count on me to perform any sort of analysis of those kids, obviously! I have to admit I've been pretty curious about them since they arrived."

Catra hummed to herself quietly. "Yeah, I suppose you have been. I appreciate your restraint in leaving them to their own devices." Her eye narrowed dangerously. "You *have* been leaving them to their own devices, right?"

"Of course, Commander! I'd get consent from them before I did anything anyway."

"Of course." Catra repeated. She dug through one of the piles of files on her desk and pulled out a folder with a triumphant sound. "Ah, there it is. Take a look." She flipped the folder open and spun it around in Entrapta's direction.

Entrapta stepped forward and bent down to take a look, which gave Catra the opportunity she needed to grab Entrapta's hair and pull her head down into the desk surface with an audible thwack. In two seconds Catra was over the desk and behind Entrapta, one arm on the back of the Princess' neck, one twisting an arm backwards.

“Who the *fuck* are you and what have you done to Entrapta?”

Before Entrapta could respond, Adora burst through the door. “Catra, I think something’s happened to…”

“Yeah.” Catra said, not taking her eyes off Entrapta for a second. “I’m aware.”

“ *Bra* vo.” Entrapta said, in a voice that was definitely not Entrapta’s voice. “How did you know? Your feedback is important to me.”

“You didn’t salute with your hair in the hallway.” Adora said. “And you called Catra by her name instead of calling her Commander.”

“Hmm,” Not-Entrapta said, “she’s definitely called Catra by her name before.”

“Not when we’re talking business,” Catra snarled, “and she’d never agree to do anything to the kids without asking for specifics.”

“Hmm, I had her pegged as the mad scientist type.” Not-Entrapta sighed. “Oh well, can’t win them all, I guess.”

Catra increased the pressure on Not-Entrapta’s neck. “You still haven’t answered my questions. Who are you and where’s Entrapta?”

“Calm down, your science officer or whatever is fine. It was a bit risky to impersonate her without locking her up somewhere first, but I figured this would be a quick enough audition and honestly, I *do* love a little risk when I’m acting. It heightens the performance, you see. As for who I am…” The not-princess’ form blurred and shifted into a lizard-like humanoid with a wide, toothy grin. “My name’s Double Trouble. I’ve got a business proposition for you.”

Chapter End Notes

This chapter was like pulling teeth - mostly because I should have just tacked on the end of the Crystal Castle stuff last chapter and figuring out how to pull off the transition to the other stuff for this chapter was kind of giving me fits. In the end, we got there, and more importantly Double Trouble has entered the building, which let me tell you is a relief. I wasn't sure how precisely I'd do it, and I wasn't sure what their ultimate role was going to be, but I was out for a run this morning cursing the now frankly ridiculous summer heat and it all clicked into place. Sometimes that happens! It's a good time when that happens.

Also this is basically meaningless and one of those things for you TRUE FANS, but I went back through the whole story last week and fixed a bunch of typos, sentences that needed to be better-written, and also I think one sort of continuity error but I don't remember entirely what it was. So if you wanted an excuse to read through the whole thing again, there you go. You have it.

Thanks for reading, commenting, kudos-ing, all that good shit. It feels like we're slowing our pace down as the temperature rises (we are, because both my sweaty man-bod and also my brain hate the summer) so don't be surprised if I don't manage to get anything else up for like the next month. Still, I am nevertheless delighted by all of you and will bring the heat as much as I can between now and then end of this thing, which is... happening sooner or later.

A Deal

Chapter Summary

> Double Trouble clarifies their situation. Scorpia tests her mettle. Catra is tired.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"You know, I'm not usually offended by bad reviews, but this might be taking things a little far, darling." Double Trouble said dryly from their position behind a force field.

"Oh, no, this isn't because of the act," Catra said, inspecting her claws idly, "this is for your own protection."

"Protection?"

"Yep." Catra nodded. "See, when you sent Entrapta off on whatever wild goose chase you sent her on, you put her into danger. There's not a *ton* of danger around here, but you know, it would be your fault if something happened to her. Added to that *who* you chose to portray when you sent her off, and, well… you probably could've picked a better person to impersonate than-"

The door leading into what was now the brig, Catra supposed, chose that moment to fly down the hallway behind her, propelled by some unholy force.

"Where are they?" Scorpia's voice boomed down the hall, echoing off the walls.

Catra raised her eyebrows slightly and turned to Double Trouble with an apologetic shrug. "They're here, Scorpia. And they're not to be harmed, is that clear?"

Scorpia hove into view, so angry that it almost seemed like the air around her was crackling with electricity. She pointed a claw at Double Trouble, and in spite of the force field between the two, their glib demeanor faltered for a moment. "You," Scorpia said, the word grinding itself out from between clenched teeth, "are very lucky Entrapta is okay."

Catra watched as Double Trouble reassembled their mask of indifference. "Of course she is, darling. I wouldn't put her in danger when I'm trying to *work* with you."

"Yeah, about that," Catra said, making a show of her own indifference, "what in the *world* makes you think I'm inclined to work with you?"

Double Trouble laughed, seeming delighted. "Well, I *had* hoped my performance was suitably convincing, but it's always important to have a surprise for the audience, so…" they reached in their pocket and withdrew a small disc. "Surveillance data, delivered fresh from the Fright Zone by yours truly. I think you'll be *very* interested in its contents, considering who I got it from."

"And that would be?"

The shapeshifter's body blurred into a familiar form and Catra had to bite back a hiss. "Why, the true leader of the Horde, of course." Their voice had shifted to the disdainful voice of Shadow Weaver. "Hordak, as you know, hasn't been focused on the war for a very long time."

Catra's eye narrowed. "Shadow Weaver's not one for technology." she said, eyeing the disc dubiously.

"Of course she isn't, darling." Double Trouble's voice coming out of Shadow Weaver's body was not particularly reassuring. "But *I* am, and I take *very* good notes. Photos, too."

"Okay, so assuming this information checks out - what's your offer?"

“I’m not in the habit of picking the losing team,” Double Trouble said, shifting back to their own form and shrugging, “and the Horde organization’s been on shaky foundation since your… retirement. I saw an opportunity to make some money while there’s still money to make.”

“So we pay you, and you feed us information from the heart of the Fright Zone, huh?”

“Simple deal, isn’t it?” Double Trouble’s grin widened. “But simple deals are the best kind. Although it’s only part of what I’m prepared to offer. You and your girlfriend,” they pointed directly at Catra, “have caught the attention of some very dangerous people. Did you know that?”

“I’m not surprised to learn it.” Catra responded airily. “We do tend to do that.”

“Well, *these* people happen to be enemies of mine as well - and trust me darling, to be one of *my* enemies you have to really screw up.” Double Trouble matched Catra’s tone, but there was a glint in their eyes that Catra recognized as that of a deep well of rage.

“So am I supposed to just guess who these enemies are, or are you going to tell me?”

“The First Ones.” Double Trouble said, spreading their hands and looking for all the world like they’d just performed a magic trick.

“Oh.” Catra said, shrugging. “Yeah, I guess that makes sense.”

For a brief moment, Double Trouble seemed to be at a loss for words. Finally, they managed a weak, “You know them?”

Catra grinned and shrugged in what she deeply hoped was an infuriating manner. “Something like that. Is that it?”

There was another moment where Double Trouble seemed at a loss for words, and then they started laughing. “Oh, *kitten!* The

stories about you don't do you *justice,* do they?"

"Depends on the story," Catra replied, deciding not to rise to the bait of being called 'kitten' just now, "but I'm happy to defy expectations now and again." Her expression hardened. "I assume you've got some additional information about the First Ones you're hoping to sell me, is that it?"

"Oh no, *that* information's free." Double Trouble said. "Provided you agree to hire me, *and* provided that you bring me along if you ever manage to locate where they're hiding. I've got a *lot* of questions for them."

"Okay." Catra said, nodding. "You sit tight here while I decide if I can trust you or not."

"I'll save you the time - you can trust me for exactly as long as your money lasts." Double Trouble grinned. "Longer if you can get me close to the First Ones."

"Then I suppose I'd better go see how long I can afford to pay you." Catra grunted, and walked off.

Scorpia lingered at the cell door, staring at Double Trouble. They stared back until eventually the silence became too much. "Well?" they finally said, challenging.

"If I get even the slightest feeling something's off," Scorpia said, with a tone in her voice that would've given Catra pause if she'd heard it herself, "the Commander won't even know what happened to you. *You* won't even know what happened to you. I'll bury you so deep and dark the whole world won't even remember you *existed* ."

" *You're* full of surprises." Double Trouble said, looking impressed. "Consider me warned." They leaned forward, a little conspiratorially. "But you should make sure your Commander's who you think she is before you go declaring your loyalties."

Scorpia laughed at that, and walked away without another word.

Catra was leaning against the wall as Scorpia exited the hallway. "So?"

"Tried to shake my trust in you." Scorpia said, snorting. "I don't trust them in the slightest - except for that stuff about the First Ones. They seemed pretty sincere about that." She paused. "Er, I don't suppose you know what the hell that was all about, do you?"

Catra sighed. "Long story short, the people that tried to control She-Ra way back when are still around as some kind of… cult, or secret organization. I'm not sure, but it's the reason everyone in the Princess Alliance is obsessed with She-Ra."

Scorpia digested this information quietly. "Huh. Sounds like trouble."

"Yeah, no kidding." Catra sighed. "Bad enough we've got to fight the Horde, but Adora breaking the Sword of Protection seems like it put us in the middle of a much older fight."

"So much for ending this war and retiring then, huh?" Scorpia asked with a wry smile. "Guess we'll still have work after Hordak's gone."

Catra laughed. "Yeah, I guess so. The only problem is we might have the Alliance on us regardless of what Princess Glimmer does."

"Cross that bridge when we come to it." Scorpia said, placing a reassuring claw on Catra's shoulder. "Or blow it up. Whichever seems best."

Catra felt immensely tired. Double Trouble's intrusion had thrown all of the day's plans into disarray, and she hadn't seen Adora since telling her firmly to leave the interrogation to her. Adora hadn't been pleased, but after Catra pointed out quite firmly that Adora was not exactly *good* at subterfuge unless you counted "punching people" as subterfuge, she'd somewhat grumpily agreed to go help Lonnie in the fields - and see the kids, which

Catra was hoping would take some of the sting out. The plain fact of the matter had in fact been that Catra simply wasn't certain whether or not interrogating Double Trouble would involve more physical forms of persuasion, and she wasn't sure how Adora would react to that. These days, Catra wasn't actually sure how *she* would react to that. She suddenly realized that Scorpia was giving her a concerned look and pulled herself back together.

"Thanks, Scorp'. I think I need some rest. This day's gone on way longer than I planned."

Scorpia nodded, then clacked her claw as she remembered something. "Oh! Do you still need to talk to Entrapta?"

Catra shook her head. "It can wait until tomorrow. If you see Adora, tell her I said she should get some rest too."

Scorpia gave Catra a knowing look. "Just make sure you let her *rest* , Commander."

"I'll have you know…" Catra started to say, before immediately realizing that Scorpia had a point. "When exactly did you become such a smartass, anyway?"

"Around the time you started trusting my judgment." Scorpia replied easily. "You believed in me."

"Well remind me to stop." Catra said gruffly, feeling unexpectedly moved and hiding it as best as she could. "You're insufferable when you're right."

"I'll be sure to make some bad decisions in front of you next time. Make sure that you still feel useful."

Catra laughed and walked off in the direction of her quarters. A short shower and change of clothes later, and she was asleep almost as soon as her head hit the pillow. She wasn't sure how long she'd been asleep when the sound of the door creaking open brought her back to consciousness. Her eye opened lazily and she took in the sight of Adora doing her level best to enter quietly.

“Hey, Adora.”

There was a guilty look on Adora’s face. “Agh, sorry. I was trying to be quiet, but the damn door-”

“I let the door creak for a reason, Adora.” Catra said, waving off the apology. “It’s safer when you can hear someone enter the room.”

“I’d say something about being paranoid,” Adora said, shrugging out of her jacket and letting her hair down, “but then again we *were* just infiltrated by a shapeshifter.”

Catra tried not to focus too much on the way Adora’s hair fanned out across her shoulders. “Yeah, I feel like my paranoia was vindicated today, you know?” she grimaced. “How’s things in the fields?”

“Good!” Adora said, brightly. “Lonnie’s got a real knack for this stuff! She’s expanding the fields again, so I helped with clearing some more space. You know, this island’s basically covered in Eternian ruins?”

“Yeah?”

“Not like, anything usable - or at least if there *is* anything usable Entrapta can’t find it, so I assume there’s nothing usable - but… I think this must have been some kind of operating base. It makes the overall layout make sense, you know?” Adora continued shedding clothes as she headed in the direction of the shower, which Catra thought made it very difficult to pay attention.

“We always assumed it had something to do with Scorpia’s people.” she finally offered, tearing her eyes away from the way Adora’s back muscles flexed as she leaned over to untie her boots. “Guess this place is older than we thought.”

“I mean Scorpia could be right - this is kind of near the borders of the old Scorpion Kingdom, after all. They were probably here first.”

Catra considered this and snorted. “Yeah, probably. Fucking Eternians came in and… well, now we’re *here* , huh?”

Adora nodded, then gave Catra a wink over her shoulder that heavily implied she was well aware of how the magicat had been staring. “Yeah. But hey, at least I’ve got you, huh?”

“There is that, isn’t there?” Catra smiled widely and then made a shooing motion. “Now go shower. I can smell you from here.”

“And here I thought you *liked* it when I worked up a sweat.” Adora said, her voice making several suggestions at once.

“Yeah, well, normally you don’t work up a sweat in such close proximity to…” Catra trailed off and sniffed the air experimentally, “the compost heap? Maybe the latrine outflow?”

Adora laughed and walked into the bathroom. Catra surprised herself by drifting off again to the sound of running water and Adora humming something to herself. The movement of the bed woke her back up again, as did Adora placing a kiss on her temple.

“Tired, Commander?”

Catra yawned. “Yeah, all those revelations took it out of me.” she groaned and sat up. “I still haven’t talked to Entrapta about the kids, either.”

Adora carded her fingers through Catra’s hair, causing a purr to rumble deep in her chest. “I talked to them a little too.” Adora mentioned. “The kids, I mean.”

“Oh?” Catra’s interest was piqued. “What about?”

“They wanted to know what my training was like.” Adora said. “You know, back in…”

“Why’d they want to know that?”

Adora sighed. “I’m not really sure. I think they just wanted to know if they really had it much harder than we did? That, and I think they like hearing stories of you pissing off Shadow Weaver.”

“That doesn’t surprise me.” Catra snorted. “From what I’ve heard from those two, Shadow Weaver was… a little more strict with them. Their training was a lot more regimented, even though it didn’t really seem to do much in the way of tamping down their more rebellious tendencies.”

Adora was quiet for a moment, and her hands stilled. “She really wanted to control those two. C’yra mentioned being told that she was the Last Hope of the Horde.”

Catra rolled her eye. “That’s dramatic, even for Shadow Weaver. Hopefully that means the war’s made her desperate. I’m pretty sure she sent that mech out too early.”

“The mech that almost killed you? That mech?”

“The mech that I disabled in about a minute and a half, yes.”

“What, you were timing yourself?”

“No, but it was over fast. Then I…” Catra’s voice faltered. “Holy shit Adora, I almost *died* . I almost died like, *two days ago.* ”

Adora pulled Catra close. “Yeah, but you didn’t. You didn’t, and you broke Shadow Weaver’s new toy, and we’re going to take a little time to plan our assault on the Fright Zone and end this stupid fucking war.”

“And then what?” Catra asked, feeling tense. “We have to fight these… First Ones, whoever they are?”

“I don’t know.” Adora admitted, knowing the answer wouldn’t be particularly comforting but unable to lie. “We find out more about them and then figure out what we need to do to stop them from getting the Heart. But uh, one thing at a time, maybe?”

“That shapeshifter seems to know them.” Catra allowed, figuring she needed to tell Adora about this sooner or later. “They also seem to have a hell of a vendetta against them.”

“Was that their ‘business proposition?’”

“More or less. They offered to be a source in the Horde for us in return for pay and the promise we’d let them in on any information we get on the First Ones.”

“And you believe them?”

“I’ve got my doubts as to how much we can trust them,” Catra admitted, “but their dislike of the First Ones seems genuine. It was the only time they really dropped character in front of me.”

“I don’t like it.” Adora said. “But if the information’s good, it might be our only chance.”

Catra sighed. “Yeah, that’s what I’m afraid of. For now, I think we can at least use them to get more intel from the Horde.”

“Okay.” Adora nodded. “Let’s hire them. See how much intel we can get, and then… I don’t know, have a backup plan for when they inevitably betray us?”

“Now you’re thinking like a Commander, Adora.” Catra said, sounding almost proud. “But if you don’t mind…” she gave Adora a kiss and fell back on the bed. “I could use some more rest. You too - that’s an order from your Commander.”

“If you insist.” Adora replied, snuggling close. A few moments later, and they were both fast asleep. The rest could wait until tomorrow. They were home, and they were safe, and that was enough.

Chapter End Notes

> Remember last summer when I was like "yeah summer sucks for me I usually do real bad in the summer."

Well, this summer was somehow worse. Maybe it was the news, maybe it was getting dumped, maybe it was the fact that my office is still closed and so I've been working from home for basically half a year now? Probably it was a combination of all three. It wasn't *all* bad, though. Here are a few cool things that happened since the last time I was here:

1. That Tony Hawk Pro Skater 1+2 remake came out and it fucking *whips*. Seriously, I felt a good 20 years younger playing it.

2. I went on vacation and saw a friend of mine I'd not seen in like a year and a half! She has a pug, and he is the best (she also has a couple kids who are pretty cool too but come on I have priorities and they are all pug-related). Maybe not the safest thing to do, but it wasn't a very long train ride and I had a mask on and also I think I would probably have gone insane if I didn't leave this apartment for at least a little while.

3. Partially related to 1, partially related to an overwhelming feeling that I might as well because 2020 has been weird enough, I took up the noble art of skateboarding. I am, I should note, 35. To date I have managed to at least learn how to ollie, which is very cool for me. Thank you, I *am* very cool, you are correct.

4. I worked on a different thing for a little while and uploaded the result On This Very Site, which is to say the Gravity Falls thing I do occasionally has a new chapter. Maybe you have read it? I don't know what the crossover is between this and that but I assume "not huge."

Anyway, now that summer is Officially Over (it's the autumnal equinox today I think? I *think*, but I'm not 100% sure) we'll probably get back to at least a monthly posting schedule here. That should be nice. I'm getting the urge to play all the Metal Gear Solid games again so I'm ready to jump back into this and get it all climax/falling resolution up in here. Or

whatever. There's a war to get to, and some intrigue, and some *boss fights*, even! It'll be cool. Trust me.

Thanks for sticking with me, and leaving comments, and telling your friends, and leaving kudos, and generally being rad.

Please enjoy this entirely unrelated She-Ra/Metal Gear Solid fanart I saw on Twitter which I thought was neat, anyway.

Early Morning Conversations

Chapter Summary

Adora gets up early. Aethina is chatty. Catra has a plan.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora woke early feeling restless. Something was bothering her - maybe a She-Ra thing, maybe just a general anxiety, she wasn't sure. She got out of bed carefully, doing her best not to wake Catra, and took a quick shower before heading out to find some breakfast with the thought that she could bring something back for Catra. *I should give Glimmer a call while I'm at it,* she thought, realizing she'd never checked in the day before.

The canteen was full of soldiers, and for a moment Adora hesitated before entering. Her presence was still new, and while Catra had assured her that their relationship was both entirely known to everyone and entirely not something people would ever discuss in their presence it was still… somewhat intimidating. Squaring her shoulders, she strode in and tried hard not to look too obviously nervous.

Contrary to her worries, nobody seemed to notice her presence. Indeed, the soldiers were all focused on their food and conversations already in progress - there were one or two nods of recognition which she returned, but not much else. She assembled a plate for herself and found herself being waved over to an empty seat near a soldier she recognized - Aethina, she thought?

"Good to see you again, Adora. Guess the rumors are true."

"Which ones?" Adora asked.

Aethina grinned. “Just the ones that said you showed up a few days ago with some big job offer from the Princess Alliance.” She paused and watched Adora’s face closely before continuing. “Oh, and something about bringing the Commander back from the dead.”

Catra would have been impressed by how Adora managed to keep her expression neutral. “Interesting rumor mill. Anything else?”

“Word is you’re staying.”

“That,” Adora said, “is indeed true.”

“Surprised Princess Glimmer let you go.” Aethina was watching her closely again.

“In spite of what you and the rest of the Rebellion’s rumor mill seem to think, Princess Glimmer isn’t my Commander.” Adora replied, maybe a little more harshly than she needed to. “She’s my friend.”

Aethina raised her hands defensively. “Ah, sorry! No offense met. It’s just…” she frowned, thinking carefully before continuing, “she’s the *princess* , you know? I was just a grunt. She said jump, we jumped.”

“Hmm, I suppose that’s true.” Adora admitted. “I never went through training with the Rebellion. Never really saw the command structure at all until a few years in. The larger battles were something the Queen handled.”

“I suppose that makes sense.” Aethina hummed thoughtfully. “There’s only so many Princesses - and the Alliance barely existed before you went all,” here she waved her hands dramatically, “ *She-Ra* and convinced them all we had a real chance of fighting back.”

“I would appreciate,” Catra’s voice drawled from just behind Adora’s shoulder, “if you kept the She-Ra stuff to yourself, soldier. Sometimes it’s useful to keep a secret or two.”

“Commander! Sorry sir, it won’t-”

Adora waved the apology off. “It’s fine, we didn’t exactly tell you to keep it under your hat when you figured it out the first time.”

“But if word gets out She-Ra’s working for a mercenary crew, well… that invites a level of scrutiny that I’m not sure we really need.” Catra finished. “I assume you’ve probably already told some of your friends, but if you could let them know to keep it to themselves, I’d appreciate it.”

“Funnily enough,” Aethina said, giving Adora a perceptive look, “I got the feeling she didn’t want to really broadcast the fact the last time we met. Figured I would keep it to myself.”

“I appreciate it.” Adora replied, not quite able to keep the relief off her face. “It’s… for the best if I just stay a soldier.”

A curious look crossed Catra’s face, but it vanished quickly and was replaced by what Adora was beginning to think of as her Commander face. “One other thing, Aethina: I’ve set up a meeting for you with Scorpia at 15:00. She’s got a new assignment for you, if you want it.”

Aethina seemed genuinely confused. “Commander?”

“You’re free to refuse, of course,” Catra said, easily, “but Scorpia thinks you would be a good fit, and I trust her judgment.”

“Uh, thank you, Commander.”

“Don’t thank me yet.” Catra replied, grinning. “Talk to Scorpia first.” She turned her attention to Adora. “Did you have any plans for the rest of the morning? I might need your help with something.”

Adora frowned. “I told Lonnie I’d see her out in the fields again, give ‘em a little more help clearing them, but I can let her know I can’t make it if it’s important.”

Catra's expression briefly shifted to something Adora couldn't quite figure out, and she nodded apologetically. "Better let her know, then."

"No problem." Adora replied. "Can you fill me in?"

Catra looked over in the direction of the breakfast buffet and her stomach growled. "Later. I'm going to grab some food first. I don't know about you, but I can't remember the last time I had a proper meal."

Once again Adora was struck by just how non-stop things had been since her arrival. Catra was right - she'd been on her feet and out the door the morning after Adora had showed up (and she certainly shared some of the blame for keeping Catra awake, she knew).

"You two are very cute together, by the way." Aethina's comment broke across Adora's thoughts and startled her.

"Wh-"

"Come on now, I've got *eyes* , Adora. Sometimes I even use them - not that it would've been difficult to figure out just by hearing the two of you talk the first time I saw you." Aethina snorted. "Besides, everyone here's pretty familiar with the story of you and the Commander. Especially the romantic bits."

"There weren't any romantic bits back then!" Adora said, a little scandalized.

"There were according to Lonnie."

"Of course." muttered Adora. "Well, I certainly won't feel bad about canceling on her *now* ."

Aethina laughed and stood just as Catra returned with a plate of food. "Well, I've got a full day ahead of me - fuller than I thought, apparently - so I'll leave you in peace for now." She gave Catra a salute and perfunctory "Commander" before heading off.

Catra watched her leave. “That one’s dangerous, you know that?”

“How so?”

“She’s clever,” Catra replied, “and very observant. It’s why I set up a meeting for her with Scorpia. She’s wasted as a grunt, so I’m having Scorpia offer her a position on our intel team. Specifically…” her voice trailed off. “Well, I’ll tell you later.”

“Does this have anything to do with our uh, new guest?”

Catra nodded. “I need someone I can trust, and I need someone who’s good at reading people. Aethina fits both of those requirements.” At Adora’s questioning look, she continued. “I met her on my first mission out. She’s technically the first soldier I ever recruited.”

“Should I be jealous?”

“Only if you think I’m the sort of person who would sleep with an underling.”

“Aren’t *I* an underling?”

“Technically, you’re a liaison for a client. Which is still kind of a problem from a business ethics standpoint, but I’m willing to make an exception if you are.”

“I think it’s probably a little late to do anything about it,” Adora said, giving Catra a look, “since I’m hopelessly in love with you.”

Catra flushed under her fur and couldn’t stop an affectionate purr from starting up. “Gods, what did I do to deserve you?”

There was a lull in the conversation as food briefly distracted them from their flirting - and Adora felt like she’d won the exchange anyway. Eventually curiosity got the better of her, however, and her mind began wondering just what Catra was planning that needed her help. Catra had something weighing on her mind, that

was clear - and if she had to guess it had to do with the First Ones somehow.

Catra leaned back in her seat and closed her eyes. “I feel like I haven’t eaten that much in years.”

Adora smiled. “Well, I have to let Lonnie know I’m canceling on her, but then I’ll come find you in your office, I assume?”

“Yeah, I’ll wait for you there.” Catra stood up and stretched, popping her back in the process. “Ugh, I think I’m getting old.”

“Well then old woman, go rest your tired bones and I’ll come see you in like ten minutes.” Laughing, Adora left the cafeteria.

The sun was just beginning to really beat down on Lonnie as she waved Adora over. “Hey! Glad you showed up, there’s some more heavy shit that needs moving and you are the perfect woman for the job.”

“Well, unfortunately you’re going to need to do without me this time.” Adora replied with an apologetic grimace. “Catra needs me for something.”

Lonnie’s eyes flicked up and down Adora and she smirked. “Uh huh. Bet I can guess the ‘something,’ too.”

“You know I wouldn’t-”

“Settle down, girl, I know you’re way too responsible to pull some shit like that.” Lonnie snorted. “I figure it’s got to be something important, huh?”

Adora hesitated for a second before responding. “Honestly? I don’t know yet. Catra seems to think so.”

“Hmm…” Lonnie looked thoughtful. “Probably something to do with our new guest, if I had to guess.”

“I’m not sure, it might be-”

"Something I don't need to know about yet - assuming I ever even need to know." Lonnie cut her off a little harshly. "I didn't volunteer for this whole farming detail because I wanted to get involved in espionage or whatever the hell it is you're getting sucked into."

"Of course," Adora said, trying to mask her surprise, "I'm uh, sorry to ramble."

A sympathetic look crossed Lonnie's face. "Look, it's just that… *this* ," she waved in the direction of the fields, "is the first time I've felt anything like peace. Like I'm doing something I *want* to do. I can give advice, I guess, but I just… I want to stay out of the rest if I can."

"I'm not sure that's entirely realistic," Adora said, thinking of what might happen if the base's location came to the attention of the wrong people, "but I understand. Hopefully we can make that happen. I'll let you get back to it."

"Don't let her monopolize all your time now, 'dora." Lonnie said, and gave a fragile grin. "Who else is gonna move all the big rocks for me?" It was, Adora knew, something of an apology by Lonnie standards for cutting her off.

"Hey, you aren't the only one who likes working in a field now and again." Adora waved and headed in the direction of Catra's office.

The building thrummed with activity, and Adora slowed her pace. There were soldiers everywhere - some discussing a recent mission, others on their way to training, still others ferrying maintenance requests to the workshop, or requisition orders, or intelligence reports. It was almost overwhelming, and Adora once again found herself astonished at what Catra had managed to build in such a relatively short time.

Catra was flipping through a file with a worried frown on her face as Adora entered. She looked up and smiled briefly before her expression slid back into a frown. "Shut the door, can you?"

Adora raised an eyebrow, having already shut the door behind her. "Yeah, of course. What's going on?"

Catra slid the folder across the desk. "Don't say anything, just… just read that. Then tell me I'm crazy for even considering it."

Adora did as she was asked and looked over the contents of the folder. Within a few minutes her expression mirrored Catra's. "You can't be serious."

"Hate to say it, but I'm being completely serious. It's the only way I can see to end the war, get the kids out, and keep this place from being wiped off the map once the Alliance doesn't have a Horde to fight."

"You're assuming the Alliance would come after you."

Catra leaned forward and pinched the bridge of her nose. "That's because I'm assuming the Alliance is controlled by the First Ones, who as we've been informed are going to come after us sooner rather than later."

"Right, but…" Adora's voice sounded close to breaking. "You *promised* ."

"I know." Catra replied, her own voice rough. "I know I did. This is the best I can do."

"We don't know for sure this is how it's going to go though, right?" Adora said, not accepting it for a second. "If we can… if we can figure out what to do about the First Ones, break their hold somehow… Glimmer could go public with your involvement, get the other Princesses on your side."

Catra leaned back in her chair, a thoughtful look on her face. "Hadn't considered that option, to be honest."

"Of course you hadn't!" Adora snorted, a little angry now, "because it would involve you believing that you could ever atone

in their eyes, right?" she sighed, and without quite meaning to, added, "Let alone your own."

Catra's eye widened and she stiffened slightly. "What do you-"

"Come *on* , Catra," Adora said, figuring she'd better get all this out in the open now instead of stewing over it, "you *showed* me what you do with new recruits. Hells, you fought me! You can't pretend that isn't as much for you as it is for them. You're going to end up-" this time her voice actually did break.

Silence hung in the air while Adora struggled to compose herself. Eventually it was broken by Catra's sigh. "They deserve a last chance to find closure," she finally said, "and I don't know how else to give it to them."

"Why does it have to be you every time?" Adora pressed. "Why not let Scorpia help? Or anyone else who's willing?"

" *Because I'm responsible for what they went through* ." Catra said, her voice almost a whisper. "I'm responsible for everything the Horde did! You think *Hordak* was giving me orders to go capture territory? It was *me* . All those battles… all those deaths, they were all my doing."

"Oh, Catra," Adora reached her hand out and took Catra's in her own, "you know that's not true. You can't take everything that happened on your own shoulders."

"Well," Catra said, with a mirthless laugh, "I'm the only one with the shoulders for it at the moment. Until we bury Shadow Weaver and Hordak, anyway."

"What you're building here is enough of a penance," Adora insisted, "you don't need to sacrifice yourself too." When Catra didn't immediately respond, Adora stood up and repeated herself in a more forceful manner. "You *don't* , Catra."

Catra took a deep breath. "Okay. What can we do instead?"

Adora gestured at the file. “Honestly, this plan is a solid start. All we have to do is… make some adjustments to the endgame.”

“That’s the real trick, isn’t it?” Catra said, sighing. “We have to keep the First Ones off our back long enough to figure out how to deal with them.”

“We’ll come up with something.” Adora said. “We’ve got time. First we deal with the Horde.”

“Right.” Catra said, sounding amused. “The easy part. End the war.”

Chapter End Notes

Oooh, it's the spookiest thing possible this Halloween: an update where nothing happens!

Well, not *nothing*, but I got on to page five, realized I wasn't even half-done with Adora and Catra's day, and decided to wrap things up. Plus, I wanted to get this out before the end of the month and I've got about an hour and twenty minutes of October left, so best get a wiggle on, as the kids say (no kid has ever said this). Finding time to sit down and write (or specifically, time to sit down and write *this*, because I've had some other writing projects swimming around that will eventually show up somewhere or other, although I'm trying to remember what they were and coming up empty. October went fast and I've spent most of it either working or continuing this absolutely ill-advised skateboarding hobby I picked up back in September. Remember September?

Yeah neither do I. Time's accelerating. You know how it is.

We're in the point of the year where I'm obliged to say "okay updates might slow down even more," particularly because even though I've already done all I can as far as Election Day goes, I'm still going to be deeply anxious about my home country sliding further into ruin. Either way, I'll be here

writing this thing and you'll be here reading this thing and the fight will continue. Stay safe out there, all.

Anyway, thanks for reading, thanks for commenting, thanks for the kudos, and most of all thanks for patiently waiting as I run about working on stuff that isn't this and, occasionally, stuff that is. Next chapter we'll see the clones that aren't clones and maybe check in with the Best Friend Squad before, well... the war intrudes again.

Departures

Chapter Summary

Adora does a little bit of training. Catra's planning continues. Swift Wind plots a revolution.

The deep breath before the plunge.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Mara was sitting on one of the benches surrounding the training ground when Adora arrived, intending to spend some time punching things and thinking through how to deal with the First Ones. Adora slowed as she approached, not quite sure where the two stood at the moment, and settled for a nod of acknowledgement as she began a series of stretches to warm up. Mara too seemed to pay Adora no mind, although when Adora began to move through a series of shadowboxing routines she watched with some interest.

Adora had been going for around fifteen minutes before Mara spoke. “Your form looks off.”

Adora paused and looked over at Mara. “Is it?”

Mara nodded. “Your back foot’s in the wrong position.”

“Ah,” Adora nodded, “you’ve been training with Catra.”

“It’s how we were trained.” Mara said, raising her chin a little.

“Well,” Adora said, “I suppose that if I learned the way you did, I would probably have changed my positioning as well. Then again, this was all just stuff we were making up as we went along.” Mara seemed interested, so Adora continued. “I keep a wider base,

because I'm less agile. Instead of dodging strikes, I just absorb the blow."

There was a moment of hesitation, then, "Could you show me?"

Adora grinned and beckoned the girl over. "Of course!"

It didn't take too long for Mara to get used to the difference in styles. Adora smiled as she watched her quickly run through a few simple routines. There were a few minor improvements she needed to make, Adora thought, but not much else. It was impressive.

"You can bend your knees even more." Adora instructed, demonstrating herself.

Mara stiffened slightly, as if she was expecting some further words or action from Adora. When none were forthcoming, she adjusted her stance and muttered an apology.

"No apology necessary, kiddo." Adora said, shaking her head in something close to disbelief. "You've picked this up incredibly quickly. Something for you to surprise C'yra with next time you spar, huh?"

Something in Mara's eyes came alive at the complement and she smiled widely. "Thanks for teaching me, Adora."

"No problem." Adora grinned. "Any time you feel like doing some more training let me know - I'll be around."

That gave Mara pause. "What do you mean?"

Adora shrugged. "I joined Catra's army."

"Why? To keep an eye on us?" there was a paranoid tone in Mara's voice that Adora recognized.

"No, to keep an eye on Catra." Adora replied, then hastily added, "I'm joking! It's just that Catra's got a plan to end the war, but she

needs my help to do it. So I'm here."

Mara cocked her head to one side and narrowed her eyes, still not quite buying it. "Why?"

"Because this war has to end - preferably sooner rather than later." Adora replied easily. "Not just because it's the right thing to do, but… I promised that you and C'yra would get to choose what you wanted to be - how you wanted to live. That starts with ending the war."

"What's your angle?" Mara said, finally, an edge to her voice. "You think that'll buy our loyalty?"

Adora looked at her a little more closely. Mara was tense, and there was a defensiveness to her posture that she hadn't noticed before. She crouched down so that she was closer to Mara's level before responding. "No, I don't think that'll buy your loyalty. I don't *want* to buy your loyalty, Mara. I'm not even sure what I'd do with it if I had it. I know that's hard to believe, but… I've never asked for anyone's loyalty. I'm loyal to my friends, and to Catra, and to the idea of ending this war, but I don't ask for that in return."

The next question caught Adora completely off guard. "Isn't Catra one of your friends?"

"She's… more than that." Adora finally said, after a pause. "Friend doesn't begin to cover it."

Mara had been watching her closely as she thought through her answer, and her expression shifted to something *incredibly* smug. "I knew it! I knew you two were making out or whatever at the temple when you sent us out to sleep with Entrapta! C'yra didn't believe me, but *I* knew."

Adora tried unsuccessfully to hide her embarrassment. "Yeah, well…" she waved her hand vaguely, "you'll understand too, one of these days."

“If you say so.” Mara’s response was delivered a little snarkily, although there was a noticeable blush on her cheeks that made Adora think she probably understood a bit more than Adora had at that point.

“My point is,” Adora said, getting back on topic, “I’m not trying to trick you into being loyal to me, or trying to get you to do what I want, because all I want - all Catra wants too, for that matter - is for you guys to be able to grow up with the ability to be free. And yes,” she said, holding up a hand to forestall the comment she knew Mara was about to make, “that means if you decide you want to be soldiers, you can do so. If that also means you still want to kill me and take your revenge, you can do that too. Although if I’m being honest, I hope I can at least convince you not to do that part.”

Mara did her best to look imperious. “We’ll see.”

“That sounds like progress, right?” Glimmer said later, as Adora related the story to her and Bow.

“I guess? I’m not sure I know like… what counts as progress in this case. At this point I’m just really hoping I don’t have to give myself up to be killed, because-”

“I don’t think she’s going to kill you.” Bow broke in. “I mean, you’ve been pretty clear that you just want her and C’yra to be able to grow up without a war happening.”

“Yeah, show a little optimism for once, Adora!” Glimmer added, before changing the subject. “Speaking of ending the war, by the way… Mom’s called a meeting of the Princess Alliance. The intel you got from Catra checks out - our own spies confirmed the Horde’s new weapon failed on its first outing. The rumor mill seems to be under the impression that Hordak’s extremely displeased with Shadow Weaver as a result, but other rumors say it’s the other way around and Hordak pushed to deploy the weapon before it was ready.”

“Either way it’s out of commission.” Bow concluded. “So we don’t have to worry about it showing up and ruining our day, at least.”

“The leaders being at each other’s throats probably isn’t great for morale either.” Glimmer added, “Although we haven’t been seeing any increase in defectors so I can’t be certain.”

“Well it’s likely any defectors have been making their way here.” Adora said, “I can ask Catra if there’s been an increase in recruits.”

“What do you think the odds are the Horde forces break and run during combat?”

Adora chewed her lip worriedly. “I’m honestly not sure. We’re trained to be loyal almost to a fault, morale be damned.”

Glimmer sighed. “So there’s no way to avoid a big fight, is there?”

Adora shook her head. “No. Even if some of the infantry cut and run, the more elite units are loyal to Hordak and Hordak alone. They won’t stop until we’re dead, they’re dead, or… maybe seeing Catra makes them realize they’ve been lied to. I’m not sure.”

“We can’t rely on that, is what you’re saying.” Bow sighed. “It’s going to be a fight no matter what we do.”

Adora sighed. “Yeah, as much as I hate to say it.”

“Well that makes it even more important that you get to us for this meeting.” Glimmer said, nodding decisively. “Mom still thinks you’re off training, but I promised her that I’d bring you here.”

“When’s the meeting?”

“Three days from now. Mermista, Perfuma, and Frosta are expected to show up in two. I assume you can get here within a day on Swift Wind?”

Adora nodded. “Yeah, I’ll head out tomorrow and give us a little time to catch up in person before the meet.”

“Are you sure Catra can stand to be away from you for that long?” Glimmer teased.

“I don’t know,” Adora said, matching Glimmer’s tone, “would Bow let you out of his sight for that long?”

“I don’t know what you’re talking about!” Bow’s voice squeaked. Next to him, Glimmer shot Adora a panicked look and mouthed *not yet* .

“Of course not.” Adora replied, and winked. “But you know, we’ll have time to talk about it when I get there.”

Contrary to Glimmer’s teasing, Catra seemed thrilled to hear that Adora was headed to a Princess Alliance meeting. “So they’re actually going to go ahead with it, huh?” She shook her head in disbelief. “I think this means I owe Lonnie at least two crates of rations. We made a bet years ago they’d never actually assault the Fright Zone.”

“Honestly, I didn’t expect to be able to convince them for at least another five years.” Adora shrugged. “You want me to loop Glimmer in on your own assault plans? Keep our forces from accidentally shooting each other?”

“Actually, I’ve got an idea about that.” Catra slid a sealed envelope across her desk to Adora, who raised an eyebrow at it.

“What’s this?”

“A missive from the Crimson Wastes, pledging the support of an army of irregulars to aid in the assault on the Fright Zone.” Catra grinned. “Negotiated by Glimmer herself, although she doesn’t know it yet.”

“Your people can blend in as part of the Lost Army of Halfmoon.” Adora’s eyes widened. “Babe, that’s *brilliant* .”

Catra blushed a little at the pet name and grinned. "I don't know if we'll *blend in* , really, but it does mean Glimmer won't *technically* be lying to her allies about having another army. More importantly, it'll give me the chance to meet this Dhar'ra of theirs. I suspect she might be interested in helping us with preparations for what comes *after* the fight."

"Do you need me to set up a meeting?" Adora asked. "They aren't exactly… welcoming to strangers, I don't think."

Catra waved a hand airily. "Nah, I've taken care of that. Our… guest was able to put me in touch."

Adora tried, and failed, not to frown. "I don't trust them."

"Neither do I! But I wanted to do this without…" Catra hesitated, then sighed and continued. "Well, without having to use you as a diplomatic tool, honestly."

"You know I would-"

Catra cut her off. "Yeah, I know. But don't you get it? These are…" her hands waved around in front of her uselessly, trying to summon the right words, "my *people* . They might've known my parents. They could be…"

"Family?" Adora supplied.

"What?" Catra shook her head. "No, *you're* my family. Those soldiers out there are my family. But they can help me learn about everything I lost. Stuff I didn't even *know* I lost."

Adora nodded, feeling a warmth at being called Catra's family. "Just… just be careful, okay? Double Trouble is… well, *trouble* , and I feel like if they sense an opportunity to take advantage of you they won't hesitate."

There was a dangerous glint in Catra's eye. "Neither will I."

Adora held Catra's look for a moment. "Okay. I'm going to go put some supplies together so I can get moving as soon as Swift Wind's ready."

As she turned to leave, Catra stopped her. "Hey, wait."

Adora turned. "Hmm?"

Catra pulled her in and kissed her. "Come back in one piece, okay?"

"Hey, I'm just going to see my friends and plan an assault on my childhood home." Adora said, resting her forehead on Catra's. "No danger there apart from the possibility that the palace guard's been infiltrated by First Ones."

"You know that's probably true." Catra said, her tail wrapping around Adora's leg briefly. "But I know you'll be fine."

Adora kissed her again. "I'll contact you once I'm in Brightmoon. You do the same once you make contact with Halfmoon."

"Deal."

Two hours later, Adora was on Swift Wind's back and flying for Brightmoon. Swift Wind had been only too happy to stretch his wings, and while Adora already found herself missing Catra, she was excited to see the princesses again. She couldn't remember the last time she'd seen the other members of the Alliance apart from Glimmer and Bow - so much had happened and the war kept everyone busy with the affairs of their own kingdoms, so she rarely saw them outside of official events anymore.

Swift Wind's voice broke into her thoughts. "You okay back there Adora? Your feelings are all over the place."

"Sorry Swifty, there's just a lot to process. It's been an eventful uh… several weeks? How long has it even been?"

“Since you broke the Sword, since you found out Catra wasn’t dead, or since…?”

“I guess the Sword?”

“Just over a week, I think. We almost immediately came back to save Catra, and then you guys went off to the castle, and uh… I don’t really know what happened after that to you, but *I* spent several very nice days exploring the island and talking to some horses I found.”

“You made friends?”

“Friends is too simplistic a term for what we are. We’re *comrades* , brothers and sisters in arms for the revolution! Our loyalty to one another knows no bounds!”

“Which uh… which revolution?”

“The revolution to free horses from their servitude, to run wild and free as we’re meant to! Or to help our friends if we want to, which is what I’m doing for you, obviously. I mean, we’re destined companions, after all.”

“Of course.” Adora digested this. “You uh, you think any of your comrades would be willing to help overthrow the Horde?”

If horses could be said to look thoughtful, Swift Wind pulled it off. “You know, probably. I guess I don’t know how many horses are actually in the Fright Zone, but I bet they hate it there. I’ll have to ask around.”

“Thanks, buddy. I think we’ll need all the help we can get.”

There was silence for a moment before Swift Wind spoke again in a surprisingly somber tone of voice. “You think this’ll work?”

“I think it has to.” Adora said. “Something tells me this might be our only chance.”

Chapter End Notes

As promised in the chapter that wasn't a chapter and no longer exists, we made it back. Can you tell this was written in fits and starts over the course of like three months, because I can! Imagine I am Kane and all "I have returned never to leave your side again" or whatever, I don't know (Tiberian Sun is the best Command and Conquer and I will fuckin' Fight You on this point).

The world didn't stop while I was gone, obviously, and it has doubtless affected us all in different ways (I started playing a lot more *Hitman 2*, for example). Things are weird and frightening, and they will not stop being weird and frightening for a while I think. I, however, am in fact back and I've been as well-rested as I can get, and you and I are going to get through this year together through the power of this dumb Metal Gear/She-Ra fanfic. I have legitimately missed you guys and I am glad to be back, and hopefully you found some rest over the holidays. Anyway, I'll be back next time - where we'll either see how the Princess Alliance meeting goes, or how Catra's own diplomatic mission goes. I haven't decided yet (that's a lie I decided while I was typing that sentence out). See you next time! Thanks for reading! Thanks for commenting! Thanks for putting up with my increasingly deranged author's notes!

A Meeting of Commanders

Chapter Summary

> Two Commanders meet in the Wastes. Catra answers some questions. Fel'cath discovers something. An alliance is formed.
>
> The final battle moves a little closer.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The Crimson Wastes were exactly as boring as Catra remembered them being. She'd had her transport drop her well away from the entrance to the Forge, figuring it was better if she headed in alone and on foot. She was wrapped up in a cloak against the sun and sand, which also had the benefit of concealing her form and face from potentially unfriendly eyes. She trudged toward the cliffside, looking for the crack that Adora had explained would be there. The data chip she'd gotten from Double Trouble weighed heavily in her pocket. They had assured her the codes on the chip would assure the Lost Army she could be trusted, and when Catra had asked Entrapta to check the contents she'd been informed the codes were in fact just a handshake authentication which (Entrapta assumed) served as a sort of identification chip.

Catra still didn't trust the chip. She planned to keep the chip as a sort of safety - something in her that she didn't want to examine too closely wanted to be accepted by the culture she never knew she had. An even more secret part of her hoped to find someone who'd known her parents, who could tell her more about them, give her an idea of the people who she *should've* known, should've been raised by.

The crack was precisely where Adora had indicated it would be. "Alright," she muttered to herself, "let's see just how far I can get before someone tries to kill me."

A clanging echoed up the corridor as Catra padded her way down to where she knew the Forge would be. The corridor itself was dimly lit at first, but the further she went the brighter it became. There was not, to her dismay, much in the way of shadows to conceal herself in, and the corridor itself was in fact clear of any kind of cover. With nothing else for it, Catra adjusted her posture to something a little more swaggering and strolled down the remainder of the hallway.

Fel'cath was hammering on something at the forge as Catra approached. He was so intent on his work that it took him several minutes to realize there was someone standing near him - and a stranger at that. Catra, for her part, regarded the other magicat and did her level best to look like she was supposed to be there. When she made no immediate move to do anything beyond stand near the anvil and watch Fel'cath work, he continued hammering the blade on the anvil until he was satisfied with its shape, then dunked it into a barrel of water to quench it. As the blade hit the water, it sent up a gout of steam, and as it billowed up he made his move, surging forward and putting the blade at her throat. Catra's hand came up and grabbed the blade, the metal still glowing.

"Is this how you greet all visitors?" She asked.

"Only the ones who show up uninvited." Fel'cath said amiably, seemingly unphased by Catra's hand. "I keep telling them we need to put a guard on that entryway, but nobody listens to me." His gaze flicked to the side and Catra had just enough time to shove the sword back into Fel'cath's body and dive to the side, barely avoiding the swipe from a guard who had snuck up on her blind side. She hit the ground, rolled, and came up with her hands in the air. Her hood fell away, revealing her face. "You know, I didn't come here to fight. I came here to talk. I want to see your leader. One Commander to another."

Fel'cath's eyes narrowed. "So the stories are true, huh? The Commander of the Horde survived."

“The Horde and I don’t exactly see eye-to-eye anymore.” Catra said, pointing her missing hand at her missing eye. “Then again, if you’ve heard the stories, then you’ve probably also heard about the whole ‘created a mercenary army’ thing too.”

“What none of those stories explain,” Fel’cath drawled, “is why the commander of this mercenary army would come here uninvited.”

“Like I said,” Catra repeated, “I want to see your leader. I have a proposition for her. Something that will help both the Lost Army of Halfmoon in its true mission.”

“And what exactly *is* our ‘true mission?’” Fel’cath said, sarcasm lacing his tone.

“If you don’t know,” Catra replied, “then I don’t know I can trust you. I don’t know who I can trust, but I know I can trust your leader.”

“And why is *that?* ”

“Because She-Ra trusts her, and I… trust She-Ra.”

Fel’cath’s expression remained unchanged. “Hmmph. Well then, *Commander* , we’ll grant your request.” His eyes flicked to the two guards. “Bind her hands.”

Catra snorted, but offered no resistance. The guards marched her (a little roughly, she thought) behind Fel’cath, who seemed to have nothing more to say to her. She considered trying to start conversation, but was all too aware that some kind of resentment was brewing under the surface of her captor’s posture - doubtless, she thought, the Horde’s operations in the Crimson Wastes had caused them grief at some point. *Best not to pick at that particular wound* , Catra thought.

When they entered the main cavern, Catra’s breath left her in a rush. She had never seen so many people like her in one place - she’d been unique among the Horde recruits, and while she’d seen other magicats since then, she’d never seen more than two

in one place. She'd also, prior to encountering C'yra, never seen a young magicat, and here there were *dozens* . Her pace slowed unconsciously and she gazed upon the scene with undisguised wonder mixed with longing. The guards did not care for the delay, and gave her a prod that was almost a shove, but not quite. Catra suppressed the urge to shove back, reminded herself why she was here, and picked up her pace.

Fel'cath stopped in front of a tent and motioned for Catra to wait there. He disappeared inside and Catra strained to hear the sound of conversation from within. Unfortunately for her curiosity, two magicats talking together who did not wish to be heard by other magicats were well aware of the tone to use. So Catra only caught a few snippets such as "came alone," "trap," and least promisingly, "don't trust her" before an unfamiliar voice raised and said, "Bring the prisoner forward" and Catra's guards marched her through.

When she saw Dhar'ra's face, Catra had to bite back a cry of surprise. The magicat commander was the spitting image of Queen Cy'ra, although she was dressed in far more casual clothing than the warrior queen from the Crystal Castle's records.

Dhar'ra gave Catra a searching look. "Something wrong? I would think even an ex-commander of the Horde would have a little less obvious shock on their face when meeting with the commander of a force holding her prisoner."

Catra recovered from her surprise quickly. "My apologies. You must be Commander Dha'ra, descended from the line of Queen Cy'ra herself. The resemblance is… strong."

"Oh? Did the Horde find time to teach you about the fall of Halfmoon while it was teaching you how to kill its inhabitants?"

"The Horde," Catra said, controlling her temper admirably, "was not one for history. But I *have* seen the Queen's last stand against the First Ones."

At this, Dhar'ra made a curt motion and the guards and Fel'cath left the tent. "And tell me, Horde Commander, what else did you see?"

Catra stood straight and continued. "I saw her sacrifice herself to buy Mara the time she needed, and how the First Ones defiled her body afterwards, leaving it to rot on the ground."

Dhar'ra rose from her seat and approached Catra with an expression that seemed to dance between curiosity and anger. "You speak of secrets known only to a few." the commander said, her voice tight, "For only one member of that team survived - cursed by cowardice, he fled and hid. We do not remember his name, but we remember his actions kindly, for he mastered himself after the battle and recovered the Queen's body in the aftermath."

"I have been to the Crystal Castle." Catra responded. "The security systems showed me her fall."

"And what exactly was the dead commander of the Horde doing in the Crystal Castle?"

"Seeking answers about the Heart of Etheria." Catra watched the commander's expression carefully. "Answers which we found, and are still trying to understand."

"We?"

"Myself and my companions," Catra replied, feeling a little apprehensive about what she was about to say, "one of which is a mutual ally of yours."

Dhar'ra's expression could have meant anything. "Oh?"

"Adora." Catra said, again watching Dhar'ra's expression for a reaction. "Or She-Ra, if you prefer. She and I are…"

"Close?" Dhar'ra supplied, looking amused. "You must be the friend she spoke of. I am sorry that I was not able to help find

your parents."

Catra was taken aback. "She asked you? Of course she would've asked. It's fine. The fate of Queen C'yra was not the only thing I learned of recently."

Dhar'ra took a moment before responding. "What were their names?"

"Does it matter?" Catra shot back, a hint of venom in her voice. "They were not a member of your kingdom." She felt like she was losing control of the situation, if she'd ever really had it. A voice very much like Adora's echoed in her head. *Tell her their names. It will help her trust you if you're open.* Catra sighed. "My father's name was Finn. My mother, as it turns out, was named C'yra."

Dhar'ra's eyes widened slightly. "I...see. Tell me, Commander… what else do you know about your parents?"

"They were sailors." Catra said. "Smugglers, maybe. I was… very young when I lost them. A Horde patrol, or something. I don't know. They boarded the ship. I hid in a box. The memory was… lost to me, until recently."

"Finn and C'yra..:" Dhar'ra seemed lost in thought. "Forgive me, Commander, but I did not ask your name."

"Commander Catra," she replied, "Formerly of the Horde, currently of a nameless army."

"Catra," Dhar'ra smiled, "your appearance here is… interesting. I assume Adora told you where to find us?"

"She did."

"Then it seems we owe another debt to She-Ra." the Commander said, smiling wryly.

"Why?"

"It is true," Dhar'ra said, "that Finn and C'yra never lived here - it was not in C'yra's nature to settle down anywhere, and Finn… Finn loved the sea too much to ever leave it."

Catra tried to keep her voice steady. "You… you *knew* them?"

"I did." Dhar'ra replied. "C'yra was dear as a sister to me once, though we'd heard very little of her. Her brother kept a closer eye on her than I did."

"Brother?" Catra repeated, incredulous. *I have an uncle?*

"Yes, her brother. It broke his heart when she and Finn sailed away one day with their daughter and never returned. We never knew what happened. You have…" Dhar'ra laughed, though tears unshed shone in her eyes, "you have brought closure to a very old question."

Catra felt a sudden, wild hope. "Is… is her brother still alive? Could I…"

Fel'cath burst into the tent, his eyes wild. "You… you're C'yra's daughter?"

Catra turned slowly. "I am."

Fel'cath's eyes shone. "We thought… we thought you dead with your parents."

Catra gave Fel'cath a closer look. He shared the same build as her mother, and shared her mother's golden eyes as well. A buried memory struggled to the surface.

Fel'cath standing on a pier, tossing Catra high and laughing as her mother rolled her eyes and her father laughed, standing on the deck of their ship. "Come back and see us soon, okay little Cat? Don't get too big for me to throw!"

"You…" her voice choked. "You used to toss me. On the pier. Every time you saw us off."

She was quite suddenly enveloped in a massive hug. Fel'cath's voice was choked as he whispered. "That I did, little Cat. That I did."

"I'd hug you back," Catra said, scrambling to maintain anything like composure and failing terribly, "but you bound my hands."

A booming laugh, watery but familiar to Catra's ear, now, echoed in the tent. "Apologies, of course." Fel'cath said, continuing to shake with laughter. He stepped back and unbound Catra's hands, and she threw them around his neck, feeling a surge of joy at the return of something lost that she hadn't even known was lost. Fel'cath twirled her around, lifting her like she weighed nothing at all.

"I'll forgive you this time… uncle." Catra said, testing the feel of the word out on her tongue. "But now *I'm* being rude, because I *did* have actual business coming here." She peered over his shoulder at Dhar'ra, who was staring at the two with undisguised delight. "I came to discuss an alliance, and a plan of action for the coming battle - and to ask for your help in another matter."

"Then, as much as I would rather call for a celebration, we shall talk business." Dhar'ra said, nodding. "I assume that your company is in the employ of the Princess Alliance for this fight?"

"That's the thing..." Catra said, launching into an explanation of the political situation. "We assume the Alliance and the Rebellion are both compromised - although the extent is unknown, obviously. In addition, my own past actions aren't going to go away - I don't want my men seen as a hostile force, so we need cover. Adora's carrying a treaty with some 'Crimson Waste irregulars' to a meeting of the Princess Alliance now, which gives my people the cover to operate openly."

Dhar'ra nodded, impressed. "I'm impressed. We'll work with you, of course. I assume you've considered how you're going to time your force's arrival?"

"Yeah." Catra pulled a file out from under her cloak and unfolded a map from it. "The main force will strike here, and hopefully draw Horde forces away from these areas to the west. At the same time, I'll take a small force of my own and head for the main compound."

"You intend to strike at Hordak yourself, then?"

Catra held up her metal hand. "I owe him for a few things. Shadow Weaver too. I'd do it alone if I could, but they're both likely to have guards on them and I'm not so arrogant as to not ask for help."

"I can spare some of my people as well, if you'd like." Dhar'ra offered, but Catra shook her head.

"No. The team I'm taking in is all ex-Horde. It's… personal."

Dhar'ra nodded. "Okay. My forces will split between supporting your forces and aiding in the other Rebellion operations. I assume they have a plan as well?"

"The Princess Alliance is meeting in two days to go through a plan, during which time Glimmer will introduce her Army of the Crimson Wastes - which will include my forces and yours, to keep us both from being exposed to whatever First Ones are around. I presume that Glimmer will reach out to you when their assault plans are finalized." Catra breathed out. "One other thing: there's the possibility we may encounter a unique hostile force - Shadow Weaver juiced them up with some kind of magic. According to Adora, they're fast and incredibly strong. I don't know how many of them there are, but it's a good bet they'll be deployed wherever the fighting is thickest."

"Or they'll be guarding Weaver and Hordak." Dhar'ra pointed out. "You said yourself there would be guards on them - why not the most powerful ones they've got?"

Catra grimaced. "I'd considered that, but my assumption is that She-Ra will draw them out. Hordak wouldn't allow She-Ra to have

control of the battlefield unchallenged.”

“You know his mind better than I do, I assume.” Dhar-Ra said, shrugging. “You were his right hand for long enough.”

“One last thing.” Catra said, ignoring the twist of guilt in her stomach and pulling out the small data chip. “I was contacted by someone who claimed to be an ally of yours. A shapeshifter named Double Trouble. They gave me this as a way of convincing you I was trustworthy, but *I* don’t think I trust *them* .”

“Probably a wise decision.” Dhar’ra said. “But I think you’ll find that Shapeshifters have more cause than most to desire vengeance on the First Ones. More, perhaps, than even we magicats do.”

“That’s a relief.” Catra replied. “It’s getting hard to keep track of all the people who might want to kill me. It also means I’ve got a better chance of getting out of this whole thing alive.”

“You’d better.” Fel’cath said. “I just found out you’re not dead.”

Chapter End Notes

> Aw naw hell naw look who it is with another chapter a less than a month after he posted a last chapter it's ya boy the Big Old Skeleton laying it down on the ones and twos, aw yeah.
>
> Courtesy of having some more time on my hands, and hey maybe the new year really did bring in a little freshness to this otherwise stanky mood. Honestly it's a miracle that I managed to tear myself away from *Hitman 3* long enough to knock this out, but I have also been trying very hard to not like, burn myself out on murderin'. None of this matters.
>
> It helps that I had a real good notion of where this chapter was going, and also where the *next* chapter is going, so who knows maybe we'll even get that one out a little faster too! Overpromise and underdeliver, that's my motto! Anyway,

hope you enjoyed me throwing ONE LAST TWIST in there re: Catra's family, and quietly setting up some other things which maybe we'll all learn about one day. Or maybe we won't. Anyway, thank you as always for your comments and kudos, and we'll see each other next time. Or maybe, inspired by a conversation with my brother earlier this week, I'll commit the cardinal sin of writing that Hitman/She-Ra fic I mentioned as a joke but then was like "okay but what if I *did*, though?"

Am I just going to become the Guy Who Crosses Over She-Ra with Video Games He Likes? I guess time will tell.

A Change

Chapter Summary

> Glimmer and Adora meet the Queen. She-Ra makes a promise. The young Queen of Brightmoon finds a new path.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Glimmer looked up from the book she was reading as Adora entered the chamber and grinned. “Hey! How was… training?”

Adora laughed and wrapped her friend up in a massive hug, twirling her around. “Hey Glim! I’ve missed you! Have things been relatively quiet here?”

“Yeah,” Glimmer said, with a little frown, “a little… *too* quiet, you know?”

“It’s just the calm before the storm.” Adora said, hoping it was true. “I’d enjoy it while you can - it’ll get plenty loud for both of us once this plan’s finalized.”

“ *If* this plan’s finalized.” Glimmer replied, grimacing. “I think mom’s getting cold feet.”

Adora pulled the letter Catra had given her out of her jacket. “Well, maybe this will help. It’s a formal treaty with a group of irregulars in the Crimson Wastes, led by one Commander Dhar’ra.”

Glimmer was fast on the uptake. “I would’ve liked to see her myself - and Bow still has a lot of ideas for that blacksmith we met - but it being quiet doesn’t mean I haven’t had a ton of stuff to keep track of here.”

Their conversation was interrupted by a rap on the door. “Princess Glimmer, Adora, the Queen requests your presence.”

Glimmer rolled her eyes. “Let her know we will be there shortly, please.” She gave Adora an apologetic look. “Sorry, I know you’re probably worn out from traveling but you can see for yourself what I mean about her having second thoughts this way.”

“It’s fine!” Adora insisted, because it really was fine. The fact that she’d have to keep up the pretense of having been off training and not spending copious amounts of time in bed with the love of her life (to say nothing of everything else she’d been up to) was nothing she was looking forward to, but something about the situation made her far more comfortable with the deception.

Angella seemed exhausted when Adora and Glimmer entered, but she smiled at the two. “Adora, I am pleased to see you well. Your presence has been sorely missed here - although I know it is selfish of me to say so.”

Adora bowed low, feeling a mixture of affection for the woman who had helped her through so much and suspicion that she was being buttered up for something. “Thank you, your majesty. I fear the war will continue to pull me away - another reason to move to end it, I suppose.”

Angella sighed. “Yes, the planned assault on the Fright Zone. Reports still indicate the Horde is licking its wounds after some encounter with an unknown force which damaged the new weapons system you uncovered. I have to confess, Adora, that I am hesitant to commit our forces to an assault without a clearer understanding of what happened.”

“I can help with that.” Adora said, shooting Glimmer a quick look. “When we made our trip to the Crimson Wastes, we encountered something of an irregular army there - I’m sure Glimmer told you about it?” At Angella’s nod, she continued. “I admit that we weren’t *entirely* honest when I said I was out training - I was also meeting with the leader of this army of irregulars to convey Glimmer’s offer to them to join the Rebellion.”

“Why didn’t you tell me this?” Angella asked, frowning. “I wouldn’t have forbidden such a meeting.”

“Sorry Mom, but in all honesty, I wasn’t sure it would work and I didn’t want you to factor it into whatever battle plans we drew up for the assault on the Fright Zone.” Glimmer said, looking appropriately apologetic. “We didn’t make a very strong offer beyond assuring them that we had no interest in making any territorial claims on the Crimson Wastes, and Adora agreed that She-Ra would be willing to help them if necessary.”

Angella nodded. “I am not thrilled you decided to keep this from me, but given the circumstances, their help will be useful. I worry, however, of what the other kingdoms will think about this.”

Glimmer snorted. “Gee, if only there were a meeting of all the princesses where we could find out coming up soon.”

“The timing is quite fortuitous.” Angella nodded, a small smile on her face. “Adora, I assume that you will be serving as a liaison with this group of Crimson Waste fighters moving forward? It would give you an excellent way to avoid having to deal with the court politics we deal with here.”

Adora felt a stab of guilt - both because they were lying to the Queen and because Angella had always known Adora’s distaste for political events and was offering her a way out of them. She forced a smile and nodded. “Correct, your majesty. The Crimson Wastes has a lot of ex-Horde there and it’s… a little easier for me to handle them.”

“Can we trust them?” Angella leaned forward, a look of concern on her face.

“Well,” Adora said, “they *are* the reason we have this chance in the first place, for starters - it was a squad of irregulars who encountered the Horde’s new battle platform and managed to disable it. I know the initial impetus for this assault was the

recovery of She-Ra's full powers, but this takes another unknown off the board."

Angella nodded. "Very true. But you, Adora, know the Horde and those in its service. Do you trust these people?"

The answer came easily to Adora, mostly because she was thinking of Catra and her army as she said it. "I do. In speaking with them I've heard how things are going in the Horde since Catra's… departure. Those who fled took an enormous risk, and they wouldn't go willingly back into Hordak's service."

There was silence as Angella gazed at Adora's face as if ascertaining whether or not she could trust her judgment. Finally, she nodded. "Very well. Glimmer, I will begin speaking with our generals to let them know we have additional forces to draw upon - but it will be on you and Adora to convince the other Princesses we can trust them."

"No problem!" Glimmer said brightly. She hesitated, then gave Adora a sideways glance. "Right?"

Adora shrugged. "I mean, they still trust our judgment, don't they?"

Glimmer gave Adora an answering shrug. "Last time I checked, but the Kingdom of Frost advisors have been up Frosta's ass about shouldering too much of the war effort for the last year, so who knows?"

"Yeah, but it's *Frosta* . She doesn't listen to anyone."

"Well then," Angella said, interrupting the two, "I shall leave the matter in your capable hands, Glimmer. I apologize that I won't be able to attend the meetings myself, but I will make sure to drop in when I can."

Glimmer tried, and failed, to hide her delight at being trusted by Angella. "We won't let you down Mom! Er, I mean, Your Majesty."

A smile crossed Angella's face. "I'm sure you won't. Now go on, I'm certain you and Adora have plenty of catching up to do."

Adora bowed, mostly out of habit, and would have walked out if Glimmer hadn't grabbed her hand and teleported the two of them back to her room immediately. She gave a loud sigh of relief. "Whew! I'm glad that went over so well."

"I think your mom knows - or guesses - more than she's letting on." Adora said, chewing her lip. "She let that whole story slide and didn't even seem that mad about our not telling her sooner."

Glimmer rolled her eyes. "Adora, you're being paranoid. Look, even if she *does* suspect who these people are, she trusts *you* ."

Adora grimaced. "That just makes me feel worse about keeping the fact that Catra's alive and running her own army from her. All the First Ones stuff too. I… I *want* to trust her."

"You think I don't?" Glimmer replied, a slight heat to her voice. "I don't *like* keeping this from her, Adora, but… I mean, she's been around for centuries! *Maybe* she hasn't been keeping us in the dark, and maybe she has… but either way I don't wanna risk anything that might put the war plan in jeopardy."

"Yeah." Adora said, feeling a little reassurance that at least she wasn't the only one feeling conflicted about the whole thing. "You're right. The Horde falls first. Then we can deal with… everything else."

"Tall order." Glimmer said, then grinned and nudged Adora in the ribs. "But hey, we've got the full powers of the mighty She-Ra and her girlfriend's army on our side, right?"

Adora felt a sudden lightness of heart, like she'd felt back when she first found the sword and won the first battle of Brightmoon. "Well yes," she said, adopting a haughty voice, "I suppose our services are at your command for now. We are *very* important people though, you know. Very busy. I'll have to pencil you in to our *sheduawls,* you know."

Glimmer laughed. “Of course, how silly of me. I’ll be sure to give you plenty of advance notice before we show up. Make sure you have time to get dressed and all.”

“Frankly, I’m surprised you teleported me back to your room.” Adora replied, grinning. “I figured Bow would be in here waiting for you.”

A voice came from Glimmer’s hammock above. “He *was* , actually, and he would like his pants back when you have a chance.”

Glimmer’s choke of embarrassment was outshone by Adora’s laughter. “Oh my *gods* I can’t believe I called it!” She scooped up Glimmer in a hug and whirled her around. “Congratulations, you two! I’m so happy for you both!”

“Yes, hooray, we’re all very happy for us.” Bow called down. “I am still pantsless. Glimmer, light of my life,dearest treasure of my heart, *please* tell me you’re not going to make me hop down naked in front of our good friend Adora to get my pants.”

Glimmer seemed to actually be considering the option for a moment. “I mean… I wouldn’t complain about the view, really…”

At Bow’s whined “Glimmerrrrrrrrr” she relented and grabbed a pair of trousers off the floor, then disappeared in a flash of sparkles, only to reappear a few feet above the hammock. There was a squeak of surprise from Bow which turned into a pleased sound that Adora tried not to think about too closely.

“You know, I can come back later if that’s…”

Glimmer’s “Okay see you later Adora!” was intermingled by Bow’s “Of course not!” and, laughing, Adora exited the room to give the two privacy. “I’ll be in my quarters! Come find me when you two are decent.”

This time, there was the sound of rustling fabric before Bow let out a “Thanks Adora!” and Glimmer’s top flew out of the hammock.

Shaking her head and still laughing to herself, Adora made her way to what had, until very recently, been her home. Her things were still scattered from where she'd quickly thrown a backpack together before rushing off to tend to Catra, and she spent some time putting the room back to rights.It had only been around ten minutes before there was a knock at her door. Adora swung the door open with a teasing grin and a "well, *that* didn't take too long-" that trailed off into an awkward silence as she was confronted by the rather confused looking face of Queen Angella.

"What didn't take too long?"

Adora's brain went through several different explanations, each worse than the last, so she settled on "Er, nothing your Majesty! Um… what can I do for you?"

At this, Angella looked uncertain in a way that Adora had never seen before. "I am… sorry to trouble you, Adora, but you are perhaps the only one I can trust to give me an honest answer. May I come in?"

"Of course, your Majesty." Adora stepped to the side and gestured to the Queen. "Please, make yourself comfortable."

Angella crossed the floor and took a seat in one of the chairs in the room and took a moment to collect herself. "My daughter filled me in about your recent unlocking of She-Ra's true potential, including memories long forgotten. I… I know it is not my place to ask, but… can I speak with her? You? I have lived for centuries, and I confess I selfishly seek the counsel of someone older than I." It was as if the regal bearing she usually wore slipped off completely.

There had been a flash of annoyance when the topic immediately turned to She-Ra, but looking into Angella's eyes, Adora was suddenly hit with a wave of pity for her - ancient by Etherian standards, unchanging until the ending of the world, and yet uncertain as to… something. "Of course, your Majesty. If you'll allow me to ask, what… exactly do you wish to know?"

Angella hesitated, and seemed to cast about for the right words. "I was raised in war." she finally said. "As a child, I remember Brightmoon nearly constantly caught up in some minor squabble with the surrounding kingdoms. I was told it was part of a proper ruler's duties to keep her people safe, and sometimes that meant going to war. When the Horde arrived, my parents were among the first to fall. I pulled together the kingdom and assembled an alliance. We fought back, for a time. You know, of course, how it ended."

Adora nodded. "Micha's death."

"Yes. His loss - along with the loss of the Queen of Salenas and the King's subsequent abdication - was more than enough to bring it all crashing down. Your appearance - *She-Ra's* appearance - was the only thing that could've possibly brought the Alliance back. But I... confess that I am…" Angella's voice was very quiet now, barely above a whisper. "I am a coward, Adora. I fear this path will only lead us to ruin again. Afraid that we do not have the strength necessary to do this. Afraid that if we *do* win, the kingdoms will once more fall to petty squabbling."

Adora felt a nudge in the back of her mind. *I shall speak to her,* She-Ra said. Adora closed her eyes, took a deep breath and slipped easily into She-Ra's form, feeling the link between her and the goddess connect. She opened her eyes and beheld the astonished face of Queen Angella, dumbstruck at the true form of She-Ra.

"Queen Angella of Brightmoon, you ask for assurance?"

Angella nodded. "I wish to know that this is the right path. That we will not repeat the mistakes of the past."

She-Ra smiled, and almost took a chiding tone. "Young Majesty, you have lived for centuries. You should know by now that there is no assurance any power can give that all will go as we hope. Time is long, and we are imperfect creatures. To seek surety beyond all doubt is a fool's errand." She held up her hand to

forestall a response. “Angella of Brightmoon, you have allowed fear to rule you for too long. I cannot give you courage, but I can tell you this much.” She-Ra walked to the window and beckoned Angella to follow. “You spent many years alone, and thought only of protecting your daughter and your people, but you do not need to be alone any longer. You have allies across Etheria willing to fight for the chance of a better future. There is *hope* , Angella, and that must be enough.”

“Can you at least promise me this, She-Ra?” Angella pleaded. “Can you promise me that my daughter will be safe?”

“The world is uncertain.” She-Ra said. “I can assure you, however, that if you allow your fear to rule you at this final step, Brightmoon and the rest of Etheria *will* fall, and any chance of a better future will be lost. The world stands on the brink of a change - both this fight against the Horde and something I cannot yet fully see. Yet I can promise you this, at least. I will do everything in my power to keep Glimmer safe - but in return I ask something of *you* .”

Angella seemed surprised. “What?”

“You have spent years staying in Brightmoon, young Majesty.” She-Ra said, giving Angella a long look. “I would ask this: when the final battle comes, ride out with me and fight. Face the Horde head on, and show your people their leader stands with them.”

Angella’s eyes widened at this, before something in her shifted. “Yes,” she said, quietly, “perhaps you are right. I have been selfish in asking you to keep Glimmer safe… I release you from that request. I will ride to battle with you, She-Ra, and give my daughter a future that is not hiding behind palace walls, or fighting in endless stalemates.” Her voice grew in volume as she spoke, and her wings unfurled. “Yes. I will fight. Thank you, She-Ra. You have given me what I sought.”

She-Ra smiled. “Then I will make you this promise, young Angella of Brightmoon: if you do not allow fear to master you, your

kingdom can indeed live at peace after this war is over. Now, you have one more question, I think, that you are afraid to ask me - do you not?"

Again, Angella was left surprised. "How did-?"

"Ask your question, Angella, and do not fear the answer."

"It is said… it is said that your last incarnation went mad. What should… that is…"

"I think you will find that much you were told as a child was not true." She-Ra said, smiling. "Yet these matters we can speak of later. Suffice it to say that there is little danger of such an event - Adora is, after all, possessed of incredible strength of will, and I am, in the end, Adora." Adora shifted back and smiled at the queen. "Years ago, I swore to aid the Alliance in the fight against the Horde. That oath still holds."

Angella nodded. "Thank you, Adora. And… forgive me. I have allowed much to pass for fear of disrupting what I perceived to be safety."

"Don't worry, your Majesty." Adora said, feeling a surge of affection for the woman who had given her a family again. "I think something I've learned recently is that it's basically never too late to change."

"Well," Angella said, and there was a power and a purpose in her bearing that hadn't been there before, "I will start with this meeting. Let the Princesses know that I will lead the Brightmoon forces into battle myself."

Chapter End Notes

> Whatever I updated twice in January so one of those counted for February, right? Plus I got distracted by an absolute *shitload* of other stuff, which, if you happen to follow me, you've been able to read at your leisure. There's Gravity Falls stuff, Nancy Drew stuff, and Hitman stuff! A lot of stuff! But

this here is my first and greatest love, which is actually why it took so fucking long.

The princesses were supposed to show up here! They didn't! Instead I kind of went a little into Angella and gave her, you know, something of a moment to reckon with herself. I really do believe the stuff Adora says there at the end, you know? Folk tend to despair, and write off people, and like... obviously if you do bad shit to people you gotta make amends and maybe you never get forgiven for that, but you can still be a better person, you know? I don't know, this whole idea of restorative justice has been on my mind lately and like everything else it bleeds into here. I'm probably not explaining this well and I don't know if I could at the moment because I'm still figuring it all out and will probably never quite get there but hey, it's the journey and not the destination or whatever.

Sometimes I don't know how these notes go off in the directions they go. Anyway, as we come up on the Lockdown Anniversary (I cannot fucking believe we've been locked down for a year) and the world seems determined to continue a slide into garbage dystopia, I keep coming back to the idea of having to ride out and face this shit head on, and to reach out to the people around you and draw strength from that. I, for example, draw strength from your comments and kudos!

There, that was a sufficiently dumb joke to shake out of the weird turn this took. Thanks for reading, we'll be back with more of this, and more of the other stuff too! Just writing all manner of bullshit! It's great! You're great! Next chapter will probably be the actual meeting of the Princesses because I selfishly want to write Mermista, because it occurred to me the other day that she rules and frankly it's a crime I haven't gotten her in here yet.

Many Meetings

Chapter Summary

> Adora catches up with some old friends. Mermista figures it out. Frosta has some opinions.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Glimmer and Bow showed up around twenty minutes after Angella had taken her leave, and Adora filled the two in on the recent shift in the situation. Glimmer digested the information quietly.

"Can we trust her?" Glimmer said, after a very long pause.

Adora hesitated slightly before replying, considering whether or not she should tell Glimmer everything Angella had said. "She asked to speak to She-Ra specifically, and while she did ask how to kill me if I went crazy," ("She *what?* " Glimmer shouted, before Adora held up a hand to let her finish), "she also seemed like she believed me when I said the story of the old She-Ra wasn't true. The fact that I was literally She-Ra at the time probably helped."

"Still, Adora, if my mother is looking for… I don't know, *weaknesses* , isn't that a bad thing?"

"I think…" Adora weighed her words carefully, "I think your mom is just trying to cover her bases. She's been around stories of the madness of She-Ra for *centuries* , Glim', it's not going to all go away after one heart-to-heart chat. Besides," she added with a wink, "I'm pretty sure I could take her if it came to that."

"Oh my goddesses, please don't make me think about you having to throw down with my mother." Glimmer groaned, pulling a hand down her face.

"I'm just saying…" Adora said, letting a grin spread across her face and taking a teasing tone, "I'm *pretty good* at the whole fighting thing." She let a little seriousness bleed back into her tone. "Look, far be it from me to give advice on the subject of parental relationships, but… maybe you should talk to her? She seemed to take my advice to heart, at any rate."

Glimmer's curiosity was piqued, and Adora winced inwardly at the slip. "What advice?"

"To go out and fight," Adora said, cursing her inability to lie convincingly, "and to trust that the Rebellion is strong enough to do the job."

"I've been telling her that for *years!* " Glimmer exclaimed, not without some anger.

"Yes, but you can't turn into a millenia-old goddess of magic who's one of the only people older than your mother, can you?" Adora said, snorting. "Trust me when I say that your mother would *not* take the advice from *me* , even if it would've been the same. I think she wanted someone older than her to tell her what she already knew, honestly."

Bow spoke up, sensing that the subject needed changing "So she's really going to fight? I don't think… I don't think I've *ever* seen her fight."

"She hasn't gone out and *fought* since Dad died." Glimmer said, shrugging. "Not unless the fight was literally on our doorstep, and even then she spent most of her time keeping the runestone charged."

"At any rate," Adora said, "we should get her integrated into the battle plan when we meet with the others."

The rest of the day was spent catching up on less fraught matters - Glimmer and Bow explained how they'd finally gotten over themselves enough to admit their feelings openly: unsurprisingly, it had been Glimmer to make the first move (which won a long-

standing bet Adora had with Mermista that she had the tact to not bring up in the middle of the story).

"When we got back from Halfmoon, and you raced off to save Catra, it just kind of… got me thinking, you know?" Glimmer admitted, her thumb rubbing small circles on Bow's hand. "I guess the fact you almost lost her made me think about losing Bow, and how I'd never, you know, *told* him how I felt. So after you left, I just… told him."

"To be clear," Bow said, pausing to plant an affectionate kiss on Glimmer's head, "this was like… *right* after you'd gone. She burst into my room, said you'd run off to save Catra, and then just…" his voice trailed off, and an immensely dopey grin spread across his features, "told me. Then I kissed her. Then we uh… both kind of burst out laughing because we'd taken so long to say what we already *knew* , you know?"

Adora laughed. "Yeah, I know the feeling."

Mermista was the first to arrive the next day, Sea Hawk in tow as always. She was in a foul mood (or maybe her normal mood. Adora was never 100% sure, even now), which Sea Hawk assured them was down to the fact they'd been on horseback instead of sailing.

"And whose fault is it we lost our ship, Sea Hawk?"

"My precious jewel of the seas, surely you do not mean to imply that running into a Horde blockade was *my plan* , do you?"

"No, but deciding to light *another of my ships on fire to run it sure as hell was, wasn't it?* "

"If there's a better way to run a blockade," Sea Hawk said, sounding a little affronted, "I'd like to hear it."

"Usually running a blockade implies that your ship is still *usable* afterwards." Mermista snapped. "And it doesn't involve almost-" she cut herself off.

“My dear, you know I was never *really* in any danger.”

“Shut up that wasn’t what I was going to say.”

“Of course, my shining emerald goddess of the ocean.”

Some things , Adora thought to herself, *never really change, do they?* She suddenly found herself missing Catra, even though it hadn’t been more than a day. *I bet she’d get along well with Catra.*

Mermista’s attention suddenly flicked to Adora. “You look different. Why do you look different?”

Adora was startled from her thoughts. “I’m… not sure what you mean?”

“You’ve got this whole…” Mermista waved her hand vaguely in front of her, “thing about you. Relaxed? I wanna say… relaxed.”

“Well, uh,” Adora said, not certain where this was going, “I… slept well last night?”

Mermista’s expression took on the same sort of look she usually got when she’d been reading too many Mermysteries. “I don’t think that’s it. Something’s changed.”

“Well,” Glimmer said, unexpectedly coming to Adora’s rescue, “it *has* been a while since we’ve gotten together.”

“Oh yeah, that’s probably it!” Adora said, nodding. “It might also be… well, related to some stuff we’ll get into later. She-Ra stuff.”

“Hmm, maybe that’s it.” Mermista said in a tone that suggested she was not convinced at all. “Where’s Perfuma and the kid? Did we really beat them here?”

“I’m as surprised as you are.” Glimmer said, shrugging.

"Please, with my magnificent navigational skills, it was simplicity itself!"

"Well in the meantime, you can get settled into your quarters." Bow said, playing the role of host. "We've got lunch being prepared too, but if you want something to tide you over there's snacks basically on request like always."

Mermista tried not to look too eager at the prospect of both food and rest, and failed completely. "Thank the fucking spirits, I could eat my horse."

"Don't let Swift Wind hear you say that." Adora said, half-serious. "He's forming a revolution of horses to help with the assault on the Fright Zone for us, and I'd hate to lose him as an ally."

Mermista fixed her with a flat look. "Uh huh. Noted, I guess."

After Mermista and Sea Hawk had left, Glimmer nudged Adora. "You know, you really ought to tell her about the whole uh… you know. Thing."

"Now is *really* not the time, I think." Adora replied, a little hastily. "After the battle, I'll tell them anything they wanna know. I can't - *we* can't - risk any distractions."

Glimmer frowned a little, but nodded. "You're probably right. Telling Mermista you're banging the person responsible for sacking Salenias probably wouldn't go over that great."

That got a loud laugh out of Adora, more from shock than actual amusement.

As it turned out, Perfuma and Frosta didn't arrive until the evening, and with a surprisingly large honor guard from the Kingdom of Snows, which made Glimmer visibly tense. Perfuma, of course, picked up on it immediately.

"It's unfortunate, but the roads from the north have become less secure." she explained, without prompting. "Queen Frosta's safety

is paramount, at least as far as her advisors are concerned."

Frosta snorted. "My advisors would be much happier if I'd meet with an accident on the road so they could pull out of the Rebellion and start selling weapons to the fucking Horde."

"Frosta, *language!* " Perfuma scolded in a scandalized tone.

"Oh please," Frosta said, rolling her eyes, "if I can't drop the whole Queenly bullshit act here, I'll go insane and start another war out of spite." She turned to Glimmer and sighed. "Look, I know the whole honor guard thing looks aggressive, but I needed to make a show of force leaving the capital city. Remind some of my less loyal staff who still has the loyalty of the army."

Glimmer seemed like she wasn't entirely mollified, but her concern for Frosta overrode it. "I didn't realize things had gotten so dangerous for you."

Frosta shrugged. "The Kingdom of Snows' political situation has always been pretty uh… what's the phrase you used, 'fuma?"

"Potentially volatile." Perfuma said.

"Which is the polite way of saying it's totally fucked." Frosta said, then grinned. "Fortunately for you, me, and my subjects, I've proven awfully difficult to kill. Not that they haven't tried."

Adora took a moment to size up the young monarch. Frosta had gone through another growth spurt since her last visit, though she was still shorter than Adora. Her hair was kept short, and her ramient was, Adora noted, simple and clearly meant for combat. She was, Adora noted, a soldier more than a queen. "Why not put your advisors on trial?" Adora asked, already knowing the answer.

"What, you testing me to find out if I'm considering going all murderous despot on them?" Frosta shot back, a flicker of amusement in her eyes. "I'd rather let my advisors have a little more rope to hang themselves with before I move openly against

them. Besides, if not for the war I would've abdicated a long time ago. I hate this queen shit."

"Good answer." Adora said, grinning.

Things were slightly less jovial during the first session of their meeting the following morning.

"No fucking way." Frosta said, flatly. "Getting a go-ahead to commit forces to this assault is hard enough without having to convince the council to trust a bunch of Crimson Waste irregulars."

"And ex-Horde to boot." Mermista added. "Not exactly the most trustworthy bunch." she paused long enough to shoot Adora an apologetic look. "Present company excluded."

"If anything, Adora's the reason we *can* trust them." Glimmer broke in, anger in her tone. "She's been nothing but loyal to us and our cause-"

"Adora's loyal, but she's the exception. Catra used to send spies into us with similar stories. That's how she got into my kingdom last time." Mermista's tone brooked no argument. "What possible assurance do we have that they aren't going to just-"

Something's coming. She-Ra's voice echoed in the back of Adora's mind. *Small. Subtle. Do not let this argument continue.*

"These are different!" Glimmer insisted. "It's not *just* Horde soldiers this time."

"Oh, so now we're supposed to trust bandits are going to be loyal as well?"

"They *aren't* just bandits!"

Almost here.

"And I'll be fighting alongside them in the battle." Adora said, quickly. "I trust them. I *know* some of them. They're done with

the Horde."

"What if it's a feint?" Perfuma spoke up unexpectedly. "I know that Catra is… gone, but she used deception in the past and it's not-"

"Shadow Weaver," Adora said, feeling a familiar prickle on her skin, "taught Catra and I everything about deception and deceit. Unfortunately, she's not subtle enough for this kind of a scheme. She's more opportunistic, waiting in the shadows, until - *there!* "

There was an explosion of golden light as Adora's hand shot out,. There was a shriek as a writhing black creature found itself suddenly pinned against the wall by She-Ra's blade. Another flash of light filled the room, and the creature shuddered and went limp. She-Ra felt more than heard a cry of pain from a great distance and smiled grimly. The assembled princesses whirled around in shock. Frosta was the first to speak.

"What the *fuck?* "

"Our enemy," She-Ra said, striding over to the creature as it boiled away into shadow, "has made her presence known. She would not do so if she were setting a trap."

"How did you-?"

"Shadow Weaver's magics are easy to detect," She-Ra replied, turning her gaze on Frosta, "when you are expecting them."

Frosta seemed to notice She-Ra's new look at this point, because her eyes widened and she couldn't quite hide a slight blush. "You uh, look different than before."

Mermista was far less concerned with concealing her reaction, openly staring. "Uh, yeah. This that 'She-Ra stuff' you mentioned earlier?"

"Shoulders." Perfuma added, before regaining control of herself. "Er, that is, I see that your aura has gotten… stronger, She-Ra."

“There is a lot to explain.” She-Ra said, openly amused at the reactions of the princesses. “I’ve recently been set free of a long imprisonment. A long deception finally undone. I am more than I was before.” She then explained the situation, eliding the details about the Kingdom of Halfmoon to merely refer to it as a ruin they’d discovered.

“I’ll be honest,” Mermista said, “when I said you were looking different earlier, I thought you’d just finally gotten laid.”

Adora coughed and blushed. “Well, it was really just…”

“Oh. *Oh* .” Mermista’s eyes were sparkling with amusement now. “So when you say you *know* some of these Horde soldiers…”

Oh what the hell , Adora thought, *it’s close enough to the truth.* “You can meet her later, alright? After the battle.”

“She isn’t the commander of this army of irregulars, is she?” Frosta asked.

“No, the commander is native to the Crimson Wastes.” Glimmer broke in. “She’s who Adora will be liaising with.” She shot a look in Adora’s direction. “Is it safe to continue?”

Adora closed her eyes and reached out. There was no hint of the previous menace that had caused She-Ra to warn her. “Yeah, she’s gone. I don’t think she’ll be back any time soon, either. When I severed the link I was not… gentle.”

“Good.” Frosta snorted. “If you ask me, she’s got it coming.”

“Oh don’t worry,” Queen Angella’s voice came from the doorway, “she’s got worse coming her way.”

The princesses stood and bowed. “Queen Angella, greetings from the Kingdom of Snows.” Frosta said, displaying remarkable diplomatic acumen.

“No formalities necessary, dear.” Angella said, smiling. “After all, we will be sharing a battlefield together.”

The princesses reacted in surprise. “Y..you’re going to fight?” Perfuma asked, sounding a little dazed.

“Yes, I will be there with you.” Angella said, and there was a fierceness in her posture that even drew a surprised look from Glimmer. “I have stayed away from the fight for too long. It is time I remedied that. I apologize that I have left you to fight this war alone for so long.”

“No apologies necessary, your Majesty.” Frosta spoke up again. “I’ve learned there are… numerous pressures on the head of state which can make things more difficult than you would think.”

“Perhaps so.” Angella hummed thoughtfully, and turned to her daughter. “Now, I believe Glimmer has a few things to explain?”

Glimmer nodded and pulled up a map of the Fright Zone. “Alright,” she said, voice confident, “here’s the plan.”

Chapter End Notes

A long wait for a short chapter, I know. In my defense, I've been busy with other ridiculous nonsense (and also deciding how much detail to go into and what to cut and what to keep took a good deal of brain power). I felt like having Frosta come into her own was important, and I felt like Mermista and Sea Hawk needed some time to clue in on things, but I couldn't quite find a place for Perfuma. Don't worry though, Perfuma fans, she'll have more to do as we enter the endgame. Which, I should go ahead and announce, we're in. I could, in fact, probably wrap this up in two chapters.

I don't think I *will*, mind you, because that would mean cutting out a chance for Adora and Catra to get one last bit of time together before everything... well. Before everything. But anyway, if I had to guess I would say the pace of production will slow since I'm liable to get even more

obsessive about making this good than usual. Or it'll all flow out so easily and naturally that we're all shocked and it all ends in a month. I can't predict how this stuff is going to go, and neither should you. Thanks for sticking with me, thanks for commenting, and I'll see you guys next time.

This might actually be the most coherent end notes I've written in the better part of a year.

Two Days Before the Battle

Chapter Summary

Adora and Catra finalize some plans, Mara and C'yra learn one more lesson, and Lonnie makes her opinion known.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora and Catra both ended up arriving back at base within a few hours of each other. Catra arrived first and was going over the battle plan with Scorpia when Adora entered the office. Scorpia was the first to notice her.

"Oh, Adora! Hi! How'd it go?"

"It went great! We've got the full support of the Alliance forces, and as an unexpected bonus, I convinced Queen Angella to fight with us as well!" Adora was positively bubbling with excitement. "I think we're actually going to pull this off!"

Catra snorted. "Glad to hear it. I'd hate to have planned all this just to lose."

"I mean, I thought we could pull it off without her," Adora backpedaled, "but-"

"I get it, dear." Catra said, giving Adora a chaste kiss on the cheek, that Adora quickly turned into a slightly less-chaste kiss. "Easy there, Adora!" Catra laughed, pulling back, "We've still got work to do!"

Scorpia waved a claw at the two. "Also hello, Scorpia still here! Please don't… I mean, it would get pretty awkward if you two just started, you know, *going at it* while I'm here don't you think? Or maybe you're into that? I'm not, though. Into that, I mean."

"Ugh, *fiiine* ," Adora groaned dramatically, "I guess we'll *finish talking about battle plans* or whatever so we win the war instead of making out."

"Don't worry," Catra whispered into Adora's ear, "this is the only thing I've got scheduled today."

Adora brightened visibly. "So then, how did the meeting with Dha'ra go?"

"Oh, pretty well." Catra replied, casually adding, "I found my uncle."

Adora's eyes widened. "You *what* ?"

"Yeah, turns out my mom was, in fact, from Halfmoon." Catra said, shrugging. "Dad wasn't - I guess he liked sailing too much to become a permanent fixture, and *mom* , apparently, shared the same interest in the sea, or she just loved dad too much to care that she was away from her parents for long periods of time."

In spite of herself, Adora felt a pang of jealousy. Her own family was probably dead somewhere halfway across a galaxy she couldn't even begin to figure out how to access. Meanwhile, Catra had managed to find an uncle, of all things, someone to tell her about her parents. *Yes, but you've found a family of your own, remember? Angella has been like a mother to you, but Catra only ever had Shadow Weaver.* "Well," she said, after a moment, "I can't wait to meet him!"

"You already have!" Catra said, laughing, "He helped you destroy the Sword of Protection."

That brought Adora up short. "Wait, *really?* Huh!"

"Yeah, small world, I guess?" Catra shrugged. "Anyway, setting the whole family reunion thing aside for a moment: Dha'ra's on board, obviously. She made a few alterations to the assault plan - she knows her people better than I do, so that's fine with me - and she said she can have her forces mustered at the rendezvous

point within a couple of days. Faster, if we really need it, but… honestly I wanted a little time with you before this whole thing kicks off, you know?"

"As it happens, we'll need time for Frosta and Mermista to marshall their forces too." Adora replied, smiling a little at Catra's comment. "So a couple of days before everything starts is fine."

"Good. Any big changes to the plan on your end, apart from the whole Queen of Brightmoon heading into battle thing?" Catra paused, then added, "How uh, how did that exactly come about, anyway?"

"Honestly, I'm still trying to figure it out myself." Adora admitted. "She came looking for me and asked to talk to She-Ra, so I turned into She-Ra and gave her some advice."

"Advice like 'maybe come out and fight instead of hiding in your castle while your subjects do all the fighting?'"

Adora laughed. "More or less that, yeah. I didn't get into the full details of the whole First Ones stuff with her, but I think seeing the real She-Ra may have shaken her belief in everything she's been taught."

"So does that mean we can trust her?"

"I don't know. I don't think I would trust her about *you* , at any rate." Adora sighed. "I *want* to trust her, but just getting her to question what she knows about She-Ra isn't the same as proving she doesn't know who the First Ones really were. Or that she'd be free of their influence."

"That's the problem with centuries-old conspiracies," Catra groused, "it makes it hard to know who to trust."

Adora gave an amused snort. "Well, at any rate I'm at least certain she's willing to fight, and that she trusts that I'm on her side as far as this war is concerned. That'll have to be enough for now."

“Works for me.” Catra nodded. “So, where is she going to position herself?”

“Here with Glimmer’s forces.” Adora said, indicating the position on the map. “We think - Glimmer, Angela, and myself, that is - that her presence will draw a significant number of Horde forces off. That will take some of the pressure off of Dha’ra and your forces, giving us a better chance to slip our strike team in and make for Hordak and Shadow Weaver.”

Catra nodded. “Okay, that works. We breach the main fortress here, then we split and hit them both simultaneously.”

Adora ran a hand through her hair, feeling a lurch of anxiety. “I still hate the idea of splitting up.”

“If there were a better option, I’d take it. Believe me.” Catra replied. “But if we go after them one at a time, we risk losing the other. The only way this war ends is if we take them *both* down. Eliminate the leadership and most of the Horde will surrender right then and there.”

“Then after that-”

“After that, I pull my forces back and disappear.” Catra said, firmly. “Then I figure out the best way to openly declare my existence without getting executed on the spot while you keep an eye on the political situation and do your best to keep the Alliance from deciding we’re a threat.”

Adora grimaced. “Not my favorite part of this plan, to be honest. I don’t like the idea of having to hide you.”

Catra folded her arms and glared at Adora, half seriously. “Well *you* insisted I wasn’t allowed to martyr myself, so this is the best plan we’ve got.” Adora rolled her eyes, but dropped the subject. Catra continued. “While I’m in hiding, Scorpia’s in command. She basically runs everything anyway, so I don’t think it’ll be that different.”

“Plus,” Scorpia added, “my status as a Princess means the odds are way lower that anyone will arrest and execute *me* , anyway. Er, we think. We’re pretty sure.”

“Your family is the rightful ruler of the Fright Zone, or so the story goes,” Catra said, “so I’m sure you’ve got some kind of diplomatic immunity or something. If anything, it’s more likely they’ll offer you the chance to take up the crown or some shit.”

Scorpia grimaced. “Oof, you think so? I’m not really… sure I think that’s a good idea.”

“We can cross that bridge when we get to it,” Adora said, “but I think you’d make a good interim leader at least.”

“The point is,” Catra broke in, “I’ll hide and work with Dha’ra to dig up more on the First Ones to get an idea of how compromised the Alliance is, as well as more information on the Heart of Etheria. You do what you can to make sure the Horde soldiers are treated fairly.”

“Don’t worry, I’ll keep them in line.” Adora said, grinning a little cockily, “They may not listen to *me* , but they’ll listen to She-Ra if nothing else.”

“Well,” Scorpia said, clicking her claws together decisively, “I think that’s it. Squad leaders all have their orders and will give their own briefings, and - obviously - I think they’ll probably want to hear from you before it all kicks off, but… I think that’s it.”

Catra took a deep breath. “All over but the waiting around, huh?”

“Looks like it.” Adora nodded, feeling a sudden rush of anxiety. “We’re… really doing this, huh?”

“Yep.” Catra nodded back. She noticed Adora’s tension and gave her arm a comforting squeeze. “Hey, now that this meeting’s over… you wanna go check in on the kids?”

Adora brightened, grateful for the distraction. “Yeah, sure! Any idea where they are?”

Catra hummed to herself and checked the clock. “If I’m not mistaken, they ought to be out learning about our farming system from Lonnie - or whoever Lonnie decided was going to take her place, I wasn’t sure how she felt about the whole thing.”

“If you ask me, I’d say it’s likely she’s doing it herself. She’s got a soft spot for kids.” Adora chuckles. “Pretty sure that’s why she was the only one of us apart from Rogelio who put up with Kyle.”

Catra couldn’t help but laugh. “You might have a point.”

The two walked leisurely to the fields, taking their time. Hanging in the air unspoken was the knowledge that this would, in fact, be one of the last times they would be able to enjoy each other’s company in anything like an open manner. Catra had, Adora knew, scouted a place where the two would rendezvous - but they’d need to be cautious, and while both Bow and Glimmer would both be briefed, Adora had for the moment no intention of telling the other princesses until she could be certain of how they would react.

It’s going to be worth it. Adora thought. *We’ll figure it out, and deal with whatever comes next together.*

Catra seemed to sense Adora’s train of thought, or perhaps she was just good at noticing when Adora was nervous, because she wordlessly reached over and threaded her fingers through Adora’s and gave a reassuring squeeze. Adora squeezed back, and the two kept their hands linked as they approached the distant forms of Lonnie, Mara, and Cy’ra.

Lonnie nodded at the two, and only a brief smirk showed that she’d noticed the two holding hands. “Hey Commander, Adora. Come to check up these two troublemakers?”

Cy’ra gave an outraged “Hey! We’re not troublemakers!” but Mara only rolled her eyes.

“She’s just fucking with you, Cy’ra.”

Cy’ra looked even more scandalized. “ *Language,* Mara!”

“Where the fuck do you think they picked up that kind of language?” Catra muttered to Adora, who promptly doubled over and started laughing.

Lonnie, for her part, seemed unphased by everything happening. “We were just wrapping up for the day, if you need my assistance with something.”

“Not really,” Catra said, “just wanted to ask these two if they were interested in a little sparring once they’re done here. I’m interested to see if they’ve learned anything new while I was away.”

A frown flickered across Lonnie’s face, then her expression shifted back to something more neutral. “Fine by me. You two, homework: I want you to choose a plant - preferably a crop we’ve talked about, but if you wanna do something else I won’t stop you - and make a list of what you’d need to grow it effectively. Y’all are going to grow something next time! Or, you know, start to.”

Mara seemed excited by the idea, which was something of a contrast to Cy’ra, who looked like she’d just been sentenced to prison. The two saluted and, in a move that seemed almost unconscious, took up positions on either side of Adora and Catra - Mara to Catra’s left, Cy’ra to Adora’s right. Catra ruffled Mara’s hair and grinned. “Come on then, I’m pretty sure the sparring grounds are free.”

“Or,” Adora broke in, “we could grab a late lunch first, and *then* you can show us what you’ve learned.”

Catra raised an eyebrow at Adora questioningly, then nodded. “Or that. Your choice.”

The two kids held a silent conversation with one another, which mostly considered of a series of shrugs and, finally, Mara making a

sort of ‘go ahead’ motion with her hand.

“I’d rather not fight on a full stomach.” Cy’ra said. “Can we eat afterwards?”

Adora nodded. “Yeah, of course!”

The group headed over to the training grounds which were, as Catra had predicted, empty. The two clones dashed into the sparring circle and took up combat stances. Catra smiled and gave the two a once-over with a critical eye.

“You’re favoring your right leg, Mara.” She said, eventually. Mara looked up guiltily. Catra crouched down, keeping her voice soft. “Did something happen?”

Cy’ra looked panicked. “It was-”

“Not Cy’ra’s fault.” Mara said, interrupting her. “An accident. We were practicing yesterday and I fell a little awkwardly at one point. I just twisted my knee a little - I can still fight.”

“I shouldn’t have gone for the knee.” Cy’ra said, still trying to take on the blame. “We were just sparring, it was going too far.”

Mara rolled her eyes. “I would’ve done the same, dummy. You have to treat every fight seriously, remember?”

“That’s… not entirely true, kiddo.” Catra said, quietly. “I know that’s absolutely not what you guys were taught, but… sparring is just sparring. The point is to train, and improve - not to win or lose. You’re making each other better when you spar, not figuring out who fought better that day. Which means that if you’re *hurt* , you have to let someone know, not hide it. It’s not weakness to admit you’re injured, kiddo. It’s just being smart.”

Mara gnawed at her lip and looked down at the ground.

“You’re not in *trouble* , kid.” Catra said, spotting an all too familiar shift in body language. “Just go visit the infirmary and have

someone look your knee over after this - and if you feel pain, we stop. Got it?" Mara nodded, and Catra stood back up, satisfied. "Good. Alright, take me through what you've been doing. Slow and steady."

The two girls took up positions again, and began going through a series of drills. Adora kept an eye on Mara, looking out for any signs of pain in her face. When she spotted Mara incorporating some of the pointers she'd given her ages ago, Adora couldn't help but feel a little proud of her. After around an hour, Catra called a halt to the proceedings.

"Not bad, you two!" She grinned, and the two beamed with pride. "Alright, food first, then the infirmary to get that knee looked at."

"A-actually," Mara spoke up, looking a little embarrassed, "My knee's starting to feel sore. Could I go to the infirmary first?"

"No problem." Catra smiled, glad that her talk hadn't been *immediately* forgotten (which, if she was being honest, was how Catra had handled any lecture she'd ever been given). "Cy'ra, I assume you want to keep an eye on her?"

In spite of being covered in fur, it was obvious that Cy'ra was blushing a little. "Y..yes Commander. If that's okay."

"Of course it is!" Adora said, giving the smaller magicat a reassuring look. "Catra and I will see you both later, okay?"

The two nodded and left, leaving Catra and Adora alone.

"Am I fucking up?" Catra asked, after the two were out of sight. She had a pensive look in her eyes and her tail was swishing back and forth thoughtfully.

"What do you mean?"

"With those two, I mean." Catra explained, her voice carrying an unfamiliar note of uncertainty. "I know Lonnie doesn't like that I'm still training them how to fight. But I mean… I promised them

they could be free to do whatever they wanted - which includes learning how to fight if that's what they choose, but…"

"But if they've only known training to be soldiers, and they're in a military base, is it putting pressure on them to stick with it, huh?" Adora finished, frowning. "Yeah, I guess you've got a point."

"That's my fear." Catra said, sighing. "Maybe I should send them somewhere else when this is all over. Find them a real family that can raise them outside of this place or something."

Adora thought about this for a moment. Catra had a point, but Adora had seen the way the two brightened when they'd caught sight of them coming to the field. "I think you might get some pushback on that idea."

Catra seemed confused. "I mean, I know some of the men would be sad to see them go, but…"

"Catra," Adora said, laughing a little, "I wasn't talking about the men. I was talking about the *kids* . I think they wouldn't want to go live with a family. I think… I think they've already found a family here. With you."

Catra's eye widened as she processed this new thought. "Oh. *Oh* . Oh no, Adora, I'm going to-" she paused, reconsidered whatever she was about to say. "I've got to bring them along, don't I?"

"Bring them along? Catra, they're too young to fight-"

"No, I meant afterwards." Catra said, almost frantic. "I can't just disappear on them, I've got to let them know that I'm not like, *gone* ."

Adora laughed again. "Wait, is that it? Catra, don't worry. I'll make sure they know what's going on. I can bring them with me to the rendezvous, if you like."

Catra blinked. "Oh, right. You're going to be able to…" she trailed off and huffed in annoyance at herself. "Sorry, I guess I'm just…

stressed."

"Well…" Adora said, and she pulled Catra in for a lazy kiss. "How about we get some food, and then I find some way to work some of that tension out for you, hmm?"

Catra had melted into Adora and couldn't help the small sigh of contentment that escaped her. "Sounds like a plan. Are you *sure* you're not a tactician?"

"Nah, that's more your thing." Adora replied, resting her forehead on Catra's. "Now come on, I think my stomach is about to start eating the rest of my internal organs."

"Lead on, She-Ra." Catra replied, a teasing note to her voice. As Adora turned to head in the direction of the cafeteria, she missed the thoughtful way Catra looked back at the training ground, and the way she muttered a quiet, " *Family* , huh?" before shaking her head and moving to catch up with her.

Chapter End Notes

Well, is everyone still here? Who can say? I hope so.

I have, as you have probably figured out, been writing other stuff on top of this stuff, for which I blame The Owl House and skateboarding entirely. I also went on a very long vacation, built a couple skateboards, and finally got around to watching Amphibia. I'm a big fan of all of it! But you have, alas, been forced to wait for me to finally get back around to this. Sometimes you gotta chase those other interests, and as I've said fairly often, I am incredibly nervous about actually bringing this thing in for a landing so there has been a lot of writing and deleting and writing and deleting (which is, to be fair, how everything I write goes to some extent). Is the big fight going to be the next chapter? Is it going to take multiple chapters to get through? Will you ever get Adora and Catra being soft with one another again in this fic? I guess you will all find out! So will I! I haven't decided yet!

My very sincere thanks to all of you for sticking around to see this thing through, and for your comments and patience as I do things like make Eda fight the Evil Dead or whatever the hell else I've gotten up to. See you next time!

Confrontation

Chapter Summary

> The battle begins. Catra finds Hordak. Scorpia has her doubts. Hordak provides a hint.
>
> Something ends.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The sound of multiple skiff engines echoed through the air as Catra's forces prepared for takeoff. She flipped a switch to begin broadcasting to the other skiffs and took a deep breath. It was time to set everything in motion. She took a deep breath and started talking.

"This is Commander Catra. By now, you all have been briefed on the coming battle. I don't need to tell you how important this fight is - you all know. We've all lost something in the course of this war, and while we might not be able to get that back…" Catra chuckled dryly and looked at her prosthetic hand, "We can make them pay for it. We can take our revenge by ending this war, today, for good. But that's not enough."

The day of what would be, one way or the other, the final fight in a long campaign dawned with a distinct lack of fanfair, Catra thought. Then again, the day dawned with her waking up tangled in Adora's limbs, so on balance she could get used to a lack of fanfair. What she really didn't want to do was risk life and limb again, especially because even if everything went the way it was supposed to, there was no guarantee of a safe return. Their intelligence was solid, but Hordak's inner sanctum hadn't been seen since before Catra's apparent death - Catra had only taken her orders from him in his grandiose throne room by the end. Hordak himself, according to intelligence, hadn't made a public appearance in nearly a year and only communicated via proxies. It

was part of the reason Catra had decided to split with Adora - Hordak probably had an escape route ready, and if they both went against Shadow Weaver, it was all but guaranteed he would slip away.

"Are you ready for this?" Adora asked, watching as Catra began donning her combat gear. Adora was already dressed in a simple uniform - she'd be spending the fight as She-Ra, anyway, so it wasn't like she needed much in the way of combat armor.

"I think so." Catra said. "I've been fighting so long, the thought of actually ending *this thing is kind of terrifying, you know?"*

Adora sighed. "I know what you mean. This is just the start of something bigger, isn't it?"

"Assuming we survive."

"We're not going to just end this war." Catra continued. "We're going to tear down the old order. We're going to make sure that soldiers like us don't become pawns in another conflict. You and I are going to build a future where we're free from conflict. This is where it starts.

"When this started, I'll admit, I was only out for revenge. Since then, we've built something new, and as we've done that I've come to see you all as comrades. As partners. Those of you in the Horde remember Hordak always used to claim we were a family, but it was a perversion of the idea. I know that now, because *you* have become my family. And because you are my family, I will fight to keep you safe. I will fight to give you something better than this. I hope I have earned the right to be considered your family. I hope you look at the soldiers next to you and see them as family. I hope you think of the personnel we're leaving behind - the medical staff, the agricultural team, everyone else - as your family too. And I hope you fight for them as hard as I'm going to fight for you."

"Catra." Adora said, voice serious. "Promise me you'll come back. Promise me that I'll see you again."

Catra felt a squeezing in her chest. "You know I can't, Adora. I'm not invulnerable."

"True," Adora replied, and her voice went low and fierce, "but you are clever, and you are the fiercest fighter I've ever known, and I swear on whatever gods exist that if you die I will march into the afterlife and drag you out just so I can kill you myself for being careless. Is that clear?"

Catra's voice was gruff. "I know we won't all make it out of this alive. I know that I am asking all of you to trust that I and our allies have come up with a plan that will work. Your trust will not be misplaced. I will not spend lives needlessly. I will be next to you, and I will fight with you, and we will come out of this victorious. I promise you - if we fail today, I will fail with you, and I will die with you. You all have your orders. It's time to carry them out. Good luck. Commander Catra out."

The skiff lurched as it lifted into the air with the others. Scorpia looked over at Catra from where she was strapped in with a tear in her eye.

"See, *that's* why you're the Commander. I'm with you to the end."

"Thanks, Scorp." Catra said, softly. Then she grinned. "I mean, it's not like I would let you hear the end of it if you backed out now anyway, but…"

"Okay, okay, I get it." Scorpia snorted. "But Comman- Catra, I just… if I don't make it out. If we don't-"

"Save it, Scorp." Catra said. "Tell me how great I am after we survive."

Scorpia laughed. "I was gonna tell you to let Entrapta know I loved her, but sure, I'll tell her after this."

Catra was quiet, then spoke up suddenly. “You know to tell Adora-”

“I know, Commander.”

The skiffs passed the first waypoint, and Catra’s skiff peeled off from the main formation along with Adora’s, containing the rest of the strike force. The pilots flew low to the ground, skimming the treetops. Catra closed her eye and let the world fall away, stepping through the plan beat by beat, visualizing what they were likely to run up against. The skiffs set down in a clearing, and the strike force assembled. The team conversed in low voices, checked their equipment, and tried to be patient as they waited for the signal that the battle was underway.

Adora hopped out of her skiff. “Good speech, Commander. Are you ready for this?”

Catra looked at the strike force, at Scorpia, and finally, at Adora. “Yeah.”

It didn’t take long. Dha’ra’s voice crackled over an open channel.

“Launch the offensive. For Half Moon!”

Queen Angella’s voice sounded next. “For the Rebellion!”

“Start the clock.” Catra said, waving to the men to begin moving. “Average response time is thirty minutes - once they realize this is a two-pronged attack, they’ll scramble everything they’ve got. We need to be out of sight before then.” She motioned to the skiffs, which fired up their engines and launched back into the sky, headed for the Half Moon front.

Adora stuck to Catra’s side as they moved swiftly through the forest, pausing only when they’d reached the main compound of the Horde fortress. Then, she turned to Catra and, not caring there were others around, dipped Catra and kissed her deeply.

“Good luck.” She whispered, and then, in a firmer tone of voice, “Come back to me.”

“As long as you come back to *me* .” Catra said, then, shouldering her rifle, began moving into position. She took a moment to look back one last time at Adora, and then the two forces melted into the blasted junkyard of the Fright Zone and disappeared.

Crossing the junk yard took nearly an hour, during which Catra could hear alarms blaring across the compound. The rumble of Horde tanks and the scream of skiff engines overhead provided all the motivation she needed to move cautiously. Reaching the perimeter wall, the soldiers began placing explosives as they worked their way around the fortress, methodically selecting structural weak points and moving on. They reached their breach point, and Catra keyed her radio in a rapid tap to let Adora know they were in position. A few minutes later, Adora signaled her readiness too.

“Ready for this, Scorpia?” Catra muttered to her companion.

“Been waiting a long time for this.” Scorpia replied, battle light in her eyes. “Let’s end this.”

A grin split Catra’s face, and she keyed the go loud signal to Adora. Then, gesturing to one of the men, she took a small satchel charge, placed it on the fortress wall in front of her, and ran like hell before triggering the detonation of it and all the other charges. The explosions punched holes in the wall just as an enormous flash of light came from Adora’s position, followed by the sound of exploding machinery.

“That’s my girl!” Catra crowed, and led her men through the wall.

Inside it was bedlam. The explosions had sent chunks of concrete flying, some of which had ended up crushing Horde equipment. The guard force was quickly overwhelmed by Catra’s squad as well as the far more pressing concern of She-Ra unleashed, wreaking havoc near the main entryway. Catra left her to it - she

positioned her men to keep pressure on the guards, diverting their attention, and slipped off with Scorpia to make for Hordak's sanctum.

The path to the sanctum was suspiciously unguarded, putting Catra on edge. Scorpia kept shooting her looks indicating she felt the same way. Two guards stood before the door to the sanctum and made no move to stop them as they approached. Catra kept her rifle trained on them and called over.

"You know who I am. Throw down your weapons and stand aside." To her surprise, the guards complied. She shot another look at Scorpia and nodded. Scorpia's tail whipped around, jabbing the guards in their necks, and they collapsed on the ground, senseless.

Scorpia held up a claw as Catra placed her hand on the door control panel. "Hey Commander, uh, this is a trap, isn't it?"

Catra grinned and punched a few buttons on the panel. "Oh *absolutely* . That's what will make this so much fun! Just uh, maybe stay back so you can save my ass when this all goes to shit, yeah?"

"Boy I just… really do *not* like this plan, Commander." Scorpia replied, but she took up position on the other side of the door as it slid open.

Hordak was waiting for her. Or, more accurately, the shell of Hordak was waiting for her, sitting on his throne, glaring at her balefully. "So, it's you. I figured it would be you. Somehow, I feel like it's only appropriate."

Catra was on full alert, but didn't show it at all. She sashayed into the room with all the casualness of someone dropping by to see an old friend - which, she bitterly thought, wasn't entirely inaccurate. "If you didn't want me here tearing your entire operation apart," she said, smiling, "you probably shouldn't have tried to kill me. Or you should've tried harder. Your pick."

“Spare me your smug victory speech.” Hordak shot back. “You wish for your revenge? Take it. I cannot stop you. The *witch* has seen to that.”

“Now what exactly do you mean by that?” Catra asked, curiosity raised in spite of herself. “Surely you’re not about to feed me some line about how this was all Weaver’s idea and you’re just a poor puppet.”

A bitter chuckle escaped Hordak’s lips that transformed into a coughing fit. He hacked and spit something black and viscous on the ground. “Indeed, I would not insult your intelligence by implying so. But perhaps I was too eager to believe you were a danger to my power, and perhaps Weaver was too persuasive. Make no mistake, however,” he raised his burning red eyes and looked Catra directly in hers, “the order to dispose of you was mine, and mine alone. The responsibility of what has come to pass since, well, perhaps that can be shared between my and the witch’s shoulders.”

“You know,” Catra said, drawing closer and getting a real good look at Hordak, “you don’t look so hot, chief. I assume that’s why you’re so angry at Weaver?”

“That is correct. She has *infected* me with something,” Hordak replied, and Catra could now see the black veins standing out against his arms, “and it has accelerated my… existing condition. I have run out of time. I will die here, on this backwater rock, shorn from the light of Prime’s gaze.”

“Yeah, I don’t know how to break this to you,” Catra replied, “but you’re going to die from the bullet I’m going to fire into your eye in a minute here.”

Hordak chuckled bleakly. “True enough, my former Commander. True enough. Perhaps that was always going to be how this all ended. Fate, or something like it.” At Catra’s look of annoyance, he snorted. “Oh come now, Commander, don’t tell me you aren’t at least a *little* suspicious we’ve all been played for fools, are you?

That this has all been part of some god's grand design? No? Perhaps it is merely my impending death that has caused me to search for meaning in this. Or perhaps I am the only one to see the complete picture. Would you like a hint, before you kill me?"

Catra considered the offer. Hordak *might* be playing for time, but Catra had spent a lot of time with him and felt like she had a good grasp over whether or not he was being honest. It did indeed seem he was sincere, at least about being resigned to death, so why not? She could show a little mercy and grant a last request, surely? "What's the hint for? This is the end of the game, Hordak."

"Oh, you think so, do you? That I and Weaver were the only forces you would contend with?" Hordak's amusement is clear. "There are other forces beyond the Horde."

"You mean the First Ones?" Catra replied, relishing the look of surprise that crossed Hordak's face. "Yeah, hate to break it to you but I already know about them."

"Ah, but do you know what they will do now?" Hordak responded, recovering from his shock. "Everything will now be dedicated to returning Etheria to real space, with or without your cooperation. And when that happens - the moment a dimensional shift occurs - I can guarantee you this, my old Commander: Prime *will* find you. When he does, the First Ones will use a weapon called the Heart, and if you think what the Horde has done to this planet's ecology is distasteful, wait until you see what the Heart will do to the whole galaxy! Oh, yes, Commander. You will want to do something to stop it, I think."

"Is that your hint?" Catra asked, raising her pistol. "Because if so, I'll just shoot you and get on my way."

Hordak laughed again. "No, that was information you should have known by now. *This* is my hint: there is a traitor in your midst, working toward a hidden purpose. Finding them should be your top priority."

“Oh come on, you’ve got to give me more to work with than *that* .” Catra rolled her eye.

“That,” Hordak said, “is the end of my hint.”

Catra sighed and raised her pistol. “Fine, then we’re done here.”

“Commander Catra,” Hordak said, and for a moment he looked almost like the Hordak she remembered and feared, “you have done well. Truly, you are my finest soldier. I am *proud* of you.”

“Yeah, well,” Catra replied, thumbing back the hammer, “you’ve got a funny way of showing it.”

The shot roared out in the room. Hordak’s head snapped backwards and a gout of black blood stained the throne. A few things happened at once:

One, the door to the room slammed shut.

Two, a small compartment on the throne slid open containing a data chip.

Three, a mechanical voice came over the loudspeaker.

Hordak failsafe activated. 400 seconds to detonation.

Catra cursed and immediately went for the door, which was (unsurprisingly) locked. Her eyes darted around the throne room, and she keyed her radio.

“Scorpia? Hordak’s dead, but I’m in a little trouble.”

“I know! I’m trying to get the door open but it won’t budge.”

“Scorpia,” Catra said, voice calm, “get out of here. Plan B, got it?”

Scorpia’s voice was angry. “Commander, you *promised!* ”

“I know I did, Scorp.” Catra replied. “But those are your orders. Got it?”

“Commander - *Wildcat* , please, don’t-”

“ *Those are your orders* , Scorpia!”

“Okay. Just…” Scorpia’s voice broke, and it was clear she’d started crying, “promise me this isn’t it. Even if it’s not true.”

Catra slid down the door, brushed back a tear. “Yeah, I promise. Now get moving.”

“Aye, Commander.”

300 seconds to detonation , the voice on the speaker chimed. Catra sighed and flipped her radio frequency over to broadcast to Alliance troops.

“Alliance, this is Commander Catra. Hordak is dead, and in a few minutes, it seems I will be too. My forces have been working in concert to end this war with the Crimson Waste army: do me a favor and don’t kill any of them. I know I’ve caused a lot of harm to a lot of you, and I don’t ask you to forgive me, but I hope this helps even the score a little. To Adora, I’m sorry about this. I know I promised I’d come back, but… I’m sorry. I love you more than I could ever adequately express, and what little time we’ve had has been more than I could have dreamed of. Sorry you’re gonna have to answer a bunch of questions about me now. I love you.” She stood up, wiped the tears from her face, and smiled. “Kick Weaver’s ass for me, babe. See you at the curtain call.”

Standing in the wreckage of a giant walking battle tank, She-Ra screamed in rage and agony as the sound of an enormous explosion cut over the radio before being replaced by static.

Chapter End Notes

> If you knew how long I've been sitting on this draft beyond the last like, page and a half you would know true pain. I was torn about posting this! Not just because of, you know, the end of it here, but also because like...

This is it. There's an end chapter count now. This will come in at a cool 53 chapters, unless something changes in my plans. We're almost done! Next chapter, we'll get what Adora was up to this whole time, and then an epilogue, and then....

Well, then it's over! I don't know how long it'll take me to get there, but there's a real finality to this whole thing! Thanks, really, to everyone for sticking with me this far. Just a little farther to go. How exciting!

An End to All Things

Chapter Summary

Adora fights. The war ends.

A fragile peace is born.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora had studied the briefings, as well as the plans for the so-called walking tank, for an extremely long time before the battle. She'd also gotten Catra to run through her own fight more than once, just to have a good idea of what to expect. In spite of this, the first thought she had as soon as the hangar doors opened and a giant robot stomped out ran roughly along the lines of *wow, that's a big fucking robot* , followed closely by *I can't believe Catra survived fighting this big fucking robot* .

Which, to be fair, it *was* a big robot -- certainly her fellow squadmates seemed to think so, having broken and scattered as soon as it appeared. She, however, had an advantage: namely, that she was something of a walking tank herself. She-Ra's power flowed through her, and while yeah, obviously Adora had been a *little* taken aback by the size of the big walking tank in front of her, she knew she was more than a match for it.

The robot raised an enormous cannon and fired, unleashing a blast of red energy that She-Ra knew instinctively came from the Black Garnet, although it carried the unmistakable taint of Shadow Weaver's own magic within it. Enraged by this twisting of Etherian power, Adora leaped into the air and swung her sword in a vicious downward strike that split the barrel in half. The cannon sparked and detonated, sending the bot stumbling sideways until it crashed against the hangar exterior. She-Ra moved in for the kill, but the mech crouched and, in a maneuver she wasn't expecting, kicked out and caught her off-guard.

Giant walking tanks, as it turned out, could put a significant amount of force into a kick. She-Ra went flying through the air and landed in a heap on the ground. The robot, moving fast for something so large, was on top of her in seconds, bringing its foot down in an attempt to squash her like a bug. She-Ra, however, was a little harder to take down than a bug. She rolled out of the way and sent a blast of energy out of her sword that split the foot in two. The mech stumbled, then toppled gracelessly forward. For a moment, the fight seemed over, until the canon swiveled and levered the mech upright. Then the canon fired, sending a bolt of red energy into She-Ra that splashed against her hastily-raised shield.

The red energy, however, did not dissipate. It crackled over the shield and leapt into She-Ra's skin, where it attempted to burrow deep. She-Ra cried out in pain, and then, Adora stood alone in a void. Shadow Weaver stood before her, her limbs shrouded in darkness, the formerly red mask discarded to reveal her scarred face wearing an insane grin of triumph. "Adora, so kind of you to save me the trouble of hunting you down myself -- and I see you've brought the Queen of Bright Moon here as well! You've done your old guardian such a favor."

Adora felt a surge of white-hot anger as she stared down the woman who'd raised her. "I didn't come here for you, Shadow Weaver. I came here to end this war. I came here for-"

"For *Catra* , yes, I know, it's *dreadful* the way you still cling to her." Shadow Weaver's expression shifted to one of disgust. "Still a distraction, even now. No matter. Hordak will play his role and I will be rid of *her* too."

Adora felt a pricking of panic before she forced it down. "I think you'll find Catra's more than a match for Hordak, Weaver."

"My dear, I'm *counting* on it. If Hordak's still alive, my ascent to ruler of this planet would be hindered. Best to get rid of two birds with one stone, don't you think? I installed a failsafe in Hordak's chambers. When he dies, so will Catra. But you, my dear, will not

see it. You have freed She-Ra from Eternian control, but *I* will bind her to me."

Tentacles of shadow rushed forward and Adora dove out of the way. The tentacles, however, were too fast and wrapped around her. Adora struggled, feeling the life begin to leave her body. It was too much, her strength wasn't enough, she was- *Oh for* fuck's sake *, Adora,* Catra's voice echoed in her head, *are you seriously going to die on me? Now? To fucking* Shadow Weaver *?*

"It's too much," Adora gasped, "I can't-"

Yes you can, and you know it. Draw on your strength, dummy! I can't believe I have to be the one to explain this shit to you.

"Oh." Adora said, and she looked up into Shadow Weaver's gloating expression and started to laugh.

"Driven mad by pain already?" Shadow Weaver said, mockingly. "Clearly I was too soft on you. Catra would hold out much longer when she and I used to have our little talks. Hours, even."

Adora closed her eyes and concentrated, and suddenly, she could see her friends. Glimmer teleported around the battlefield, setting up shots for Bow. The two were laughing as they blasted Horde bots apart. Frosta and Queen Angella stood back to back, the young Queen whooping a war cry as Angella unleashed wave after wave of magical energy that shook the very ground, a blazing beacon against the darkness of the oncoming Horde. Adora saw two of the modified soldiers attempt to approach the queen, only to find their feet encased in ice. Another wave of magic from Angella incinerated them, and she turned to Frosta and gave her, somewhat awkwardly, a high five. And Catra -- Adora watched Catra lead the assault and walk through the door to Hordak's chambers, completely unafraid.

Ah, good, She-Ra's voice suddenly echoed in her head, *you've come back. Hello Adora. Shall we end this?*

"Yeah," Adora said aloud, "we'll end this together."

The shadows caught fire, and Shadow Weaver screamed in agony, stumbling backwards. Adora blazed like a newborn star, banishing the darkness of the void. She-Ra snapped back to reality and detonated, sending an explosion of magical power directly into the mech's cockpit. The metal nose crumpled, followed by a chain of explosions that ripped the torso apart. The mech fell to the ground in a smoking ruin. She-Ra approached the cockpit, gripped the canopy hatch, and ripped it off.

Inside, the body of Shadow Weaver was slumped over the controls. She-Ra dragged the body out and slammed it against the wreckage of the tank, eliciting a bloody cough from the sorceress.

"What trap did you set for Catra?" She-Ra snarled, blazing in fury.

"It's too late, Adora." Shadow Weaver wheezed. "Hordak's chambers are wired to blow should his lifesigns flatline."

She-Ra grabbed her radio to contact Catra, only for Catra's voice to suddenly crackle over the radio. Heart sinking, Adora listened to Catra's speech, apology, and confession all at once.

"Catra," Adora whispered, " *no* ."

"Kick Weaver's ass for me, babe. See you at the curtain call."

Time seemed to stand still, She-Ra's grip on Shadow Weaver's throat tightening. "If she dies," She-Ra said, "I will end you, Weaver."

"Then I suppose," Weaver replied, laughing, "that you will have to end me. There is no stopping this."

"Catra's beat longer odds than this." She-Ra insisted. "She'll find a way."

"Oh *please* ," Shadow Weaver responded, "you know as well as I do that it was blind luck that saved her. Luck which has long since run out."

The explosion was enormous. She-Ra frantically keyed her transmitter, tried to raise Catra on the channel they'd set aside for emergencies, and came up empty. She screamed in rage and agony, and turned her blazing gaze on Weaver.

"Will you kill me now, Adora?" Weaver asked. "It will not save her. It is meaningless. You know vengeance brings no peace."

"No," Adora said, dropping She-Ra's form, feeling strangely at peace. "it does not."

"Very good, Adora:" Weaver said, failing to keep an edge of triumph out of her voice. "I surrender. I have much to tell you about the First Ones. About the Heart of Etheria. Ensure my survival, and I will tell you how to trigger the failsafe and destroy it. We will bring Etheria out of this prison, and-"

Adora drove her dagger through Shadow Weaver's throat with such force that it pinned her to the side of the wreckage. The sorceress flailed, choking on her own blood. "I will live without peace," Adora growled, "if it means ridding Etheria of *you* ."

She turned and walked away from the wreckage. Across the Fright Zone, Horde soldiers threw down their weapons and surrendered, save for a few holdouts who fought bitterly to the death. A group of Rebellion soldiers helped Adora sift through the rubble of Hordak's chambers, where they found Catra's body. Adora took a deep breath, laid her hand on Catra's still form, and began glowing.

Then, to the confusion of all present, Adora began laughing. By the time Glimmer and the others reached her, Adora was cradling Catra's body, still laughing so hard that tears ran down her face.

"I'm going to kill her." Adora choked out, finally. "I'm going to fucking *kill her* for this. She *promised* ."

It was Scorpia, oddly enough, who placed a claw on Adora's shoulder. "She told me to tell you she was sorry."

“Yeah,” Adora said, finally relinquishing the body, “I know.” She turned to the Princesses and assembled members. Her voice rang out clear in the silence that had fallen.

“I know Catra hurt many of you. She hurt me too. She would want me to make sure you know that she didn’t regret it either. She rejected the idea of being a hero, even though the things she did for her men and for members of the Alliance itself were heroic. She’s gone now. This was the only way she knew how to make things right. Her parting gift: the end of this war.”

“But this isn’t the last time we’ll fight, I’m sure. This may not even be the biggest fight of our lives. Remember we all came together, when the time comes. Remember that even those we considered our great enemies could see the error of their ways and strive to make things right. Remember Catra as a hero,” Adora smiled, “if only because it would really piss her off if she knew.”

Mermista approached and embraced Adora. “It was her, huh?”

“Yeah.” Adora said.

“Sorry.” Mermista replied. “We weren’t… well, you know. But if she did all this, well. Couldn’t have been *all* bad I guess.”

Angella knelt in front of Adora. “I’m so sorry.” She said. “I wish… this had been different. I am glad you had some time with her, however short.”

“I’m sorry for the deception.” Adora replied, honestly. “But she was… a complicated topic.”

“I would have forgiven her,” Angella said, “if I’d known what she’d become. I am sorry that my own… foolishness made it seem that you had to keep her a secret.”

“Thank you, Angella.” Adora said. “But I won’t allow myself to be consumed by what could have been. You shouldn’t either.” She turned to Scorpia. “Can you… see to the arrangements? I’m… I need to tell- I need to tell the others.”

“Of course, Adora.” Scorpia said. “There’s a skiff standing by to take you to the base.”

“That won’t be necessary.” Swift Wind said. “I’ll take you.”

Mounting up, Adora looked at those assembled. “I’ll be back soon. I promise.”

The funeral was kept small at Adora’s request. Catra’s body was buried in a small grave on the border between the Fright Zone and the Whispering Woods. The business of establishing peace quickly became the only thing on anyone’s mind, and for a few weeks Adora was kept so busy she’d barely had time to consider her next move. Mara and C’yra elected to stay at the base that had become their home, and Adora visited as frequently as she could. Adora had spoken to them privately, filling them in on everything that had happened.

“So, C’yra,” Adora had said, “will you kill me now? I’ve ended the war, after all. My time’s up.”

“Would it change anything?” C’yra responded, giving Adora a serious look. “Did killing Shadow Weaver make you feel better?”

“No,” Adora replied, “not really. It *was* nice to get her to shut up finally, though.”

“Well,” C’yra said, smiling slightly, “I guess it’s a good thing you’re not as annoying to talk to.”

“Hey, Adora?” Mara said, speaking up suddenly. “Can we… I mean, can you…” She worried at her lip, looked down, and seemed suddenly very shy. “We’ve… we never really had *parents* .” She finally said.

Adora knelt down, tears in her eyes, and pulled the two in close. “You do now.” She said, and that had been that.

A few days later, a group of ambassadors from the Princess Alliance arrived at the base -- namely, Perfuma, Glimmer, and Bow

-- to conduct negotiations with Scorpia, who was acting Commander. That had been the official reason, at any rate -- the *actual* reason had been that Adora wanted to introduce them to Mara and C'yra.

"Oh, the delegation?" Scorpia responded when Adora asked where they were. "Entrapta's giving them a tour. Think they're out at the fields at the moment."

"-these crop rotations all your idea?" Perfuma's voice carried on the wind as Adora approached.

"Oh no," Entrapta replied, waving a hand dismissively, "I've never been any good at this stuff. That's all Lonnie's doing."

"Who's Lonnie?" Bow asked.

"What, you don't remember me?" Lonnie said, walking out of one of the greenhouses. "I'm almost insulted. We fought each other like, a million times back in the day."

"Shoulders." Perfuma muttered to herself, then shook her head. "Hi, I'm Perfuma! It's nice to meet you! You know um, when we aren't trying to kill each other."

Lonnie had an easy smile on her face as she replied, "Yeah, how about that, huh? So, you're interested in my crops?"

Perfuma's eyes lit up. "Yes! I'm amazed what you've managed to do with limited resources! If you had time, I'd love to talk to you about it later!"

"I'm sure I can make some time." Lonnie replied, pointedly ignoring the look Adora was giving her. "I'll come find you later tonight, yeah?"

"Sounds great!" Perfuma replied, pointedly ignoring the looks she was getting from Bow and Glimmer.

Negotiations were, as far as Adora was concerned, a resounding success.

Around a month later, Adora packed a backpack and told her friends that she needed some time off. "I'll be back in a week or so." She said, giving Glimmer a hug. "You think you and Bow are up for keeping an eye on the two troublemakers?"

"Oh please, they *love* hanging out with their Aunt Glimmer! Plus I think Bow promised to show Mara some of his new arrow designs. That one's got a surprising interest in technology."

"Spending too much time with Entrapta and Scorpia, I'll bet." Adora snorted. "Not the worst thing that could happen."

"Are you sure you're okay?" Glimmer asked, pulling back. "I know this whole… Catra thing is-"

"I'm sure." Adora replied, and gave a genuine smile. "Sometimes you've just got to make the best of things, you know?"

"I guess." Glimmer said, a little dubiously. "Still, I wish things could have been… you know."

"Yeah, I know." Adora sighed. "We'll get through it. This trip will help."

"Contact me and Bow when you get there?"

"Of course." Adora said, and mounted up on Swift Wind. "Come on, Swifty!"

"Thought you'd never ask!" Swift Wind replied, and launched into the sky.

A solitary cabin sat on a cliff, overlooking the sea. Adora landed Swift Wind on the beach, patted his nose appreciatively, and watched him take off. Then, she began climbing. She *could* have let Swift Wind fly her up, of course, but Adora needed the

exercise. It would help clear her head, at any rate. That had been the point of the whole trip.

Her muscles burned pleasantly as she ascended. She-Ra's voice echoed in her mind. *You know, we still have a lot of work to do* .

"Yeah, I know." Adora muttered. "But come on, you're me. You know we need this."

I would never imply otherwise .

"Good. Because the point of this trip is to forget about everything for a while." Adora said. "You know, *figure our shit out* and all that."

Yes, I know , She-Ra's voice had an amused tone, *I was there when you said it, after all.*

All things told, the ascent took around twenty minutes. Adora heaved herself over the edge of the cliff and lay on her back, panting. "I've gotta be getting soft." She muttered. "Too many state functions slowing me down."

She walked to the cabin, took a deep breath, and opened the door. A fire crackled in the fireplace, and Adora chuckled as she saw the figure curled up on the sofa, snoring gently. She lay a hand on a furred shoulder and squeezed.

"Hey there, sleepyhead."

A purr filled the room as Catra, one-time Commander of the Horde, one-time mercenary, currently assumed dead thanks to a favor from a shapeshifter, stretched luxuriously and sat up. "Not my fault you took forever to climb that cliff." She murmured as Adora pulled her in for a kiss.

Adora pulled back and huffed in amusement as she looked at the face of the woman she loved. "Kept you waiting, huh?"

Chapter End Notes

Loose ends are all wrapped up, don't you think?

Well, maybe there's a few left.

Which is to say: Shoo! There's an epilogue! I'll gush in it there, okay? Okay.

Epilogue

Chapter Summary

> It's not a Metal Gear Solid crossover without a post-credits sting, is it?

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Recorded call between Double Trouble and unknown party. Surveillance was unable to recover the other end of the call.

"It's me, darling. Went off just how you planned it."

indistinct response

"No, she doesn't suspect a thing. She got what she wanted, didn't she?"

indistinct response

"Yes, the deaths of Shadow Weaver and Hordak were confirmed. No wriggling out of it for either of them."

indistinct response
"Of course, darling. It was the performance of a lifetime: behold, the corpse of the one-time Commander of the Horde! Adora gave a pretty speech too, even though she knew it was all a fake as soon as she tried to heal me."

indistinct chatter

"I may have suggested it as a fallback plan in case the opportunity arose."

indistinct chatter

"No, Catra was never in any danger. I'd made certain some air vents were unlocked. She got out of there with at least *a hundred seconds to spare."*

indistinct chatter

"Yes, I lifted the data drive off of her when we met up and swapped it out with the copy I'd made that includes your alterations. Your secret's safe."

indistinct chatter.

"Yes, Catra's off the board, so to speak. Only the Princesses know she's still alive, and they're happy to use her memory as a way to improve relations with the former Horde."

indistinct chatter

"Of course! I'll make sure they find the control room for the Heart and dimensional shift."

indistinct chatter

"No, Light Hope won't interfere. She wants to get out of here as much as we do."

indistinct chatter

"Yes, the First Ones still think I'm Prince Peekabloo, working diligently to bring about the return of their grand empire. Kind of a boring role to play, but I've had worse."

indistinct chatter

"Of course, I'll keep you informed on any developments."

indistinct chatter

"Yes, Queen Angella has started to investigate the First Ones, just as you'd hoped. She's doing quite well."

indistinct chatter

"Yes. Of course... Your Majesty."

Final Note: Signal triangulation indicates the other party was located somewhere on Beast Island.

Chapter End Notes

Holy shit.

We got there.

This has been... a long, *long* journey. I started this with the tag "I'm going to regret this" and folks, I gotta say that I think that tag was probably inaccurate. What a fucking ride it's been. Some of you have been here for literal years! This started before the pandemic! Before *season three!* This has been part of my life for actual years! It is, to date, the longest thing I've ever done.

It may also be the thing I'm proudest of, because this started off with two ideas: Start with Catra losing an eye and a hand, and end with Adora saying "Kept you waiting, huh?" and we went from there. Thank you. Thank you all so, so much for reading this and following along and commenting and... I don't know what else to say apart from that. I have loved writing this, I hope you have loved reading this, and... well. Thank you. I cannot believe it's done! It hasn't sunk in yet! If you comment I will get emotional at you in the comments, probably!

This is the longest thing I've ever written, like I said before. I did something I didn't know was possible, which was write a long thing and actually keep it going and hey here we are. Took a while to get to the end, but we're here now. I will see you guys around -- feel free to check out any of the other stuff I've gotten up to, and look, maybe one day we'll see

how these guys are doing. Until next time, seriously, I love you guys and thank you, thank you so fucking much for sticking with me through to the end. I hope it's a good ending!

It's not goodbye, as a fellow once said, it's see you later. So.

See you later.

End Notes

So uh, I guess I had another one of these in me after all.

This idea was heavily (and I mean like, *heavily*) influenced by two things: Metal Gear Solid V, and this fic. I uh, I'm not entirely sure where it'll end up going, but I have some notions. Unlike the last multi-part fic I did, I have no idea how long this one will be, and it's all hazy enough that updates will be much fewer and far between. Set your expectations accordingly, and don't forget that I warned you.

UPDATE: Turns out this ended up being pretty fucking long!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!